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The Epistemology of Resistance

GENDER AND RACIAL OPPRESSION, EPISTEMIC INJUSTICE, AND RESISTANT IMAGINATIONS

José Medina

The Epistemology of Resistance

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For Carlos Thiebaut, in friendship and admiration, because his life is a testament to *resistance* (in all its positive meanings).

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{ FOREWORD }

Insensitivity and Blindness

Insensitivity is the key theme of this book. As I understand it, insensitivity involves being cognitively and affectively numbed to the lives of others: being inattentive to and unconcerned by their experiences, problems, and aspirations; and being unable to connect with them and to understand their speech and action. This kind of insensitivity is at the core of the epistemic injustices I will discuss. Although I favor the terms *insensitivity* and *numbness* because they have both cognitive and affective connotations and because they are broad enough to cover different aspects of our epistemic life, the literature I engage with typically refers to epistemic deficiencies of this sort in perceptual terms and, more specifically, in visual terms: in terms of *blindness*. Although I have tried to use the term *insensitivity* and other related expressions whenever possible, avoiding the visual metaphor and the term *blindness* has not always been possible or advisable for various reasons. In the first place, I draw on classic authors (such as W. E. B. Du Bois and Franz Fanon) and contemporary ones (such as Linda Alcoff and Charles Mills) who talk about insensitivity (especially racial insensitivity) in terms of blindness. I could have only mentioned "blindness" (in quotes) without using the term, but there are specific notions of racial *blindness* that I wanted to modify or broaden (for example, by introducing the notion of *meta-blindness*). I did not want to break the continuity of my own discourse with those bodies of literature, classic and contemporary. In the second place, there are particular issues and ideologies that appear in relation to racial and sexual oppression that are difficult to discuss without using the term *blindness* and the visual paradigm, because these issues and ideologies are already formulated in those terms—especially important in this respect is "color-blindness." In the third place, the use of the metaphor of sight and blindness to deal with issues of social sensitivity and insensitivity is also pervasive in different literary traditions—think, for example and especially, of Ralph Ellison's *Invisible Man* and José Saramago's *Blindness* (which have inspired some insights and arguments in this book). The book contains only brief discussions of literary treatments of insensitivity, but they set the tone and the rhetoric of the phenomenon as I approach it. And finally, in the fourth place, ordinary language is plagued with visual

metaphors to talk about communication, understanding, and knowledge ("seeing or not seeing the point," "seeing or not seeing an alternative," etc.); and although it is often advisable to avoid those metaphors and to shift to a different conceptual paradigm, there are particular visual concepts that were important for me to use as they are formulated in ordinary language, connecting the rhetoric of the book with ordinary experiences and ordinary practices. In particular, I wanted to use the ordinary notion of "blind spot" as it functions in the practice of driving, for it provides an apt metaphor for epistemic gaps that we learn to detect through painful experiences (our own or that of others) in which people get into trouble for not taking into account such gaps.

Although I have not succeeded in overcoming the visual paradigm of blindness to talk about insensitivity, I hope to have contributed a bit to such overcoming by avoiding the visual language at least in some of my discussions when it was possible and appropriate, but also—and more important—by calling attention to the problems associated with equating epistemic deficiencies with perceptual disabilities such as blindness (or deafness). Both in academia and in everyday speech we are surrounded by discourses that privilege able-bodied perspectives. Instead of simply erasing any reference to the ubiquitous metaphor of blindness, I have introduced a sustained critical discussion about our rhetorical devices to discuss epistemic deficiencies in social interaction. In order to begin such discussion, I offer three reasons why the terms *insensitivity* and *numbness* are far more appropriate than *blindness* to describe deficient epistemic sensibilities. In the first place, the problem of having been desensitized to certain aspects of social relationality has a perceptual dimension, but the perceptual numbness involved is multidimensional and affects not only sight, but the other senses as well—in particular, it affects our capacity to hear and listen properly. In the second place, the terms *insensitivity* and *numbness* are more appropriate than *blindness* because, although clearly related to our embodied sentience, they can be easily extended to the non-perceptual, and indeed the epistemic deficiencies in question go beyond our perceptual organs. There is an important disanalogy between the failure of a sensory organ (such as sight) and the communicative and interpretative failures I will discuss (those associated with social ignorance grounded in oppression). For this reason, it is more adequate to talk about forms of numbness or insensitivity, which are sometimes perceptual (involving the inability to see something or to hear something, for example), but sometimes not. Finally, in the third place, the terms *numbness* and *insensitivity* can avoid problems that appear in the use of the metaphor of blindness: this metaphor facilitates the circulation of distorted images that sighted people have about the experience of blind people; and indeed the equation of blindness with ignorance is disrespectful and offensive for blind people and contributes to the

"otherness" of people with disabilities.[1] Interestingly, the kind of insensitivity that the use of the metaphor of blindness exhibits exemplifies well the kind of *meta-insensitivity* that my view denounces, namely, the lack of critical awareness of what we know and do not know about the experiences of people who are significantly different from us.

[1] I am grateful to two of my colleagues, Marilyn Friedman and Lisa Guenther, for calling my attention to this problem. I am also grateful to an anonymous reviewer of the manuscript for her/his critical remarks about the use of the metaphor of blindness in the literature. These remarks led me to realize that the problematic use of this metaphor is an excellent exemplification of my very argument about insensitivity and social ignorance.

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The Epistemology of Resistance

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Introduction

RESISTANCE, DEMOCRATIC SENSIBILITIES, AND THE CULTIVATION OF PERPLEXITY

A. The Importance of Dissent and the Imperative of Epistemic Interaction

We want to walk: so we need *friction*. Back to the rough ground!

— WITTGENSTEIN, *PHILOSOPHICAL INVESTIGATIONS, 1958, §107*

This book is about the epistemic aspects of our social interactions. More specifically, the focus will be on social interactions that take place in complex and diverse communities under conditions of oppression and on the *resistance* that we can find in those interactions. The kind of social epistemology presented here is heavily influenced and informed by theories of oppression—especially those developed within feminism and race theory—and also by the liberatory movements articulated to fight sexual and racial oppression. The epistemology of resistance I will develop has both an *analytic* and a *normative* side: it tries to elucidate the epistemic aspects of oppression, but it also tries to offer a way out of the epistemic injustices that accompany oppression. Epistemic injustices (such as unequal access to and participation in knowledge practices, vitiated testimonial dynamics, phenomena of hermeneutical marginalization, to name some central ones) call for *epistemic resistance*, that is, for the use of our epistemic resources and abilities to undermine and change oppressive normative structures and the complacent cognitive-affective functioning that sustains those structures. Epistemic injustices—and therefore the need for epistemic resistance—are pervasive not only in nondemocratic societies, but also in societies that have or aspire to have democratic structures and practices. And in fact the focus of this book will be on epistemic injustices in democratic societies or at least in societies that are in their way to develop a democratic culture, even if the democratic attitudes of that society have strong limitations and coexist with nondemocratic ones. According to the picture of epistemic interaction that will emerge from the discussions of this book, achieving and maintaining a democratic temperament is always a struggle, an ongoing

struggle that never ends, for our democratic sensibilities always have blind spots we need to be attentive to; and a crucial part of that perfectionist ongoing struggle toward democracy is the resistance against epistemic injustices. In all societies—democratic and nondemocratic ones—people live surrounded by epistemic injustices that call for resistance. But the difference is that in democratic societies, given their commitment to free and equal epistemic participation, there is a prima facie interest and obligation to detect and correct the systematic disparities in the epistemic agency that different members of society can enjoy and the inequalities associated with them. As the reader will soon discover, in this book *epistemic resistance* dos not simply designate something of instrumental value or a transitional stage; it refers to a mode of relationality that is crucial for democratic sociability—in fact, the heart and soul, the epistemic centerpiece, of a democratic culture. In what follows, *resistance* will refer to central epistemic and political mechanisms and activities that make democratic interaction possible: the mechanisms and activities of *contestation*. Although this book does not contribute to democratic theory, it draws from theories of democracy that pay attention to contestability and the epistemic dimension of social interaction.

What are the epistemic features of our democratic practices? What are the epistemic powers that go into democratic participation (participation not only in formal democratic institutions and forms of government, but also and more importantly in democratic culture, that is, in everyday practices and activities in a democratic form of life)? One answer focuses on *consensus*, defining democratic participation as participation in activities designed to create and sustain agreement among the members of the relevant group or community. But, as Elizabeth Anderson has shown in "The Epistemology of Democracy" (2006), consensus-producing activities do not necessarily integrate key features of democratic life, in particular, the following three: diversity, interaction, and dynamism. I will return to these three features in the next paragraph, but, intuitively, it seems quite possible that a society may develop practices and institutions oriented toward consensus while remaining quite homogeneous, noninteractive, and static. To the consensus model of democratic interaction I want to oppose and defend what I call the *resistance model*, which I find in various feminist epistemologists and political theorists but especially in Elizabeth Anderson and Iris Marion Young. I will reserve Young's framework of communicative democracy for later, but I want to introduce here some of the central ideas for a resistance model of democratic interaction that we can find in Anderson. Let me start with Anderson's critique of what I call consensus models of democracy.

Anderson considers two epistemic models of democracy that revolve around consensus. The first one is the model based on the so-called Condorcet jury theorem, which stipulates that for any choice, if there is a better than 50 percent chance of choosing the best option, the probability of the majority

vote being right approaches 1 as the number of voters increases. Anderson raises three key objections against this model. In the first place, the model is supposed to work independently of whether the voters are epistemically homogeneous or epistemically diverse. But, as Anderson puts it, we need "a model of democracy in which its epistemic success is a product of its ability to take advantage of the epistemic diversity of individuals" (2006, p. 11). In the second place, given the independence requirement, this model divorces the two key forms of information-pooling characteristic of democracy: voting and public discourse. Democracy is not only about voting but also about talking. In fact, talking is prior to voting because, if voting is about ratifying certain proposals, public discourses are antecedently needed for the formulation and discussion of those proposals: "Talk is needed to articulate proposals to make certain concerns a matter of public interest"; "a free press, public discussion and hence mutual influence prior to voting are constitutive, not accidental features of democracy" (2006, p. 9 and p. 11). Without such discussion, voting would give expression only to private preferences and not to a public interest. Moreover, for democratic practices of decision-making to be effective and properly attuned to the life of the community, communication (talking, or public discourse) also needs to be continued after voting, critically revisiting the consequences of the adopted agreements and interrogating the advisability of renewing and continuing such consensus. And this takes us to the third objection that Anderson formulates against this consensus model: that it "fails to capture the *dynamic* features of democracy's epistemic functions," for the success of laws and policies "is a function of their consequences, not of their *ex ante* popularity" (2006, p. 12). Anderson argues that a proper epistemic model for democracy needs to allow for learning and self-correction, which require the recognition of democratic fallibility and the institution of "feedback mechanisms by which it can learn how to devise better solutions and correct its course in light of new information about the consequences of policies" (Ibid.). The consensus model based on the Condorcet jury theorem fails in this respect as well, since it presents majority decisions as nearly infallible and it provides no corrective mechanism for them.

Anderson considers another consensus model based on a different theorem: the diversity trumps ability (DAT) theorem. This theorem exploits the insight that the solution of complex problems requires the pooling of resources of epistemically diverse agents; and it states that, in a diverse society where problem solvers work together in moderate sized groups, "a randomly selected collection of problem solvers outperforms a collection of the best problem solvers" (Ibid.). This model does a good job in explaining the epistemic superiority of democracy over technocracy; it is a substantial improvement over the first consensus model, and it seems well equipped to accommodate the first two features of democracy: diversity and interaction (although the latter seems confined to in-group communication, without the communicative interaction

across groups playing any significant role). But, as Anderson argues, by focusing on the convergence or consensus of diverse groups, the DAT theorem does not properly accommodate the dynamism of democratic life and the learning processes required for the epistemic functioning of democracy: "the DAT theorem does not model the epistemic functions of periodic elections and other feedback mechanisms designed to change the course of collective decisions in light of information about their consequences" (2006, p. 13).

As an alternative to the two consensus models of democracy that Anderson criticizes, she finds a better epistemic model in John Dewey's *experimentalism*. Dewey's experimentalist account of the epistemic powers of democracy epitomizes what I call a *resistance* model, given the central role that dissent and contestation play in this model. As Anderson argues, when compared with the consensus models of democratic interaction, Dewey's experimentalism is the only model in which dissent is epistemically productive. And following Dewey, Anderson offers "an account of the multiple epistemic roles of dissent at different points in democratic decision-making" (2006, p. 9). It is the role of dissent in democratic epistemic practices that gives us a rationale for valuing diversity, interaction, and dynamism: it is because we want to exploit the benefits of productive dissent that we need to recognize and take advantage of the heterogeneous situated knowledge of diverse agents; that we want all agents and groups to be in communication and to interact epistemically, so that they can interrogate each other and cooperate; and that we want diverse experiences and reactions to be used for critically revisiting and perfecting decisions and policies. It is especially the third feature—dynamism—that according to Anderson gives Dewey's experimentalism an advantage with respect to the other epistemic models of democracy. As Anderson puts it, Dewey's experimentalist model helps us see the epistemic import of democratic institutions that make dynamic social learning and self-correction possible: free press, protests, public discussion of the policies and performances of administrative agencies, periodic elections, and so on. "In Dewey's model, these are mechanisms of feedback and accountability that function to institutionalize fallibilism and an experimental attitude with respect to state policies" (2006, p. 14).

I want to emphasize that the Deweyan experimentalist model involves not only an *experiential* approach, but also an *imaginative* approach, for the kind of democratic communication needed to accommodate epistemic diversity, adequate interaction, and dynamism requires imagination. Democratic communication is the communication of diverse experiences *and* diverse imaginations: it is aimed at putting our practices and institutions in sync with the heterogeneous *experiences* of diverse members of society, but also with the heterogeneous *imaginations* that individuals and groups can exercise. Following Dewey, Anderson argues that we should think of democratic deliberation as "a kind of thought experiment, in which we rehearse proposed solutions to problems in imagination, trying to foresee the consequences of implementing

them, including our favorable or unfavorable reactions to them" (2006, p. 13). The epistemology of resistance I articulate and defend in what follows revolves around *resistant experiences* and *resistant imaginations*, that is, around the beneficial epistemic friction that significant differences in experiences and imagination can produce. Experience and imagination are the two poles of the feedback loop needed for democratic processes of social learning. Our experiences are expanded and critically assessed in and through the imagination, which enables us to connect our actual experiences with possible ones, extending and projecting them into alternative pasts, presents, and futures. But at the same time, as suggested by Anderson's emphasis on the importance of revisiting decisions and policies in the light of the experience of their consequences, our imagination has to be constantly interrogated by the actual experiences of those affected by the practices and institutions we set up; and the continuation and correction of those practices and institutions should be the result of the collective responsiveness to the experiences and imaginations of all members of society.

The aim of the *epistemic interaction* in which resources are pooled and experiences and imaginations are shared, compared, and contrasted is both practical and epistemic: democratic epistemic interactions aim at perfecting not only our practices but also our *sensibilities*. Democratic sensibilities require free and equal epistemic interaction among the heterogeneous groups that are part of society. This is what I call the democratic *Imperative of Epistemic Interaction*, which is an epistemic version—with minor modifications—of the "imperative of integration" that Anderson has argued for so persuasively in her 2011 book. In *The Imperative of Integration* Anderson argues that a critical democratic failure of contemporary US society is the de facto segregation that survives decades after segregation was legally abolished.[1] Anderson contends that, in order to become truly democratic and guarantee freedom and equality, American society and its publics have the obligation to integrate in all areas of social life: housing, schooling, marriage, cultural expression, and so on. Although in general I agree with Anderson's arguments and conclusions, I want to relax her imperative of integration to allow for social spaces and practices that are intended primarily (if not exclusively) for the members of minority groups that struggle to achieve self-empowerment or to preserve their distinctiveness. Such social spaces and practices do not have to be separatist in a strong sense, but they do not need to be committed to integration in a strong

[1] The most surprising finding of Anderson's rich analysis of the empirical data is that the de facto segregation of today is in fact *worse* than the legal segregation of the first half of the twentieth century in many areas of social life. When it comes to housing and education, for example, neighborhoods and schools are less mixed today as a result of voluntary segregation than they were when segregation was legal and enforced by state agencies. Anderson's analysis converges with mine in chapters 4 and 5 when I discuss the ideology of color-blindness that obscures these realities and protects racial ignorance.

sense either. In particular contexts, practices and institutions designed to provide a safe and nurturing space for underprivileged groups can have great democratic value. Under specific conditions, such practices and institutions may be precisely what are required for the self-empowerment of oppressed groups, or for the articulation of a public whose formation has so far been blocked. Anderson is certainly right that real racial desegregation in the United States has not yet been achieved and remains a key democratic challenge for the accomplishment of real equality. But, as Anderson's own analysis poignantly shows, desegregation is a process—a very complex historical process—and not all aspects and phases of this process require that *all* social spaces and practices be fully integrated to the point of losing all group specificity.[2] For this reason, I suggest that the broader and weaker notion of "interaction" is preferable to that of "integration" to characterize what is imperative in a heterogeneous democratic society. The latter notion can be too strong from the point of view of the oppressed and marginalized, that is, when the imperative of integration is understood, not as the duty to share privileges of the better off, but as the obligation of those who have been so far excluded and marginalized to find their place in practices and institutions that have not been traditionally theirs. And it is not clear that the latter can always happen. In particular, it is not likely that it will happen immediately after well-entrenched patterns of segregation are first challenged. Therefore, as mainstream practices and official institutions diversify and become progressively accessible to everybody equally, safe havens should be not only allowed but encouraged and protected, so that those who are still struggling to achieve equal status and to enjoy full agency within society can take refuge. In this sense, it is hard to see historically black colleges as a democratic failure and not as a democratic achievement, although their creation and trajectory have been entangled with anti-integrationist attitudes. It is also hard to see institutions bilingual in English and Spanish (e.g., private businesses such as banks, or educational programs in public schools) as a democratic *problem* (and not as a democratic opportunity) just because they cater primarily to Latinos. Although these institutions may not—at least immediately and directly—serve integration, they facilitate the overall social interaction of the different groups in society, for they advance the educational and financial abilities of the underprivileged so that they can start to interact with members of more privileged groups on a more equal footing.

Throughout her book (2011) Anderson talks about integration as the promotion of intergroup contact (see, for example, p. 21), and she carefully distinguishes integration from assimilation (the former, but not the latter, being

[2] It is important to note here, though, that this danger does not apply to the weak notion of integration that Anderson defends, which is carefully distinguished from *assimilation* precisely on this point. Anderson's notion does not require the loss of group distinctiveness.

compatible with the preservation of group distinctiveness). I have no dispute with this weak sense of integration and it is also what my Imperative of Epistemic Interaction tries to capture. But there is a stronger sense of integration often used in the literature, which requires that our institutions and public spaces lose any form of group specificity—the stronger version of this being the melting-pot model of multiculturalism. Integration—in its different senses—may or may not be advisable; its advisability has to be carefully contextualized and considered from multiple perspectives. In general, "interaction" is a weaker and more basic notion—prior to integration—which calls mainly for communication and cooperation, that is, for developing the ability to share social spaces and practices without ignoring each other, but fully taking into account each other's different experiences, interests, and aspirations. The Imperative of Epistemic Interaction calls for the development of communicative and reactive *habits* that operationalize our responsiveness to diverse and multiple others (no matter how different from ourselves). It calls for the cultivation of *sensibilities* that open ourselves to diverse others cognitively, affectively, and communicatively and enable us to share spaces responsibly and to engage in joint activities. Democratic sensibilities consist in cognitive-affective attitudes that facilitate and promote the capacity to relate, to listen, to feel concerned, and to care for the interests and aspirations of others. The establishment and maintenance of such attitudes require effective communication among diverse publics. And for such effective communication to take place, publics have to be formed and to become able to express themselves; and social sensibilities of openness have to be cultivated for those publics to be listened to and to be responded to properly. Fostering adequate democratic sensibilities involves meeting some minimal requirements on expressibility as well as on receptivity and responsiveness. The *expressibility requirement* demands that the different groups that a social body can contain have the opportunity to coalesce in a public with expressive capacities, so that they can articulate their shared experiences and perspectives. The *responsiveness requirement* demands that the social and epistemic conditions of communication and interaction be such that the expressions of a public have the proper uptake by other publics and by society as a whole.

On the side of expressibility, adequate democratic interaction requires providing spaces and opportunities for group formation, that is, for the development of social movements and the emergence of publics that can articulate their own experiences, interests, and concerns. As Anderson argues, following Dewey, the effective communication about the impact that a social arrangement has on a particular social group "requires that the group organize into an association or party, so that its members can share their experiences and, through discussion, articulate shared complaints and advance proposals to address them" (2006, p. 14). But, as Anderson puts it, "Effective communication of complaints and proposals requires not just that people be free to speak their

minds, but that they be open to listening to others" (Ibid.). This takes us to issues concerning communicative receptivity and uptake. On the side of responsiveness, adequate democratic interaction requires that people take an interest in listening to others, that they develop the requisite sensibility for proper listening, and that they respond to what others say concerning their experiences, interests, and problems. As Anderson suggests, we can draw here on Dewey's concept of "freedom and fullness of communication," which goes well beyond a purely formal and legalistic notion of freedom of speech, placing demands on our cultural habits, attitudes, and daily interactions.[3]

Most of the discussions of this book concerning epistemic injustices will revolve around ways of falling short in these minimal requirements on expressibility and responsiveness. As we shall see, in the hermeneutical and testimonial injustices we encounter in our epistemic interactions, we find specific problems and obstacles that disadvantage subjects and limit their capacities to express concerns and demands, and they also limit their interlocutors' capacities to register, process, and respond to those concerns and demands adequately. The democratic sensibilities we need to cultivate to work toward epistemic justice are sensibilities that enable us to appreciate the epistemic value of dissent, sensibilities that encourage us not only to be open to contestation, but to actively search for dissenting viewpoints and to benefit from critical engagements with them. An epistemic model of democracy that gives centrality to the ever-present possibility of dissent and contestation is what I call a *resistance model* of democracy, which is superior to the consensus model in giving us a powerful rationale for valuing the mutual engagement of diverse perspectives. As Anderson warns us, "Conditioning decisions on the achievement of consensus often leads to undue pressure on and even coercion of dissenting minorities" (2006, p. 16). By valuing agreement over dissent, a consensus model of democratic decision-making runs the risk of suppressing "public airing and responsiveness to the continuing reservations individuals may have about the decision" agreed upon, for the achievement of a consensus is construed as implying that all objections have been met or have been overridden by more weighty considerations (Ibid.). By contrast, in the resistance model, "minority dissent remains open rather than suppressed, reminding us that any given decision remains beset by unresolved objections" (Ibid.). The orientation toward consensus is certainly important in the life of a democracy, but the resistance model teaches us that epistemic friction among diverse perspectives is something broader and more basic than reaching agreement. Such friction is required prior to the formation of a consensus, at

[3] As Dewey put it in "Creative Democracy: The Task before Us," "Merely legal guarantees of the civil liberties of free belief, free expression, and free assembly are of little avail if in daily life freedom of communication, the give and take of ideas, facts, experiences, is choked by mutual suspicion, by abuse, by fear and hatred" (1981, pp. 227–28).

the moment of achieving agreement, and after an agreement has been reached and is implemented. Democratically achieved consensus requires resistance.[4] But resistance is also at the core of other forms of democratic interaction that do not aim at the production of agreements. From the point of view of the resistance model, democratic interactions involve much more than the achievement of agreement. But it is important to note also that the resistance model is not an attempt to value disagreement over consensus, as some agonistic views propose. In fact, the resistance model operates at a different conceptual level than consensus and agonistic views. This model teaches us that democratic interaction is broader and goes deeper than reaching or breaking consensus. For democratic interactions are, first and foremost, *communicative engagements*, and the convergence and divergence of perspectives can be important episodes in those engagements, but they are ultimately mere transitory moments that need to be revisited.

Democratic interaction requires resistance, that is, epistemic friction and the mutual contestation of perspectives. "We want to walk: so we need *friction*. Back to the rough ground!" (1958, §107) As Wittgenstein tells us, in order to properly elucidate our normative activities and to provide normative guidance for our interactions, we should avoid idealizations and go back to the rough ground of our actual practices where we find differently situated knowledges and perspectives—where there is friction. Idealizations do not provide an adequate starting point and a proper level of theorization for philosophical reflection on our practices and social realities. This is carefully avoided in the resistance model I propose. Here too I follow Anderson's epistemic model of democracy, which is a nonideal theory.[5] Dewey's experimentalism provides a perfect exemplar of such nonideal normative theorizing of social practices. As I understand it (and as exemplified by Dewey's social theory), the methodological commitment to the primacy of the nonideal, where there is friction, is a triple commitment. First, it is a commitment to *particularism*, to giving priority to the specificity of particulars, not to abstractions and generalities that divert our attention away from concrete realities. Idealizations tend to be partial and distorting, obscuring the heterogeneity and complexity of actual experiences and concrete practices, which is why they do not provide an adequate standpoint for the diagnosis of social problems and injustices. As Anderson puts it, "When we assess whether a society is deviating from ideal justice, we

[4] As Anderson argues, following Westlund (2003), if the consensus of a group is to be consistent with the autonomy of its members, it "requires some resistance at the individual level to anyone else's proposal, so that the eventual object of joint willing is the product of mutual accommodation and compromise rather than blind subordination" (2006, p. 16).

[5] As she puts it in *The Imperative of Integration*, "This is a work in non-ideal theory. I do not advance principles and ideals for a perfectly just society, but ones that we need to cope with the injustices in our current world, and to move us to something better" (2011, p. 3).

still assess it from the standpoint of representative positions in the ideally just society" (2011, p. 5). As we will discuss later, when it comes to racial injustices, for example, the color-blindness of idealizations can become an important obstacle for acknowledging their very existence: "The principled color-blindness of ideal theory is epistemologically disabling: it makes us blind to the existence of race-based injustice" (2011, p. 6). In the second place, nonideal theory is founded in a commitment to *empiricism and fallibilism*, to the test of experience and the conditionality upon future experiential tests. On this theoretical model, there is never final and absolute proof of the correctness of our norms, for our norms can only be backed up by how they impact the actual experiences of those affected by them. This experimentalist approach does not dispense with ideals, but ideals here are conceived differently: not as ahistorical standards of assessment for any society, but as imagined solutions for particular problems, or as hypotheses. If our hypothetical ideals pass experiential tests, they are not validated once and for all—outside of history, as it were—for, as Anderson puts it, "Circumstances change, and new problems and complaints arise, requiring the construction of new ideals" (Ibid.). Finally, in the third place, the commitment to nonideal theory is also a commitment to *meliorism*, to making things better without being shackled to any particular picture of "the best." Rather than starting from an ideal picture of a problem-free society, nonideal theory starts from the diagnosis of specific problems and complaints in our society, and it sets out to investigate how to address these particular problems. As Anderson sums it up,

> Knowledge of the better does not require knowledge of the best. Figuring out how to address a just claim on our conduct now does not require knowing what system of principles of conduct would settle all possible claims on our conduct in all possible worlds, or in the best of all possible worlds. (2011, p. 3)

This book will not present or rely on a theory of epistemic justice (for Wittgensteinian reasons, I suspend judgment on whether or not there can be a *unified* theory of what is just in *all* our epistemic interactions). Rather, it will offer contextualist elucidations of particular epistemic problems and injustices, some of which are so pervasive to the point of seeming omnipresent. The methodological commitment to the priority of the nonideal is a commitment to the priority of real *in*-justices over ideal justice. If our normative theories should start where we are, in medias res, we should start our theorizing by reflecting on the details of the actual injustices that surround us, rather than by speculating about what perfect justice might be. We need a *theory of injustice* more than a theory of justice. As Anderson puts it, "We need a theory that begins from a structural account of the systematic disadvantages imposed on people" (2011, p. 6). As I will argue below, when it comes to the epistemic domain, the priority of real injustices over ideal justice is crucial, for idealizations

about our epistemic interactions desensitize us about the ubiquitous hermeneutical and testimonial injustices we are surrounded by in our everyday practices, minimizing the importance of the epistemic obstacles and problems that differently situated subjects are differentially exposed to in their daily activities. It is dangerous to indulge in idealizations for the normative elucidation of epistemic activities: when in such elucidations we postulate an ideal case in which there are no preexisting epistemic obstacles or disadvantages, we assume that the normal conditions are conditions of epistemic justice. But why should we assume such a thing? Miranda Fricker, for example, has shown brilliantly that "various degrees of testimonial injustice happen all the time" and, echoing Judith Shklar, she denounces the misconception of thinking "falsely of justice as the norm and injustice as the aberration" (2007, p. 39). As Shklar puts it, "This normal model of justice does not ignore injustice but it does tend to reduce it to a prelude to or a rejection and breakdown of justice, as if injustice were a surprising abnormality" (1990, p. 17). The normalization of a presumed justice and the concomitant abnormalization of injustice have important ideological effects: they contribute to the invisibility of everyday injustices, to the formation of active bodies of ignorance that perpetuate the injustices and desensitize us to the suffering they cause. Just as Shklar argued that injustice is the normal social baseline and efforts toward justice tend to be the exception, Fricker argues that "testimonial injustice is a normal part of discursive life" and "cries of resentment are relatively few and far between" (p. 39). The resistance model of epistemic interaction that I will defend follows this line of theorizing that starts from actual systematic injustices rather than from justice, and proceeds in a nonideal way, that is, in a particularistic, fallibilistic, and melioristic fashion. To further clarify my methodological commitments and my overall theoretical framework, in the next section I will offer a preliminary analysis of the notion of resistance, highlighting some crucial ideas of key thinkers in the philosophical traditions from which I draw: Jane Addams, Ludwig Wittgenstein, and Michel Foucault.

B. Resistance, Perplexity, and Multiperspectivalism

> Where there is power, there is resistance . . . *a multiplicity of points of resistance*: these play the role of adversary, target, support, or handle in power relations. These points of resistance are present everywhere in the power network. Hence there is no single locus of great Refusal, no soul of revolt, source of all rebellions, or pure law of the revolutionary. Instead there is a plurality of resistances, each of them a special case . . . Are there no great radical departures, massive binary divisions, then? Occasionally, yes. But more often one is dealing with mobile and transitory points of resistance, producing cleavages in a society that shifts

> about, fracturing unities and effecting regroupings, furrowing across individuals themselves, cutting them up and remolding them, marking off irreducible regions in them, in their bodies and minds. (Foucault: 1978, pp. 95–6; my emphasis)

As suggested by Foucault, resistance is a complicated and heterogeneous phenomenon that defies unification and explication according to abstract and rigid principles of subversion. Our cognitive, affective, and political lives are permeated by different forms of conformity and resistance that shape our lives in various (and not always fully coherent) ways. Struggles of resistance should be studied in their specificity, but without thereby renouncing investigation of their connections, intersections, and points of convergence and divergence. This book aims to contribute to a better understanding of how our cognitive-affective lives become shaped by systems of oppression and by the different forms of resistance that appear within and around them. My goal is to bring a contextualist perspective to bear on the recent debate concerning epistemologies of injustice. In particular, I try to offer a contextualist and intersectional analysis of distinctive forms of sensitivity and insensitivity, of lucidity and blindness, as they appear in contexts of oppression, trying to shed light on a host of epistemic issues such as the following: the testimonial and hermeneutical injustices produced by heterosexism and racism, the relationship between epistemic vices and virtues and experiences of privilege and oppression, our epistemic responsibilities with respect to self-knowledge and social knowledge, and the crucial mediation of the social imagination in our cognitive-affective lives. Gender and sexual ignorance, racial ignorance, and their interrelations are a central focus of the discussions of this book. I propose to investigate how these bodies of ignorance are produced by systems of oppression, what their ramifications in our social and personal lives are, and what we can do to resist them. Although the focus of this book will be the epistemic side of oppression and resistance, the sociopolitical will be omnipresent and will be explicitly discussed in various sections. Drawing on feminist theory, queer theory, and critical race theory, my polyphonic contextualism will be methodologically promiscuous. The epistemology of resistance defended in this book brings together converging and intersecting contextualist views in European and American philosophy, in particular, Foucaultian, Wittgensteinian, and pragmatist approaches. I will briefly sketch this productive convergence and the uses to which it will be put in the discussions of this book.

Foucault has been widely used in feminist and queer theory. In this Foucaultian literature, we find rich discussions of resistance both as an epistemic strategy and as a political strategy. In *Racism and Sexual Oppression in Anglo-America: A Genealogy* (2009), Ladelle McWhorter has made productive use of the Foucaultian genealogical method as an epistemic and political strategy to provoke "insurrections of subjugated knowledges" that can open up new fronts

in the battles against racism and heterosexism. And in the now classic *Unruly Practices* (1989) Nancy Fraser offered a Foucaultian account of the formation of "oppositional discourses" and "counterhegemonic publics." According to Fraser, needs and experiences are politicized when they become contested across discursive arenas and among resisting publics. Through discursive resistance, distinctive counter-publics have been formed along various axes, such as class, gender, race, sexual orientation, ability, and so on. These counter-publics and their counter-discourses offer resistance against the oppression of hegemonic discursive standpoints by articulating alternative descriptions and interpretations of experiences and needs. It is clear that, for Foucault, discursive resistance can be exerted from a multiplicity of social locations in which differently positioned agents can relate to power in different ways. In order to understand the diversity and heterogeneity of forms of resistance, we need to understand the positionality and relationality of social agents in networks of power relations. Foucault insists that "resistance is never in a position of exteriority in relation to power" and that in order to understand how resistance works, we need to understand "the strictly relational character of power relations" (1978, p. 95). Although this may be obscured by the use of oppositional language by Foucaultians such as Fraser, resistance does not in principle require fully differentiated discourses that oppose each other, for it can be exerted even from within hegemonic discourses and by members of privileged publics. Although not without difficulties, as we shall see, resistance can be found (and should be looked for) in the very entrails of privilege and in mainstream practices and perspectives.

The ability to exert critical resistance both within and around our discursive practices—at their very center as well as at their periphery—has also been stressed by feminist and queer interpretations of the Wittgensteinian view of language-games. As Peg O'Connor (2002) has argued, just like Foucaultian oppositional discourses, Wittgensteinian language-games offer opportunities to subordinated social groups to develop alternative practices where their social identities and perspectives can flourish and they can resist dominant ideologies. As O'Connor puts it in her Wittgensteinian analysis of the queer practices of "coming out" and breaking silences:

> Wittgenstein says in *On Certainty* that a group can use their language game as base from which to combat others (§609). The language games of coming out and breaking silence, with all their attendant activities and newly created recognizable meanings are, in many ways, loci from which to fight against the dominant language games we have all played. (2002, p. 445)

Using Wittgenstein's analogy of language as "an ancient city: a maze of little streets and squares . . . surrounded by a multitude of new boroughs with straight regular streets and uniform houses" (1958, §18), O'Connor argues that "oppositional discourses are, in many ways, the boroughs or suburbs of the

older city," "not completely detached" but "clearly recognizable as different from the city," "newer" and "more planned" (p. 446). This is indeed one form that resistance can take: from the periphery, and as a well-structured and planned effort to produce alternatives. But besides looking into this particular shape and form that resistance can take in our practices of contestation and activism, we also need to look into other varieties of resistance—more spontaneous, more twisted, less planned and intentional (even unconscious). There are many ways in which ordinary people can resist different forms of domination in their daily lives. We need to look for possibilities of resistance in every discursive practice and every social location—in every neighborhood and every street of this imaginary discursive city—in order to identify the wide spectrum of practices of resistance in which epistemic friction can be found. As Naomi Scheman (1997) and other Wittgensteinians—including myself (2006a)—have argued, Wittgenstein offers other resources for resistance besides inventing new meanings or abandoning existing practices. Linguistic resistance can be internal to the oppressive language-games themselves, and it can aim at the subversion of the very normative core of mainstream practices: what Scheman has called "queering the center" and what I describe as "speaking from elsewhere" while remaining within. Our communities of resistance cannot leave the mainstream critically untouched. It is a mistake to think that the forms of exclusion, subordination, and marginalization that we can find in mainstream culture can be resisted only from the outside, and not also from within. The contextualist account of resistance I provide in this book covers cases of internal resistance as well as cases of external resistance, for the multifaceted activity of *resisting* is conceptualized as *contending with*, and not exclusively or fundamentally as *contending against*.

Experiences and practices of resistance should not be understood exclusively, or even primarily, in oppositional terms, as if resisting were always a matter of opposing from the outside, of experiencing a clash of wholly distinct opposing forces. Resistance often takes other phenomenological shapes. It can feel more like being pulled in different directions from the inside, like being torn from within. Experiencing resistance can often be like feeling a rupture that one does not know what to do with (at least initially), like feeling perplexity. I am interested in the experiential and phenomenological aspects of resistance, but I am even more interested in its agential and practical aspects, for resistance is not simply something that happens to us, but it is fundamentally something we do (or fail to do) and for which we have to take responsibility.

Resistant subjects are active subjects, subjects who exert resistance. What are the responsibilities of a resistant subjectivity? And do all subjects have an *obligation to resist*? One of the most central theses of this book will be that those who live under conditions of oppression—however they happen to inhabit contexts of domination (as victim, as oppressor, as a bystander, as both victim and oppressor, etc.)—have an obligation to resist. And when it comes to

epistemic oppression, this obligation to resist leads to many epistemic duties: to fight against ignorance, to know oneself and others in certain respects, to learn and to facilitate the learning of others, to resist epistemic vices and to work toward epistemic virtues, to meliorate epistemic habits and attitudes, and in short, to collaborate in the pursuit of epistemic justice. But I will also argue that this obligation to resist epistemically has to be contextualized, for differently situated subjects have differential *epistemic responsibilities* (different not only in degree, but also in kind). We all share collective responsibilities in meliorating our epistemic life in common and in fighting against the bodies of ignorance bred by relations of domination. But we have differential obligations to resist the forms of epistemic domination that shape our lives depending on how these forms of domination reach our epistemic trajectory and our location within systems of relations, that is, depending on our social positionality and relationality. We should all be alert to avoid possible epistemic vices that arise in contexts of oppression and can vitiate our epistemic interaction, but of course we are differently exposed to those vitiating factors. We should all actively search for opportunities to cultivate epistemic virtues that can meliorate our cognitive-affective habits and attitudes, but of course we have differential access to such opportunities.[6]

My contextualist analysis of the cognitive-affective perspectives afforded by our social positionality and relationality will establish an intimate connection between our sensibilities and our cognitive potential. We develop particular sensibilities as situated agents in social networks who are exposed to specific cognitive-affective structures; and these sensibilities simultaneously constrain and enable our capacities to know ourselves and to know others, and hence our capacities to make distinctive contributions to the melioration of social knowledge and to the fight against ignorance. I will argue that our epistemic sensibilities govern simultaneously our capacities for acquiring self-knowledge and our capacities for acquiring knowledge of others. It will be my contention that our social gaze and our inner gaze work in tandem and deeply affect each other. More specifically, I will elucidate the interrelations between self-knowledge and the social knowledge of others as they work for sexual and racial matters and in the context of well-entrenched bodies of sexual and racial ignorance. I will argue that in contexts of sexual and racial oppression there are cognitive-affective deficits that amount to specific forms of epistemic *insensitivity*: the inability to listen and to learn from others, the inability to call

[6] And as standpoint theory has suggested and I will argue throughout the book, the socially and epistemically privileged are often epistemically underprivileged in having fewer opportunities to develop certain critical epistemic virtues. But this *asymmetry thesis* needs to be carefully formulated and qualified in order to avoid mystifications (such as the romanticizing of oppression) and overstatements (such as conferring automatic epistemic privilege to the oppressed). I will offer detailed discussions of this thesis in chapters 1 and 2.

into question one's perspective and to process epistemic friction exerted from significantly different perspectives. I will argue that racial and sexual insensitivities result as much in lack of knowledge of social realities as in lack of self-knowledge (or knowledge of one's own positionality and relationality with respect to the relevant categories and the relevant forms of oppression). Thus, for example, I will argue that what Charles Mills (2007) has termed *white ignorance*—the recalcitrant, active ignorance of privileged white subjectivities on racial matters—crucially involves both racial self-ignorance and social ignorance of racialized others.

How can we find large-scale systems of oppression in the most familiar and intimate aspects of our epistemic life, within ourselves and our sensibilities? The socio-epistemic analyses of this book draw inspiration from the numerous voices in the women's movement that taught us that the personal is political and the political is personal. These activist voices both laid the foundations for the argument of this book and also performatively exemplify what it means to resist deficient social sensibilities and their blind spots, triggering a process of social learning that benefits us all, for their activism expanded our sensibilities and taught us to pay attention to the interrelations between our public practices and our most intimate feelings, emotions, desires, and beliefs. I will argue that in order to be able to expand and meliorate our social sensibilities, we need to start by exposing ourselves and making ourselves vulnerable, by opening up our perspective to processes of critical scrutiny and resistance, that is, by putting our perspective in communicative interaction with the perspectives of significantly different others so that there can be epistemic friction among perspectives. Hence the crucial importance of the diversity of viewpoints and of their interaction, for only when significantly different perspectives are available and they are allowed to interact so as to learn from each other and to make maximal use of their difference, only then can we have epistemic and political practices that can be self-corrective in a democratic way.

Democratic social interaction requires resistance, but resistance begins *at home*, that is, in the most intimate aspects of our cognitive-affective functioning. Resistance has to begin within ourselves and in the activities in which we feel at home. This is why I will argue that democratic sensibilities that are truly open and responsive to differences, rather than being defensive and self-protecting, must be distrustful and self-questioning. Such democratic sensibilities can be established only when subjects make themselves vulnerable to challenges and become exposed (either by choice or by social design) to processes of self-questioning or *self-estrangement*, that is, processes of deep self-interrogation in which we become strangers to ourselves. Becoming *perplexed* about who we are—that is to say, becoming strangers to ourselves in particular areas of our life and looking at ourselves with fresh eyes—affords us opportunities to interrogate what we find in the most intimate corners of our perspective, and to recognize its

limitations and the possibilities of correction and improvement. In very different ways, queer theory, feminist standpoint theory, and critical race theory teach us the importance of unmasking and undoing the process of social construction of our perspective, of interrupting the flow of familiarity and obviousness, making the familiar unfamiliar and the obvious bizarre. And this critical exercise should not be thought of simply as the quaint activity of some peculiar activists and intellectuals, but rather as a crucial part of the growth and development of critical subjects of knowledge, of subjects who learn how to resist their cognitive-affective limitations and to improve their sensibilities and capacities. We all have a prima facie obligation to undergo a process of *self-estrangement*, to cultivate openness to perplexity and to interrogate received attitudes and habits. If we fail this obligation, the failure of other epistemic responsibilities will ensue and possibilities of critique and resistance will be thwarted.

Perplexity and self-estrangement are of the utmost importance for cognitive, affective, ethical, and political learning; democratic sensibilities depend on them. This intuition is the centerpiece of Jane Addams's plea for a deeply social ethics in *Democracy and Social Ethics* (2002). The different chapters in this often neglected American philosophical classic are structured around different experiences of perplexity, examining the productive ethical use that we can make of these experiences. But what is the connection between perplexity and ethical learning? As Charlene Seigfried (2002) has emphasized, Addams was a pioneer in taking women's experiences and oppressive conditions as central for the development of ethical theory, thus giving robust social content to the pragmatist ethical theory that was emerging at the time in the works of William James and John Dewey. As Seigfried argues, Addams's ethical approach converges with those of Dewey and James in establishing an intimate connection between perplexity and social sympathy in processes of ethical learning. As Seigfried puts it,

> All three [Addams, Dewey, and James] show how social sympathy can be aroused and developed through the *perplexities* we feel in the normal course of everyday life, specifically those caused by the clashes of belief, habits, and interests inevitable in highly diversified societies. (p. xxiii; my emphasis)

The experiential disruptions that arise in interaction with significantly different others are precious opportunities for developing an awareness of our interdependence and a critical consciousness of the limitations of our perspective vis-à-vis others'. By seeking these experiences of perplexity and disruption and using them as a mechanism of learning, we can cultivate a social sensibility that opens our eyes, ears, and hearts to other ways of thinking, feeling, and living. This kind of social learning is, for the pragmatists, the driving force of moral development. As Dewey puts it, "Interest in learning from all the contacts of life is the essential moral interest" (1980, p. 370).

As Seigfried explains, for Addams, "'a perplexity' refers to someone's personal involvement in a situation that baffles and confuses her, because her usual understanding and responses are inadequate to explain or transform a troubling situation" (pp. xxv–xxvi). The perplexed subject is confronted with a difficult existential choice: to continue to hold on to her assumptions or to begin to call them into question. If she chooses the latter, she must "undergo a painful process of rethinking her presuppositions and values" (p. xxvi). For Addams, perplexity is the kind of existential discomfort that goes to the very roots, to the normative grounding of one's life, and constitutes the initial stage of ethical inquiry. As Seigfried puts it, in her discussions of perplexity Addams

> gives a nuanced account of the interplay of personal feelings and objective conditions; of the difficulties involved in responding to other classes, races, and cultures; and of the choice involved in the ways one responds to challenges to accepted beliefs and familiar values." (Ibid.)

Addams explains the productive work and learning processes that can result from the existential disruptions and perplexities experienced by the charity workers she collaborated with in Chicago in the 1920s. Addams criticizes the unexamined racism and classism that distorted the social perceptions of the well-intentioned charity workers. She saw, as a constant source of miscommunication and distorted social perception, the failure to reflect critically on the racial and class gaps that existed between the charity workers and the recipients of that charity in destitute inner-city neighborhoods. This is how Addams describes the perplexity of a reflective charity worker: she "is continually surprised to find that the safest platitude may be challenged" (p. 18); and

> She discovers how incorrigibly bourgeois her standards have been, and it takes but a little time to reach the conclusion that she cannot insist so strenuously upon the conventions of her own class, which fail to fit the bigger, more emotional, and freer lives of working people. (p. 21)

Collaborative processes of ethical and political learning can be prompted by experiences of perplexity of this sort. This is how Seigfried summarizes the kind of learning that Addams saw as required by the proper resolution of these experiences: "What is needed to satisfactorily resolve the perplexity is better insight into the social requirements of a genuine democracy and the implementation of a cooperative experimental approach" (p. xxvii). This also summarizes well the proposals of my own social contextualism in this book.

The cultivation of perplexity that Addams recommends is the cultivation of our openness to being challenged and affected by other experiential perspectives. This critical experiential approach converges with that of Hannah Arendt in *Men in Dark Times* (1965) where she argues, following Lessing, that one of the greatest intellectual, moral, and political failures is to become "immune to

other experiences in the world."[7] Arendt argues that trying to attain "a definitive view of the world" is a vain and dangerous ambition that breeds intolerance and makes social learning processes impossible, for it leads people to "cling firmly to a single possible perspective" and it fosters critical immunity to alternative experiential perspectives. The kind of openness to alternative experiential standpoints that both Addams and Arendt argued for is at the core of the *multiperspectivalism* that I will defend in this book: the imperative to renew our perplexities and to reinvigorate our openness to alternative standpoints is the imperative to constantly expand our personal as well as shared perspectives and sensibilities, our individual and collective imaginings. The centerpiece of my polyphonic and kaleidoscopic social contextualism will be a critical account of social perception and its deficits—of social *blindness*, *numbness*, or *insensitivity*[8]—and of how melioration through the epistemic friction among genuinely different perspectives becomes possible. I will draw from black and Latina feminists and activists to explain how social perception undergirds political action and to explain the social conditions of insurrectionary acts of resistance. Bringing together feminists and queer theorists as different as Linda Alcoff, Elizabeth Anderson, Moira Gatens, María Lugones, and Ladelle McWhorter, I will also explore the role of the *social imagination* in aiding or obstructing the formation of pluralistic communities and open publics, and in facilitating or precluding what I call "beneficial epistemic friction" through critique, resistance, and the cultivation of open-mindedness. How should we use the social imagination so as to become more adept at communicating across differences, achieving the pluralistic communicative sensibilities that Iris Marion Young has argued are fundamental for a vibrant democratic life? I will argue that a kaleidoscopic social imagination can expand social sensibilities and facilitate pluralistic forms of solidarity.

We are interested in practices and habits of resistance because they are the heart and soul of solidarity: "Resistance is connected to solidarity, which is a matter of identifying *with*, rather than *as*" (Scheman: 1997, p. 147). It is in and through resistance that relations of solidarity against domination and across different forms of oppression become possible and effective. It is in and through resistance that we discover new possibilities of social relationality by paying attention to new forms of social identification—understood, following Naomi Scheman (1997), as ways of identifying-with, not of identifying-as. This is

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[7] See especially pages 18–19 of the opening essay, "On Humanity in Dark Times: Reflections on Lessing." There Arendt argues that "thinking for oneself," "independent thinking," is not an activity that the sealed-off individual is capable of. This is a persuasive argument for what I have called the Imperative of Epistemic Interaction.

[8] Although I will continue to use the visual language of *blindness* that is often used in this literature and echoes the classics (such as Du Bois), I will supplement it with the auditory language of *deafness* and I will also use the more general language of becoming cognitively and affectively *numbed* or *insensitive*.

much more than a mere attempt to resuscitate old-fashioned identity politics. The epistemology of resistance I will defend offers a more complex path for our cognitive-affective and sociopolitical melioration. Through practices of resistance we can learn to go beyond the strictures of inherited cognitive and affective habits, and we can learn to envision new cognitive-affective attitudes and orientations toward others. Both our ability and our inability to relate to others (and to particular aspects of ourselves) is mediated by the social imagination, the kind of imagination that opens our eyes and hearts to certain things and not others, enabling and constraining our social gaze. We all have responsibilities toward the pluralization of this social gaze so that we can collectively produce a kaleidoscopic social imagination, a fluid way of imagining ourselves and others in which patterns of relations are constantly emerging and vanishing, seamlessly and ceaselessly, with some relational possibilities giving way to others, constantly resisting the ossification of our categorizations.

Nobody can be exempted from the obligation to resist and to contribute to the formation of a kaleidoscopic social imagination. But, interestingly, those subjects who are often better positioned to exert resistance and to pluralize the imagination (because their experiences have been silenced or rendered opaque, abnormal, or unintelligible) are often the most vulnerable, and we cannot overburden their already precarious agency with the task of pluralizing the social imagination for all of us. On the other hand, the privileged subjects who are less inclined and worse equipped to resist inherited habits of social perception, those who find their experiences and perspectives most obvious and unproblematic, are precisely the ones who should bear a heightened responsibility and should make special efforts to resist and undo the exclusions and marginalizations of the social imagination. As feminist theorists and race theorists have argued in the recent literature, privileged subjects should play a special role in the fight against racism and heterosexism, which should start with their own self-problematization, that is, with the problematization of their social gaze and of their privileged perspectives and privileged lives. However, the shared burdens of fighting epistemic injustices should not disproportionately fall on the shoulders of any single group or particular range of subject positions, but on the entire collective social body. It is of the utmost importance that there be good relations of communication among social groups so that there can be a collective process of learning, in which the epistemic trajectories of differently situated subjects can enrich each other; and subjects can learn to fulfill their epistemic responsibilities, to benefit from the epistemic contributions of others, and to contribute themselves to the enrichment of others. We need a well communicated social body so that we can all share experiences, compare and contrast perspectives, learn about the insights and limitations of differently situated social gazes, and engage in the difficult process of social learning across differences. The analyses and discussions of this book hope to make some contribution to a better understanding of our

shared but nonetheless distinct responsibilities in the collective fight against socio-epistemic oppression and the pursuit of epistemic justice.

C. Overview

The first three chapters of this book articulate and defend the key elements of my view of *epistemic injustice*: chapter 1 focuses on the epistemic virtues and vices that we can find in contexts of oppression; chapter 2 focuses on issues of epistemic authority, credibility, and testimonial injustice; and chapter 3 focuses on silencing and hermeneutical injustice. The last three chapters develop an account of *epistemic responsibility*, first by analyzing its failures and consequences for ethical and political agency (in chapter 4), but later by exploring what it means to assume responsibility for epistemic justice, and by investigating how we can become progressively more responsible through interactive forms of agency (*chained actions*—in chapter 5) and through *resistant* uses of the imagination (in chapter 6). While chapter 4 focuses on epistemic irresponsibility (insensitivity, complicity, and shared responsibility for epistemic injustices), the last two chapters of the book turn to more positive and forward-looking reflections concerning how we can develop epistemically responsible forms of agency that can correct insensitivities and lead to pluralistic democratic sensibilities. In chapters 5 and 6 I argue that the work toward epistemic justice can only be achieved through forms of social interaction that repair neglect and insensitivity, through a sustained social activism that expands people's capacities for feeling concerned, and through imaginative ways of relating to each other and forging solidarities across differences. In what follows I offer a more detailed summary of the contents of each chapter.

Focusing on racial and sexual oppression and their interrelation, chapter 1 provides an analysis of *active* ignorance and of three epistemic vices that support it: epistemic arrogance, laziness, and closed-mindedness (offering an account of how these vices are formed among privileged subjects). I argue that structural active ignorance can be corrected only by developing epistemic virtues such as epistemic humility, curiosity/diligence, and open-mindedness (sketching an account of how these virtues appear among oppressed subjects). I argue that the overcoming of active ignorance requires *beneficial epistemic friction* in interactions with significantly different epistemic others, and I offer two regulative principles for achieving such friction: the *principle of acknowledgment and engagement*, and the *principle of epistemic equilibrium*. In the next chapter I apply these principles and my account of active ignorance to the domain of testimonial injustices.

In chapter 2 I argue that testimonial injustice involves a lack of proportionality in the appraisals of epistemic qualities such as credibility. According to my proportional view, an epistemic appraisal is always comparative and contrastive

and, therefore, it always concerns more than the particular subject(s) under consideration given the comparison and contrast classes that support the appraisal. In my view, epistemic appraisals always contain an element of social systematicity, even when they appear to be quite isolated, because they operate against the background of a system of relations and they involve interpersonal perceptions that are mediated by the social imagination. According to my argument, testimonial injustices concern not only the epistemic deficits that oppressed subjects have to endure, but also the epistemic excesses (excessive authority and credibility, excessive self-confidence, etc.) that privileged subjects enjoy and that spoil their epistemic character. I further argue that the epistemic vices of the privileged tend to produce a particular form of ignorance which I referred to as *meta-blindness* or *meta-insensitivity*—a cognitive and affective numbing that can be described as *insensitivity to insensitivity*. In my view, the problem of meta-blindness calls for a cognitive-affective restructuring, which involves a process with multiple and interrelated normative dimensions: an epistemic, ethical, and political re-education that touches on all aspects of our life.

The discussion of meta-insensitivity is continued in chapter 3 through an analysis of social silences and hermeneutical injustices. This chapter develops a contextualist approach to hermeneutical injustice that is pluralistic, interactive, and dynamic. First, I offer an expansion of Miranda Fricker's analysis of *silencing*, arguing that we need to pay attention to the performative and pragmatic aspects of communicative dynamics to fully appreciate the patterns of silence that are part of epistemic injustice in general and of hermeneutical injustice in particular. In the second place, I argue that a more deeply pluralistic account of hermeneutical justice is needed, one that takes into account the communicative dynamics of a plurality of publics that are internally heterogeneous and contain multiple voices and perspectives. Finally, I use my polyphonic contextualism to expand Fricker's view of what counts as *virtuous interpretative responsiveness* and to offer a more robust notion of epistemic responsibility with respect to hermeneutical justice. This notion lays out the foundation of the social connection model of shared epistemic responsibility I develop in the next three chapters.

Chapter 4 elucidates the relationship between responsible agency and knowledge. Pace Akeel Bilgrami, I argue that responsible agency requires only minimal self-knowledge that need not include explanatory knowledge of the mental causation of one's actions. But, on the other hand, I also argue that responsible agency requires more than minimal self-knowledge: it requires minimal social knowledge of others and minimal empirical knowledge of the world. I subsume these epistemic implications of responsible agency under what I call the *thesis of cognitive minimums*: namely, that responsible agency requires that one be minimally knowledgeable about one's mind, about the social world, and about the empirical realities one encounters. Focusing on the cognitive minimums of self-knowledge and social knowledge, I go on to argue

that there are different ways in which we may partake in shared culpable ignorance about nonmainstream subjects, groups, and experiences; and I begin to develop an account of shared responsibility with respect to epistemic justice for the correction of blind spots and social insensitivities associated with racism and (hetero)sexism.

Chapter 5 focuses on how to fulfill epistemic responsibilities under conditions of oppression and, in particular, how to develop lucidity precisely where social blind spots exist. In this chapter I analyze a particular kind of lucidity characteristic of oppressed subjectivities: a *meta-lucidity* produced by epistemic friction. I address the issue of how to promote this kind of meta-lucidity for differently situated subjects, including those in a position of privilege whose life experiences may not have put them in the best position to become lucid. In the case of racial oppression and racial ignorance, I discuss how "white ignorance" can be corrected so that racially privileged subjects can also become lucid with respect to race and improve both their self-knowledge and their knowledge of racial others. I connect these issues with the larger and more challenging issue of how to remove epistemic obstacles and achieve cognitive melioration not only for particular individuals and groups, but for the entire social fabric and in a durable way that will affect future generations. I discuss the phenomenon of what I call *epistemic heroes*, that is, extraordinary subjects who under conditions of epistemic oppression are able to develop epistemic virtues with a tremendous transformative potential. I argue that epistemic heroes should be understood as emblems: figures who become emblematic because they come to epitomize the daily struggles of resistance of ordinary people. According to my contextualism, the transformative impact of performance that we consider heroic is crucially dependent on social networks and daily practices of resistance in which the performance in question is taken up or reenacted (what I call the phenomenon of *echoing*). Detaching the contributions that epistemic heroes make toward social justice from the social support that precedes and follows their actions is, I suggest, a dangerous trap that the dominant individualism in Western cultures sets up for social movements of resistance. I offer two examples of cultural icons of resistance who appear to be "epistemic heroines," one from the history of Latina feminism (Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz) and the other from the history of the civil rights movement (Rosa Parks), emphasizing in both cases how the heroic figure becomes part of ongoing daily practices of resistance.

Chapter 6 brings together many of the discussions of the book that converge on the key relationship between the imagination and epistemic sensitivity or insensitivity. This chapter examines the role of the imagination both in the production and in the prevention of social harms. Different ways of imagining can sensitize or desensitize people to human experiences; they can make people feel close or distant to others; and they can create or sever social bonds, affective ties, and relations of empathy or antipathy, solidarity or lack

of solidarity. Stigmatizing ways of imagining play a crucial role in causing expressive and epistemic harms—and more indirectly other kinds of harm as well—by distorting and excusing the suffering of some, making it appear as if it were tolerable or even necessary. But *resistant* ways of imagining can contest exclusions and stigmatizations, and they can help us become sensitive to the suffering of excluded and stigmatized subjects. I argue that in order to develop pluralistic democratic sensibilities, we need to cultivate a resistant imagination that is polyphonic and experimentalist. I conclude by developing a conception of *network solidarity* grounded in a kaleidoscopic social imagination, arguing that we have the shared obligation to exercise resistant ways of imagining that make us sensitive to symbolic exclusions, expressive harms, and epistemic mistreatments. I use the women's movement as a model for the increasing pluralization of a public which, through the resistant imaginations of its heterogeneous members, has learned to develop a kaleidoscopic social sensibility.

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Active Ignorance, Epistemic Others, and Epistemic Friction

> The capacity to give knowledge to others is one side of the many-sided capacity so significant in human beings: namely, the capacity for reason. . . . No wonder . . . that in contexts of oppression the powerful will be sure to undermine the powerless in just that capacity, for it provides a direct route to undermining them in their very humanity.
>
> —FRICKER, *EPISTEMIC INJUSTICE, 2007, p. 44*

In a situation of oppression, epistemic relations are screwed up. Inequality is the enemy of knowledge: it handicaps our capacity to know and to learn from each other. Social injustices breed epistemic injustices; or rather, these two kinds of injustice are two sides of the same coin, always going together, being mutually supportive and reinforcing each other. This is the premise of this book. It is also a conclusion supported by empirical studies in psychology and in the educational sciences; and it is also an idea amply discussed in the recent philosophical literature on social knowledge, especially in normative epistemology,[1] feminist theory, and critical race theory. Racist and sexist ideologies make us all cognitively worse off: they instill distrust; they lead people to underestimate or overestimate their cognitive capacities; and they are the breeding ground for all kinds of biases and prejudices that distort perception, judgment, and reasoning. Social injustices typically have a negative impact on our epistemic relations to each other (deteriorating epistemic trust, endangering impartiality, weakening the credibility people ascribe to each other, etc.), and also on our epistemic relations to ourselves (undermining our epistemic confidence, self-trust, and self-reliance; compromising our epistemic goals and projects; weakening our motivation for learning and cognitive improvement, etc.). Members of groups that have been systematically disadvantaged and mistreated (e.g., women and racial minorities) are often unfairly depicted as intellectually inferior, mischaracterized as lacking

[1] See especially the different essays in Haddock, Millar, and Pritchard (eds.), *Social Epistemology* (2010).

certain cognitive capacities, or simply given less authority and credibility than members of other groups. And it is not uncommon for members of unjust societies to have distorted images of themselves as knowers: for members of a privileged elite to overestimate their cognitive powers, or for members of underprivileged groups to underestimate their capacities, thus interiorizing a superiority or inferiority complex, with negative epistemic consequences in each case. As a result of social injustices, people are prone to have important epistemic deficits that have ramifications in multiple aspects of their life. In particular, people tend to lack knowledge of themselves and of others around them, and such a lack of personal and interpersonal knowledge affects their capacity to impart knowledge to others and to receive knowledge from others—their capacity to hear and to be heard correctly.

People's participation in cognitive activities is often impaired by epistemic distortions and biases that limit their capacity to learn, to teach, and to engage in joint epistemic projects. In this chapter and the next I will focus especially on a particular kind of epistemic cooperation: testimony. Following the trend in the recent literature,[2] I will use a very broad definition of *testimony*, as any kind of telling in and through which the expression and transmission of knowledge becomes possible. Testimonial exchanges are those in which communicators participate as knowers and possible epistemic benefits can be obtained. These exchanges can be more or less explicit, more or less formal and structured, and more or less articulated (ranging from silences and inchoate expressions to sophisticated propositional and discursive structures). Testimonial knowledge can be obtained through a wild variety of interactions: speakers engaged in conversation, writers and readers exchanging texts, artists and audiences sharing symbolic constructions, people giving signals to each other in a shared situation or jointly witnessing an event, and so on. This chapter will lay out the general framework I will use to discuss how biases and epistemic distortions created and sustained by oppression affect the production and transmission of knowledge and ignorance, especially through the multifarious forms of testimonial exchanges that we can find in everyday practices.

We are all affected by the epistemic obstacles and distortions that arise in situations of oppression. But differently situated groups and subjects have different epistemic predicaments: their epistemic deficits are different, and their resources to overcome these deficits and to resist dominant ideologies are also different. *Epistemic oppression is not an equal opportunity institution: it affects all of us, but not all of us equally*. I will discuss how differently situated subjects and groups accrue different epistemic gains and losses, and how the epistemic advantages and disadvantages become distributed among members of society. Epistemic advantages and disadvantages, fortunately, do not correlate perfectly

[2] See Fricker (2007), especially page 60.

with non-epistemic forms of privilege and oppression. Although it is certainly true that the economically and sociopolitically privileged enjoy epistemic benefits that more disadvantaged members of society do not, it is not the case that the economically and sociopolitically privileged accumulate only epistemic benefits. The epistemic advantages of the privileged tend to be rather explicit: access to information, access to educational institutions, capacity to disseminate knowledge and to command epistemic authority, having a credible voice, and so on. Some of the epistemic disadvantages of the oppressed are equally obvious and well known; they are in fact the mirror image of the advantages just listed (lack of access to information and to educational institutions, obstacles or prohibitions against the dissemination of knowledge, lack of a credible voice and authority, etc.). But critics in race theory and feminist theory have shown that the situation is more complicated than it may seem, for privileged elites also have epistemic disadvantages, whereas oppressed subjects (or their out-of-the-mainstream standpoints) can enjoy some epistemic advantages. Race theorists and feminist theorists have identified the blind spots of those in privileged positions and some important epistemic advantages of those who have been marginalized in, and often excluded from, epistemic practices. In the next two sections I will offer a preliminary analysis of the epistemic disadvantages of the privileged and the epistemic advantages of the oppressed. This analysis will set the stage for my argument for the crucial importance of *epistemic counterpoints* and for my proposal of the regulative principles of *epistemic friction*, which I develop in the last section of this chapter (section 1.3). Further details of my account of the advantages and disadvantages of differently situated subjects and their perspectives will be provided in later chapters where I elucidate positive and negative *epistemic resistances* (resistances to knowledge and to ignorance) and how they can contribute to maintain epistemic oppression, or to fight against it.

The epistemic disadvantages of the privileged that I am interested in identifying are not external or accidental disadvantages that those in a position of power may have, but rather, epistemic flaws that are grounded in the very character of those subjects, being part and parcel of their personality structure and constitutive of the social identity they have acquired. It follows from this that for these subjects to overcome these flaws, they have to change themselves; and, as we will see, this complex process of self-transformation (a deep restructuring of the self that requires the development of new habits and the destruction of old ones) requires also a process of social change. An epistemic predicament that is (or becomes) a character flaw is what in virtue epistemology[3] would be

[3] Virtue epistemology can be traced back to Aristotle's account of intellectual virtues. For an Aristotelian account of epistemic virtues, see Zagzabski (1996). Different approaches to virtue epistemology in the contemporary scene are articulated and defended in Fairweather and Zagzabski (2001).

called an *epistemic vice*: a set of corrupted attitudes and dispositions that get in the way of knowledge. On the other hand, an *epistemic virtue* is a character trait that constitutes an epistemic advantage for the individual who possesses it and for those who interact with him or her: roughly, a set of attitudes and dispositions that facilitate the acquisition and dissemination of knowledge. Since I am interested in offering a normative elucidation of the cognitive psychology of differently situated subjects and not in a list of all the advantageous or disadvantageous factors that may play a role in their epistemic agency, the advantages and disadvantages that I will discuss will be epistemic virtues and vices. My examination of these virtues and vices will use a developmental approach. What are the epistemic vices that the better-off of society can (or even tend to) develop? And what are the epistemic virtues that the worse-off of society can (or even tend to) develop? My account of the epistemic vices of the privileged and the epistemic virtues of the oppressed will require many qualifications that will be issued piecemeal as the account progresses. Hopefully, these qualifications will succeed in avoiding the romanticizing of oppressed subjects and the demonizing of their oppressors at the epistemic level. Indeed, as we will see, privileged subjects can have epistemic virtues as well as vices, and oppressed subjects epistemic vices as well as virtues. Moreover, the epistemic vices of the privileged and the epistemic virtues of the underprivileged are not their exclusive property; differently positioned subjects may have them as well. But, as we will see, these epistemic character traits do have a distinctive sociogenesis for subjects who occupy a particular social position. There are epistemic virtues and vices with distinctive lines of social development, and all of us, from our own social positionality, can learn some lessons from an examination of these epistemic character traits and their formation.

1.1. Active Ignorance and the Epistemic Vices of the Privileged

Those in a position of power tend to be better off. Is that also true epistemically? Perhaps. The most powerful classes in society certainly enjoy important cognitive benefits. But could these benefits sometimes be too much? Could the privilege of knowing (or always being presumed to know), of always being heard as a credible speaker, of always commanding cognitive authority, sometimes spoil people? To be conceited (epistemically or otherwise) is not good. To overestimate one's powers (epistemic or otherwise) can get one in trouble. Those who grow used to carrying with them the presumption of knowing, of speaking authoritatively, of not being cognitively suspect, have but rare opportunities to find out their own limitations. Those who are epistemically spoiled have a hard time learning their mistakes, their biases, and the constraints and presuppositions of their position in the world and their perspective. Those who are so spoiled are in danger of becoming know-it-alls, of thinking themselves

cognitively superior. This kind of cognitive self-indulgence or cognitive superiority complex is what I will call *epistemic arrogance*. Epistemic arrogance is only one of the central vices that can be characteristic of privileged subjects. This is not a flaw that is always present in the cognitive psychology of the powerful and privileged. But those in a position of power are certainly more at risk of developing this flaw (more on this later). There are other epistemic vices that privileged subjects are more likely to develop than underprivileged subjects. I will not provide an exhaustive list of such vices, but I will identify a few central ones with large consequences that affect most aspects of one's socially mediated cognitions. Epistemic vices (such as epistemic arrogance) are flaws that are not incidental and transitory, but *structural and systematic*: they involve attitudes deeply rooted in one's personality and cognitive functioning. Epistemic vices are composed of attitudinal structures that permeate one's entire cognitive life: they involve attitudes toward oneself and others in testimonial exchanges, attitudes toward the evidence available and one's assessment of it, and so on. These vices affect one's capacity to learn from others and from the facts; they inhibit the capacity of self-correction and of being open to corrections from others (which requires some amount of epistemic humility and open-mindedness). In short, these vices are deep and serious flaws in epistemic character that limit the subject's learning capacities and contributions to the pursuit of knowledge, and therefore they also damage the social knowledge available and harm the chances for epistemic improvement of the subject's community.

Epistemic arrogance is one of the obvious ways in which the powerful and privileged can be spoiled and come to exhibit a cognitive immaturity that—in some radical cases—can even become pathological, namely, when the subject becomes absolutely incapable of acknowledging any mistake or limitation, indulging in a delusional cognitive omnipotence that prevents him from learning from others and improving. Although the pathological version of epistemic arrogance in this extreme form is perhaps rare, it does indeed exist and it can provide a paradigmatic example of this vice. It can be found, for example, in Alexis de Tocqueville's vivid psychological picture of the US slaveholders of the 1830s.[4] Epistemic arrogance, I contend, is an important brushstroke of this powerful psychological picture. Tocqueville (1990) tells us how, from early infancy, the white Southerner learns to become "a domestic dictator," and that "the first habit which he contracts is that of ruling *without resistance*" (p. 394; my emphasis).[5] An important part of this "ruling without resistance" is not being called into question in one's opinions, that is, having

[4] Tocqueville's racial discussions and psychological pictures of the master and slave mentalities have been discussed by contemporary race theorists. See Sullivan (2006), pages 25–27, and Lucius Outlaw's essay in Sullivan and Tuana (2007).

[5] Sullivan's analysis called my attention to this passage. See her reading in Sullivan (2006), page 26.

an undisputed cognitive authority. Thinking whatever one wants to think, without resistance, does not lead to the development of good epistemic habits.

In the extreme case, reality in its entirety can be perceived by the subject as being at his disposal and at his will, as of his own making. This arrogant and narcissistic perspective can even be linked to an interesting version of skepticism about the external world: a version in which the external world has been swallowed up by the all-encompassing perspective of the arrogant subject who does not recognize any other authoritative perspective. But less dramatically, letting one's perspective go unchecked results in an unavoidable, mundane accumulation of oversights, errors, biased stereotypes, and distortions. In this way, racist and sexist biases become undetectable and incorrigible blind spots, for when the subjects who have inherited them become insensitive to contrary evidence and to alternative viewpoints, they are unequipped to detect and correct those biases in their perspective. Enjoying too much cognitive esteem—having an unquestioned epistemic reputability—results in one's epistemic perspective and agency becoming so slanted that one has effectively given up the pursuit of knowledge for lack of impartiality and objective access to the world. When whatever one says, goes—because one's word is the law or the truth others are bound to uphold and abide by—there is a complete lack of resistance from the world and from others that gets in the way of knowledge acquisition, that is, in the way of discovering facts without prejudging, of articulating and justifying one's claims properly, of responding to objections responsibly, of being genuinely open to contrary evidence, and so on. In short, becoming immune to contestation and, therefore, epistemically arrogant is not good cognitive policy.

But the powerful can be spoiled not only by enjoying in a disproportionate way the privilege of knowing (or, rather, of being assumed to know), but also by having the privilege of not knowing or of not needing to know. Sometimes there are entire domains that those in a position of privilege do not need to familiarize themselves with. For example, traditionally, members of the upper classes as well as men of all classes (at least until recently) did not have to concern themselves with the minutiae of the domain of domesticity. Not having to do much about housecleaning, meal preparation, the care of children, and so on certainly freed people's time and cognitive energy so that they could do other things, learn other things, and familiarize themselves with other domains. But this epistemic neglect for the domestic also produced some cognitive limitations and cognitive dependencies on others when it came to the domestic aspects of daily life. These cognitive dependencies and limitations have been investigated by feminist theorists and race theorists.[6] To an important extent,

[6] These theorists have also emphasized the corresponding epistemic advantages accrued by those who are forced to do housework and come to develop interesting forms of domestic expertise that can have important ramifications for what one can know in many areas of one's life. See Allison Wylie (2003).

how things were done in the household were out of the control of subjects who, no matter how powerful, ignored the details of domestic arrangements. Another area that is also sometimes put out of the cognitive reach of powerful elites is the domain of the mechanisms of oppression that create marginalization, subjugation, and social death[7]—including physical extermination, as in the case of genocide. Although the machinery in charge of the discipline and punishment of the oppressed is certainly in the hands of those in power, its day-to-day operations—and sometimes even the machinery itself—are not always rendered visible to all who occupy a position of power. In fact, in some cases, especially those in which the oppressive mechanisms are particularly violent (as in systematic torture or genocide), the machinery of oppression is rendered *invisible*: it is literally put out of sight to protect some members of the privileged class, either because they are depicted as unable to handle it, or just to spare them unnecessary "troubles." Thus, despite their greater access to the facts of social life, privileged subjects often ignore the most violent and hard-to-swallow aspects of social confrontation. Those with enormous amounts of power can sometimes be quite ignorant of the violence committed to maintain their privilege, and can be quite genuinely surprised when they find out facts about the oppression of which they are the main beneficiaries. But it is not just these particular bodies of ignorance that I am interested in (ignoring the domestic, or ignoring social violence, for example). Rather, I am interested in exposing the cognitive attitudes that support these forms of privileged ignorance, the epistemic vices that privileged subjects develop to protect themselves. And the main epistemic vice that results from the privilege of not needing to know is a lack of curiosity about those areas of life or those social domains that one has learned to avoid or not to concern oneself with. This socially produced and carefully orchestrated lack of curiosity is what I will call *epistemic laziness*.

We all feel lazy on occasion; we can all lack the motivation to find out about certain things—in fact, only a superhuman knower could be always ready to embark on every possible discovery journey that comes her way. But epistemic laziness can become a serious problem. It can be said to be a blameworthy cognitive problem when it becomes a habit. A habitual lack of epistemic curiosity atrophies one's cognitive attitudes and dispositions. Continual epistemic neglect creates blinders that one allows to grow around one's epistemic perspective, constraining and slanting one's vantage point. As we shall see, responsible epistemic agency requires a minimum of diligence, because knowledge requires work and its acquisition will not happen without the active participation of the

[7] I borrow the notion of social death from Orlando Patterson (1982) to refer to slavery, servitude, and other ways of curtailing rights that diminish and even destroy one's status as a social actor and a full member of society.

knower. Becoming lazy is letting oneself go epistemically; and it damages the objectivity of one's perspective and limits one's epistemic agency. These are also the immediate consequences of epistemic arrogance I just highlighted. The epistemic vice of laziness converges with that of arrogance in seriously compromising one's learning potential and contributions to knowledge. Like epistemic arrogance, epistemic laziness also has a negative impact not only on the subject's cognitive perspective, but also on the cognitive perspectives of those around the subject and on the social knowledge that becomes available or unavailable to the relevant communities. Arrogance and laziness support and reinforce each other, individually contributing to the deterioration of the epistemic character of the subject and jointly producing epistemic injustices that ultimately affect all members of society. We need to add a third element to this preliminary sketch of the central vices of the socially spoiled and unvirtuous epistemic agent.

Social agents can be ignorant in many ways. As we just saw, sometimes there is ignorance out of luxury—when one does not need to know. But sometimes there is also ignorance out of necessity—when one needs not to know.[8] There is *not needing to know* and there is *needing not to know*. The cognitive predicament of the privileged involves, in some cases, a not needing to know that leads to epistemic laziness, but it also involves, in other cases, a needing not to know that creates blind spots of a different kind: not just areas of epistemic neglect, but areas of an intense but negative cognitive attention, areas of epistemic hiding—experiences, perspectives, or aspects of social life that require an enormous amount of effort to be hidden and ignored. Ignorance in these cases functions as a defense mechanism that is used to preserve privilege. This kind of avoidance mechanism leads to the third central epistemic vice that can often be found among the privileged: *closed-mindedness*. In our epistemic lives, we all have things we would rather avoid: things that are hard to hear, things that are difficult to accept or even to acknowledge. We are all closed-minded on occasion; and it would be inhuman to expect that people be open-minded in every respect and in an absolute way. But when one's mental processing remains systematically closed to certain phenomena, experiences, and perspectives, come what may, and that closed-mindedness erodes reliability, epistemic trust, and one's general capacity to learn, closed-mindedness has become an epistemic vice, that is, a structural and systematic flaw of one's

[8] There are indeed many other forms of ignorance that could be added here. For example, we could talk about the ignorance that arises *out of desire*, that is, when one simply wishes or chooses not to know. A volitional element may be involved in the ignorance motivated by need (i.e., wanting to ignore) or by lack of need (i.e., not wanting to know); but certain volitions (independently of particular epistemic needs) may also give rise to a distinctive kind of ignorance. Be this as it may, in this discussion I am only interested in the contrast between the ignorance that arises from epistemic needs (needing not to know) and the ignorance that arises from lack of epistemic need (not needing to know).

epistemic character. Epistemic closed-mindedness can be very narrowly focused, targeting very specific experiences and perspectives that one's mind becomes closed off to. But it usually involves the lack of openness to a whole range (no matter how broad or narrow) of experiences and viewpoints that can destabilize (or create trouble for) one's own perspective. Among the obvious examples of closed-mindedness, we can mention the white supremacist who has deemed the voices and perspectives of members of other racial groups as unworthy of epistemic respect and, therefore, is not open to listen to them and to learn from them; or the sexist man who systematically undermines the epistemic authority of women, gives them no credibility and pathologizes their perception, reasoning, and testimony (depicting them as irrational or hysterical, for example). But closed-mindedness can be an epistemic vice that becomes narrowly circumscribed in a much more specific way: for example, having one's mind closed off to the evidence surrounding a particular historical event (such as a genocide), or a particular set of experiences (such as the suffering of victims of date rape). The blindness to practices of social violence (such as torture or genocide) mentioned above can in some cases be produced out of epistemic laziness, but it can also be produced out of closed-mindedness: as a result of an active effort not to see, no matter what the evidence may be; as a result of a constant distortion and redescription that leads the subject to be open only to the denial of the phenomenon in question. It is the latter form of blindness that we typically have in mind when we talk about subjects and groups being "in denial" about certain things—such as, for example, the Armenian genocide, the systematic practices of torture during the Bush administration, the cruel exploitation of illegal immigrants along the Southern border of the United States, and so on.

Is closed-mindedness more likely to appear among the privileged? Does it find a particular form of genesis in the processes of socialization of the upper classes?[9] As a defense mechanism, those in a position of privilege are often encouraged to hide their heads in the sand like ostriches with respect to certain aspects, presuppositions, or consequences of the oppression that sustains their privilege. They need to ignore certain social realities. They need to live without having certain truths present in their minds. They need to avail themselves of blinders so that they do not have to take into account certain things and certain perspectives. This form of cognitive self-protection that constitutes closed-mindedness is typically not erected openly and consciously: that

[9] John Dewey was among those philosophers who argued that, at the social level, there is an innate form of closed-mindedness that appears in the shape of a natural tendency to fear the foreign and unfamiliar ("the distinctive aversion of mankind to what is new and unusual"). He linked this "natural tendency" to xenophobia and racism. For an illuminating discussion of Dewey's view and for arguments against the analysis of racism as a mere outgrowth of this native tendency, see Sullivan (2006), pages 33–43.

is, people do not tell themselves "Let us make ourselves blind to this or that" or "Let us ignore these uncomfortable truths that can undermine our privilege." Closed-mindedness as an avoidance strategy is typically an unconscious defense mechanism. It does not result from a decision or a conscious effort to ignore, but from a socialization that leads one to be insensitive to certain things and immune to certain considerations. One of the central goals of this book is to explore the implicit attitudes and unconscious habits that support the kind of closed-mindedness that protects privilege. But interestingly, this kind of closed-mindedness has become an explicit part of the social and political strategies to deal with oppression. An illustration can be found in the liberal strategies with respect to racial and sexual differences in American culture and politics: I am referring to the ideologies of *color-blindness*[10] *and gender-blindness*.

I will not focus on the legal, sociopolitical, and institutional aspects of ideologies of color-blindness[11] and gender-blindness. Rather, I will focus on the interpersonal dimension of color-blindness and gender-blindness, that is, on how this alleged blindness figures in face-to-face interactions and on its cognitive and affective aspects. It is interesting to find so much social encouragement not to pay attention to skin color and gender in a culture that seems obsessed with the racial signifiers of the body and the markers of masculinity and femininity. What does it mean today (or worse yet, in the 1980s and 1990s) not to perceive color or gender in one's social interactions? And why should anybody think that such blindness constitutes a cognitive and ethical achievement? Consider the following claims: "When I look at you, I do not see gender: I do not see a woman." "When I look at you, I do not see color: I do not see a black person." Is that a compliment? It appears to be more a reflexive remark about the perceiver than a remark about the object perceived. But although

[10] The ideology of color-blindness has been recently discussed by prominent race theorists such as Linda Alcoff (2006) and Patricia Williams (1997). It will be discussed in later chapters, esp. in 5.2.

[11] Color-blindness has figured prominently in discussions of racial issues in legislation, social policy, and institutional arrangements (such as the educational system). From Frederick Douglass to Martin Luther King, key African-American thinkers have argued that the ideal of color-blindness can play an important role in the struggle for racial justice. From Justice Marshall Harlan to David Hollinger, liberal thinkers have thought of color-blindness as required by procedural conceptions of justice according to which justice must be administered *blindly*, that is, by treating everybody equally irrespective of gender, race, ethnicity, and so on. For a rich discussion of the different ideologies of color-blindness in the United States, see chapter 2 of Ronald Sundstrom (2008). More recently, Anderson (2011) has discussed color-blindness both as an ideal and as a policy, showing that it is conceptually confused (when different concepts of race are taken into account), empirically misguided (when we consider the evidence about the role of racial differences in our actual lives), and lacks a morally coherent rationale (see chapter 8). Anderson acknowledges that color-blindness can be "a valid ideal," but her arguments persuasively show that this ideal "has no direct application in our nonideal world," and that it may even be the case that the best way to achieve that ideal would be "to adopt race-conscious integrative policies" (2011, p. 156).

there is indeed a certain amount of reflexivity in this attempt to develop epistemic appreciation for one's blindness, there is also a distinctive lack of reflection: the subject disregards the presuppositions of his or her own perspective and its relation to the perspective of others as genderized and racialized subjects. Color- and gender-blindness require being actively and proudly ignorant of social positionality, which involves a double epistemic failure: a failure in self-knowledge and a failure in the knowledge of others with whom one is intimately related. These two failures go together because the lack of familiarity and critical awareness of one's social positionality involves not knowing oneself in relation to one's relevant others, that is, not knowing how one's perspective in the world positions itself vis-à-vis differently situated others and their perspectives.

"When I look at you, I do not see color or gender." What kind of claim is this? And could it ever be made proudly? If so, under what conditions could someone become convinced that blindness is a cognitive or ethical achievement of some sort? Perhaps the blind subject who takes pride in not seeing color or gender in others could be calling attention to aspects of social perception that we are better off without because they distort interpersonal relations: "Others see you through racial or gender stereotypes; I do not." Racist and sexist prejudices operate in such a way that people who see through them perceive others as inferior in particular respects. We are certainly better off without such prejudices; but unfortunately they do not disappear by fiat. And note that the complete refusal to see color or gender in a racist or sexist society involves implicitly the refusal to acknowledge the force of racist and sexist prejudices and their insidious impact on interpersonal dynamics: "I do not see you as affected by these prejudicial stereotypes, and my social perceptions and social relations are unaffected by them." In other words, the disavowal of racialized or genderized perception involves distancing oneself from the social reality of racism and sexism, and failing to properly acknowledge their influence on social cognition.[12]

Color- and gender-blindness often function as naïve disavowals of sexism and racism. Their naïveté consists in assuming that racism and sexism are ideologies that can be simply rejected by choosing what we see, as if our genderized and racialized habits of seeing gender and racial markers could simply be rejected by a volitional act that goes against personal training histories and cultural tendencies. It is very telling that "I do not see gender" typically means, "I do not see you as a woman," and "I do not see race" typically means, "I do

[12] Of course racial and gendered seeing involves more than merely negative social perceptions. As Alcoff (2006) suggests, racial and gender identities provide complex interpretative horizons that embodied subjectivities use to navigate the world and make sense of their experiences and that of others.

not see you as a racial minority." We would be dealing with a different scenario and a different dynamics if the color- and gender-blindness were directed at a privileged subject: "I do not see you as a man", or "I do not see you as white." In this case the object of epistemic hiding would be privilege. It is not accidental that the proud proclamation of color- and gender-blindness is often used with respect to oppressed genderized and racialized subjects, for it is used as a denial or disavowal of negative bias and prejudice, that is, to distance oneself from racist and sexist ideologies and social discrimination. But presumably those who do not see gender and racial differences do not see sexual and racial privilege either; and, therefore, their blindness is a form of inattentiveness not only to social stigmatization, but also to privilege: they do not *see* (or fail to pay attention to) how masculinity and whiteness can operate as a locus of privilege in their lives or that of others.

Gender- and color-blindness are forms of active ignorance supported by the epistemic vices we have discussed. Gender- and color-blind subjects tend to arrogantly assume that there is nothing to see, that those aspects of identity can play no role or have no significance, no matter what others see. These subjects also become epistemically lazy, because their pronouncements about what is there to see are prior to and independent of empirical findings, and they express an attitude that blocks questions and empirical explorations. And, finally, these subjects become closed-minded: they close their minds to certain possibilities no matter how strong the social and subjective evidence for the relevance of these considerations happens to be.

What kind of position does the subject occupy while treating others as genderless and colorless subjects? What kind of relationality does she/he/(it?) enact? Is the subject genderless and colorless? The idea of a genderless and colorless subject remains a *social fiction*[13] today and one that runs contrary to our social practices. This fiction seems to be particularly dangerous in a society (such as the United States) in which the mechanisms of social recognition (our social perceptions and imaginings) are so heavily genderized and racialized. This fiction seems to be doing a lot of ideological work, a lot of covering-up and blocking of social scrutiny. Even now that a culture of recognizing and celebrating differences seems to be flourishing, there are still those who congratulate themselves for their color- or gender-blindness as an accomplishment others should aspire to achieve. But what does that mean? What does this "blindness" involve? Is it a pretend-blindness in which one denies what one sees, or a genuine blindness resulting from having been trained not to see? And why should anyone feel proud of having this blindness, of not

[13] Much more will be said in later chapters about how social fictions and the social imaginary function in relation to social knowledge and social ignorance, sometimes enabling us to see and hear things, but very often precluding us from seeing and hearing certain things (see especially the discussion of social resistances to know in chapters 2, 3, and 5).

seeing certain things—are they not there (at least in some sense)? What does this pride tell us of the subject who proclaims it and of the culture that promulgates it?

According to my analysis, the phenomena of color- and gender-blindness occur as part of a larger cultural phenomenon: the phenomenon of the normalizing and homogenizing tendencies of a privileged perspective that protects itself by blocking our recognition of differences. More will be said later about different forms of insensitivity or "blindness", and about the active ignorance of social positionality that they involve. I only want to point out now that these forms of gender and racial blindness involve the three epistemic vices associated with privilege I have highlighted: they involve arrogance, insofar as the subject presumes to know all there is to know from his own racial and gender perspective (often without realizing that she or he has one); they involve laziness, insofar as there is a clear lack of effort and motivation to find out more about how racial or gender differences might have an impact on people's experiences and standpoints; and they involve closed-mindedness, insofar as there is a lack of cognitive openness to the relevance and importance of racialized or genderized experiences and perspectives. I am interested in exploring the convergence of these epistemic vices not only in the cognitive functioning of color- and gender-blindness, but more generally and importantly, in the formation of a particular epistemic character: that of the *actively ignorant subject*.

The epistemic vices of arrogance, laziness, and closed-mindedness greatly contribute to the production of a particular form of ignorance: *active ignorance*, an ignorance that occurs with the active participation of the subject and with a battery of defense mechanisms, an ignorance that is not easy to undo and correct, for this requires retraining—the reconfiguration of epistemic attitudes and habits—as well as social change. Those who are epistemically arrogant, lazy, and closed-minded are *actively ignorant*. Actively ignorant subjects are those who can be blamed not just for lacking particular pieces of knowledge, but also for having epistemic attitudes and habits that contribute to create and maintain bodies of ignorance. These subjects are at fault for their complicity (often unconscious and involuntary) with epistemic injustices that support and contribute to situations of oppression. We need to investigate how this form of active ignorance relates to social justice. For example, is ignorance the cause of racial injustice, as Dewey and the early Du Bois, among others, suggested? Or is active ignorance a mere consequence or side effect of a more basic form of injustice and oppression, as classic Marxists would argue? Following pragmatist race theorists (especially Sullivan), I will defend a transactional view according to which epistemic injustices are neither the unidirectional cause of social injustices nor their consequence. My overall argument in this book aims at providing a more nuanced account of the relationship between epistemic and social injustices.

Before we proceed with that argument, a few general remarks and caveats are in order. In the first place, as already pointed out, belonging to the dominant classes is *not a necessary condition* for having any particular epistemic vice. The vices I have identified as likely to be found among the privileged are not exclusive to this group; they can be found in all corners of the social spectrum—including among the oppressed—but they take different shapes and exhibit different sociogeneses. The starting point of my analysis is simply that the social positionality of agents does matter for the development of their epistemic character, and that particularly extreme and damaging forms of epistemic vices (such as arrogance, laziness, and closed-mindedness) can be found in the privileged classes. In the second place, membership in the privileged classes is *not a sufficient condition* for the epistemic vices I discuss either. These vices are not universal and automatic features of the cognitive psychology of the privileged: not all members of privileged classes have them, and those who come to belong to these classes do not develop them automatically just by virtue of their membership in this social group. Finally, it is also worth pointing out that, although I take a developmental approach to epistemic virtues and vices, I do not discard genetic factors playing an important role. My account is neutral to the presence of genetic influences and predispositions that can affect social cognition and the development of attitudes and habits that compose one's epistemic character. My discussion will focus on social positionality and habit-forming processes of socialization, but without denying that different subjects may respond quite differently to the same social exposure as a result of their particular genetic predispositions.

1.2. Lucidity and the Epistemic Virtues of the Oppressed

It would be a mistake to romanticize the predicament of the oppressed, or to underestimate the gravity of the cognitive obstacles they have to endure. There is no reason to think that oppressed subjects are at all likely to develop impeccable epistemic characters: epistemic vices of all sorts are definitely possible outcomes of a socialization under conditions of oppression; but, moreover, some epistemic vices are indeed more likely to be found among oppressed subjects, for example (and most prominently), epistemic insecurity or lack of self-confidence on cognitive matters. Accounts of the "Negro mind" from the nineteenth century can be used as an illustration. The other side of Tocqueville's psychological picture of the white Southerner in the 1830s United States is his account of the slave mentality that is produced by an ongoing intellectual subjugation through processes of socialization and control. As Tocqueville's provocative thesis at the time suggested, an enslavement that resorts not only to physical violence but also to mental and intellectual violence is much more powerful and lasting than a purely and exclusively

physical subjugation.[14] There were all sorts of training processes and cultural practices that carefully crafted the slave's manners, attitudes, disposition, and mental habits. The slave mentality that Tocqueville observed during his travels was created through the slave's internalization of the master's judgments and expectations. A crucial part of this mindset was the underestimation of one's cognitive powers and abilities to the point of an utter lack of self-confidence and epistemic self-trust. Thankfully, the oppressions we still live with today tend to take a much milder form, but they also have an epistemic side; and among the cognitive consequences for marginalized subjects is the feeling of intellectual inferiority, a poor self-assessment of one's cognitive assets and capacities, which has many ramifications and an overall negative impact on one's daily life (the way one speaks or thinks; the way one envisions goals as legitimate and feasible, the way one responds to challenges, and so on). In this respect we can think of the feminist research that denounces the epistemic side of the subjugation of women, detailing and elucidating the negative cognitive effects that sexism (along with the wide array of cultural practices that support it) can have for women.[15] Since oppression involves corrupted and distorted forms of social relationality, it is not surprising to find that it produces epistemic biases in the form of unfair comparative judgments that operate implicitly in social interactions and become internalized, with privileged subjects feeling cognitively superior and oppressed subjects feeling cognitively inferior. Sometimes these epistemic biases are internalized to the point of leading to inferiority and superiority complexes.[16]

If, as mentioned above, the thought of being in full cognitive control of reality can illustrate an extreme form of epistemic arrogance of privileged subjects, the analogous illustration of an extreme form of epistemic humility (even self-humiliation) of oppressed subjects can be found in the thought of having no cognitive control whatsoever, even to the point of thinking of oneself as having no cognitive power or no mind at all. In this sense, the particular brand of skepticism that can be most peculiar of the predicament of the oppressed is not skepticism about the external world or about other minds, for indeed oppressed subjects cannot help but feel, often painfully, the resistance of the

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[14] It is of course doubtful that there could be enslavement based purely on brute force and without mental subjugation of *some* sort. But there could be a more superficial and external form of slavery that does not produce a slave mentality that is internalized by the slaves themselves. It is this slave mentality that Tocqueville identified in the United States as being the basis of a particularly powerful and resilient form of enslavement. As he put it, white Southerners had created "intellectual securities for the duration of their power," employing "their despotism and their power against the human mind" (1990, p. 379).

[15] See, for example, Alcoff (2006).

[16] For a brilliant and influential discussion of these complexes and the processes of internalization that cause them, see Fanon (1967).

world and the resistance of those subjects who subjugate them.[17] If there is a form of skepticism that is characteristic of the oppressed, it is *ego skepticism*: a skepticism about the self, about its capacities and even about its very existence. An internalized lack of appreciation and a constant self-questioning can lead to a poor self-esteem, a lack of self-confidence, and even an inferiority complex. And a skeptical self-questioning can go to the extreme of no longer having any certainty about one's status as a real person with a mind with full cognitive powers, that is, about one's status as a subject of knowledge, about one's humanity and mentality. Charles Mills (1998) has explained this point masterfully. As he puts it, as a result of the "intellectual domination" inflicted by those in a position of power and authority, the oppressed subject may be "frequently assailed by self-doubts, doubts about whether he *is* a real person who deserves their respect or perhaps an inferior being who deserves the treatment he has received" (p. 9).[18] But besides the possibility of falling into radical skepticism or developing a cognitive pathology (such as an inferiority complex), oppressed subjects will often face more mundane epistemic problems and disadvantages that are constitutive of their oppression (such as lack of access to information and education, and so on). Nothing in what follows tries to deny this or to minimize its importance. But, for the purposes of my analysis of the epistemic virtues and vices that can be found in situations of oppression and can be exploited to fight against it, I want to call attention to the positive epistemic features we can find in oppressed subjects.

Those who grow and live under conditions of oppression are exposed to practices and processes that erode their epistemic character. And yet some epistemic advantages and even some distinctive epistemic virtues have been argued to be characteristic of oppressed subjects in race theory and feminist theory. Following this literature, I want to highlight here three epistemic virtues: *humility*, *curiosity/diligence*, and *open-mindedness*. As they appear among the oppressed, these epistemic virtues are the mirror-image of the epistemic vices of the privileged identified above (arrogance, laziness, and closed-mindedness); and, as I will begin to explain in the next section, they exhibit a parallel underlying epistemic structure. The same caveats I issued with respect to the

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[17] As Charles Mills (1998) puts it, "Only those most solidly attached to the world have the luxury of doubting its reality, whereas those whose attachment is most precarious, whose existence is dependent on the goodwill or ill temper of others, are those compelled to recognize that it exists. . . . If your daily existence is largely defined by oppression, by *forced* intercourse with the world, it is not going to occur to you that doubt about your oppressor's existence could in any way be a serious or pressing philosophical problem; this idea will simply seem frivolous, a perk of social privilege" (p. 8).

[18] Mills uses Ralph Ellison's *Invisible Man* as a powerful illustration of this point. As Ellison's nameless narrator vividly puts it, "You often doubt if you really exist . . . You ache with the need to convince yourself that you do exist in the real world, that you're part of all the sound and anguish, and you strike out with your fists, you curse and you swear to make them recognize you. And, alas, it's seldom successful" (1952, pp. 3–4).

epistemic vices of the privileged apply also to the epistemic virtues of the oppressed: (1) these virtues are *not exclusive* to this group (they can be found among members of other groups); (2) they are *not universal* features of the epistemic character of oppressed subjects (there are oppressed subjects who lack these virtues); and (3) they are *not automatic* features (they are not had by subjects just by virtue of their membership in a social group).[19] But I am interested in elucidating the particular shape that these epistemic virtues can acquire among oppressed subjects and their distinctive genesis under conditions of oppression. I will now provide a brief introduction of these virtues before I start discussing their formation, functioning, and underlying structure in more detail.

When not taken to the extreme, attentiveness to one's cognitive limitations and deficits can indeed be a virtue: the virtue of *epistemic humility*. When it does not undermine one's confidence and erode one's character (that is, when it does not become pathological), epistemic humility can afford great benefits. Having a humble and self-questioning attitude toward one's cognitive repertoire can lead to many epistemic achievements and advantages: qualifying one's beliefs and making finer-grained discriminations; identifying one's cognitive gaps and what it would take to fill them; being able to formulate questions and doubts for oneself and others; and so on. Insofar as humility involves epistemic attitudes and habits conducive to the identification of cognitive lacunas, it can facilitate learning processes and one's overall cognitive improvement. In this sense, epistemic humility can be seen as a close ally of another epistemic virtue that I want to characterize in a hybrid way in order to capture both its motivational and its performative elements. I will refer to this second epistemic virtue by the name of *intellectual curiosity/diligence*.

Intellectual curiosity is more likely to be found among those who come to recognize what they do not know than among arrogant subjects (know-it-alls) who are not well attuned—sometimes even blind—to the cognitive deficits of their perspective. But of course not all subjects who identify what they cannot claim to know are automatically motivated to know it; not all such subjects feel an intellectual curiosity that motivates them to fill in their cognitive gaps and to overcome their cognitive limits. And even when subjects are so motivated, it is often the case that, under conditions of oppression, social arrangements and circumstances get in the way of these subjects doing the requisite work to achieve the relevant knowledge: in some cases because they may not have the time or opportunity; in other cases because they may be forbidden from doing so. But at the same time, at least in some areas of life, the intellectual curiosity

[19] The last two points demand that we build fallibility into our epistemic analysis of standpoints, for no matter how lucid a standpoint may be compared to others, it is always possible for those who hold that standpoint to be in error. The particular brand of standpoint theory that I defend contains an error component, which I hope will become clear throughout the book.

and diligence of oppressed subjects often receive some special incentives: these subjects often find themselves in need of certain bodies of knowledge in order to escape punishment or stigmatization, sometimes even to survive. Oppressed subjects frequently find themselves forced to acquire deep familiarity with certain domains, developing forms of expertise than no one else has. They often need to know more than they are supposed to—sometimes more than their oppressors. They are often forced to anticipate outcomes and moves in the social game; and sometimes they are also forced to hide this knowledge and render it invisible. Relations of oppression create certain cognitive needs: in order to satisfy one's master, one needs to learn how to, and this involves knowing the master's desires and expectations as well as (or better than) the master himself—knowing the details, processes, and procedures concerning the ways in which demands can be satisfied. In other words, the dynamics of oppression creates cognitive disparities that, epistemically speaking, go in the favor of the oppressed because they are the recipients of a surplus of intellectual curiosity and diligence. This is not to be found everywhere, of course, but mainly in those places and areas of social life where privileged subjects do not dwell or dwell only through the mediation of underprivileged subjects (which creates an interesting kind of cognitive dependence).

The enhanced intellectual curiosity/diligence of oppressed subjects constantly takes them beyond the confines of their parochial perspective or the standpoint of their own group. This directly relates to a third epistemic virtue: *open-mindedness*. Oppressed subjects tend to feel the need of being more attentive to the perspectives of others. They have no option but to acknowledge, respect, and (to some extent) inhabit alternative perspectives, in particular the perspective of the dominant other(s). They are often encouraged and typically even forced to see reality not only through their own eyes, but also through the eyes of others whose perspectives and social locations matter more. In this way oppressed subjects accomplish the epistemic feat of maintaining active in their minds two cognitive perspectives simultaneously as they perform various tasks. This is what in race theory, following Du Bois, has been called having a "double consciousness". The epistemic perspective of oppressed subjects often exhibits a characteristic kind of hybridity, inclusivity, and open-mindedness, whereas the cognitive functioning of privileged elites tends to be more parochial and one-sided, often operating in complete disregard of alternative standpoints. My pluralistic account of oppressed and privileged perspectives and their complex relations will complicate this a bit, so that we need to talk about a *kaleidoscopic* consciousness (rather than a merely dual one) as the proper outcome of epistemic open-mindedness.

In the same way that the three vices of privileged subjects converged in what I called active ignorance, the three virtues of oppressed subjects also have a converging point: a special kind of lucidity, *subversive lucidity*, which can take different forms, including *critical* and *experiential* lucidity. Epistemically humble,

curious/diligent, and open-minded subjects are likely to detect and overcome blind spots and to develop new forms of lucidity that can enrich social cognition. If we add to that kind of virtuous character the experience of oppression, of not fitting, of having an alternative viewpoint, then the lucidity of the virtuous subject can have a subversive character, having the potential to question widely held assumptions and prejudices, to see things afresh and redirect our perceptual habits, to find a way out or an alternative to epistemic blind alleys, and so on.

The characteristic form of lucidity that *can* be found outside the mainstream, in the alternative cognitive perspectives of marginalized subjects, relates to the recent literature that has emphasized the epistemic advantages of the oppressed. But should nondominant or underprivileged perspectives enjoy a prima facie presumption of epistemic superiority, as some have argued? In general, I will contend that this is not the case, because the social distortions and epistemic obstacles created by conditions of oppression affect all subjects, both oppressors and the oppressed, and no one can adjudicate to a particular group a cognitive perspective that is in principle epistemically superior to that of others, claiming to be untainted or to possess some kind of *cognitive innocence*. However, differently situated subjects are affected differently by conditions of oppression; they often accumulate different sets of experience and, as a group, they can collectively develop a distinctive repertoire of cognitive assets and cognitive deficits. We cannot generalize and talk about *the* epistemic perspective of the oppressed or *the* epistemic perspective of the oppressor. Such rigid and homogeneous categorizations of social groups lead to nothing but stereotypes, bad sociology, and bad epistemology. There are many heterogeneous perspectives that can coexist in a group or social location, for a social location can be inhabited in many different ways; one can belong to a social group and participate in the life of the group in many different ways. We cannot determine in advance, just by virtue of the social location the subject occupies, what his or her epistemic character is and how it compares to that of differently situated subjects. That is, we cannot make such determinations *prior to* the examination of the subject's trajectory and of the epistemic character the subject has developed. But we can examine individual trajectories and epistemic characters of socially situated subjects, and we can find distinctive epistemic resources and advantages among the members of a group (even if only particular members of that group actually have them). Therefore, although I will depart from those strong positions that attribute some kind of epistemic superiority to oppressed groups, I will defend the claim that there are distinctive epistemic advantages that can be found among oppressed subjects: there are some critical and demystifying experiences with important consequences for the epistemic character of those who have them, which can only be found in subordinate groups; and there is a special kind of lucidity with a particular subversive force, which *can* be found among members of those groups. In this sense, I take my qualified position to be close to that of Charles Mills.

In his judicious critical review of feminist and race theory (1998, pp. 21–39), Mills divides the arguments for the epistemic privilege of subordinate groups into two kinds: essentialist arguments from biological causation and constructivist arguments from social causation. The former have been heavily questioned in recent years because the biological differences between men and women or among members of different races do not seem to constitute the foundation of cognitive differences, at least not independently of how those differences are taken up by particular cultures in particular ways.[20] On the other hand, constructivist arguments for the epistemic privilege of subordinate groups have also been criticized, especially when they offer a unified or even universal account of how social structures or locations cause epistemic benefits, as Marxist theorists and standpoint theorists sometimes have done. However, while accepting that universal accounts of oppression and homogeneous notions of social locations as unitary perspectives are unsatisfactory, Mills also acknowledges the lessons from black Marxism[21] and socialist feminism[22] and insists that much can be learned from an examination of racism and sexism as *lived experiences*.

Although there is no universal and unified kind of epistemic privilege that subordinate groups enjoy, I will argue, following Mills, that oppressed groups do have a distinctive set of experiences and that they are better positioned and better equipped for a particular kind of *epistemic subversion*: what Mills and others have called "the inversion of perspectives." As Mills puts it, "Hegemonic groups characteristically have experiences that foster illusory perceptions about society's functioning, whereas subordinate groups characteristically have experiences that (at least potentially) give rise to more adequate conceptualizations" (p. 28). Although oppressed subjects can indeed fall victim to socially generated illusions, they often have more resources to undo these illusions, they have a richer (or more heterogeneous) experiential life that they can use to dismantle the accepted description of reality that rules the day. Members of subordinate groups typically have experiences that from the point of view of the dominant ideology or hegemonic perspective are considered *alien*. As Mills puts it, these experiences are alien because they are "outside the hegemonic framework" and "they redraw the map of what was thought to be already explored territory" (Ibid.). Alien experiences of this sort do not fit in the dominant perspective; they call for a redrawing of conceptual boundaries, for a rearticulation of epistemic norms; and this is not simply a mere adjusting of our perspective, but a radical questioning of assumptions and taken-for-granted descriptions, a challenging in

[20] This could be said, for example, about the experience of pregnancy, which may belong exclusively to a particular biological group but nonetheless is culturally mediated and, *as lived experience*, may contain inextricably bound biological and cultural elements.

[21] See Orlando Patterson (1982) and Cedric Robinson (1983).

[22] See Alison Jaggar (1983) and Sandra Harding (1983).

fundamental ways of available frameworks—in short, an inversion of perspectives. This not-fitting, this call for a deep transformation, this inversion of perspective, typically has the experiential character of *a surprise*: it is surprising to the experiential subject who has this experience for the first time, as well as to the rest of society. Mills explains that "the shock arises not merely from the simply alien but from the alienated familiar, the presentation of the old from a new angle" (Ibid.). People (including the experiencing subject) may not be ready to accept these alien experiences as genuine experiences, and they may not answer the call for a radical rearticulation or inversion of perspective; instead, their reaction may be to dismiss the experience and block any alternative descriptions of social realities that may result from it. This is to be expected, since we all develop resistances to accept alternative descriptions of our experienced reality; and typically the more invested people are in those accepted descriptions, the more reluctant they will be to accept alternative ones. But this is all the more reason to be attentive to alien experiences and their critical and transformative potential. This is the core of Mill's argument for *alternative epistemologies*: those that take into account non-hegemonic perspectives and thus provide an alternative to the abstract (decontextualized and dehistoricized) ways of framing epistemological discussions that have dominated the Western philosophical tradition and have been too complicit with dominant or hegemonic standpoints.

As I will discuss in chapter 5, the main cognitive asset of epistemically virtuous subjects among oppressed groups is their *meta-lucidity*: their capacity to see the limitations of dominant ways of seeing. This meta-lucidity has a critical and subversive potential: it provides insights into the functioning of perspectives that makes it possible to redraw our cognitive maps, to redescribe our experiences, and to reconceptualize our ways of relating to others. Lucid experiences of oppression can yield new insights that trigger struggles for the redescription of the relevant experiences—the cognitive side of social struggles. In the women's movement, for example, there have been many experiences that have led to the rethinking of sexual norms and the rearticulation of concepts such as that of sexual abuse. These experiences of course encountered resistances of all sorts; and they themselves, on the other hand, became part of a struggle and, therefore, of a way of resisting hegemonic conceptions and the form of oppression supported by those conceptions. It is in this sense that Sandra Harding talks about "the struggle we have had to get women's testimony about rape, wife battering, sexual harassment, and incest experiences accepted as reliable by police, psychiatrists, other men and women, etc." (1987, p. 77). Social struggles of this sort draw on the lucid experiences of oppressed subjects and involve a fight against different forms of insensitivity and epistemic resistance. My examination of the cognitive side of these struggles will include an analysis of the subversive lucidity that motivates critique and cognitive transformation, a lucidity that in order to do its transformative work and produce social change must be supported by epistemic virtues such as

humility, intellectual curiosity/diligence, and open-mindedness. In the next section I will sketch my proposal for a unified analysis of the active ignorance and the subversive lucidity that can be found in contexts of oppression.

1.3. Resistance, Epistemic Responsibility, and the Regulative Principles of "Epistemic Friction"

Of the "experiential space" in which a subject leads his or her cognitive life and develops habits, attitudes, and an epistemic character, Charles Mills has said that it is not a homogeneous space, the same for all, but rather, a distinctively social space "full of structured heterogeneities and discontinuities" (1998, p. 27). This is why, Mills argues, we can talk about a "differential group experience." In contrast with the frictionless experiential space of the abstract and universal subject of traditional epistemology, Mills explains the differential experiential perspective of socially situated subjects in terms of *resistances*:

> Far from its being the case, then, that an asocial Cartesian knower can move freely along all axes of this space, *certain resistances* linked specifically to one's social characteristics and group membership will determine, at least tendentially, the kinds of experiences one is likely to have and the kinds of concepts one is accordingly likely to develop. (1998, p. 28)

Resistances can be a good and a bad thing, epistemically speaking. The resistances of your cognitive life keep you grounded. As Wittgenstein would put it, in order to have a real (and not simply delusional) cognitive life, "we need friction," we need to go "back to the rough ground." But there are also resistances that function as obstacles, as weights that slow us down or preclude us from following (or even having access to) certain paths or pursuing further certain questions, problems, curiosities. As a good Aristotelian would say, "resistance" can be predicated in many ways. Without falling into equivocation, we should pay attention to the interrelated senses of resistance that have epistemic relevance.

"Resist" comes from the Latin *resistere*, to take a stand. Its dictionary definition includes both an active and a passive meaning: to exert oneself so as to counteract or defeat; and to withstand the force or effect of. But what would it mean to talk about active or passive resistance *epistemically*? Can we talk about countering or withstanding *epistemic forces*? It may seem peculiar to talk about "force" in a cognitive context. We are used to talking about forces in affective contexts, in relation to desires and emotions. But what does it mean to talk about forces in relation to beliefs and belief systems? What ordinary ways of talking can help us make sense of force in a cognitive sense? What are the epistemic forces that our everyday and philosophical discourses seem to recognize? We do talk about being *cognitively moved*, that is, having motivation to

believe or not to believe. In this sense, William James, for one, offered a provocative account of "the will to believe" (see "The Will to Believe" in his 1896/1992). We also do talk about *cognitive influences* that play a role in the formation of beliefs. Beliefs can be understood as propositional attitudes that are open to influences of all sorts, coming from all angles. There is a complex set of cognitive influences that impinge upon one from the inside and from the outside. External cognitive influences are typically the focus of attention in discussions of persuasion. Internal cognitive influences are discussed in accounts of the subject's cognitive tendencies and predispositions to believe. So, at least in these two senses, it seems intuitive to talk about cognitive forces: as cognitive motivations and as cognitive influences. But note that when we talk about resistance, we need to talk about forces *in the plural*, that is, about the interaction of forces contending with each other. To talk about "resistance" is to talk about *opposing forces*. When we talk about the resisting subject in a passive way, we focus on the forces that impinge upon her or him, but, if only indirectly, we also talk about the subject's force as reactive. When we talk about the resisting subject in an active way, we call attention to the force that propels the subject's cognitive trajectory, but, if only indirectly, we also talk about external forces as the background against which the subject steers a course and forms beliefs, the external forces now appearing as reactive, that is, as reacting to the subject's trajectory. "Resistance" has a strong *reactive meaning*: it involves the interplay of forces reacting against each other. The term *resistance* is often defined in terms of "opposing or retarding forces." In its biological meaning, the term refers to "the inherent ability of an organism to resist harmful influences (as disease, toxic agents, or infection)."[23] In psychoanalytic theory, resistance is "a psychological defense mechanism wherein the patient rejects, denies, or otherwise opposes the therapeutic efforts of a psychotherapist." In political terms, resistance typically refers to "an underground organization of a conquered or nearly conquered country engaging in sabotage and secret operations against occupation forces and collaborators." Since my account of epistemic resistances will be grounded in the social positionality and relationality of embodied agents, the sociopolitical, psychological, and even biological meanings of resistance are not entirely irrelevant and will indeed be echoed and used to enrich my account of contextualized epistemic relations; but my focus will be on the epistemic, and the other senses of resistance will remain secondary.

What are the different kinds of epistemic resistance that subjects exert or endure in their cognitive lives? There are both internal and external epistemic resistances and each of them can be positive or negative. For example, an

[23] Merriam-Webster also defines *resistance* as "the capacity of a species or strain of microorganism to survive exposure to a toxic agent (as a drug) formerly effective against it."

opposing internal force that counteracts external epistemic influences can be positive insofar as it is critical, unmasks prejudices and biases, reacts to bodies of ignorance, and so on; but it can also be negative insofar as it involves a reluctance to learn or a refusal to believe—the kind of stubbornness that gets in the way of knowledge. On the other hand, the external epistemic resistances one encounters can be positive insofar as they offer *beneficial epistemic friction*, forcing one to be self-critical, to compare and contrast one's beliefs, to meet justificatory demands, to recognize cognitive gaps, and so on; but they can also be negative insofar as they produce *detrimental epistemic friction*, censoring, silencing, or inhibiting the formation of beliefs, the articulations of doubts, the formulation of questions and lines of inquiry, and so on. As Bernard Williams and others have argued,[24] there is such a thing as *epistemic luck*: people can be more or less lucky in the epistemic environments they find themselves in; they can be lucky or unlucky in being exposed to beneficial or detrimental resistances. But individuals as well as groups also have to take responsibility for the epistemic environments and the forms of resistance that they contribute to create and to perpetuate.

I propose two guiding principles for the epistemology of resistance, principles that will facilitate our analyses of cognitive forces and their interplay. These are regulative principles that will enable us to dissect and assess different forms of epistemic friction and to navigate our cognitive lives through them. They are the *principle of acknowledgement and engagement*, and the *principle of epistemic equilibrium*. The former dictates that all the cognitive forces we encounter must be acknowledged and, insofar as it becomes possible, they must be in some way engaged (even if in some cases only a negative mode of engagement is possible or epistemically beneficial). The latter principle lays out the desideratum of searching for equilibrium in the interplay of cognitive forces, without some forces overpowering others, without some cognitive influences becoming unchecked and unbalanced. In particular, as we shall see, it is important to aim at equilibrium between the internal and the external, or between the perspective of the subject and that of others. This will become tricky because, given processes of internalization and externalization (i.e., of introjection and projection), there is no hard and fast boundary between the inner and the outer, or between the individual subjects and the social groups in which they are embedded. Nonetheless, without presupposing any autonomous inner core of the subject untainted by the external and the social, or any social outside unaffected by the individuals composing it, we can elucidate the transactional traffic between the subjective and the intersubjective as mutually constituting and interdependent domains that have to acknowledge and engage each other

[24] See B. Williams (1993) and (1995). See also Fricker (2007), especially pages 101–4.

and work together toward maintaining some sort of epistemic equilibrium (no matter how tenuous, fragile, and perfectible). In fact, the principles I just mentioned, far from establishing separate and autonomous domains, strongly encourage the recognition of the constitutive interrelations between the individual and the social, and between the inner and the outer.

The acknowledgment of and engagement with cognitive influences and the epistemic equilibrium among them are of the utmost importance, because our cognitive lives are a constant tour de force among a variety of cognitive powers and authorities, of perspectives of varying force, of cognitive impulses and compulsions. In this tour de force that is our cognitive life, epistemic resistances of all sorts, internal and external, have to be acknowledged and, insofar as it is possible, engaged. We need such resistances, and we need to be attuned to their operations and their effects. The absence or denial of internal or external epistemic resistances will lead to epistemic disequilibria and, over time, to bad epistemic habits and attitudes, that is, to epistemic vices. Thus, the absence of or insensitivity to external resistances is heavily implicated in the constitution and maintenance of the epistemic vices characteristic of some privileged subjects mentioned above: arrogance, laziness, and closed-mindedness. On the other hand, the absence of or insensitivity to internal resistances is heavily implicated in other epistemic vices that will not be the focus of this book, such as naïve credulity and conformism, the lack of epistemic autonomy (i.e., not being an independent thinker, not having a criterion of one's own), and the lack of self-confidence. By contrast, being attuned to the epistemic resistances in one's life can have beneficial consequences in the formation of one's epistemic character. Being sensitive to the presence and influence of cognitive forces is crucial for the achievement of epistemic virtues. Indeed, as emphasized above, the willingness to put one's cognitive perspective in relation to that of others—calibrating the different cognitive forces, impulses, and compulsions one is exposed to—is the path to the epistemic virtues that take a characteristic shape among oppressed subjects. It is mainly because of their special attunement to external epistemic resistances that such subjects exhibit open-mindedness (attentiveness to the perspectives of others, to cognitive and interpretative differences); curiosity/diligence (answering cognitive calls to find out, to face epistemic challenges head-on, to meet cognitive demands, etc.); and humility (recognizing their cognitive limitations and gaps, qualifying their claims, etc.).

My discussions in subsequent chapters will try to elucidate epistemic virtues and vices under conditions of oppression in terms of epistemic resistances and their absence. I will argue that the absence of or insensitivity to epistemic resistances promotes active ignorance and the epistemic vices that support it, whereas the acknowledgment of and engagement with epistemic resistances facilitate the achievement of epistemic virtues and, under some conditions, can also produce a subversive lucidity that can have an enormous critical and transformative impact on the epistemic community and its environments.

A recurrent theme in the discussions that follow will be the *epistemic responsibility* that individual subjects and communities have in their dealings with epistemic resistances: responsibility for the resistances they contribute to maintain or to eradicate, for the ways these resistances are acknowledged or ignored, engaged or failed to be engaged, and for the epistemic equilibriums or disequilibria they contribute to establish and sustain. Before we start with more detailed analyses, I offer a preliminary discussion of epistemic responsibility to give the reader a sense of how this notion will function within the framework of my epistemology of resistance.

The ensuing discussions of knowledge and ignorance will be couched in terms of epistemic activities and epistemic forms of inaction. The epistemological framework of this book is a *performative* and *pragmatist* one, influenced by Ryle, Wittgenstein, James, and Dewey, among others. According to this framework, knowing is mainly a matter of *doing*, that is, of engaging in epistemic actions and participating in epistemic practices. My account of epistemic agency in terms of resistances offers a new concept of epistemic responsibility: the responsibility of subjects qua knowers or epistemic agents is, first and foremost, the responsibility to confront internal and external resistances. I will argue that individual epistemic responsibility cannot be understood independently of shared epistemic responsibility, for the former is intrinsically social, consisting of our epistemic orientation toward ourselves and toward others, that is, in our responsivity to our own epistemic attitudes (often socially generated or socially mediated) and to the epistemic attitudes of others. On the other hand, in my view, the responsibility of an epistemic community also involves the obligation to confront internal and external resistances, that is, resistances that can be found in the inner workings of the community and resistances that can be found in the interactions between the community in question and other communities (actual or possible).[25] As we will see, any discussion of collective epistemic responsibility should be tied, directly or indirectly, to the individual agents who have the capacity to engage in epistemic transactions, but at the same time, the analysis of the epistemic responsibility of agents cannot disregard the social groups in which these agents are formed. In order to capture this interdependence between the epistemic responsibilities of individuals and communities, I propose an interactionist view of epistemic agency and, following Iris Marion Young (2006, 2011), a *social connection model* of responsibility which focuses on *shared* (rather than merely individual or collective) responsibility.[26] The capacity for

[25] As in the case of the individual, both internal and external resistances can be either positive or negative, becoming epistemic resources or epistemic obstacles. But this will be elucidated later when we discuss prejudices and critical friction.

[26] This model will be explicitly discussed in chapter 4.

epistemic responsivity and for taking shared responsibility for patterns of epistemic interaction is developed socially.

As a long Aristotelian tradition has argued, the epistemic character of a subject results from the processes of socialization and training the subject has received. Epistemic sensibilities are formed through processes of acculturation and habituation. These sensibilities are typically tacit, implicit, and unconscious. In their daily transactions, agents are typically not conscious of their epistemic attitudes, dispositions, and sensibilities. That is, they are not critically aware of their own epistemic character and how it affects their epistemic transactions (of claim-making, assessing, questioning, doubting, etc.). Nonetheless, epistemic agents are responsible for the cognitive actions, practices, and products that their psychological structures produce or contribute to produce; and they are (at least partially) responsible for their attitudes, dispositions, and sensibilities as such—that is, for their epistemic character—when they are (or can be) challenged or called into question. It will be a very tricky issue when a subject and a community can be said to be in a position to become critically aware of their epistemic pitfalls and to start seeing things differently, doing things differently, and in short learning and improving. Issues of historical contingency, situatedness, and epistemic luck will be in play. Determining what counts as relevant epistemic alternatives will become crucial; and this calls also for an elucidation of the *role of the imagination* in our epistemic life.

Clearly we are not responsible for the family, community, or culture into which we are born, but we do bear a certain amount of responsibility (shared responsibility) for the marks left on us by different social groups, that is, for sustaining the influence of those groups in our acts and in our lives. We are not responsible for the ethical attitudes and norms of our family, community, or culture; but, to some degree, we are responsible for the influence that those ethical attitudes and norms have had on us, in our character, in our actions, in our lives. The same is true for epistemic attitudes and epistemic norms. At some point in one's life one must take responsibility for the epistemic character one has developed and its component parts (particular attitudes, habits, and sensibilities). As I will argue, this involves becoming aware of who one is, where one is, and where one comes from, that is, understanding one's social trajectory and social positionality. In this sense, responsible agency requires understanding oneself (at least minimally), which, in turn, requires understanding others—understanding social positionality and social differences—for people can become aware of who they are and where they come from only in relation to different social groups and social locations: the groups they have belonged to and currently belong to, as well as those groups they have not, do not, and perhaps will not belong to; and the locations they have occupied and currently occupy, and the locations they have not, do not, and perhaps will not ever occupy. The kind of self-knowledge that is required for responsible epistemic agency involves understanding oneself in relation to those *significant*

others who are similar and different to oneself in various respects,[27] understanding how one relates to them and who these others are. Responsible epistemic agency requires both self-knowledge and knowledge of others, simultaneously. That epistemic responsibility (as well as responsible agency more generally) is intimately tied to self-knowledge is an idea that has become familiar to us through Donald Davidson (1984 and 1986) and some of his followers, such as Akeel Bilgrami (1992 and 1998). But I will argue that the same is true of our knowledge of others: responsible agency (including epistemic agency) requires (minimal) knowledge of those social others with whom we interact.

A particular subcategory within epistemic responsibility is *testimonial responsibility*, which includes all the epistemic obligations we have in giving and receiving testimony. Miranda Fricker (2007) has articulated a concept of testimonial responsibility that converges with the social view of epistemic responsibility I am sketching. Fricker focuses on the receiver's side of testimonial responsibility and analyzes it in terms of the obligations we have as hearers to give adequate credibility assessments to speakers who give testimony. In testimonial exchanges, hearers who give less credibility than deserved to speakers commit an *epistemic injustice*, and a systematic one if their unfair credibility assessments are motivated (or simply mediated) by *identity prejudices* that amount to structural biases against members of certain groups. As Fricker argues, in testimonial exchanges epistemic justice is mainly a matter of *corrective* virtues, requiring a set of capacities that enables hearers to overcome biases, correct unfair credibility assessments, and become virtuous listeners. Avoiding testimonial injustices requires that subjects examine their social positions and memberships in social groups and their relations to other groups. As Fricker insists, nothing short of a critical awareness of one's social positionality and social relationality can correct identity prejudices. To avoid epistemic injustices and to become epistemically virtuous, agents need to understand (if only intuitively) how identity power functions in their society, and how epistemic appraisals (such as credibility assessments) and testimonial exchanges are mediated and colored by social perceptions and stereotypes. Therefore, Fricker argues, "Testimonial responsibility requires a *distinctly reflexive critical social awareness*" (p. 91; my emphasis). Those who are not critically aware of their own social identity and that of others, those who are not sensitive and responsive to the epistemic consequences of social positionality and relationality, cannot correct biases and achieve (or contribute to the achievement of) epistemic justice. In a similar vein, I will argue that epistemic responsibility involves, crucially (perhaps even constitutively), obligations to know oneself

[27] In "Identity Trouble" (2004a) I have analyzed how different aspects of our identity are formed and sustained through complex and heterogeneous networks of similarities and differences with others in particular respects.

and to know others with whom one's life and identity are bound up. In order to acquire and transmit knowledge responsibly, one needs to be critically aware of one's identity and that of others; one must have at least a minimal amount of self-knowledge and social knowledge of others. The exact kind and amount of self-knowledge and knowledge of others required for responsible agency can only be contextually determined, taking into account who one is, the kinds of epistemic actions and transactions in which one engages, and the socio-historical contexts in which one lives. The analyses of epistemic transactions and the resistances encountered therein that I provide in the following chapters will illustrate and give more precise content to these claims about epistemic responsibility and their contextual determination.

{ 2 }

Resistance as Epistemic Vice and as Epistemic Virtue

Resistance is not always good, not in every sense of the term. There are *resistances to know*, obstacles to the process of knowledge acquisition. Far from being a beneficial epistemic friction, this kind of resistance contributes to the perpetuation of ignorance. There are both external and internal forms of this resistance to know. Different kinds of censorship, taboos, and cognitive prohibitions are probably the most obvious and explicit forms of external resistances to know. But the many ways in which biases and prejudices operate in institutions, social structures, and social practices often involve an element of resistance to know certain things. These external negative resistances will be in the background of my analysis. But in this chapter I will focus on an *internal resistance to know* that is an integral part of the phenomenon of *active ignorance*. I will also address the difficult task of lifting this detrimental kind of internal resistance and exercising epistemically beneficial forms of resistance. Thus, while the first two sections of this chapter focus on the epistemic vices associated with the resistance to know, the last section will shift to beneficial epistemic friction and will discuss the epistemic virtues associated with the resistance to ignorance. Resistance as an epistemic vice is the kind of internal resistance that involves a negative relation to external epistemic friction, that is, an active avoidance of the resistance of epistemic others (sometimes even a denial of their capacity to resist). I am interested in the internal resistance of the subject who actively avoids resistances from without, trying to eliminate or hide alternative perspectives, protecting her or his own perspective against any epistemic powers or authorities that do not conform with it, either by destroying them or by becoming insensitive to them. How can this kind of internal resistance that precludes or vitiates epistemic friction come about? One possible sociogenesis of this kind of psychological obstacle to knowledge can be found in *privilege* and the kind of training and character-formation processes that are often present among privileged classes.

As already suggested in chapter 1 (and exemplified by Tocqueville's discussion of the formation of the white Southerner as "a domestic dictator" from early infancy), privileged subjects tend to develop an inflated sense of their epistemic character: they overestimate their capacities and the cognitive

repertoires available to them; and they underestimate their cognitive gaps and limitations. If knowledge has a hybrid nature that involves both commitment and entitlement,[1] the epistemic obstacle we find here is an *overinflated sense of entitlement* that is maintained at the expense of the underlying commitments and justificatory burdens that go along and support those entitlements. The overinflated sense of epistemic entitlement presents only the *appearance* of knowledge (epistemic entitlements that turn out to be hollow because they cannot be backed up in the right way). Epistemically spoiled subjects simply learn to *pose* as knowers, without ultimately having the right attitudes, habits, and forms of responsivity required of a knower. The epistemic overindulgence that can often result from privilege is directly related to epistemic arrogance, but also indirectly related to the other epistemic vices we mentioned before: laziness and closed-mindedness.

My discussion of the active ignorance associated with privilege in this chapter will try to prove two main theses. In the first place, I will argue that the vicious epistemic resistances that result from privilege involve a double epistemic deficit: a deficit in self-knowledge but also and simultaneously a deficit in the knowledge of others with whom one is epistemically related. That is, these resistances rest on an ignorance of social positionality and relationality: the insensitivity (and resistance to become sensitive) to one's position and set of relations in an epistemic community. In the second place, I will argue that the vicious epistemic resistances that result from privilege are not exclusively cognitive and are intimately related to *social injustices*. I will explore the complex relation between epistemic failures, on the one hand, and ethical and sociopolitical failures, on the other, arguing that active ignorance involves social irresponsibility and contributes to systemic failures in social justice. I will provide some concrete illustrations, showing how the privileges of male dominance and white dominance have led to vicious resistances and active forms of ignorance: forms of insensitivity that have often been an integral part of the habits of masculinity and whiteness.

2.1. The Excess of Epistemic Authority and the Resulting Insensitivity

Active ignorance involves more than the mere absence of belief or the mere presence of isolated false beliefs—these being skin-deep epistemic failures that can be easily corrected by providing the relevant information. Active ignorance has deep psychological and sociopolitical roots: it is supported by psychological structures and social arrangements that prevent subjects from correcting misconceptions and acquiring knowledge because they would have

[1] For an account of knowledge as a hybrid deontic status that involves both commitments and entitlements, see Brandom (1994, pp. 202ff.).

to change so much of themselves and their communities before they can start seeing things differently. Active ignorance is the kind of ignorance that is capable of protecting itself, with a whole battery of defense mechanisms (psychological and political) that can make individuals and groups insensitive to certain things, that is, numbed to certain phenomena and bodies of evidence and unable to learn in those domains. In this section I want to explore the link between this kind of active ignorance and the excess of credibility and epistemic authority typically given to privileged subjects. I will argue that active ignorance has to be understood as a form of *meta-ignorance* that involves inadequate second-order epistemic attitudes, that is, wrong attitudes about epistemic attitudes—these are the meta-attitudes present in arrogance, laziness, and closed-mindedness, that is, meta-attitudes that involve vicious resistances. I will analyze how this meta-ignorance is fostered and maintained through certain patterns of epistemic injustice, in particular, through the systematic misattribution of credibility and authority in testimonial exchanges.

Miranda Fricker has analyzed better than anyone the relationship between credibility appraisals and epistemic justice, providing an account of how inadequate credibility judgments can stem from (and at the same time contribute to) structural epistemic injustices. As Fricker shows, assignments of epistemic authority and credibility assessments can be inadequate for all sorts of reasons, some spurious and accidental, others recalcitrant and systematic. Fricker is particularly interested in the link between unfairly biased credibility judgments and identity prejudices. The negative prejudices about a particular group circulating in a culture can denigrate the epistemic character of the members of that group, affecting how they are perceived. Subjects stigmatized by negative identity prejudices may not be regarded as normal subjects, as reliable conveyers of information, and, therefore, they will not receive proper recognition in testimonial exchanges and will be unfairly treated, with their epistemic agency being seriously handicapped in a systematic way. Interestingly, Fricker argues that identity-prejudicial epistemic injustices have to be related to those inadequate assessments of epistemic authority that institute undeserved credibility deficits, but not to those that institute undeserved credibility excesses: "The primary characterization of testimonial injustice . . . remains such that it is a matter of credibility deficit and not credibility excess" (2007, p. 21). She offers two arguments for this claim: in the first place, she contends that a credibility excess does no immediate harm, even if it can have a cumulative unfair effect; and, in the second place, she argues that a credibility excess on someone's part cannot be automatically correlated with a credibility deficit on someone else's part, for credibility is not a scarce good of which we have a finite and limited amount and, therefore, distributive fairness (getting an equal share or an amount proportional to one's needs or dessert) does not apply to this epistemic quality. I will look in more detail into these arguments in order to paint a broader picture of epistemic injustices.

Fricker asks whether there could be "circumstances in which being overly esteemed in one's capacity as a knower would do one harm of a sort that merits the label 'testimonial injustice'" (p. 20). She acknowledges that when one tends to receive a credibility excess from most interlocutors (as members of a ruling elite typically would), one is likely "to develop such an epistemic arrogance that a range of epistemic virtues are put out of his reach, rendering him closed-minded, dogmatic, blithely impervious to criticism, and so on" (Ibid.). So, Fricker asks, isn't the subject in this case wronged in his capacity as a knower in and through these excessive attributions of credibility? Yes and no. Fricker insists that it is *only* through the *cumulative* effect of these inadequate attributions that an epistemic wrong occurs:

> I do not think it would be right to characterize any of the individual moments of credibility excess that such a person receives as in itself an instance of testimonial injustice, since none of them wrongs him sufficiently in itself. (p. 21)

But the fact that no epistemic harm can be detected in this immediate way only shows the short-sightedness of an analysis that focuses exclusively on the individual moments of testimonial exchanges among particular subjects. It should not be surprising that there is no immediate harm that can be detected at the very moment of a credibility assessment, as a direct and immediate consequence of it. For epistemic injustices are typically not direct and immediate harms; they have a temporal trajectory and they reverberate across a multiplicity of contexts and social interactions. This is particularly true of those injustices that have to do with the development of epistemic characters and the agency subjects acquire or lose as they participate in testimonial exchanges over time and across interactions. Epistemic injustices of this sort are temporally and socially extended. Epistemic injustices (as well as the forms of justice that contrast with them) are created and maintained through a sustained effort over time and across interactions and cannot, therefore, be confined to a single moment of testimonial exchange. The proper analysis of a testimonial exchange requires looking into what happens before and after the exchange, looking into what happens in other exchanges and in society as a whole. We have to follow the trajectories that intersect at (converging in and diverging from) the moment of the exchange. We have to pay attention to the social trends that may affect in direct or indirect ways what happens in the particular interaction and how participants perceive and appraise each other. To the extent that an excessive attribution of credibility belongs to a chain of attributions that promotes epistemic vices, that attribution contributes to epistemic injustice. But we can only appreciate the unfair character of that attribution, its contribution to an epistemic injustice, if we put it in a broader context: a context in which the attribution can be perceived as a component part of a complex process—a temporally and socially extended process—that vitiates epistemic exchanges

and the epistemic tendencies and characters of those involved. The harms that excessive attributions of credibility can inflict will indeed not be perceived in an immediate and direct way, given the holistic aspect of injustice. Epistemic injustices have robust temporal and social dimensions, which involve complex histories and chains of social interactions that go beyond particular pairs and clusters of subjects. And these thick concepts of historicity and sociality are lost if our analysis is restricted to particular interactions between individuals at particular moments. Because epistemic injustices are a holistic matter, their analysis too must be holistic. Because epistemic injustices are temporally and socially extended, they call for a sociohistorical analysis that contextualizes and connects sustained chains of interactions, an analysis that is able to uncover how contributions to justice and injustice appear and develop in and across concrete sociohistorical contexts.

2.1.1. EPISTEMIC JUSTICE AS INTERACTIVE, COMPARATIVE, AND CONTRASTIVE

So, from the holistic (i.e., sociohistorical and contextualist) approach to epistemic injustice I am developing, Fricker's thesis that credibility excesses can only qualify as a special case of cumulative injustice, but not as a regular case of testimonial injustice, is unconvincing. Moreover, Fricker's claim that a credibility excess does not handicap the speaker in the course of the exchange in the same way that a credibility deficit does is dubious. Some of what Fricker considers the long-term effects of credibility excess can actually appear in the course of a testimonial exchange if this exchange is complex enough and goes for long enough: we can perceive the speaker becoming arrogant and dogmatic as a result—at least in part—of the disproportionate authority he has been given by the interlocutors; he can be perceived to be unmoved by dissent and impervious to criticism; he can be perceived to become a bully in the very course of the interaction. Also, we can perceive *effects on the interlocutors* (including even those who have indulged in the excessive attribution of credibility): they may feel intimidated by the speaker's authoritative voice, inhibited to express dissent or to raise objections, and so on. This raises a crucial point: when Fricker claims that a credibility excess does no immediate harm, she clearly means that no harm is done (directly and immediately) to its recipient; but the epistemic harms that excessive attributions of credibility can do go well beyond the speaker being epistemically appraised in a wrongful way from a second-person perspective. It is very telling that Fricker's analysis has an *exclusive focus on the speaker* who is the target of a credibility assessment. The underlying assumption of Fricker's normative analysis is that hearers can commit injustices because they can do harm to the speakers whose credibility they assess. But the analysis does not take into account that hearers can contribute to the formation and perpetuation of injustices in many other ways. For example, I, as a hearer, can *wrong myself* by

attributing a credibility excess to all those who are different from me and credibility deficits to those who are like me. This pattern is grounded in an inferiority complex, and contributes to perpetuate it. My excessive attributions to those who are different from me in particular respects (for example, Anglos or heterosexuals) can have the effect of my voice feeling inhibited, my becoming vulnerable to gullibility, my self-trust shaken or fading in comparison to the disproportionate epistemic trust given to the speaker, and so on. I can also *wrong other interlocutors* of the speaker I am assessing with the disproportionate epistemic trust attributed to him, by implicitly encouraging/echoing/backing up his authority in an arbitrary way while at the same time (at least indirectly) minimizing/undermining/creating obstacles for dissenting voices.

Credibility judgments have effects (both proximal and distal) not only on their recipients, but also on others involved in the interaction as well as others indirectly related to it (predecessors and successors of the exchange). The *immediate* and *long-term* effects of credibility judgments are interrelated and are not always easily distinguishable or extricable from each other; and there is also a middle level of consequences that are not immediate but relatively proximal, not too far removed from the interaction. Also, the effects that credibility judgments have for different subjects (speaker, hearer-attributor, other interlocutors, and the various groups to which they belong) are not wholly independent and easily extricable from each other either, but are in fact intimately related. Like many other epistemic qualities, credibility has an *interactive* nature; and its proper or improper attribution reflects that essential interactive aspect in being *comparative or contrastive*: implicitly, being judged credible to some degree is being regarded as more credible than others, less credible than others, and equally credible than others. Credibility never applies to subjects individually and in isolation from others, but always affects clusters of subjects in particular social networks and environments. So it should not be surprising that, in the case of excessive attributions of credibility, the disproportionate epistemic trust given to the speaker affects everybody involved in the interaction and not just the speaker, for it affects the very dynamic that unfolds in the interaction. By assigning a level of credibility that is *not proportionate* to the epistemic credentials shown by the speaker, the excessive attribution does a disservice to everybody involved: to the speaker by letting him get away with things; and to everybody else by leaving out of the interaction a crucial aspect of the process of knowledge acquisition: namely, opposing critical resistance and not giving credibility or epistemic authority that has not been earned. Insofar as the transmission of knowledge is affected, there is an epistemic harm that affects all involved in the testimonial exchange—speaker, hearer-attributor, and other interlocutors included.

However, Fricker rejects the implication I have drawn from the comparative and contrastive dimension of credibility judgments for epistemic justice: namely, that excessive attributions of credibility constitute an epistemic

injustice because not only their recipients but also others are wronged and mistreated by apportioning inadequate levels of epistemic trust and authority in the relevant community (or communities) and social network(s). According to Fricker, by judging some subjects and groups of subjects as disproportionately trustworthy, we are not also indirectly judging other subjects unfairly, that is, as disproportionately untrustworthy or as deserving a differential level of trust under the same conditions and with the same merits and credentials. Fricker resists the link between credibility excesses and credibility deficits in her account of epistemic injustice because she thinks that this would be to rely on a *distributive conception of justice* that is not applicable to epistemic goods such as credibility. As she puts it,

> Credibility is not a good that belongs with the distributive model of justice. . . . Those goods best suited to the distributive model are so suited principally because they are finite and at least potentially in short supply. . . . Such goods are those for which there is, or may soon be, a certain competition. . . . By contrast, credibility is not generally finite in this way, and so there is no analogous competitive demand to invite the distributive treatment. (pp. 19–20)

I can give maximal credibility to all my interlocutors (and even to myself) at the same time! In Fricker's view, giving a particular degree of credibility affects not at all my other attributions of credibility to other speakers. Well, this is in a sense true, but it is also misleading. Credibility is indeed not a finite good that can be in danger of becoming scarce in the same way that food and water can (although the social conditions can be such that a good case can be made—even if figuratively—for credibility becoming a rare commodity in short supply and obtainable only through competition). But I have suggested that we should conceive of credibility as interactive and as involving implicit comparisons and contrasts (potential comparison and contrast classes that operate counterfactually); and a comparative and contrastive quality is not the same thing as a distributive good: in particular, it does not need to be a finite and scarce good that requires just and equal distribution. Accepting that credibility has no distributive nature, there is nonetheless an *intimate relation* between credibility excesses and credibility deficits. This intimate relation is particularly clear in situations of *oppression* where there are social disparities that affect the differential levels of recognition given to different groups and where there are, as a result, all sorts of *disproportions*, including epistemic ones. In situations of oppression, members of some groups get disproportionately more credibility and others disproportionately less; in other words, their epistemic authority is not *proportionate* to their epistemic capacities and assets. And note that, in my view, it is an issue of *proportionality* and not of equal distribution. We have to aspire to making our credibility judgments as proportionate to epistemic deserts and credentials as possible, avoiding disproportions that reflect and are

grounded in (positive and negative) prejudices that involve the differential treatments of members of different groups. The value that guides epistemic justice in this case is not equal distribution but proportionality—that is what fairness means in this case.

Let me lay out more clearly why credibility judgments are implicitly comparative and contrastive and should be guided by the value of fair proportionality in order to avoid epistemic injustices and move toward epistemic justice. Credibility is not assessed one person at a time in complete isolation from all other subjects and their social affiliations. Credibility is not assessed in the abstract, independently of social positionality and judgments of normalcy, but rather, in a comparative and contrastive way, that is, by comparison to what is considered extraordinary, normal, and abnormal. So, those who have an undeserved (or arbitrarily given) credibility excess are judged comparatively more worthy of epistemic trust than other subjects, all things being equal; and this is unfair, not only to them but also to others who do not receive this privileged treatment, not because of a failure in equal distribution but because of a failure in proportionality, for the degrees of credibility given to subjects have to be *proportional* to their epistemic merits and the presumptions that apply to subjects in their situation. Credibility excesses are unjust because they involve an *undeserved* treatment of epistemic subjects, which indirectly affects others who are also unfairly treated as enjoying comparatively less epistemic trust. On my view, this is not due to a misdistribution of a finite good, but to a *disproportion* in credibility and authority assigned to members of different groups.

Credibility is not a scarce good that should be distributed with equal shares, but excesses and deficits are to be assessed by comparison with what is deemed a normal subject and knower. The epistemic injustices concerning credibility and epistemic authority result from a lack of proportionality or an undeserved disparity in the epistemic reputability of social groups. It is not at all an accident that some groups are viewed as more credible and others as less credible because credibility is a comparative matter, and because perceptions of credibility and authority are forms of social recognition that are bound to be affected by the cultural habits of recognition available for differently positioned subjects with respect to different social groups. The excess of epistemic authority of some constitutes an injustice that is directly related to the credibility deficits of others. For example, as many social scientific studies have shown, students in American universities, from day one when they enter the classroom, tend to give more authority and credibility to male teachers than to female teachers, to white teachers than to non-white teachers, to native speakers of English than to those who speak with a foreign accent,[2] to those

[2] Although clearly not all foreign accents carry with them a deficit in epistemic authority, and there are some that in some contexts carry the presumption of higher authority (this is often the case with French and German in academic settings, but not with Spanish or Portuguese).

perceived as heterosexual than to those perceived as non-heterosexual. All things being equal, apparently male, heterosexual, white teachers who are native speakers of English command an automatic authority among the students that teachers who are not perceived to fall into these identity categories do not enjoy. And of course the credibility excess given to teachers who are perceived to be male, heterosexual, white, and native speakers of English is not unrelated to the credibility deficits that teachers who are perceived as members of other groups tend to accrue. For indeed American students tend to assign (at least initially) differential levels of credibility to members of different groups when they occupy a position of intellectual authority.[3]

2.1.2. Differential Authority, Systematic Injustice, and the Social Imaginary

Under conditions of oppression, social disparities often result in differential presumptions of epistemic authority and credibility. We can see this in more detail through an example, which can help us explore how credibility excesses promote the central epistemic vices not only of arrogance, but also of laziness and closed-mindedness. Although I will focus on a fictional example, I will also briefly discuss testimonial injustices committed against domestic abuse victims in real life. Throughout, I will bring to the fore the complex relations between social reality and social fiction. First, in this section and the next, I will elaborate on one of Fricker's central illustrations to make explicit the link between credibility deficits and credibility excesses and the ramifications of the epistemic injustices that result from them. Secondly, following Moira Gatens, in section 2.3 I will offer a brief analysis of the epistemic issues associated with gender violence, focusing specifically on judicial misconduct in domestic abuse trials.

For Fricker, the paradigmatic cases of testimonial injustice involve credibility deficits resulting from negative prejudices and not credibility excesses resulting from positive prejudices. Her examples are supposed to illustrate this. However, I will use Fricker's most central example to show that credibility excesses are also crucially involved in cases of testimonial injustice, and that credibility judgments have to be put in a wider social context so that we can assess normative issues of justice. The example is Harper Lee's novel *To Kill a Mockingbird* (1960/2002). The part of the story of interest for our purposes goes as follows: in 1935 Alabama, a young black man, Tom Robinson, is accused of raping Mayella Ewell, a poor white girl who lives in the borderlands that separate blacks and whites. As Fricker puts it,

[3] See Andersen and Miller (1997), Basow (1995), Burns-Glover and Veith, (1995), Centra and Gaubatz (2000), and Miller and Chamberlin (2000). For a rich discussion of these pedagogical issues in the context of feminist and race theory, see the essays in Crabtree, Sapp, and Licona (2009). See also Giroux and Giroux (2004) and bell hooks (2003).

> The trial proceedings enact what is in one sense a straightforward struggle between the power of evidence and the power of racial prejudice. . . . But the psychology is subtle, and there is a great complexity of social meanings at work in determining the jury's perception of Tom Robinson as a speaker. (2007, p. 23).

Tom Robinson's lawyer, Atticus Finch, proves that the defendant could not have beaten Mayella Ewell because she sustained injuries inflicted by a left fist and Tom Robinson's left arm is disabled. But nonetheless this is not enough to invalidate the charge and exculpate the defendant. The fact that Tom ran away from the Ewell house is taken to imply culpability; and Tom's testimony is undermined by the prosecutor to the point of depicting him as completely untrustworthy. A turning point in the prosecutor's interrogation is when Tom is asked why he stopped by at the Ewell house regularly and helped Mayella with her chores. He answers "I felt right sorry for her." "*You* felt sorry for *her*, you felt *sorry* for her," the prosecutor replies. As Fricker emphasizes, the prosecutor can ridicule a black man's pity for a white woman and use it to damage fatally whatever epistemic trust the all-white jury had given to the witness because, in the context of a racist ideology, the sympathy of a black person for a white person is a taboo sentiment:

> A black man is not allowed to have feelings that imply a position of any sort of advantage relative to any white person. . . . The fact that Tom Robinson makes the sentiment public raises the stakes in a way that is disastrous for legal justice and for the epistemic justice on which it depends. (pp. 24–5)

I agree with Fricker's illuminating reflections on the trial proceedings of *To Kill a Mockingbird*, but I want to introduce two crucial additions that put the analysis of this case in quite a different light. I want to examine, first, the role that credibility excesses play in the testimonial dynamics of this case and, second, the contributions that the social imagination makes to the epistemic injustice committed. In the first place, Fricker analyzes the epistemic injustice being committed only in terms of the credibility deficit assigned to Tom Robinson by the prosecutor, by most members of the white audience, and especially—ultimately and fatally—by the all-white jury. This is indeed one of the salient features of the case; but there are also credibility excesses (even if they often remain in the background) that give essential support to the epistemic disparities at play and the biased testimonial dynamic that leads to the injustice. There is clearly an unfair differential treatment of the witnesses. And it is noteworthy that Fricker does not analyze Atticus Finch's interrogation of Mayella Ewell and how she is perceived by the jury, which is indeed a crucial part of the proceedings and an essential element in the production of the epistemic injustice. The depiction of Tom Robinson as a presumptuous, lying Negro

is not only created and maintained during his interrogation, but also in and through everything else that happens at the trial. Such depiction becomes successful not exclusively because of what happens in Tom's interrogation, but also, in part, thanks to the credibility excess antecedently given to his accuser as a member of a privileged racial group (despite her economic underprivileged status). Such credibility differentials were already in place even before the defendant and his accuser walked into the witness stand; and, in the eyes of the jury, they were corroborated and augmented in their testimonies. In fact, I would say that in the trial proceedings of *To Kill a Mockingbird*, there is an entire hierarchy of credibility presumptions at play: white women are more credible than Negros; and white men are more credible than white women—hence it is not surprising that both Finch and the prosecutor are depicted as speaking for Mayella in a more credible voice than she can muster. The comparative and contrastive character of credibility assessments can also be appreciated in the jury's perceptions of the defendant and his interrogator as they interact, for their authority and credibility shrink and grow simultaneously and in tandem as they go back and forth. Tom's credibility is ruined because it diminishes to the point of disappearance when his claim about pity is encountered with an ironic resistance voiced by a far more credible white man who echoes the white social imaginary in such a powerful and authoritative way that the plausibility of Tom's claim becomes inaudible, unimaginable, to the white audience. The discrediting of Tom's testimony does not happen in a vacuum; his credibility is not undermined independently of the credibility of those around him, but in fact the diminishing of his testimonial authority is achieved through the epistemic authority implicitly given to his questioner: the prosecutor is assumed to be a better evaluator of sentiments and their plausibility than the witness. In my view, the novel illustrates how a credibility excess—that of whites, and more specifically that of Mayella's testimony and that of the prosecutor's questioning—constitutes a *misplaced trust* that can easily lead to possible harms to others. Interestingly, although Fricker ignores the crucial relation between credibility deficits and excesses in her analysis, she nonetheless implicitly acknowledges this relation in passing when she says, "There are those on the jury for whom the idea that the black man is to be epistemically trusted and the white girl distrusted is virtually a psychological impossibility" (p. 25).

Credibility deficits and excesses clearly go together in this case. This is not surprising, since we are dealing with an epistemic injustice that is grounded in a *comparative* social injustice: the unfair differential agency given to members of different racial groups, whites and non-whites; and the epistemic aspects of that agency will also be attributed differentially, giving more to some and less to others. As the social advantages and disadvantages produced by racism go together, so do the epistemic advantages and disadvantages produced by racism. The comparative and contrastive character of the epistemic disparities

in this case tracks (and results from) the comparative and contrastive character of the social disparities on which they are built and to which they give support. The epistemic injustices we are examining have a *systematic* character: they are produced by—and are at the same time productive within—a complex *system* of social relations and practices in which unfair disparities among groups are maintained. As Fricker puts it, "Systematic testimonial injustices . . . are produced not by prejudice simpliciter, but specifically by those prejudices that 'track' the subject through different dimensions of social activity—economic, educational, professional, sexual, legal, political, religious, and so on" (p. 27). And this is true whether the prejudices in question are positive or negative, that is, whether they assign an excess of credibility and authority that "tracks" a privileged position in social activities (economic, legal, educational, professional, etc.), or a deficit in credibility and authority that "tracks" an underprivileged position in those activities.

In the second place, besides expanding Fricker's analysis by putting credibility deficits in (systematic) relation to credibility excesses, I also want to expand it in another direction by going beyond individual voices in testimonial exchanges and their authority and credibility, or rather, by putting them in a broader context and in relation to social trends and social limitations that create and sustain epistemic injustices. In this sense, I submit that what stands in the way of the achievement of justice in the case under consideration goes *beyond testimonial credibility*: the central problem is not that Tom Robinson's testimonial authority is discredited, but rather, that certain affects and relations have been rendered *incredible* (in fact, almost unintelligible) in that culture; and achieving justice becomes practically impossible in that culture until those affects and relations become *imaginable*, until they can be thought meaningfully and those who lay claim to them do not become discredited by their very claims. In other words, the key to understanding what goes wrong in the interrogation of Tom Robinson has to be found in the relation between the epistemic attitudes and reactions depicted and the workings of the *social imagination*.[4] The interrogation stumbles upon something that falls outside the social imaginary: a Negro feeling sorry for a white girl. What lacks all credibility is not so much Tom Robinson as a knower and informer, but the idea of black pity for white subjects in Jim Crow Alabama. Similarly, in the interrogation of Mayella Ewell another *incredible* proposition surfaces: Atticus Finch's insinuation that it was Mayella who made sexual advances on Tom. Here we

[4] For the notions of the social imagination and the social imaginary, I rely heavily on the works of Castoriadis (1997a, 1997b, 1998, and 2007), Gatens (1996), and Gatens and Lloyd (1999). In the last chapter I will elucidate how the social imagination interacts with our epistemic sensibilities. The repository of images and scripts that become collectively shared—the so called *social imaginary*—constitutes the representational background against which people tend to share their thoughts and listen to each other in a culture.

find another taboo idea, something that was completely outside the bounds of the social imaginary of white Southerners at the time. It is not so much Mayella's hysterical denials of the insinuation that makes it incredible in the jury's eyes, or any amount of credibility given to her—in fact, she is depicted as commanding little authority and, if anything, her hysterical reactions seem to confirm Finch's insinuation. It is, rather, that the proposition goes against all the guiding principles and underlying assumptions that regulated at the time the gender and racial relations of the South; and hence the proposition appears as incredible. Here the epistemic obstacle is the *unimaginability* of a white girl coming on to a Negro. Finch is asking the jury to ascribe an incredible sort of sexual agency to a white woman (the agency to initiate sexual activity!) and a misplaced object of desire (a Negro!). And there is yet another hard-to-swallow proposition in the mix: that if Mayella has not been abused by Tom, she must have been abused by her own father. The jury is faced with the choice between an easily imaginable, ready-made scenario (a white girl being raped by a Negro), and something unimaginable coupled with something imaginable but shattering (the white girl desiring a Negro and being physically abused and possibly raped by her own father). The jury is epistemically lazy, shares the arrogance and closed-mindedness of the dominant racial ideology of the time, and finds Tom guilty.

I want to emphasize that in this case the *resistance to know* (to open one's mind to alternative possibilities and to ponder the available evidence fairly) comes from *the social imaginary* (or from limitations herein). It is the social imaginary that, in this case, breeds arrogance, laziness, and closed-mindedness. The social imaginary produces *active ignorance* by circulating distorted scripts about sexual desire according to which Negroes have a sexual agency out of control whereas white women lack sexual agency.[5] Those under the sway of this social imaginary—essentially all those who have been raised under the influence of these imaginings and the cultural representations they produced—are likely to develop epistemic habits that protect established cultural expectations and make them relatively blind and deaf to those things that seem to defy those expectations. In the first place, they will lack the motivation and intellectual curiosity to probe the evidence more fully, to ask about alternative explanations and to find out more. In other words, the social imaginary produces a strong form of epistemic laziness that blocks evidentiary explorations. This laziness becomes an epistemic obstacle in the pursuit of knowledge that can easily lead to epistemic injustices. In the second place, the strongly biased social imaginary that was dominant at the time produced closed-mindedness: a strong

[5] In recent years there have been numerous studies of the racial and gender aspects of cultural representations of sexuality, exposing the myths and social distortions that have pervaded the sexual imagination of our culture. For a particularly detailed and influential study of this kind, see Patricia Hill Collins (1990).

resistance to look at things from another angle. No matter how implausible things may initially look from other, unfamiliar angles, it is epistemically beneficial to consider things from multiple angles, to use a kaleidoscopic approach to the events, and to compare and contrast as many perspectives as possible. It would have been beneficial to take seriously Tom's perspective as a sexually uninterested passer-by who feels pity for a woman and tries to help her. It would also have been beneficial to take seriously Mayella's perspective as a victim of domestic abuse and as a woman pursuing a man she desires (a perspective that she herself has a strong resistance to admit and articulate, feeling ashamed, rejected, and socially encouraged to pose as a victim of racial violence and not as a victim of domestic violence). Finally, and in the third place, it is clear that the view of the events stemming from the prevailing racial ideology was epistemically arrogant; and, as suggested above, the arrogance of the dominant perspective and the arrogance of particular subjects who give voice to that perspective can be understood in terms of the credibility excesses assigned to certain ideas and certain voices. So, in short, the epistemic injustice committed against Tom has to be understood as part and parcel of a systematic sociopolitical injustice against a group; and this epistemic injustice is perpetrated thanks to a social imaginary and the vitiated epistemic habits that it has fostered among the members of the jury (epistemic vices that include arrogance, closed-mindedness, and laziness). In this fictional case the social imaginary acts in such a way that, despite the available evidence, it becomes difficult for the jury to see Tom as anything other than a guilty Negro who gave in to his sexually aggressive instincts, and as a lying Negro who escapes the scene of the crime and makes up extremely implausible (to the point of unimaginability) excuses to cover up the results of his sexually aggressive nature, which is assumed to be there despite all appearances in Tom's behavior, attitudes, and history. The insensitivity to the overwhelming evidentiary elements in the trial proceedings that points in another direction are fostered by culturally powerful and socially reputable scripts of black men attacking vulnerable and defenseless white women—for example, the so-called *myth of the black rapist*.[6] Over generations and through the confluence of different forms of exclusion and stigmatization, the social imaginary has created the active ignorance that operates here: namely, the inattentiveness to evidence suggesting that a white woman may desire and pursue a black man and that a black man may feel sorry for a white person he finds desperate and helpless and may try to assist her without an ulterior motive. Moreover, another blind spot in the social imaginary converges here by obscuring the possibility of an alternative explanation for the brutal aggression—for if Tom was not the perpetrator, then who? An alternative

[6] For critical analyses of this social script, its use for motivating and justifying lynching, and its legacy, see Davis (1983) and Collins (1990/2000).

explanation seems lacking because another form of active ignorance makes it hard to imagine: the (relative) cultural insensitivity to domestic abuse and gender violence. Properly addressing these instances of active ignorance—these forms of insensitivity—requires deep transformations of the social imagination and the cognitive and emotive restructuring of attitudes and habits, so that epistemic vices (such as arrogance, laziness, and closed-mindedness) are eliminated and the cultivation of epistemic virtues (such as humility, curiosity/diligence, and open-mindedness) becomes possible.

2.2. The Vice of Avoiding Epistemic Friction, Hermeneutical Injustice, and the Problem of "Meta-Blindness"

In the trial proceedings we are examining, there is a lack of genuine engagement with epistemic counterpoints. Alternative epistemic perspectives are not even fully recognized. There is only a very superficial acknowledgment that becomes unavoidable because an alternative viewpoint becomes part of the trial proceedings through Finch's interrogation of Tom and Mayella and in his concluding remarks. But the acknowledgment of this alternative viewpoint remains superficial because it is never recognized as a valid alternative perspective, credible and authoritative; and, therefore, it does not become a genuine epistemic counterpoint that deserves full consideration, that needs to be integrated and explained (even if its claims are ultimately rejected and explained away). It never amounts to a viewpoint that can exert genuine resistance, for it is not given much epistemic force; it is simply dismissed without much explanation by appealing to the authority and credibility of the dominant perspective on racial and gender relations according to which all Negroes are sexual predators and white women have no sexual agency. By violating the normative principles of acknowledgment and engagement, another normative principle of epistemic friction is violated: no epistemic equilibrium of any kind can be achieved by the epistemic forces at play. The lack of epistemic friction characteristic of the racist dominant perspective breeds arrogance, laziness, and closed-mindedness; that is, it produces actively ignorant subjects whose vitiated epistemic perspectives avoid friction and protect themselves against alternatives. It is quite clear that in this fictional case the epistemic resistances to fully acknowledge and engage alternative viewpoints become a resistance to knowledge; they become epistemic obstacles that make it impossible for alternative voices to be heard, for incongruent pieces of evidence to be seen, and for the truth to surface; they conspire to impose a fabricated lie that will crush—ultimately destroying physically—the subject who embodies the discordant perspective, Tom Robinson.

The epistemic injustice is committed because the members of the jury do not live up to their epistemic responsibility of confronting epistemic friction, of

considering epistemic counterpoints and seeking an equilibrium among them. This particular epistemic injustice belongs to (and has to be understood within) a much larger pattern of injustice that operates at the economic, sociopolitical, and cultural levels, keeping the members of a racial group in a subordinate position. As part of that larger pattern of injustice we find the contributions of the social imaginary, which makes certain things highly visible and audible and others nearly invisible and inaudible. This limiting and oppressive social imagination affects not only the white members of the audience and the members of the jury but all who have been exposed to it, blacks included. In this sense, the inhibited and diminished voice of Tom—hesitant, under-confident—results from being in the uncomfortable position of running contrary to a powerful social imagination that has created no place (in fact, has eradicated any possible place) for the things he has experienced: pity and compassion for a white person; and being the object of desire of a white girl. Although herself an important contributor to the epistemic and legal injustice committed against Tom Robinson, it is clear that Mayella Ewell is also a victim (a victim of sexual abuse and of a racist and sexist ideology), and her voice is also inhibited and diminished and clearly coerced to lie—to hide and dissimulate—about those things that the culturally dominant mindset defends itself against and the social imaginary rejects. The social imagination can, in this sense, be a negative epistemic force that silences subjects and renders certain things invisible, making it very difficult—and in the extreme case, impossible—for subjects to even register epistemic friction, much less to handle it responsibly.

Although in our example the epistemic interactions where friction is avoided are clearly cases of testimony in the most standard and formal sense (i.e., speaking as a witness in a courtroom), nonetheless we are dealing with an epistemic injustice that—as noted above—goes beyond the testimonial. The testimonial injustice suffered by Tom (and, in a different sense, by Mayella) is grounded in an epistemic injustice that goes deeper. And although Fricker does not analyze it in this way, she does have the theoretical resources to do so, for the deeper epistemic injustice in question—the one rooted in the cultural oppression inscribed in a biased social imaginary—is what she calls a *hermeneutical injustice*. Both Tom and Mayella belong to hermeneutically marginalized groups and their voices and perspectives are unfairly treated because they are subject to *a situated hermeneutical inequality*. Hermeneutical injustices happen because "a collective hermeneutical gap prevents members of a group from making sense of an experience that is in their interest to render intelligible" (2007, p. 7). As a result of their incapacity to make sense (sometimes both to themselves and to others) of their life experiences and predicaments, hermeneutically marginalized subjects enter communicative interactions in a disadvantaged position, for they are conceptually ill-equipped to make sense of certain things, and they are disproportionately more likely to be ill-understood. This is exactly the unfair hermeneutical situation that Tom and Mayella find

themselves in, and this is the nature of the epistemic injustice they face; the wrong done against them as witnesses, the testimonial injustice, is only an effect of a broader and deeper epistemic injustice they have to endure as communicators and epistemic subjects for occupying certain social locations, that is, by virtue of belonging to social groups—blacks and women—who cannot talk about certain things—feeling pity or sexual attraction for members of other races—without their intelligibility (and hence the validity of all their claims) being called into question. Hermeneutical injustices of this sort result from obstacles and limitations in the social imaginary that produce the inability to see and hear certain things, forms of insensitivity that limit the communicative and epistemic capacities of members of certain groups and preclude a genuine understanding of their experiences, problems, and situations. In later chapters I will explore further these negative resistances to see and hear that are firmly grounded in the social imaginary with real-life examples (the social bodies of active ignorance about gender and race that have surfaced in different cultural contexts).

Situations of hermeneutical injustice are improbable contexts for adequate epistemic interactions in which people can learn from each other and knowledge can be transmitted. In situations of hermeneutical injustice, the epistemic virtues required for successful epistemic interactions are rare, and even more so among those who are not negatively affected by the hermeneutical injustice in question. Although hermeneutical injustices affect all members of the epistemic community, they do not affect everybody equally. When we talk about the inability to make sense of certain problems and experiences, we are talking about the problems and experiences of particular groups of people; and those who belong to these groups are the ones who are hermeneutically disadvantaged, the ones who will run into hermeneutical limitations as speakers and will not be listened to properly when it comes to those things. Interestingly, though, in an important sense, the hermeneutically privileged (or non-disadvantaged) are epistemically worse off *as interlocutors* because *their epistemic characters* tend to become more corrupted than those against whom the epistemic harm is done. It takes an exceptional figure such as Atticus Finch to escape that corruption and to develop epistemic virtues that enable him to listen to people openly and to look at things differently. The vices of arrogance, laziness, and closed-mindedness that prevent people from listening properly are more likely to appear as a result of the hermeneutical injustice among those whose lives are not negatively affected by it. So, when it comes to ruining certain areas of their lives and to ruining their chances to succeed in epistemic interactions that concern those areas, the hermeneutically disadvantaged are clearly worse off; but when it comes to ruining their epistemic character, the hermeneutically privileged (or non-disadvantaged) are actually worse off—even if the epistemic character flaws they develop give them epistemic benefits (such as authority and credibility). For example, sexist prejudices and distortions about female sexuality

have created hermeneutical injustices that have affected us all, but these injustices have not affected men and women equally: while women socialized in a culture that gives them very limited sexual agency (as was the case with Mayella Ewell) have a hard time making sense of their desires and pleasures, it is in fact the men who are epistemically worse off in the long run, because they do not even have the experience of there being anything missing when they listen to women talking about sex or pay attention to their sexuality, and thus they inhabit the sexist perspective comfortably, without any resistance or epistemic friction, speaking and listening through it with arrogance, laziness, and closed-mindedness. It is an open question whether gay men and heterosexual men are equally arrogant, lazy, and closed-minded when it comes to female sexuality. On the one hand, they are all likely to have internalized the same prejudices and stereotypes about female sexuality. But on the other hand, gay men have been traditionally hermeneutically disadvantaged with respect to their own sexuality, which dominant culture has hidden from view, covered in silence and rendered unintelligible or abnormal. In some important respects, gay men and women share having been socialized as the sexual others of heterosexual men. But having experienced hermeneutical handicaps in their sexual lives does not guarantee that gay men will be able to overcome the arrogance, laziness, and closed-mindedness about female sexuality that sexist cultures instill in men. However, although there is no guarantee that the experience of hermeneutical marginalization and oppression will be transferable, having such experience *can* provide an alternative point of entry into the experiences of other marginalized subjects (especially in similar areas of life) that have been hidden, silenced, or systematically ill-understood, without the requisite resources for their expression and communication being rendered available by the dominant culture.

My argument here is that *the experience of being hermeneutically disadvantaged itself can become an epistemic advantage*—or at least the seed or foundation for possible epistemic advantages, the springboard for learning processes that can lead to alternative epistemic perspectives or the expansion of existing ones. Because the hermeneutically privileged (or non-disadvantaged) do not have the experience of being unable to properly conceptualize certain things, they have little opportunity to realize (and little motivation to accept) that there is more to see and talk about than what the culturally available hermeneutical tools enable people to recognize. By contrast, the hermeneutically disadvantaged tend to be better listeners, having a *more acute attentiveness to hermeneutical gaps* (at least in some respects, if not in others). But this claim should not be understood as a way of demonizing those who are hermeneutically privileged or of romanticizing those who are hermeneutically disadvantaged. In a situation of hermeneutical injustice, the hermeneutically disadvantaged group may have the inability to recognize and properly conceptualize the phenomena in question as much as the hermeneutically privileged. But at the

very least they will be better positioned to be attuned to the hermeneutical gap, to exhibit an inchoate sensitivity to what is missing, reacting to their own inability and that of others to name and communicate about something that in some sense feels real. The better attunement to the hermeneutical gaps comes from experiencing their own inability to speak as well as the inability of their interlocutors to listen to them. This experience is the fertile soil for the development of a special *sensitivity to insensitivity*. But it is debatable whether this sensitivity to insensitivity can be transferred and carried over from issue to issue, from area of life to area of life. There have been those who thought this was the case and argued for a sensibility of the oppressed that could serve as the basis for coalitions across different forms of oppression.[7] But there have also been those who warn us that coalitions tend to fail and break down, insisting that their fragility derives from the lack of solid support beyond the purely contingent and instrumental convergence of heterogeneous interests. There is no deep solidarity or common sensibility of the oppressed, the skeptic will say: women can be as homophobic and racist as anybody; blacks as sexist and xenophobic as anyone; and have the oppressed economic classes or the persecuted religious groups, for example, proven to be immune to prejudices? Does the marginalized and disadvantaged subject develop a thick skin in her exposure to the oppressive side of the social imagination?

Being hermeneutically disadvantaged in one respect does not guarantee critical openness and sensitivity to epistemic disadvantages in other respects. But the experience of oppression does afford the *opportunity* to go beyond the received dominant view, to recognize its limitations and flaws, and occasionally to develop an alternative viewpoint, a dual consciousness, or even a kaleidoscopic consciousness that can hold and maintain active multiple perspectives simultaneously. Not all members of the marginalized group will take advantage of this opportunity, but enough of them may, so that, collectively, the group can produce an alternative perspective—a counterpoint to the dominant viewpoint—that can exert epistemic friction. The liberatory moves and the hermeneutical tools for emancipation produced by an oppressed group are not always transferable and applicable to the fight against other hermeneutical gaps, against other oppressive limits to intelligibility and other forms of insensitivity; but they constitute resources that are good to have and can prove helpful when encountering oppression and hermeneutical marginalization elsewhere, if only in the sense of being familiar with the predicament of being hermeneutically excluded, of having uninterpretable experiences and problems, and not in the sense of knowing a way out or being able to provide new interpretative tools.

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[7] For a critical discussion of the possibilities for such coalitions and their dangers, see Lugones (2003).

There is only a loose and collective experiential advantage of the oppressed over the privileged in their capacity to offer resistance to hermeneutical gaps and to fight epistemic injustices. Even before the conceptual tools to repair the collective insensitivity are developed, hermeneutically marginalized subjects are better positioned to detect the hermeneutical gaps and to offer epistemic resistance.[8] Members of hermeneutically marginalized groups have a special motivation to look at things differently, to listen to people differently; they have a special sensitivity to insensitivity. By contrast, the hermeneutically privileged have a pronounced *insensitivity to insensitivity*, a sort of *meta-blindness* (or meta-insensitivity), a special difficulty in realizing and appreciating the limitations of their horizon of understanding. As a result of not ever having the experience of running into cultural limitations that render their experiences, problems, and even their lives unintelligible, as a result of not ever feeling severely constrained as speakers and subjects of knowledge, privileged subjects tend to be particularly reluctant to acknowledge the limitations of the horizon of understanding that they inhabit; that is, they tend to be *blind to their own blindness*, numbed or insensitive to the cultural blind spots that they have inherited and they recirculate in their epistemic lives. If the resistance to epistemic friction—to acknowledge and engage epistemic counterpoints—is an epistemic vice, we find here a particularly heightened form of this vice, for we have a double resistance or a doubly reinforced resistance to friction: the inability to see alternatives (a first-order resistance to friction, a lack of openness to epistemic counterpoints), plus the inability to see one's inability (a second-order resistance or meta-resistance, a resistance to recognize one's lack of openness to epistemic counterpoints). This double blindness or meta-blindness blocks paths to fight and repair hermeneutical gaps and the injustices that result from them. If one is not even able to recognize one's blind spots, if one is blind to one's own blindness, how is it possible to embark on a journey to improve one's epistemic perspective and sensitivity? This is what I call the *problem of meta-blindness*.

2.3. Striving for Open-Mindedness: Epistemic Friction and Epistemic Counterpoints as Correctives for Meta-Blindness

The problem of meta-blindness reveals and tries to address a limitation that has existed in the metaphor of blindness used to conceptualize the active ignorance produced by systems of oppression such as racism and sexism. From W. E. B. Du Bois to Ralph Ellison and Charles Mills, the metaphor of

[8] This will be further elaborated in chapter 5 when we discuss the special lucidity (*meta-lucidity*) that oppressed subjects can acquire.

blindness has been very fruitful and productive for elucidating the active ignorance produced and sustained by racist ideologies and racist lifestyles. But, like any metaphor, no matter how apt, this one too has its limitations; and these become so salient in the case of active ignorance that the very concept of blindness needs to be stretched. A proposed extension of the concept is what my notion of *meta-blindness* offers. For meta-blindness (or meta-deafness, or more generally and accurately, *meta-insensitivity* or *meta-numbness*) is unlike any regular sort of blindness in the following respect: a blind person has no access to a whole range of stimulations but typically has an acute awareness that there is much more to the empirical world than what she or he can perceive. By contrast, the meta-blind ignoramus arrogantly assumes that there is nothing else to perceive beyond what she or he can see or hear. And it is this persistent, stubborn denial that defines meta-blindness: *the inability to recognize and acknowledge one's limitations and inabilities*. This meta-blindness protects the first-order forms of blindness, which become particularly recalcitrant and resistant to change and improvement: cognitive deficits that are not even recognized are especially difficult to correct, and their correction will require transformations that the meta-blind subjects are ill-prepared to carry out by themselves. Precisely because of the obstacles and defense mechanisms that operate at the meta-level, meta-blind individuals will need external help: the concerted efforts of others in bringing them to the realization that there are things they miss—for example, that there are aspects of the social world they do not see and should care about. On the other hand, the meta-blind group or culture will need the help of other groups or cultures, or of alternative viewpoints within them.[9] But, of course, the more empowered the meta-blind individual, group, or culture is, the more difficult it will be for others to do the proper interventions and to set in motion the process of transformation and cognitive-affective melioration. The process of undoing meta-blindness involves much more than a mere "cognitive therapy."[10] As we shall see below, it involves the restructuring of habits and affective structures. And as we shall see in later chapters, it also involves political action and deep cultural transformations.

With this in mind, let's now return to the case of Tom Robinson and the epistemic injustice committed against him. The white jury members who convicted Tom Robinson seemed to have suffered from a meta-blindness. They failed to recognize that there were things they could not recognize: they were

[9] Luckily, social groups and cultures are not so homogeneous and monolithic that they contain no discordant or dissenting voices, or at least their possibility. In my *Speaking from Elsewhere* (2006a) I have argued that this possibility is always there.

[10] I am here alluding to the charge of falling into a superficial intellectualism that reduces the fight against oppression to a "cognitive therapy," which Alison Bailey (2007) has launched against Charles Mills.

blind to their inability to understand certain things; they were unable to acknowledge that they were ill-equipped to understand certain sentiments and reactions. Had they not been so, they would have been less comfortable in keeping things out of the bounds of intelligibility; and they would have been more attentive to the silences, the gaps, the cryptic remarks and inchoate allusions to what cannot be said, the evasive responses, the highly emotional reactions to certain questions and insinuations. By contrast, the black people sitting in the atrium of the courtroom constituted a better audience for Tom Robinson's testimony than the whites sitting below; they proved to be better listeners in the relevant respects, less blind and deaf in their reception of the evidence presented. The hermeneutically disadvantaged listeners, thanks to their special sensitivity to insensitivity—their painful awareness of the prevailing blindness, could understand why certain things were not said, why others were only half-said, and why others appeared laughable or illogical even though they could very well be real. The hermeneutically privileged audience members did not have this capacity to understand (or to acknowledge that there is more to understand) readily available; and in fact, because they were not only blind but meta-blind, because they were insensitive to their own insensitivity, they faced serious obstacles against becoming good listeners, against acquiring or developing that capacity to understand what is difficult to understand. So the segregated courtroom contained two hermeneutical levels, two ways of listening and interpreting the testimonial exchanges. We have here a hermeneutically mixed audience, with two distinct groups. As a result, the testimonial exchanges acquired dual meanings, two distinct semantic layers. But although there are interpretative splits and we could talk about two audiences, it would be a mistake to overstate the differences of these two groups of listeners and to segregate them radically, as a matter of principle, and not as a matter of contingent (and reversible) historical and psychological facts, as if the spatial segregation of the courtroom established something *de iure*. It is important to note that there is no radical separation between the two groups; there are interpenetrations and traffic between the two audiences and the two hermeneutical levels.

To begin with, some among the white listeners can "see in black" (as Atticus Finch can); and some among the black listeners may very well be listening "in white." But also and more importantly, we need to recognize here the artificiality of this way of speaking: "seeing (and listening) in black and white." We have here a very strong and distorting polarization of viewpoints, of alternative ways of perceiving that are construed as mutually exclusive and as exhaustive, as if people had to choose between perceiving things in one way or in another—without combining them or looking for other alternative ways of seeing and hearing—between belonging to one audience or another (without there being a third or a mixed one), between going upstairs or downstairs in the courtroom. "This or that, and nothing more." This "nothing more" is a way

of expressing or performing meta-blindness, a particularly recalcitrant kind of closed-mindedness which is unable to recognize its own lack of openness by remaining convinced that there is nothing to be open to. As an antidote to this meta-blindness, we need to appeal to the *principles of epistemic friction*, actively searching for more alternatives than those noticed, acknowledging them (or their possibility), attempting to engage with them whenever possible, and seeking equilibrium among them. This is what it means *to remain open* to epistemic counterpoints. It is crucial to have more than one form of receptivity culturally available; but it is also important to have the ability to move back and forth among alternative sensibilities, to look at the world from more than one perspective, to hold different viewpoints simultaneously so that they can be compared and contrasted, corrected by each other, and combined when possible. It is important to entertain different perspectives without polarizing them, dichotomizing them, and presenting them as exhaustive. Even more important than entertaining the perspectives culturally available to oneself is to remain open to other viewpoints. When we think of the strong limitations of the dominant Southern white culture of the 1930s, we have to think of resources within and without in order to look for ways of fighting those limitations and their consequences: we have to look at the vibrant Negro culture(s)[11] available as well as the different subcultures that existed within differently racialized communities (including white communities). Besides the mainstream racist imaginary, there were alternative (even if marginalized) social imaginaries that could provide ways of escaping the dominant social ideology.[12] Besides the dominant testimonial sensibility that was strongly prejudicial in racial and sexual matters, there were also alternative (even if marginalized) ways of speaking and listening, alternative standpoints to occupy in testimonial exchanges. Alternative social imaginaries can serve as correctives of each other, epistemic counterpoints that enable people to see limitations of each viewpoint, creating beneficial epistemic friction. Alternative testimonial sensibilities can also serve as correctives of each other when they are objectively compared and contrasted, or when they are given a sufficiently unbiased space to engage with each other, yielding beneficial epistemic friction. Epistemic friction can meliorate people's capacities to see and hear, and it can

[11] The Harlem renaissance had taken place in the 1920s and it had echoed pre-existing, vibrant, and subversive black cultural movements in the South as well as in many other places in the African diaspora. See Locke (1925/1992).

[12] Of course, alternative social imaginaries are not sealed off from each other and they have noticeable influences upon one another, typically with those more mainstream and socially empowered exerting a more pervasive and hard to escape influence. As a result, there are often assumptions and limitations that all the closely related social imaginaries will share; and even the most marginal standpoint and the most eccentric alternative way of imagining social reality may reproduce important aspects of the mainstream. An account of this can be found in Bourdieu's discussions of generational conflicts. See Bourdieu (1984) and (1991).

facilitate the development of virtues that improve epistemic interactions and, in particular, testimonial exchanges.

Which epistemic virtues could have enabled jury members to see and hear things differently? Many such virtues might have helped. Among them are the ones we have been focusing on: *humility* may have enabled them to detect the flaws of the dominant perspective; *curiosity/diligence* may have led them to ask questions, draw implications, and pursue evidentiary searches further; but first and foremost the epistemic virtue that seems to be most crucial for overcoming biases and becoming able to hear virtuously is *open-mindedness*. This virtue allows the subject to consider and give fair treatment to alternative epistemic perspectives, that is, to expose any viewpoint to epistemic friction, to entertain epistemic counterpoints and to learn from the comparisons and contrasts that they make possible. It is this virtue that seems most lacking in the trial of Tom Robinson and it is its absence—more than the absence of any other epistemic virtue—that made the testimonial exchanges hopelessly unjust. It is important to note that open-mindedness is an epistemic virtue that goes beyond the testimonial: it can appear, for example, when the subject of knowledge operates on her own and actively seeks epistemic friction for her perspective by considering epistemic counterpoints; it can also appear when subjects cooperate with each other in non-testimonial epistemic practices (such as a philosophy debate, the brainstorming of scientists in formulating hypotheses, a discussion with friends about a movie or a novel, etc.) if they actively seek out comparisons and contrasts among epistemic perspectives, looking at things from various angles and formulating points in alternative vocabularies. But although open-mindedness is an epistemic virtue that goes beyond the testimonial, it is also clearly crucial for virtuous hearing in testimonial exchanges. As a testimonial virtue, my conception of open-mindedness is closely related to what Fricker calls *critical openness*.

According to Fricker, critical openness is what is most characteristic of the responsible hearer's stance. Following McDowell, she defines critical openness as "a rational sensitivity such that the hearer may critically filter what she is told without active reflection or inference of any kind" (2007, p. 69). McDowell had argued that a hearer gains knowledge by testimony by virtue of exercising "doxastic responsibility," which he characterized in Sellarsian terms as a sensitivity to one's place in "the space of reasons" that need not involve the making of inferences.[13] The conceptualization of the hearer's reception as a *testimonial sensitivity or sensibility* involves treating it as a *perceptual capacity* in the same way that in the Aristotelian tradition moral judgments had been

[13] "A standing in the space of reasons can be mediated by the rational force of surrounding considerations, in that the concept of that standing cannot be applied to a subject who is not responsive to that rational force" (McDowell: 1998, p. 430).

construed as moral perceptions. In the Aristotelian tradition, the virtuous subject had been said to have a socially trained moral sensibility that enables her to see the world, so to speak, in moral color. Similarly, Fricker argues that testimonial epistemic virtue is a socially trained perceptual capacity, namely, the capacity for social perception that enables her to "see his interlocutors *in epistemic colour*" (p. 71; my emphasis). As Fricker summarizes it, "The main idea is that where a hearer gives a suitably critical reception to an interlocutor's without making any inference, she does so in virtue of the perceptual deliverances of a well-trained *testimonial sensibility*" (Ibid.). Epistemic perceptions and judgments—deliverances of epistemic sensitivity—are not a matter of applying preset principles. Rather, the subject "'just sees' her interlocutor in a certain light, and responds to his word accordingly" (p. 76):

> Having explained the moral case in terms of a sensitivity to the moral saliences of situations, actions, and people, we can see that, in the testimony case, the hearer must exercise a parallel sensitivity to the epistemic saliences—the many aspects of the speaker's performance in the context that relate to trustworthiness. (Ibid.)

As soon as we apply this framework to our example, we find the following problem: critical openness is what is most needed for attaining justice in the trial of Tom Robinson, but critical openness is also precisely what we should not expect to find! The critical openness required to hear Tom Robinson virtuously will not be found in a racist society in which people's sensibilities will not be trained to see blacks in a fair epistemic color. Tom will not be given adequate amounts of credibility by his racist interlocutors. He will appear in their eyes as a deficient witness, as lacking the ability to report on his own experiences and perceptions. What will it take for these interlocutors to overcome their racism in the testimonial interaction and to perceive Tom in a *just epistemic color*? We have already pointed out one of the crucial obstacles that factor into these listeners' inability to see things aright: the limitations of the social imaginary that colors their perception. So, in that sense, in order to address the injustice we have to go well beyond the individuals involved in the exchange: we have to go to the *social roots* of the problem. But there is more. The failure to have the requisite kind of critical openness as a listener in testimonial exchanges involves the failure to establish the right personal connection with one's interlocutor. The problem is *both social and personal*. And the personal failure is both—and simultaneously—*cognitive and emotive*: it involves the inability to see the relevant epistemic saliences and also the inability to feel the interpersonal relation of trust required for the transmission of knowledge. Trust can be characterized as a relation that has both a cognitive and an affective dimension.

As Karen Jones (1996) has argued, trust requires the capacity to have certain affects, in particular, *empathy*. We can describe virtuous listeners as those who

are exceptionally empathetic (or at least more empathetic than the rest of us), being able to see things from the speaker's perspective and being able to hear things as the speaker would have us hear them. Empathy makes people better listeners; it enables them to calibrate the degrees of trustworthiness that can and should be assigned to their interlocutors. For example, as Fricker explains, the hearer's perception of her interlocutor's sincerity or insincerity involves an "emotional engagement": "she must empathize sufficiently with him to be in a position to judge, and empathy typically carries some emotional charge" (p. 79). What is required for interlocutors to become more virtuous hearers is to learn to develop proper relations of trust, that is, to bestow adequate degrees of trustworthiness on their interlocutors and to proceed in the testimonial exchanges accordingly. And this is both a cognitive and an affective achievement. As Fricker puts it, "When the virtuous hearer perceives his interlocutor as trustworthy in this or that degree, this cognitive achievement is inevitably partly composed of an emotion: a feeling of trust" (Ibid.). We have here a conception of testimonial virtue that places it at the crossroad of the cognitive and the emotive.[14] A cognitive-affective sensibility that includes empathy is indeed a crucial ingredient to virtuous listening. But how can we expect people who have been raised in a racist, segregated society to have the affective habits and structures that enable them to empathize with people of a different race? Worse yet, we are not just talking about a regular lack of empathy, but an *antipathy* that protects itself in such a way that it does not appear to the subject or to the group as a lack of sensibility of any sort. In other words, we are not just talking about any kind of insensitivity, but a particularly recalcitrant one: *insensitivity to insensitivity, an emotional meta-blindness*.

We have thus encountered another aspect of the problem of meta-blindness. The problem of meta-blindness is not only a cognitive problem (as the label *meta-ignorance* may suggest to some), but also an emotional problem: it involves the failure to relate to others affectively; a problem created by rigid and impoverished affective structures. Therefore it calls for both cognitive and affective restructuring. We have here a cognitive and emotive meta-blindness that functions as a block to learning and improving epistemically: if subjects are not even able to recognize their blind spots, if they are blind to their own blindness, how are they going to be able to embark on a journey to improve their epistemic perspective? And if the cultural milieu does not help, if society

[14] As Fricker puts it, this view rests on "a conception of emotion as capable of cognitive content" and "a conception of cognition as permitting emotional content" (p. 78). For Fricker, emotions can have "a positive cognitive input"; she views "the hearer's feeling of trust or distrust, or any other feelings associated with a particular empathetic engagement, as making a positive cognitive contribution to her epistemically loaded perception" (p. 80). Fricker draws on Martha Nussbaum's account of emotions as "composites of belief and feeling" (Nussbaum: 1990, p. 78), but also on earlier feminist work on the epistemic, moral, and political power of the emotions. See Jaggar (1989), Spelman (1989), and Fricker (1991).

makes things worse with its dominant factions reproducing and inculcating this meta-blindness, what hope is there for a transformative process—a kind of (epistemic, ethical, and political) re-education that will result in cognitive-affective melioration? How can a lack of empathy that is blind to itself not only individually, but collectively, be corrected?

Hermeneutical injustices are rooted in forms of meta-blindness that are both individual and collective: the social imaginary renders certain things (experiences, events, problems, etc.) unintelligible and, as a result, subjects become meta-blind to their lack of empathy and inability to trust when it comes to those things. Hermeneutical injustices seem to be such that, for as long as they persist, testimonial justice becomes impossible for the hermeneutically disadvantaged subject. And how can one get out of this situation? There is no easy way out. Moreover, I contend that there is no way out at all if we do not remove two theoretical roadblocks that have plagued the literature on oppression and liberation: one is the false dichotomy between the individual and the collective in discussions of responsibility; the other is the false trichotomy among the epistemic, the ethical, and the political in discussions of normativity. In the first place, issues of hermeneutical justice concerns both individuals and collectivities, involving their different and interrelated forms of agency and responsibility at all levels. It would be a fatal mistake to assume that our diagnoses and treatments of hermeneutical injustices have to choose between the individual and the collective level, without being able to operate at both levels simultaneously—and indeed, as I will argue below, without being able to operate at a crucial intermediate and hybrid level: the level of *shared responsibility*. It would be a mistake to think that in order to improve people's ability to make sense of things, to talk and hear about them, to participate in epistemic practices in more sensitive and fair ways, we need to choose either to meliorate individual's abilities or the community's resources. For example, in court cases of domestic violence, how can we address the epistemic injustices committed against women who are systematically misheard by judges and jury members? As Moira Gatens (1996) argues in her examination of these cases, individuals' capacities and attitudes have to be critically examined and meliorated, but this—far from excluding—actually requires the critical examination and melioration of sociopolitical conditions and structures. Gatens criticizes the way in which judicial education programs on "gender awareness" were introduced in Australia without paying attention to how the differential social perceptions of men and women were rooted in institutional conditions, habits, and ways of life.[15] In these programs judges were exposed to reenactments of gender violence and expected to develop spontaneously a relation of empathy with the victim. Worse yet, the

[15] See especially her discussion of judicial "mishandling" on pages 136–41.

program naïvely assumed to be instilling a kind of empathy and gender sensitivity that the judges would be able to transfer to other victims of abuse when they took the stand to give testimony, as if somehow watching reenactments of abuse automatically made people better listeners to testimonial accounts of abuse. As Gatens explains, in Australia, these programs were supposed to address notorious cases in which blatant sexist judicial attitudes had been made explicit. For example, Gatens cites a marital rape case in which the judge instructs the jury as follows:

> Experience has taught the judges that there have been cases where women have manufactured or invented false allegations of rape and sexual attack. . . . There is, of course, nothing wrong with a husband, faced with his wife's initial refusal to engage in intercourse, in attempting, in an acceptable way, to persuade her to change her mind, and that may involve a measure of rougher than usual handling. (Gatens, p. 137)

Can judges who look at victims of gender violence in this light and invite jury members to do so be made better listeners simply by providing them with reenactments? I concur with Gatens that the "gender awareness" programs that simply provide information and reenactments are deeply flawed. They have a blind faith in the judges' ability to change their cognitive-affective attitudes and to improve their listening, as if their blind spots could always be removed by providing new observations or more information and did not have cognitive and affective defense mechanisms that made them resistant to isolated exercises. The critical reexamination and re-education required to improve communication in these cases is both individual and social: it requires a deep interrogation of the perspectives of judges[16] (and of other members of the judiciary) not only as individual perspectives but also as instances of social perspectives and in relation to other social perspectives. It requires examining how members of certain groups are perceived and listened to by members of other groups in the context of a systematic questioning of past and present dominant perceptions of social groups (contrasting them with alternative social perceptions of those groups that may also be available). It is in this sense that Gatens calls for a critical analysis and interrogation of the "dominant social habits, practices and beliefs" concerning women, marriage, and sexuality within the marriage. She asks what the dominant social attitudes are

[16] Gatens argues that "if it is the consciousness of the judges that requires 'raising' then it is *appropriate* to make the lives, experiences and beliefs of the *judges* an object of analysis. This would be to examine their beliefs not simply in relation to the *object* of those beliefs but in relation to the *subject of those beliefs*, that is, the embodied context of the judges themselves. The assumption of those who promote the present educational programmes is that judges can gain 'experience' of the lives of those whom they judge while their own lives, their own particular 'ways of being,' remain private or 'sacrosanct'" (pp. 140–41).

toward women and marriage that are embodied in our civil existences, and she answers,

> Women have not historically been entitled to protection from the civil body. Rather, the civil body had extended protection to its citizens, who as (male) heads of households were expected to provide protection for their wives in return for service and obedience. (p. 119)

As Gatens suggests, we cannot correct the flaws of sexist judicial attitudes unless we take on how judges (especially male judges) imagine women and how their imaginings derive from a particular social imaginary, inheriting distorted images of women and their perspectives. We cannot extend the judicial gaze or the judicial ear without examining how its limitations and biases have come about and how they operate. We cannot expect judicial minds to suddenly open up to a range of phenomena and perspectives precisely when they have been closed to them for quite some time and when there is an entire history and network of social practices that back up the closed-mindedness in question. To ensure that the plural perspectives of a diverse civil society are properly heard within its judicial system, this system has to be made answerable to different groups and constituencies, including and especially those who have been left out, those whose voices and perspectives may not carry equal weight and may face special challenges precisely because of their history of exclusion and oppression. Oppressed groups have unique vulnerabilities and require special attention precisely because the violation of their rights is often neglected (even unnoticed) and encounters a lack of community response and an inadequate social sensitivity that reinforces itself, becoming insensitive to insensitivity or meta-blindness. In order to tear down the walls of this meta-blindness, we need to start unveiling the history of exclusion and the multiplicity of practices, habits, and attitudes that have contributed to render certain people, their perspectives, and their suffering virtually invisible. This is exactly the approach that Gatens takes toward the phenomenon of domestic violence and the individual and collective responsibilities that are involved in it. She argues that, in order to address cases of judicial mishandling as well as the crimes of domestic violence themselves, "what is required is an analysis of women's historical and present relation to citizenship, that is, a study of the specific conditions of women's civil existence" (p. 120). Only in the context of that social analysis can we start understanding why in contemporary Western democracies, despite legal protections, so many women are abused and even killed by their partners acting in defiance of restraining orders, and why sometimes, despite the evidence, their particular cases do not find justice in the courtroom. And the lack of legal justice involves, crucially, a lack of hermeneutical justice, for it involves a failure of understanding and communication. This legal and hermeneutical injustice concerns a failure of epistemic responsibility not only on the part of the individual judges who preside over these

particular cases, but also on the part of society and its institutions (the media, the police, the educational system, etc.). It is a matter of the collective responsibility of a society that needs to learn to be more vigilant with certain vulnerabilities and to listen better to certain groups and their perspectives. I will come back to the phenomenon of domestic violence and the epistemic injustices surrounding it in section 4.3.

For now, it suffices to point out that the epistemic responsibilities we need to fulfill in order to ensure hermeneutical justice with respect to victims of domestic abuse are both individual and collective: they are deeply personal and profoundly political. As we have learned from previous waves of feminist theorists, the personal is political and the political is personal. This can be seen vividly in the issue of epistemic responsibility and, in particular, testimonial responsibility, which involves—among other things—the ability to empathize and to develop proper relations of trust. There has been recent work in feminist epistemology emphasizing the interrelations between the personal and the political in issues of trust. As Karen Jones (1996, 2002) and Naomi Scheman (2011) have argued, when it comes to empathy and trust, we have to look at both the personal and the political dimensions simultaneously. In chapter 4 I will discuss how individual epistemic responsibility extends into the social in crucial respects. And if individual responsibility is unavoidably social and can only be understood in relation to collectivities, collective responsibility inevitably implicates individuals and cannot be understood independently of the normative grasp it has on individual subjects. As I hope the reflections on the social imagination and collective agency in the last two chapters will make clear, collective responsibilities, far from being abstract and detached matters, concern concrete and situated individuals quite directly.

On the other hand, there is no way of escaping or overcoming hermeneutical injustices for as long as individuals and communities insist in finding one-sided solutions for liberation that mistakenly focus exclusively on a single dimension of normativity, whether this is epistemic normativity, ethical normativity, or political normativity. When it comes to communicative interactions and complex practices that require mutual understanding, the epistemic, the ethical, and the political are inextricably intertwined dimensions of normativity. In order to overcome situations of oppression, we need to transform the polis and its citizens simultaneously, and in multiple ways; we need to change their ethical, their political, and their epistemic ways of relating. The mistake of intellectualism is to think that by changing the epistemic, the ethical and the political will follow, whereas in fact people's concepts and cognitions may not control at all their emotions, moral characters, and political attitudes. Similarly, the mistake of ethicist perspectives is to think that by changing the moral dispositions of individuals, we take care of epistemic and political justice, whereas in fact epistemic interactions can be as biased as before (the social imaginary, for example, remaining intact) and sociopolitical relations as oppressive as

before. And, finally, the mistake of structuralist and collectivist views (such as classic Marxism) is to think that by changing the sociopolitical structures, people's ways of thinking and of relating to each other will automatically change, whereas in fact a structurally more equitable society can nonetheless retain its epistemic and ethical injustices in its everyday interactions and practices. Against these one-sided views of normativity—intellectualism, ethicism, and collectivism—I contend that deep-rooted injustices that affect communication—such as hermeneutical injustices—can only be addressed by a deep transformation and restructuring of people's epistemic, moral, and political sensitivities. These changes will typically take multiple generations and they require not only the transformation of the epistemic sensibilities that society is capable of instilling (the concepts rendered available, the epistemic perceptions, judgments, and ways of imagining that people are trained into), but also the reengineering of the ethical dispositions and affective structures that compose people's moral character, as well as a sociopolitical restructuring that calls for sustained political action and deep interventions in social and political structures. In other words, when the normative structures that govern our epistemic, ethical, and political lives become corrupted, the challenge that we face—as we shall see, both individually and collectively—is to change simultaneously people's minds, their moral character, and the structural conditions in which they live. This fits well with recent epistemologies of ignorance in race theory and feminist theory, which have provided an explosive interrogation of epistemic responsibility that blurs the boundaries between epistemology, ethics, political philosophy, and the social sciences.[17]

Following Fricker, I argue that we cannot properly address the epistemic independently of the ethical. But going beyond Fricker, I also argue that we cannot properly address the epistemic and the ethical independently of the political. My starting point for this multilayered view of normativity is Fricker's account of testimonial virtue as involving a hybrid virtuous perception that is both moral and epistemic. I fully agree with this hybrid account, but I will expand Fricker's normative stance by connecting the epistemic and the moral with the political in ways that ultimately depart from her ethicist approach. Fricker's hybrid view can be summarized in the following claim: one cannot see one's interlocutors in epistemic color without seeing them in ethical color.[18] My revision and expansion of this view adds the following claim: one cannot see one's interlocutors in epistemic color without seeing them in political color.[19] We can run a quick and dirty version of the argument by

[17] See especially Mills (1997) and (1998), Sullivan (2006), and Sullivan and Tuana (2007).

[18] As she herself puts it, "Seeing a speaker in epistemic colour entails seeing them in some moral colour" (p. 76).

[19] In the literature on testimony, this step has already been taken by some. See especially Karen Jones's (2002) "The Politics of Credibility."

noting how the epistemic, the ethical, and the political converge in relations of trust. Fricker argues that "epistemic trust incorporates ethical trust, because epistemic trustworthiness incorporates one kind of moral trustworthiness: namely, sincerity. Accordingly, the virtuous hearer's sensitivity to epistemic saliences will involve a sensitivity to some moral saliences" (p. 76). When this trust is broken as a result of a negative stereotype that casts doubt on the epistemic capacities of an agent, the agent's ethos and ethical relations are called into question. Unfairly produced distrust involves dysfunctional epistemic and ethical relations. And if the unfair distrust is produced as a result of systematic prejudices against a group that are part of a situation of oppression, the epistemic and ethical dysfunctions in question take a particular form: a *political* form, I contend. According to Fricker,

> If the stereotype embodies a prejudice that works against the speaker, then two things follow: there is an epistemic dysfunction in the exchange—the hearer makes an unduly deflated judgment of the speaker's credibility, perhaps missing out on knowledge as a result; and the hearer does something ethically bad—the speaker is wrongfully undermined in her capacity as a knower. (p. 17)

I contend that there is also a *political dysfunction* in addition to the epistemic and ethical dysfunctions recognized by Fricker. By contrast, Fricker argues that "the primary harm" is an ethical harm:

> The harm that concerns us here is not the epistemic harm incurred by the hearer or the epistemic system, nor any implied damage done to the foundations of the polity and its institutions, but rather the immediate wrong that the hearer does to the speaker who is in the receiving end of a testimonial injustice. (p. 44)

Fricker goes on to explain this "immediate wrong" in ethical terms: the speaker is "wronged in her capacity as a knower," which is "a capacity essential to human value"; therefore, she is wronged in her humanity. This seems correct, but why should it be taken to imply the primacy of the ethical over the political, as Fricker's view of epistemic injustice suggests? What Fricker describes as the "immediate wrong" done to the speaker not only has immediate political implications (as she acknowledges), but it is in fact grounded in and mediated by political factors (the categorization of people into social groups, the sustained relations among these groups, the prejudices that circulate about them, etc.); in fact, the "immediate wrong" that takes place in a testimonial interaction is quite derivative and impossible to understand outside the context of systematic political harms that precede it and follow it.

A lack of trust can entail not only epistemic and ethical mistreatment, but also political mistreatment. In this sense, we need to expand Fricker's analysis of unfair credibility assessments that are biased by a negative stereotype and

result in credibility deficits. Fricker argues that the hearer whose credibility assessments of a speaker are under the sway of a negative stereotype misconceives the speaker's epistemic and ethical character, diminishing him or her as a knower and a doer (depriving the speaker of epistemic and/or moral qualities such as reliability, sincerity, etc.) and, therefore, committing both an epistemic and an ethical injustice. The crucial additional aspect I want to introduce here is political: a *political injustice* is also being committed when the epistemic and ethical mistreatments occur, for these mistreatments also involve, in a crucial way, the differential treatment of entire groups—not only of individuals—which contributes to an unjust configuration of the whole polis. The epistemic and ethical dysfunctions that occur in testimonial exchanges cannot be properly understood as taking place exclusively between two isolated individuals. They have to be put against the background of the systematic unfair relations among social groups that precede those exchanges and affect them, making it not only possible but also more likely than not that minoritized subjects be epistemically mistreated in situations of oppression. In a case of testimonial injustice in which an identity prejudice is operating, a hearer does an epistemic and an ethical wrong; but also, and even more importantly, a political wrong is also committed, even if it is not entirely the hearer's doing, even if the hearer is only implicitly relying on it and unknowingly contributing to it. For note that the object of the unfair treatment—who is being "undermined in his/her capacity as a knower," as Fricker puts it—is *not just* the speaker, not the speaker *simpliciter*, but the speaker as a member of a group—of a hermeneutically marginalized, disadvantaged group; therefore, social relationality is thus compromised and vitiated, prior to and beyond this particular exchange. The unfair treatment occurs as it does in the exchange because of existing pernicious political habits that inform people's (epistemic and ethical) lives; and the unjust exchange thus becomes an event in a whole array of incidents that in turn feed those pernicious political habits and contribute to their perpetuation. We have here a *political dysfunction* within which the epistemic and ethical dysfunctions have to be located and understood, since the latter result from (while at the same time feeding into) the former. I agree with Fricker that in unfairly biased credibility assessments there is a "dual epistemic and ethical dysfunction" (p. 17). But both of them are in fact grounded in, facilitated by, and sustained by a political dysfunction.

Looking at epistemic injustices as being triply dysfunctional (i.e., as involving epistemic, ethical, and political dysfunctions) fits in well with what has been a guiding theme of this chapter: namely, the expansion of the notion of epistemic injustice. Initially, this expansion took place by showing that epistemic injustice involves a lack of proportionality in the appraisals of epistemic qualities such as credibility. According to my proportional view of epistemic justice, an epistemic appraisal is always comparative and contrastive and, therefore, it always concerns more than the particular subject(s)

under consideration because the comparison and contrast classes that support the appraisal are also affected. In my view, epistemic appraisals always contain an element of social systematicity, even when they appear to be quite isolated, because they operate against the background of a system of relations and they involve interpersonal perceptions that are mediated by the social imagination. According to my argument, integral parts of epistemic injustices are not only the epistemic deficits that oppressed subjects have to endure but also the epistemic excesses (excessive authority and credibility, excessive self-confidence, etc.) that privileged subjects enjoy and which spoil their epistemic character. I further argued that the epistemic vices of the privileged tend to produce a particular form of ignorance which I referred to as *meta-blindness* (or *meta-insensitivity*)—a cognitive and affective numbing that can be described as *insensitivity to insensitivity*. How can we sensitize people to insensitivities? We saw before that the problem of meta-blindness called for a cognitive-affective restructuring of people's lives, which can improve epistemic interactions and interpersonal relations; and we now see that the requisite cognitive-affective melioration requires a very complex transformative process that has multiple and interrelated normative dimensions: an epistemic, ethical, and political reeducation that touches on all aspects of people's lives in common. These two ideas are interrelated: the realization that the problem of meta-blindness is an epistemic, ethical, and political problem goes hand in hand with the realization that the reconstruction of cognitive and affective structures requires not only epistemic interventions, but also and simultaneously moral and political ones. These multiple levels of normativity will be involved in my analysis and discussion of responsibility in subsequent chapters. Although the focus of my discussion will be *epistemic responsibility*, I will also explore its relation to the ethical and the political, trying to show that certain epistemic obligations are required in order to be ethically and politically responsible, and that being epistemically responsible also involves living one's ethical and political life in particular ways.

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Imposed Silences and Shared Hermeneutical Responsibilities

In a preliminary way, we can roughly define *hermeneutical injustice* as the kind of epistemic injustice that occurs when a subject is unfairly disadvantaged in her capacities to make sense of an experience. Although I am in agreement with Miranda Fricker's context-sensitive approach to hermeneutical injustice in her ground-breaking book *Epistemic Injustice* (2007), in this chapter I will argue that this contextualist approach has to be pluralized and rendered relational in more complex ways. In the first place, I argue that the normative assessment of social silences and the epistemic harms they generate cannot be properly carried out without a pluralistic analysis of the different interpretative communities and interpretative practices that coexist in the social context in question. Social silences and hermeneutical gaps are incorrectly described if they are uniformly predicated on an entire social context, instead of being predicated on particular ways of inhabiting that context by particular people in relation to particular others. I contend that a more nuanced—*polyphonic*—contextualization offers a more adequate picture of what it means to break social silences and to repair the hermeneutical injustices associated with them. In the second place, I argue that the particular obligations with respect to hermeneutical justice that differently situated subjects and groups have are *interactive* and need to be determined *relationally*. That is, whether individuals and groups live up to their hermeneutical responsibilities has to be assessed by taking into account the forms of mutual positionality, relationality, and responsiveness (or lack thereof) that these subjects and groups display with respect to one another. I will develop the core of my argument through an examination of what in contemporary epistemologies of ignorance has been termed "white ignorance," that is, the kind of hermeneutical inability of privileged white subjects to recognize and make sense of their racial identities, experiences, and positionality in a racialized world.

This is how I plan to make Fricker's social contextualism more deeply pluralistic, interactive, and dynamic. In section 3.1 I will offer an expansion of Fricker's analysis of *silencing*, arguing that we need to pay attention to the performative and pragmatic aspects of communicative dynamics to fully

appreciate the patterns of silence that are part of epistemic injustice in general and of hermeneutical injustice in particular. In section 3.2 I will try to show that a more deeply pluralistic account of hermeneutical justice is needed, one that takes into account the communicative dynamics of a plurality of publics that are internally heterogeneous and contain multiple voices and perspectives. Finally, in section 3.3, I will use my polyphonic contextualism to expand Fricker's view of what counts as *virtuous interpretative responsiveness* and to offer a more robust notion of epistemic responsibility with respect to hermeneutical justice.

3.1. Silences and the Communicative Approach to Epistemic Injustice

In the communicative approach I will be developing in this chapter, hermeneutical injustice will be treated, roughly, as the kind of injustice that appears when there are wrongful interpretative obstacles that affect people differently in how they are *silenced*, that is, in their inability to express themselves and to be understood. Understanding the communicative dynamics in and through which people are differentially silenced, and the plurality of ways in which this can happen in sociohistorical contexts of communication, is the key to understanding hermeneutical injustices. Fricker distinguishes two different kinds of socially produced silences based on identity prejudices. In the first place, there are *preemptive silences*: people can be *preemptively* silenced by being excluded in advance from participating in communicative exchanges. As Fricker puts it, there is "*pre-emptive* testimonial injustice" when there is "a tendency for some groups simply not to be asked for information in the first place" (p. 130). Fricker emphasizes that preemptive silencing is "highly context-dependent." It is unlikely that we could find subjects "whose knowledge or opinions were *never* solicited on *any* subject matter" (pp. 130–131). Instead, our contextualist analyses of preemptive silencing should look for specific contexts of communicative interaction in which the participation of particular groups of people become constrained in particular respects. But within a particular context and with respect to a particular topic or set of issues, the communicative dynamics may not exclude any group from participation, and nonetheless the members of different groups may enjoy quite different voices in that context, and they may be heard differently. In other words, even when people are not entirely excluded from participation, their communicative agency may be constrained or compromised in important ways; and the appreciation of their contributions may not be on a par with that of others. This is addressed (at least in part) in the second kind of silencing that Fricker analyzes: what she calls "*epistemic objectification*" (p. 133).

In this second kind of silencing, people's participation in communicative exchanges is allowed, their contributions are in fact used for knowledge-production and knowledge-transmission purposes, but nonetheless, they are

not treated as informants—that is, as subjects of knowledge or "epistemic agents who convey information"—but only as sources of information—that is, as objects or "states of affairs from which the inquirer may be in a position to glean information" (p. 132). Here too Fricker emphasizes that "context is all" when it comes to determine whether an epistemic objectification amounts to an epistemic injustice (p. 133). Regarding others as objects in epistemic interactions is not intrinsically wrong and, in fact, it is unproblematic when the speakers so regarded are *also*, at other moments, treated *as subjects* of knowledge and *not as mere objects*. It follows from this contextualist insight that we need to follow communicative exchanges long enough in order to detect their patterns of epistemic interaction and the communicative dynamics that unfolds in them over time. I could not agree more with this contextualist perspective. As I argued in the previous chapter, epistemic injustices can be detected only in temporally and socially extended contexts where patterns of communicative interaction unfold. However, while in agreement with Fricker's contextualist approach, I submit that her notions of silencing and "epistemic objectification" need to be expanded.

According to Fricker, a speaker is epistemically objectified when she is undermined "in her capacity as a *giver* of knowledge" (p. 133; my emphasis). But a speaker can also be undermined in her capacity as a *producer* of knowledge, that is, not as an *informant* who reports to an inquirer, but as an *inquirer* herself, as an investigative subject who asks questions and issues interpretations and evaluations of knowledge and opinions. Assuming that all silencing and all objectifying are avoided when speakers are treated as *informants* is wrong, for their voices can still be constrained and minimized, and their capacities as knowers can still be undermined. The epistemic agency of an informant *qua informant* is limited and subordinated to that of the inquirer's. Qua informant, the epistemic agency of a speaker (her capacity to convey information and act as a giver of knowledge) is at the service of the inquirer's epistemic agency (her questions, her assessments, and her interpretations). There is of course nothing wrong in treating someone as an informant. But there could be problems of epistemic justice in treating someone *only* as an informant, for there is *no full and equal epistemic cooperation* when that is the case. When one is allowed to be an informant *without* being allowed to be an inquirer, one is allowed to enter into one set of communicative activities—those relating to passing knowledge and opinions—but not others, precisely those others that are more sophisticated, happen at a higher level of abstraction, and require more epistemic authority: formulating hypotheses, probing and questioning, assessing and interpreting knowledge and opinions, and so on. Giving people "epistemic subjectivity" instead of treating them as mere objects does not guarantee that "their general status as a subject of knowledge" may not be constrained or minimized in specific respects in particular communicative dynamics. The treatment of

women as hysterics, of queer people as pathologically deviant, and of people of color as perennially immature was consistent with treating them as informants with epistemic subjectivity and agency (though limited and defective). Even on the topics and in the contexts in which these subjects have been given a differential voice and differential epistemic agency, they could nonetheless be treated as subjects of knowledge, but without the full range of epistemic capacities that other subjects enjoy as inquirers and evaluators of knowledge.

Identifying deficits in attributions of epistemic agency requires that we pay attention to subtle aspects of the communicative dynamics among participants in epistemic exchanges. Communicative contexts are typically populated by differently situated voices with differential epistemic agency; and participants in communicative exchanges have to make special efforts to promote their equality and to work against biases that affect their interaction. As fair communicators who treat each other as equals, participants in these exchanges have communicative obligations with respect to epistemic justice that go beyond allowing others to speak and to enjoy the generic status of an epistemic subject. In particular, they have an obligation to remain open to the (in principle) *reversibility* of roles in communication, inquiry, and interpretation. The communicative relations that are established in epistemic interaction have to be in principle *reciprocal*, with their roles—of inquirer and informant, for example—being potentially reversible. Nothing short of this reversibility and reciprocity can guarantee the equality in communicative participation required by fair epistemic practices. This has been emphasized by those theorists who have drawn normative epistemic implications from speech act theory. It was done by Jürgen Habermas in his *Theory of Communicative Action* (1984), and more recently by Jennifer Hornsby and Rae Langton in "Free Speech and Illocution" (1998).

Fricker discusses the work of Hornsby and Langton and their notion of *reciprocity*: "a primitive relational stance that fellow communicators have towards one another *as* communicators" (p. 140). Hornsby and Langton establish a close link between reciprocity and uptake, arguing that relations of reciprocity foster communicative climates that facilitate uptake. This emphasis on uptake underscores the *interactive* dimension of epistemic exchanges. In the communicative dynamics of a communicative exchange it is crucial to pay attention not only to how the speaker's utterances are semantically assessed by the hearers, but also how the hearers performatively address the speaker and how they respond or fail to respond to the illocutionary aspects of the speaker's speech acts: for example, responding to "Look out!" as a warning, or to "No!" as an act of refusal or withholding consent. Hearers are not mere spectators who analyze and assess utterances from a distance; they are engaged participants who have the capacity to respond and engage with the speaker's communicative actions. A continued lack of reciprocity and a

systematic failure of uptake silence speakers and produce *communicative dysfunctions*, which call for special efforts at interpretation. The paradigmatic case of dysfunctional communicative dynamics that Hornsby and Langton analyze is that of women's attempts at rejecting sexual advances when they receive no proper uptake. They argue that in cases such as these we should construe the lack of uptake as a form of silencing. Fricker agrees with Hornsby and Langton's treatment of these communicative dysfunctions:

> It may be legally important, for instance, that a less than fully successful illocution of 'No' can be sufficient for withholding sexual consent, lest failure of uptake on the part of an attacker be construed as exculpating him from a charge of sexual assault. (p. 141)

But Fricker takes issue with the *communicative* account of silencing that Hornsby and Langton offer, failing to integrate in her view an interactive approach to epistemic exchanges in which uptake and performative negotiations figure prominently.

Fricker contends that Hornsby and Langton provide "a purely communicative conception of silencing" which is non-epistemic (p. 141). She argues that, on this account, what is at issue is not the hearer's appraisal of the speaker's credibility, but rather, the performative dynamics between them and the illocutionary possibilities available to the speaker:

> The silenced woman's problem is not that her interlocutor regards her word as so worthless that when she says "No" he doesn't hear her; rather, his stance towards her in the context is such that she is prevented from (fully successfully) performing the illocutionary act of refusal in the first place. (Ibid.)

By contrast, Fricker argues that her "epistemic model . . . requires less erosion of women's human status" (p. 142), explaining the silencing of women's voices only in terms of their lack of credibility. But Fricker's epistemic analysis, I want to suggest, is perfectly compatible with the performative analysis; in fact, they nicely complement each other. Women's credibility is indeed at issue, but so is the broader issue of whether women can mean what they say and are in a position to assess their communicative intentions vis-à-vis others. And the latter concerns basic communicative capacities that subjects must enjoy if they are to be considered epistemic agents in a full sense. Fricker goes on to argue, persuasively, that "when someone is excluded from the relations of epistemic trust that are at work in a co-operative practice of pooling information, they are wrongfully excluded from participation in the practice that defines the core of the concept of knowledge" (p. 145). Indeed they are attributed a deficient and inferior epistemic subjectivity and a precarious epistemic agency. I could not agree more. But these epistemic exclusions and deficient attributions can be properly detected *only* if uptake and communicative

dynamics are taken into account. The interactive and performative approach enables us to recognize whether subjects can talk back and have agency and negotiating power in the interpretation and evaluation of their experiences, and whether they have full status as inquirers and interpreters. Asking us to choose between the communicative and the epistemic analysis of the phenomena of silencing creates a false dichotomy that we should not be confronted with, for silencing raises both an epistemic and a communicative problem. As I will discuss in the next section, silencing is typically accompanied by processes of *struggling to make sense*, in which issues of credibility and issues of intelligibility are intertwined. Silencing is one of the areas in which we cannot separate out communicative and epistemic agency: it is because of impoverished communicative dynamics without reciprocity and uptake that epistemic trust cannot be established and credibility is undermined; and when epistemic subjectivity and agency are seriously compromised, the subject's communicative capacities cannot be recovered and she will enjoy, at best, an inferior voice in the interaction. When communicative negotiations are impaired, epistemic negotiations become limited and defective, and vice versa.

The communicative and performative approach to epistemic interactions offers us an *enlarged conception of epistemic agency* that has at its core the communicative reversibility of epistemic roles. Epistemic agency crucially involves the capacity to engage in epistemic negotiations, and it is not properly understood if its interactive dimension is disregarded and subjects of knowledge are simply conceived as adopting one epistemic role at a time—now informant, now inquirer, now conveyer of information, now assessor and evaluator—without looking into the communicative dynamics in which these roles are entangled, become alive, grow, shrink, and develop interrelated trajectories. It is crucial to develop a dynamic and interactive view of epistemic activities that pays attention to (and traces the trajectory of) people's responsiveness to each other's contributions, so that we can assess the degree of cooperation and joint participation in all the aspects of epistemic interaction. Epistemic interaction involves more than the mere pooling of information; it also involves negotiating processes of mutual interrogation and the collaborative generation of meanings and interpretative possibilities.

Drawing on the interactive communicative approach defended here, in the next section I will argue that Fricker pays insufficient attention to the communicative and performative dimension of hermeneutical injustice, which is treated mainly as a *semantic* phenomenon concerning the intelligibility of experiential contents. In the second place, although Fricker offers a powerful contextualist approach that I endorse, I will argue that this approach is insufficiently pluralized, making it difficult to account for some cognitive dysfunctions and hermeneutical harms that recent epistemologies of ignorance have analyzed.

3.2. Communicative Pluralism and Hermeneutical Injustice

As suggested in the previous chapter, hermeneutical and testimonial injustices are often interrelated so intimately that we cannot understand one without the other. Fricker talks about their convergence as if it were an occasional occurrence, a special case in which "a double epistemic injustice" is committed and "the speaker is doubly wronged: once by the structural prejudice in the shared hermeneutical resource, and once by the hearer in making an identity-prejudiced credibility judgment" (2007, p. 159). This "grim possibility," Fricker observes, appears when we find a "speaker struggling to make herself intelligible in a testimonial exchange"; in such a case, "hermeneutical injustice might often be compounded by testimonial injustices" (Ibid.). Indeed the hermeneutically disadvantaged speaker is likely to find unsympathetic listeners who find her insufficiently credible. But my communicative interactionism suggests an even deeper connection in which these two types of injustice become intertwined, feeding each other and deepening the effects of each other. On the one hand, hermeneutical injustices are maintained and passed on through testimonial dynamics that exhibit systematic failures of communicative and performative responsiveness: interpretative gaps among partners in communication are formed, maintained, and passed on, because those who are struggling to make sense are persistently not heard and their inchoate attempts at generating new meanings are blocked or unanswered. In other words, these gaps emerge from and are supported by *testimonial insensitivities*. And, on the other hand, testimonial injustices become not simply likely but almost inescapable when the persistence of hermeneutical gaps renders certain voices less intelligible (and hence less credible) than others on certain matters, and their attempts to articulate certain meanings are systematically regarded as nonsensical (and hence incredible). Because of difficulties in expressing and interpreting certain things—because of *hermeneutical insensitivities*—people's credibility can get undermined; but also their lack of credibility can call into question the intelligibility of their formulations and interpretations, especially when they are advancing new meanings and struggling to make sense in the face of widespread hermeneutical limitations. Testimonial insensitivities and hermeneutical insensitivities feed each other.[1]

[1] As argued in the previous chapter, this is well illustrated by one of the novels that Fricker analyzes, Harper Lee's *To Kill a Mockingbird* (1960/2002). According to my analysis, this novel illustrates how a number of antecedent hermeneutical and testimonial obstacles make it very difficult for epistemic justice to take place at the trial of Tom Robinson. These obstacles make it difficult for people to understand interracial desire and women's sexual agency; and, as a result, Tom has a hard time making his testimony on Mayella's sexual attraction to him credible. His audience does not exhibit much sympathy, communicative cooperation, or interpretative charity. The failure of his listeners is both testimonial and hermeneutical. For listeners such as these to become more charitable and virtuous, they would have to improve, simultaneously, their hermeneutical and testimonial sensibilities.

The central suggestion of my communicative interactionism is that hermeneutical gaps have to be understood in terms of failures in communicative and interpretative responsiveness, that is, as deficits in hermeneutical sensibility. Hermeneutical insensitivities involve the inability to respond to attempts (however inarticulate) to express certain aspects of our experience or the experience of others. It is because of socially cultivated hermeneutical insensitivities that communicative attempts to articulate certain meanings can remain systematically unattended and hermeneutical gaps can be formed and kept in place. The agential aspect of hermeneutical gaps is obscured by Fricker's analogy with ozone holes, which can be misleading: "Hermeneutical lacunas are like holes in the ozone—it's people who live under them that get burned" (p. 161).

But hermeneutical gaps are nothing like ozone holes if these are conceived as fixed spots whose existence and power over our lives are independent of our agency. On the other hand, they are a lot like ozone holes if these are conceived as intimately and interactively related to our agency: as the result of our ways of moving about and inhabiting the world, as an accumulation of negative effects of our actions, these "holes" are formed and, once formed, they have a negative impact on our lives. It is—at least in part—because of the cumulative effects of our environmentally insensitive behavior that ozone holes are formed, and, once in place, they handicap our environmental lives and are hard to eradicate. Similarly, it is—at least in part—because of the cumulative effects of our hermeneutically insensitive behavior that hermeneutical gaps are formed, and, once in place, they handicap our communicative lives and are hard to eradicate. In order to identify and properly diagnose hermeneutical insensitivities, communicative dynamics matter deeply: it is of the utmost importance *who* is communicating (or trying to communicate) *what* to *whom*. But specific communicative processes are not explicitly considered in Fricker's analysis of hermeneutical injustice, which focuses on the lack of intelligibility of the experience of certain groups, without specifying for whom experience is being rendered unintelligible, in what kind of communicative interaction and according to which dynamic.

Communicative dynamics are not at the forefront of Fricker's analysis of hermeneutical injustice, which is not initially couched in explicit communicative terms, but in semantic terms, that is, in terms of the *intelligibility* of experience. Initially, in chapter 7, Fricker describes hermeneutical injustice as resulting in the "occluded experiences" of hermeneutically marginalized subjects, contending that what characterizes hermeneutically disadvantaged groups is their inability "to understand their own experiences" (pp. 147–8). Later, however, the focus shifts to the communication of these experiences, and Fricker then describes being hermeneutically marginalized as enjoying unequal participation in communicative practices in which meanings are generated and expressed. The problem resides with the ambiguity in the expression "the

intelligibility of experience," which can refer to people's abilities to understand their own experiences or to their abilities to communicate about them with diverse others. The multifaceted aspects of the *struggles to make sense* of one's experiences to oneself, to those who undergo similar experiences, and to other groups are obscured by simply talking about the intelligibility or unintelligibility of experience without specifying to whom, in what communicative context, and with what dynamic—because quite different possibilities are opened up (or can be opened up) depending on those variables: whether one is talking to oneself, to sympathetic subjects, or to unsympathetic subjects; whether the communicative context—or the speakers claiming agency in it—allows for semantic innovations, flexibility, and playfulness; whether the speaker finds receptivity and responsiveness when deviating from standard semantic expectations; and, in general, how the communicative interaction unfolds.

Fricker remarks that hermeneutical injustices take place when and because "a collective hermeneutical gap prevents members of a group from making sense of an experience that is in their interest to render intelligible" (p. 7). What is meant by this hermeneutical activity of "making sense of an experience" that is undermined? Making sense to whom? To oneself? To others? And which others? There are different communicative processes by which we try to make sense of our experiences. It is not the same to try to make sense of one's experience to oneself, to others within one's group or in the same predicament, or to others who do not share the experience in question.[2] And when it comes to hermeneutical gaps, it is crucial to pay attention to the communicative processes in which subjects *struggle to make sense to themselves* of what they cannot yet communicate to others, especially to those others who do not share their predicament. Through these communicative attempts, subjects start to work on the melioration of hermeneutical sensibilities, starting with their own and with the sensibilities of those in communicative contact with them. Through repeated attempts to communicate with ourselves and with those around us about experiences that have been obscured and hermeneutically marginalized, we can expand our hermeneutical sensibilities and eventually add to the hermeneutical resources of our group through contributions that could also spread to other groups, with new interpretative tools acquiring progressively wider circulation. According to this dynamic view of hermeneutical resources and agency, it is misleading to assume that only what has been antecedently recognized and included in the "shared hermeneutical resource" can be rendered intelligible, whether to oneself or to others. In this sense, it is dangerous to establish too close a link between intelligibility and linguistic labels.

[2] These communicative interactions are distinct, but interrelated in crucial ways. Indeed, how we learn to communicate experiences to others influences tremendously—but does not fully determine—what we manage to make sense of to ourselves.

Fricker is certainly right that sometimes we find "a lacuna where the name of a distinctive social experience should be" (pp. 150–151). But multiple struggles to make sense have to be sustained over time for a group of subjects to develop this definite sense of the contours of a social experience that still lacks a name. This is, roughly, the story of new interpretative tools created by movements of resistance such as the women's movement, the civil rights movement, or the sexual liberation movement. As Fricker points out, "speak-outs" were organized in the women's movement to address experiences of sexual intimidation even before labels such as "sexual harassment" were available. And, as Fricker remarks, women activists found themselves in the peculiar situation that "the 'this' they were going to break the silence about had no name" (p. 150).

We should be careful not to tie too closely people's hermeneutical capacities to the repertoire of readily available terms and coined concepts, as if oppressed subjects did not have ways of expressing their suffering well before such articulations were available. For example, non-heterosexual subjects had ways of signaling to themselves and to others like them that they were being sexually oppressed long before terms such as "homophobia" and "heterosexism" were in circulation. And women suffering abuse from their partners were struggling to make sense of their experiences and to give expression to their predicament, even if in fragmentary and precarious ways, long before labels such as "marital rape" and "domestic violence" were available.[3] It is crucial to develop *a hermeneutical sensibility with respect to embryonic and inchoate attempts at communicating* about experiences that do not yet have standard formulations. Nascent meanings may be in an embryonic process of formation, and their tentative expressions may not yet be accepted by the mainstream public (or even by most publics) within a culture. And this goes not only for negative experiences of suffering that are silenced, but also for positive experiences and life-affirming situations that new emerging publics may be struggling to make sense of, or simply struggling to convey to others. For example, the intelligibility of same-sex relations should not be directly tied to the emergence of labels such as "same-sex marriage" or "civil unions," or to a woman's capacity to refer to her lesbian lover as "girlfriend," "wife," "spouse," or "partner," and a man's capacity to refer to his gay lover as "boyfriend," "husband," "spouse," or "partner." I am not suggesting, of course, that these labels have not helped in gay people's struggle to make sense of their relationships. Rather, I am suggesting that they are a late chapter in that struggle, and we lose sight of the more

[3] In this sense, it is instructive to consider Uma Narayan's cross-cultural comparisons between discourses about domestic violence in countries such as the United States, where such labels have currency, and in countries such as India where their application is blocked. See especially chapter 3 of Narayan (1997): "Cross-Cultural Connections, Border-Crossings, and 'Death by Culture': Thinking about Dowry-Murders in India and Domestic Violence in the United States," pages 82–117. I will discuss some of the issues raised by Narayan, in section 4.4.

dynamic, interactive, and complicated processes of communication through which gay people made sense of their sexual and affective attachments and commitments in the absence of those labels.

There may be such hidden communicative processes and embryonic formulations of meaning even in the most adverse hermeneutical contexts. As Charles Mills (2007), for one, has suggested, even during slavery there were multiple ways in which black voices found ways to express their suffering and to speak out against racial oppression. And it would be to indulge in a dangerous fiction to postulate a dark time in which *everybody* was blind to the wrongs of slavery and *nobody* knew how to communicate about them.[4] As I have argued elsewhere (2006a), communicative contexts are always polyphonic, and the plurality of experiential and hermeneutical perspectives in any given context is such that we can always find voices that depart from the available communicative practices and dynamics, and their eccentric agency exceeds standard meanings and interpretative resources. There is a point in Fricker's discussion where she formulates this pluralistic phenomenon of there being perspectives that go beyond what the dominant interpretative framework and its hermeneutical resources allow. This is where she describes the experience of *dissonance* between one's experience and the interpretative horizon one has inherited. She describes this experience as the source of an important form of "resistance"—*hermeneutical resistance*, we can call it—which originates in the following way:

> Authoritative constructions in the shared hermeneutical resource . . . impinge on us collectively but not uniformly, and the non-uniformity of their hold over us can create a sense of dissonance between an experience and the various constructions that are ganging up to overpower its nascent proper meaning. (p. 166)

Hermeneutical resistance shows vividly that conflicts can appear in communicative dynamics. Fricker pays some attention to communicative dynamics in her discussion of hermeneutical injustice when she shifts from semantic contents to voices and expressive styles: "a hermeneutical gap might equally concern not (or not only) the content but rather the form of what can be said" (p. 160). At this point Fricker's discussion turns to the development of a voice under adverse hermeneutical climates, shifting the focus from the semantics of experiential contents to the pragmatics of meaning-making and meaning-sharing activities. However, Fricker's discussion quickly goes back

[4] Mills (2007) writes, "Black counter-testimony against white mythology has always existed but would originally have been handicapped by the lack of material and cultural capital investment available for its production" (p. 33). There have been all kinds of mechanisms in white epistemic practices that have contributed to maintain "the repudiation of an alternative black memory" (p. 30). This will be discussed in section 6.4.

to the semantic level as she goes on to analyze "the wrong of hermeneutical injustice" in terms of the intelligibility or unintelligibility of experience. Given the heterogeneity and fluidity of discursive possibilities in communicative interactions, I find it problematic that Fricker operates with the working assumption that when there is a hermeneutical gap, a range of experiences will be rendered unintelligible *for everybody* independently of particular communicative dynamics. To begin with, the unintelligibility of an experience in the speaker's terms is quite different when the speaker's attempts to communicate the experience encounter inattention, hermeneutical neglect, or hermeneutical incapacity—that is, when the interlocutors are unmoved or unable to identify what is being talked about—and, on the other hand, when speakers encounter *counter-interpretations* that systematically distort their communicative attempts—for example, when a woman's attempts to convey that she feels sexually harassed are interpreted as an overreaction to "harmless flirting." Systematic distortions of this sort typically limit some subjects' capacity to understand under some conditions, but not of the whole social body. As epistemologies of ignorance have emphasized, it is not always the case that hermeneutical gaps render experiences unintelligible for everybody equally and in every communicative dynamic. As epistemologists (such as standpoint theorists) writing on interracial, intergender, and intersexual (mis)communication and (mis)understanding have emphasized, when we encounter hermeneutical problems in situations of oppression, it is of the utmost importance to keep in mind that a complex society often contains diverse publics with heterogeneous interpretative resources and practices.

Public silences, even when they do involve unfair hermeneutical disadvantages, should not be equated with a complete expressive and interpretative incapacity. Sometimes oppressed or marginalized publics do not communicate about certain things with other publics not because they are hermeneutically incapable of doing so, but because, given the special vulnerabilities they have accrued, it is not in their interest to do so. In my view, this amounts to a hermeneutical injustice because these publics—unlike hermeneutically privileged ones—are forced to inhabit communicative contexts in which they cannot exercise their hermeneutical capacities to make sense of their experiences, or they can only exercise them at high costs that others do not have to pay. A perfect illustration of this kind of hermeneutical injustice is provided by Patricia Hill Collins's analysis of black women's silence about sexuality. According to Collins's analysis, there are three different factors "shaping patterns of silence" here (1990/2000, p. 125). The first one is the suppression of black women's voices by dominant groups: "Those who control the schools, news media, churches, and government suppress Black women's collective voice" (p. 123). But Collins observes that since in the twentieth century black women have become quite outspoken about other topics despite the institutional suppression of their voices

in mainstream contexts, this suppression cannot fully explain their persistent silence about sexuality. A second factor behind the patterns of silence that Collins analyzes is what she calls "Black women's struggles to work within the confines of norms of racial solidarity" (p. 125). In the United States, Collins shows, black women have been discouraged to speak about sexual topics that put black men at risk. Following norms of racial solidarity, black women have prioritized the vulnerabilities of black men over their own vulnerabilities, and they have often chosen not to speak about rape, incest, and sexual violence in the black community, not because they did not have a language or a context to do it, but because of distrust of non-black publics and because of fear of deepening the sexual stigmatizations of black men. In the third place, another factor that has shaped black women's sexual silence, according to Collins, is self-protection. The "potential benefits of remaining silent" (p. 124) have counseled black women to retreat to the safety of intimate spaces and communities to talk about sexuality. Secrecy about sexual matters has been crucial for black women's safety, given their sexual stigmatization:

> This secrecy was especially important within a US culture that routinely accused Black women of being sexually immoral, promiscuous jezebels. In a climate where one's sexuality is on public display, holding fast to privacy and trying to shut the closet door becomes paramount. (p. 125)

Finding safe spaces of interaction and developing agency and resources to resist required that black women keep silent about certain topics that could compromise their struggles and deepen their vulnerabilities. In the eloquent words of Darlene Hine, "Only with secrecy, thus achieving a self-imposed invisibility, could ordinary black women accrue the psychic space and harness the resources needed to hold their own in the often one-sided and mismatched resistance struggle" (quoted by Collins, p. 125).

So black women's long-standing sexual silence has been due not only to the lack of opportunities and resources to talk about sexual matters, but also and more importantly to the need to protect others and to protect themselves. Traditionally black women reserved their discussions of sexuality to the confines of their own community, refusing to engage communicatively with other publics on sexual matters. As a result, they have appeared to be *silent on the outside*,[5] while being talkative in the inside and among themselves. But it would be a distortion to describe this silence on the outside as a merely *chosen* or *self-imposed* public silence, as if there were no problem of justice here, for black women's voices have been unfairly coerced to remain silent where others could speak freely and at no (or little) cost, and, therefore, this constitutes a

[5] I borrow this expression from the dissertation of Carolyn Cusick, a Ph.D. student at Vanderbilt University. I am indebted to Carolyn for her insightful remarks on Collins's analysis of silence.

hermeneutical injustice even though the victims do not lack the expressive resources and capacities to communicate. In order to analyze properly the different public silences that different groups may experience, we need to take into account the plurality of publics that interact communicatively in different contexts, for it may very well be that the pattern of silence has definite contours and subjects may appear silent in the interaction with some publics and not with others (or among themselves). There are different expressive resources available to different publics, and there are different costs in breaking a silence that diverse publics can face. This heterogeneous plurality of hermeneutical predicaments has to be captured in an analysis of hermeneutical injustice. Since the obstacles and stakes in breaking a silence can be quite different for different groups, the proper analysis of unjust silences and hermeneutical lacunae requires a thoroughgoing pluralistic approach.

There is a significant degree of pluralism in Fricker's perspective, which derives from her contextual approach: she does emphasize that differently situated subjects are affected differently by pervasive hermeneutical gaps. But, nonetheless, she does assume that all subjects will be affected by these gaps, as if they were inescapable and all-encompassing lacunas that cover the entire social fabric. This is dangerous to assume, because it is important to keep always open the possibility that we may find more hermeneutical resources than we expected in remote and obscure corners of the social fabric. Fricker's contextual approach has to be further pluralized, and the assumptions she makes about the pervasiveness of hermeneutical lacunas and their influence on entire collectivities have to be interrogated. These assumptions are expressed in her very definition of hermeneutical injustice:

> Hermeneutical injustice is: the injustice of having some significant area of one's experience *obscured from collective understanding* owing to a structural identity prejudice in *the collective hermeneutical resource*. (p. 155; my emphasis)

But *whose* "collective understanding"? And *whose* "collective hermeneutical resource"? If the collectivity in question has multiple publics, which in turn contain heterogeneous subgroups, it is not clear that we can (or should) talk about the "collective understanding" of an experience without qualification. And, more importantly, Fricker's expression "the collective hermeneutical resource" strongly suggests that we can pool all the hermeneutical resources available to all groups and create some kind of exhaustive inventory. But no matter how unified and well communicated the social body happens to be, such inventory should be suspect, for it is likely to be an artificial unification invoked from a theoretical standpoint, which always runs the risk of disregarding some marginalized and hard-to-find interpretative resources—those that are still in the making and remain fragmentary and inarticulate. Even highly monolithic and homogeneous societies are likely to contain interpretative

diversity, and they could at least contain the *possibility* of hermeneutical dissidence and of the embryonic formation of counter-publics. Moreover, a heterogeneous social fabric contains multiple publics with different ways of talking and of making sense of their experiences; and it is not at all clear that there is always some unified hermeneutical realm where the interpretative resources of all can be pooled; and even within distinctive publics with their peculiar resources, there will be differences, deviations, and idiosyncratic supplemental interpretative tools. It is crucial to pay attention to this diversity and not to assume what a collective social body, *as a whole*, is or is not in a position to understand. Of course there are quite extended social blind spots and hermeneutical insensitivities, but it is also frequent to find in those scenarios some groups or collection of individuals struggling to make sense of experiences that fall into those blind spots and have been so far ill understood (if recognized at all) by most people. So, we need to ask: what about those hermeneutical resources that are *not widely shared*, especially those that are buried in the interstices and obscure corners of the social fabric? It is not helpful to talk about "the collective hermeneutical resource" without introducing heterogeneity of perspectives, interpretative forms of dissidence, and embryonic possibilities of emerging meanings.

A complex social body always contains heterogeneous hermeneutical publics with diverse resources, but this heterogeneity is accentuated and radicalized in a society that is fractured, for the social division typically results in groups developing their own communicative and interpretative practices and dynamics. This is what happens under conditions of *oppression*. For example, in *The Souls of Black Folk* (1903/1994), W. E. B. Du Bois famously talked about the two Americas divided along racial lines, black and white, and he gave us powerful descriptions of the hermeneutical predicaments of: (a) those who lived exclusively in the white world—unequipped to understand what took place not only in the other world, but even in their own world; and (b) those who were forced to live in two worlds—the one that was forced on them and the one that they created, the one they served and the alternative one they could call home. For Du Bois, while white Americans exhibited a special kind of blindness and deafness in the obscure world they had created, black Americans developed a "double vision" and a "double consciousness" that was attentive to dual meanings and had special insights into the two worlds. Following Du Bois, I would add that racially privileged subjects tend to develop a *special kind of hermeneutical insensitivity with respect to racial meanings*, whereas racially oppressed subjects tend to become attentive and sensitive to them. Interestingly, the subjects who become *most epistemically harmed and hermeneutically disadvantaged in their ability to make sense of their social experiences of racialization* were in fact those who benefit the most from the hermeneutical obstacles, those who receive the non-epistemic benefits that these obstacles helped to produce or maintain. The Du Boisian analysis of the racial blindness of racially privileged subjects has been elaborated further under the rubric of "white ignorance" in

the recent literature. In his now-classic *The Racial Contract*, Charles Mills (1997) put white ignorance on the agenda of critical race theory. There Mills argues that privileged white subjects have become unable to understand the world that they themselves have created; and he calls attention to the cognitive dysfunctions and pathologies inscribed in the white world and constitutive of its epistemic economy, which revolves not only around the epistemic exclusion and stigmatization of people of color, but also around a carefully cultivated racial blindness of the white gaze. As Mills suggests, white ignorance is a form of self-ignorance: the inability to recognize one's own racial identity and the presuppositions and consequences of one's racial positionality.

In *Revealing Whiteness*, Shannon Sullivan (2006) has offered a detailed analysis of how privileged white subjects have maintained the ignorance of their own racialization through well-entrenched racial habits that hide themselves: whiteness has been rendered invisible for white subjects and needs to be revealed. Not having developed their own expressive practices and interpretative devices to understand their experiences of racialization, white subjects have been lost in a racialized world. A lot has been written on the invisibility of whiteness and the hypervisibility of blackness in the racialized world of American culture. But of course whiteness has been invisible only for the white gaze but not for racially oppressed subjects, who—as Mills emphasizes—have formed a powerful counter-public, with their alternative experiences and interpretations, and their counter-memory. The variously silenced black experiences and counter-memories that Mills describes as getting systematically disqualified and whited out contained scattered hermeneutical resources, which, in fact, gave interpretative advantages to the oppressed and otherwise hermeneutically marginalized subjects.

As the analyses of white ignorance in race theory show, until recently, privileged white subjects have lacked the motivation and the opportunity to develop expressive activities and interpretative tools to make sense of their own social experiences of racialization and to understand how their lives have been affected by racism and its legacy. And of course this self-ignorance, this inability to interpret their social experiences on racial matters, certainly undermined their hermeneutical sensibilities in their communicative interaction with others. The phenomenon of the active ignorance and interpretative impoverishment of the privileged has also been analyzed by epistemologists of ignorance with respect to gender and sexuality.[6] Feminist and queer theorists have argued that gender and sexual experiences are particularly opaque to gender and sexual conformists who, not having interrogated their own trajectories in these areas of social life, become especially ill-equipped to understand their

[6] See especially the pioneering work of Nancy Tuana (2004, 2006). See also Sullivan and Tuana (2007).

own gender and sexuality, lacking interpretative tools and strategies specifically designed to apply to their own case.[7] This is why what passes for obviousness or transparency in relation to masculinity, femininity, and heterosexuality typically hides a lack of awareness and sensitivity to nuanced and plural gender and sexual meanings. As epistemologists of ignorance have shown, the hermeneutical gaps that emerge from structures of oppression and identity prejudices create bodies of active ignorance for those subjects whose privileged positions are protected by the hermeneutical blind spots and insensitivities in question. Not only are the privileged subjects not exempted from the hermeneutical harms, but they are in fact *more negatively affected* in some areas of their experience. This constitutes an *anomaly* in Fricker's view; and it runs contrary to her pronouncements when she considers the "idea that relations of unequal power can skew shared hermeneutical resources":

> *The powerful tend to have appropriate understandings* of their experiences ready to draw on as they make sense of their social experiences, whereas *the powerless are more likely to find themselves having some social experiences through a glass darkly*, with at best ill-fitting meanings to draw on in the effort to render them intelligible. (p. 148; my emphasis)

But what if it is the powerful who tend to have "some social experiences through a glass darkly," enjoying precarious interpretative resources (if any at all), as seems to be the case in the phenomenon of white ignorance? There are two important considerations in Fricker's discussions that can be used to address this kind of case, but I will argue that they do not explain, fully and adequately, the hermeneutical harms of the privileged and their contributions to hermeneutical injustice, and, therefore, white ignorance remains a recalcitrant case.

In the first place, Fricker offers some considerations that are directly relevant to the phenomenon of privileged subjects becoming hermeneutical disadvantaged. She discusses explicitly one case in which "the proverbial white, educated, straight man" (p. 157) finds himself unable to understand certain things and to be understood when he talks about them. This is the predicament of the protagonist of Ian McEwan's novel *Enduring Love*, which Fricker analyzes (pp. 156–158). This character is being stalked by another male character, and he has a hard time rendering his experience of harassment intelligible when he talks to his wife and to the police about it. Fricker argues that the hermeneutical disadvantage encountered here is "a one-off moment of hermeneutical marginalization" (p. 157), thus assimilating it to those cases of hermeneutical injustice that "are not systematic but *incidental*" (p. 156). This is because, Fricker reasons, the character's hermeneutical disadvantage "has

[7] On this point, see especially Scheman (1997).

nothing to do with any general social powerlessness or any general subordination as a generator of social meaning" (p. 157). I am not sure this is true,[8] but clearly, in the case of white subjects who find themselves unable to understand their racialized identities and experiences and to talk about them meaningfully, their hermeneutical inabilities are part of a widespread pattern of social powerlessness and subordination. Clearly, in privileged white ignorance we have something quite systematic and not merely *one-off and incidental*, something that supports patterns of inequality. White ignorance is a prime example of *active ignorance*—a recalcitrant, self-protecting ignorance that builds around itself an entire system of resistances. This ignorance has deep roots in systematic distortions and in hard-to-eradicate forms of insensitivity. Active ignorance involves being hermeneutically numbed to certain meanings and voices, and the systematic kind of hermeneutical insensitivities involved here cannot be brushed off as merely incidental.

In the second place, Fricker recognizes that "different groups can be hermeneutically disadvantaged for all sorts of reasons, as the changing social world frequently generates new sorts of experience of which our understanding may dawn only gradually" (p. 151). And she is right to emphasize that hermeneutical disadvantages only amount to hermeneutical injustices if they are not only "harmful but also wrongful" (Ibid.). Fricker provides a persuasive example in which subjects who suffer from a yet unknown medical condition find themselves unable to render intelligible what is going on with them, given the lack of relevant medical knowledge. Here we have indeed a hermeneutical disadvantage that is not part of an injustice. As Fricker puts it, the "non-comprehension of their condition . . . is a poignant case of circumstantial epistemic bad luck" (p. 152). However, privileged white ignorance is not simply a matter of mere *epistemic bad luck*, but rather, an integral part of a pattern of epistemic injustice. Unlike the example of an unknown medical condition, in the case of white ignorance we can link the hermeneutical disadvantages directly to an unfair and discriminatory treatment. The hermeneutical disadvantages inscribed in white ignorance are not only harmful, but wrongful, although the wrong is committed against someone else: interestingly and crucially, the hermeneutical harms are *wrongful for others*, not for those upon whom the epistemic harms are directly inflicted.[9] Here we can make use of Fricker's

[8] After all, we are talking about a man being stalked by another man, which is an experience on which a number of widespread hermeneutical gaps can impinge, and it is not unreasonable to suppose that in our culture many people would be ill prepared to talk about such an experience and to display adequate hermeneutical sensibility in such discussions. And the hermeneutical disadvantage does seem to be directly related to the "general social powerlessness" and the "general subordination" of non-heterosexuals.

[9] Of course, the inability of white subjects to understand their own racial identity and experiences *also* hermeneutically harms others who, in communication with them, will have a hard time making themselves understood on racial matters.

distinction between *primary* and *secondary harms* in her discussion of situated hermeneutical inequality (p. 162). Roughly, the primary harm of a hermeneutical inequality is the inability to render something intelligible, whereas the secondary harms include all the further practical harms that result from such inability, such as psychological, economic, or political consequences. In white ignorance, however, we have an epistemic asymmetry in which the hermeneutically disadvantaged (i.e., those without resources to understand their racial identities and experiences) are not those who suffer the practical consequences (i.e., those victimized by racial ignorance); that is, the recipients of the primary harms are not the recipients of the secondary harms in this situated hermeneutical inequality. In fact, in white ignorance the primary and secondary harms diverge so radically that those who are unable to make sense of part of their identity and experience—the white subjects—at the same time enjoy practical benefits and ways to hold on to their privilege thanks to their hermeneutical disadvantage, whereas others who are comparatively more hermeneutically advantaged with respect to racial meanings suffer the practical and political consequences of the hermeneutical gap. The white subjects' inability to understand their own racialized identities and experiences is part of a pattern of injustice not against them, but against those whose subordination supports their privileged identities and social positions without their knowing it. This interesting phenomenon of racial hermeneutical injustice runs contrary to Fricker's contention that subjects can only be hermeneutically harmed with respect to those areas of their experience that relate to exclusion and subordination (e.g., as "black," as "woman," or as "lesbian"), but not with respect to those that relate to privilege (e.g., as "white," as "man," or as "straight").

White ignorance does not quite fit in Fricker's definition of hermeneutical injustice, which includes being prevented from understanding experiences that are *in your interest* to render intelligible. While in one sense it may be in the epistemic interest of privileged white subjects to overcome their racial ignorance (so that they can better navigate their social world and improve their self-understanding), it is not in their interest in another sense (insofar as it makes them vulnerable, undermines their authority, and requires them to pay attention to things that can be uncomfortable and disempowering). And, at any rate, it is undoubtedly *in the interest of others* that such ignorance be overcome, for its overcoming will meliorate the communicative and epistemic agency of underprivileged subjects, allowing them to interrogate privileges, to make unequal dynamics and their consequences visible and intelligible, and to communicate their experiences. The interests that render white ignorance an injustice are both epistemic and non-epistemic (e.g., economic, legal, political) interests. So the first point to notice is that, in an important sense, in white ignorance, the experiences that are obscured are not *primarily* in the interest of the hermeneutically disadvantaged subjects to understand and know. But it is clearly and primarily in the interest of those who suffer the practical consequences of white ignorance that

those experiences be understood and known. And if "interest" is considered in socioeconomic terms and not in epistemic or ethical terms, it can even be argued that it is in the interest of the hermeneutically disadvantaged white subjects *not* to understand and know the obscured experiences.

In "On Needing Not to Know and Forgetting What One Never Knew" (2007) Robert Bernasconi has suggested that the active ignorance that protects privilege and hides complicity with oppression is motivated by the *need not to know*, which in turn is directly related to the *need to know* of those negatively affected by the injustice or of those genuinely interested in fighting it. Maintaining privilege can indeed be a powerful source of resistance against expanding one's hermeneutical sensibilities, resulting in a stubborn refusal to understand certain things that can destabilize one's life and identity. Maintaining the secondary (practical) harms of white ignorance can provide a powerful motivation for the self-inflicted harms that happen at the epistemic level, that is, for white subjects to bring the primary (hermeneutical) harms upon themselves. I am not suggesting, of course, that anybody does this consciously and deliberately, but there have been obvious incentives for white culture to foster ignorance and hermeneutical insensitivity among its most privileged subjects. But whatever its sociogenesis, white ignorance remains a case that Fricker's account of hermeneutical injustice, as stated, does not cover: privileged subjects are also hermeneutically marginalized subjects, for they are conceptually ill-equipped to make sense of certain things; but the things that they are ill-equipped to understand are precisely the things they may not want to understand, the things that could be in their advantage to remain opaque—perhaps the things that they *need not to know* if they are to keep enjoying their privileges without having to face uncomfortable questions.

Whether conscious or unconscious, socioeconomically motivated or otherwise generated, white ignorance clearly involves a *failure in hermeneutical responsibility* if one is obligated to be responsive to the meanings and expressive concerns that circulate in one's milieu. In the next section I will offer some reflections and suggestions about our responsibilities with respect to hermeneutical justice. These concluding remarks will lend support to Fricker's own conclusions, although I will arrive at them through a very different route.

3.3. Our Hermeneutical Responsibilities with Respect to Multiple Publics

How do we responsibly respond to hermeneutical inequalities and work toward the equal participation of all in the generation and expression of meanings? Communities share a collective responsibility to do everything they can to facilitate everyone's ability to participate in meaning-making and meaning-expressing practices. Institutions and people in a position of power

bear special hermeneutical burdens, but we all share the collective responsibility to facilitate the hermeneutical agency of all communicators, especially if they have been marginalized. As a rule of thumb, our hermeneutical efforts and interpretative charity should be proportional to the degree of hermeneutical marginalization experienced by the subject in question.[10] But besides these general aspects of our hermeneutical duty, we also have specific hermeneutical responsibilities with respect to the interpretative gaps that appear in the communicative dynamics in which we participate, and we have an obligation to actively find out what those gaps might be. In order to become hermeneutically responsible interlocutors, in our communicative interactions, we are obligated to interrogate the limits of our interpretative horizons and to expose ourselves to interpretative challenges that may require extending or transforming the interpretative resources available to us. Fricker's account of hermeneutical virtue at the end of her chapter 7 (2007) teaches us a great lesson about hermeneutical responsibility, which includes the hermeneutical obligation to confront our interpretative limitations and vulnerabilities and to cultivate hermeneutical openness. However, although I am in agreement with the normative conclusions of Fricker's account, I disagree with her disavowal of any direct responsibility on the part of interlocutors with respect to hermeneutical injustices (see especially p. 159, quoted below). A more agential and interactive approach to hermeneutical injustice is needed in order to develop a more robust notion of hermeneutical responsibility.

Differently situated subjects' and groups' responsibility with respect to hermeneutical justice needs to be determined *relationally* in particular contexts of interaction. That is, whether individuals and groups live up to their hermeneutical responsibilities has to be assessed by taking into account the forms of mutual positionality, relationality, and responsiveness (or lack thereof) that these subjects and groups display with respect to one another. Our communicative interactions (with their illocutionary speech acts and their uptake or lack thereof) can work to accentuate or to alleviate the hermeneutical gaps and silences that our cultures have created over time. Hermeneutical gaps are performatively invoked and recirculated—*reenacted*, we could say—in the speech acts of daily life. And we have to take responsibility for how our communicative agency relates to the blind spots of our social practices (reinscribing them,

[10] Therefore, the more hermeneutically privileged our interlocutors are (their communicative perspective nicely fitting into the mainstream perspective), the less compelled we should feel to make special interpretative efforts to understand them. And of course we need to take into account the hermeneutical positions of both speaker and listener as they relate to each other, so that our hermeneutical responsibilities should be greater when we interact communicatively with those more marginalized than we are, and lesser when we interact with subjects more hermeneutically privileged than we are. As I will suggest below, this is why there can be communicative contexts in which hermeneutical responsibilities can be suspended for some subjects: for example, for oppressed subjects when they interact with their oppressors and need to speak obliquely to block their understanding for self-protection.

challenging them, etc.). We have to evaluate whether our communicative actions and interactions are contributing to interrogate and expand hermeneutical sensibilities or not. However, since Fricker's primary focus on the semantic dimension of hermeneutical gaps eclipses the importance of their pragmatic and performative dimension, her view makes it hard to appreciate any direct link between hermeneutical injustices and people's communicative and interpretative agency. In fact, she denies such a link:

> No agent *perpetrates* hermeneutical injustice—it is a purely structural notion. The background condition for hermeneutical injustice is the subject's hermeneutical marginalization. But the moment of hermeneutical injustice comes only when the background condition is realized in a *more or less doomed attempt on the part of the subject to render an experience intelligible*. (p. 159; emphasis preserved and added)

But why is the attempt to make sense of a hermeneutically marginalized experience "more or less doomed"? When we have the sense that a speaker has next to no chance of getting herself understood when she is struggling to make sense of something, it is because her interlocutors have been trained not to hear or to hear only deficiently and through a lens that filters out the speaker's perspective. And indeed, under those conditions, most interlocutors would display little interpretative charity and hermeneutical responsiveness; and the habitual ways in which interlocutors fail to respond to the speaker's communicative attempts, or respond only in a negative way, will keep stacking the hermeneutical odds against the speaker, whose future attempts will be in the same, or even worse, situation. But speakers and hearers should keep trying; new communicative dynamics may succeed in bringing about more hermeneutical openness. It may appear that we will need *hermeneutical heroes* to do that—that is, that we will need extremely courageous speakers and listeners who defy well-entrenched communicative expectations and dominant hermeneutical perspectives, and against all odds are lucky enough to change (or at least disrupt) hermeneutical trends so as to make room for new meanings and interpretative perspectives. But typically hermeneutical melioration is not due to the agency of exceptional communicators and interpreters; it is the result of the sheer accumulation of partially failed and partially successful communicative attempts on the part of wholly ordinary speakers who have received the attention of ordinary but hermeneutically sensitive hearers. However, for as long as we remain entrenched in dynamics that block new forms of understanding and foster communicative dysfunctions, we are contributing to hermeneutical marginalization and, if that marginalization is based on identity prejudices and correlated with disparities in identity power, we are *perpetrating* a hermeneutical injustice.

It is important that we take responsibility for impoverished communicative and interpretative habits, no matter how well-entrenched, unconscious,

and inescapably socially produced those habits may be. And it is also important to keep in mind that there is always at least some minimal wiggle-room to start modifying those habits. Even if hearers cannot be expected to be able to suddenly develop a *complete* openness with respect to something they have been trained not to hear or to hear only deficiently, they can be blamed for not even trying in the least to interrogate their interpretative habits and to make an effort to put themselves in the shoes of the speaker and consider what she could possibly be trying to convey. And this shift of the communicative and interpretative burdens from the speaker to the hearer applies especially to hermeneutically marginalized speakers, who have the odds of being understood stacked against them. In the spirit of making special arrangements for antecedently marginalized subjects, Louise Antony (1995) has suggested a policy of *epistemic affirmative action*, which recommends that interpreters operate with the "*working hypothesis* that when a woman, or any member of a stereotyped group, says something anomalous, they should assume that it's *they* who don't understand, not that it is the woman who is nuts" (p. 89). Fricker sees some merits in this proposal, but she argues, persuasively, that "the hearer needs to be *indefinitely context sensitive* in how he applies the hypothesis," and that "a policy of affirmative action across all subject matters would not be justified" (p. 171; my emphasis). Indeed, hermeneutically marginalized speakers have the odds of being understood stacked against them only in certain areas of experience and only in certain communicative contexts and dynamics. To address the highly situated forms of hermeneutical marginalization that interlocutors can encounter, what we need is not a set of fixed principles of interpretation, but rather, as Fricker argues, something like a communicative and interpretative *virtue*: an indefinitely context-sensitive hermeneutical sensibility that displays an attentiveness and responsiveness to those struggling to make sense given adverse hermeneutical climates. This is exactly what Fricker's account of the corrective nature of the virtue of hermeneutical justice captures.[11]

The special interpretative efforts required to respond adequately to attempts to communicate hermeneutically marginalized experiences and to articulate nascent meanings are best approached from the perspective of a virtuous sensibility, and not from the point of view of a policy that regulates communicative interactions. I find Fricker's position here the most promising because of its plasticity, dynamicity, and context-sensitivity. In fact, Fricker's account of the virtue of hermeneutical justice invokes precisely the kind of communicative pluralism and polyphonic contextualism I

[11] "The form the virtue of hermeneutical justice must take, then, is an *alertness or sensitivity* to the possibility that the difficulty one's interlocutor is having as she tries to render something communicatively intelligible is due not to its being a nonsense or her being a fool, but rather to some sort of gap in collective hermeneutical resources." (Fricker: 2007, p. 169; my emphasis)

defend. She grounds the open and corrective nature of virtuous hermeneutical sensibility precisely in the responsiveness to the plurality of interpretative perspectives that one can find in communicative contexts: in the "reflexive awareness" that a speaker may appear "to be making no sense to one hearer . . . while to another hearer . . . she may seem to be making a manifestly reasonable point" (p. 169).

As I announced earlier, I am in full agreement with the normative conclusions of Fricker's account. And yet I find problematic the lack of attention that Fricker pays to the agential aspects of hermeneutical injustice. Although her account can accommodate the interactive hermeneutical responsibilities I have called attention to, she nonetheless introduces an *unnecessary gap* between hermeneutical injustice and the communicative and interpretative agency of participants in epistemic exchanges. This introduces an *unnecessary tension* in Fricker's view. Why not accept that where there is a virtue—a way of *excelling* in and with your agency, there is also a vice—a way of *failing* in and with your agency? In our daily communicative interactions, there are all kinds of specific ways in which we can fulfill or fail to fulfill our hermeneutical responsibilities with respect to multiple publics. And in the same way that hermeneutically sensitive and alert interlocutors can contribute to bring about hermeneutical justice, hermeneutically insensitive and numbed interlocutors can also be the *co-perpetrators* of hermeneutical injustices. One can exhibit a more or less virtuous hermeneutical sensibility depending on one's communicative openness and responsiveness to indefinitely plural interpretative perspectives. But if one exhibits a complete lack of "alertness or sensitivity" to alternative hermeneutical possibilities, one's communicative interactions are likely to contain failures in hermeneutical justice for which one has to take responsibility, even if it is a shared and highly qualified kind of responsibility.

Those subjects who become co-perpetrators of hermeneutical injustices may often do so without their knowing it and despite their best communicative intentions. Except under special conditions in which hermeneutical responsibilities are suspended (more on this below), those who, by being nonresponsive or deficiently responsive, fail to aid speakers in their attempts to render their experiences intelligible perpetrate hermeneutical injustices. Although they certainly cannot be said to produce the hermeneutic injustices all by themselves, the communicative dynamics they participate in do help to reproduce them and to keep them in place. Hermeneutical gaps are not produced by a single individual or by small clusters of individuals, for they require collective and sustained efforts across temporally and socially extended contexts, that is, they require *patterns* of impoverished communication with specific hermeneutical insensitivities. But those who find themselves in those patterns typically have *some* limited agency to accentuate the gaps or to contribute to their erosion. Judith Butler's concept of the responsibility of *resignification* can

help here:[12] all communicators have no option but to repeat the coined meanings they have inherited—even in rejecting those meanings they are forced to repeat them; but their repetitive use can *resignify* those meanings. Being doomed to repeat does not make us symbolic automata, for, given all sorts of contextual constraints, it is up to us how to repeat, and we have to take responsibility for our repetition, for the specific ways in which we recirculate and resignify received meanings. Of course we always have limited options for resignification no matter how courageous and imaginative our communicative agency happens to be. But it is also true that there are always at least *some* options to meliorate a hermeneutical climate. Most of the time, the failure of our hermeneutical responsibility begins with refusing to take responsibility in the first place, that is, with assuming that derogatory connotations, interpretative lacunas, and expressive limitations are simply there without having anything to do with us and our daily use of interpretative resources. That is why it is so important to insist on our obligation to become increasingly aware of the limitations of our expressive resources, and of how the voices and expressive styles we cultivate might be complicit with those limitations.[13]

In our communicative interactions we must make room for eccentric voices and we must respond to their nonstandard ways of entering communicative dynamics. Being hermeneutically open means being alert and sensitive to eccentric voices and styles as well as to nonstandard meanings and interpretative perspectives. We should collectively assume and share the responsibility of making our communicative contexts and dynamics more hospitable to plural and diverse experiential standpoints. We should open up possibilities for resisting the imposition of mainstream meanings and interpretations, and for countering hermeneutical perspectives that have become exclusionary and hegemonic. Fricker herself, as we saw, recognizes the *possibility of resistance*

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[12] See especially Butler (1997). As Butler puts it, discursive responsibility concerns *citation*, that is, it concerns *how to repeat or cite* in performative chains of speech acts: "The speaker assumes responsibility precisely through the citational character of speech. The speaker renews the linguistic tokens of a community, reissuing and reinvigorating such speech. Responsibility is thus linked with speech *as* repetition, not as origination (p. 39).

[13] There are many things we can do to fulfill that obligation, which can be segmented into smaller and more manageable obligations to improve our hermeneutical sensibilities. We can develop communicative and interactive habits that make us increasingly aware of the contours of our interpretative standpoints. For example, we can train ourselves to compare and contrast our expressive resources with that of others; and we can engage in interpretative practices that make our familiar meanings unfamiliar. The former suggestion is contained in Edward Said's argument for the critical and transformative potential of *comparative literature* in connecting different cultural imaginaries that can challenge each other and learn from each other. See especially the introduction of Said's *Orientalism* (1979/1994). The latter suggestion is contained in the interpretative strategies elaborated by queer theorists, who have developed critical genealogies of gender and sexual meanings and have offered the discursive mechanism of *queering* for the disruption and transformation of those meanings. On what it means to queer our received meanings, see especially Scheman (1997).

against hermeneutical marginalization in the phenomenon of dissonance (pp. 166–8). She points out that the sense of dissonance is "the starting point for both the critical thinking and the moral-intellectual courage that rebellion requires" (p. 168). And rebellious hermeneutical interventions have a tremendous transformative potential, for they can transform not only one's own communicative life but also that of those around us. As Fricker remarks, hermeneutical resistance and rebellion can be contagious: "one hermeneutical rebellion inspires another" (p. 167). And if it is possible for interlocutors (both as speakers and as hearers) to fight against unfair hermeneutical climates and dynamics, it must also be possible for them to contribute to the *production* of hermeneutical injustices at least in the indirect sense of *failing to resist* or to minimize their occurrence. Fricker's remarks on hermeneutical resistance and rebellion are, therefore, in tension with her remarks on there being no perpetrators of hermeneutical injustices we can hold responsible. It is of the utmost importance that we learn to assess such responsibilities and that we become attentive to them in our communicative interactions, for such critical awareness and attentiveness are required for the cultivation of self-corrective hermeneutical sensibilities and the melioration of hermeneutical climates.

Sometimes there are exceptional forms of hermeneutical resistance and rebellion, but more often there are just simple ways in which ordinary folks resist and rebel against adverse hermeneutical climates. Unfortunately, even more frequently, there are simple ways in which ordinary folks fail to resist and rebel against hermeneutical injustices in their daily communicative interactions. If there are subjects and groups we could call *hermeneutical heroes* because they are exceptional in defying hermeneutical obstacles and expanding interpretative resources, there are also subjects and groups we could call *hermeneutical villains* because they are exceptional in maintaining hermeneutical gaps in place and blocking attempts to bridge those gaps.[14] Most speakers and listeners are not

[14] The expressions *hermeneutical heroes* and *hermeneutical villains* should be taken with a grain of salt. I use these expressions, as I will later use the more general expressions *epistemic heroes* and *epistemic villains*, as rhetorical devices to dramatize in an exaggerated way the roles of agents who make efforts to facilitate or to impede epistemic interactions. But this dramatization should not be taken in a literal way as suggesting that there are special agents who are the ones who in our epistemic practices either create problems and inflict harms (the villains) or repair them (the heroes), while the rest of us remain neutral with respect to epistemic injustices. On the contrary, what I want to suggest is that the dramatic figures of the epistemic hero and the epistemic villain are the extreme cases and that we are in between these extremes, or in other words, that we all have (or can have) a little bit of a hero or a villain in us, something heroic and something villainous in our epistemic characters and actions, some aspects of complicity and of resistance. But this dramatization is a distortion if it is understood as suggesting that the agents of justice and injustice are exceptional individuals, for we are all such agents: epistemic agency is the capacity to engage in fair and unfair epistemic transactions and, therefore, the capacity to facilitate and promote epistemic justice or injustice. As we shall see through different arguments in what follows, resistant agency and resistant imagination do not fall on the shoulders of a few exceptional subjects, but on the shoulders of *all* epistemic agents, although their burdens and responsibilities

exceptional; most interlocutors cannot be characterized in such dramatic ways. But that does not mean that they cannot be praised or blamed for their hermeneutical sensibilities and the interpretative responsiveness that they exhibit or fail to exhibit in their communicative interactions. Hermeneutically responsible interlocutors must evaluate their communicative acts and interpretive reactions: they must hold themselves and each other responsible for how they react to inherited meanings and expressive resources, and for what they do to add to them and in response to attempts to add to them. But these interactive hermeneutical responsibilities have to be contextualized and relativized to the positionality and relationality of the subjects involved in particular communicative dynamics.

Are interlocutors always obligated to help each other improve their understandings and expand their hermeneutical sensibilities and expressive resources? As Fricker has taught us, in the ethics of knowing and interpreting, *context is everything*. And indeed, interlocutors' hermeneutical obligations have to be contextualized, taking into account how hermeneutical inequalities map onto sociopolitical inequalities and power dynamics. Although interlocutors are generally obligated to share hermeneutical resources and to facilitate the communicative and epistemic agency of each other, there could be cases in which these obligations can be relaxed and even suspended if fulfilling those obligations might put sociopolitically oppressed subjects in an even more vulnerable position and at risk of further social harms. The oppressed may occasionally feel obligated to exploit the hermeneutical and epistemic disadvantages of the oppressor in order to resist the situation of oppression. Although it may seem counterintuitive, ignorance and incomprehension can be a means of protection and empowerment for the sociopolitically oppressed, who may be justified in preserving whatever epistemic privilege and hermeneutical superiority they may have as a means of social survival. Oppressed subjects are not obligated to facilitate the communicative and epistemic agency of more privileged subjects if that can worsen their precarious situation and deepen their oppression. As many Latina feminists and colonial theorists have argued, colonized peoples have a long tradition of exploiting the ignorance and hermeneutical limitations of the colonizers to their advantage, which can be justified for the sake of their survival. Similar points have been made by black feminists—such as Collins (1990/2000 and 2005)—who have called attention to how black women have used invisibility as a survival strategy and have exploited public silences for self-protection, to hide themselves and to inhabit safe spaces of intimacy away from the scrutiny of mainstream publics.

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differ depending on the social positions and relations they occupy. Using concrete examples from the women's movement and the civil rights movement, in section 5.3 I will debunk the idealized image of the epistemic hero or heroine, underscoring that we are all agents of justice with the responsibility to resist oppression and that, in fact, the success of leaders or heroic figures in a struggle of resistance is crucially dependent on the resistant everyday actions of ordinary folks.

As some epistemologists of ignorance have emphasized, the ignorance of privileged subjects that typically accompanies systems of oppression can be exploited by the oppressed to their own advantage.[15] This is what Alison Bailey (2007) has called *strategic ignorance*, which includes the various "ways expressions of ignorance can be wielded strategically by groups living under oppression as a way of gaining information, sabotaging work, avoiding or delaying harm, and preserving a sense of self" (p. 77). Bailey argues that "the project of undoing white ignorance" calls for a relational understanding of ignorance and should be put in the context of "a broader coalition of resistance that includes strategic uses of ignorance by people of color" (p. 90).[16] Similarly, I would argue that the various projects of disarming hermeneutical insensitivities and undoing hermeneutical injustices call for a relational analysis of communicative and interpretative dynamics, and for coalitions of diverse forms of hermeneutical resistance and rebellion.

So, in short, differently situated subjects' obligations with respect to hermeneutical justice need to be assessed in a pluralistic and relational way. Given the demands of hermeneutical justice, Fricker argues that the virtuous listener is obligated "to help generate a more inclusive hermeneutical microclimate" (p. 171). My pluralistic and relational approach adds an important qualification: namely, that differently situated subjects and groups can bear very different burdens and responsibilities with respect to the minimization of hermeneutical gaps and obstacles; and that, occasionally, these hermeneutical obligations can be suspended and even reversed in order to allow for cases in which contributing to maintain a social silence or to reinforce the hermeneutical gaps of certain communities may not be blameworthy and unjust, but the ethical thing to do. As suggested by some race theorists, oppressed groups can be justified in maintaining their oppressor's ignorance and inability to make sense of certain experiences until a more equal participation in hermeneutical practices is available to all (or perhaps, precisely in order to make more equal participation possible for all). We should think of the work toward hermeneutical justice as being socially and temporally extended in such a way that differently situated subjects should be expected to carry different burdens, and these burdens should also be temporally segmented in such a way that they do not automatically kick in but are subject to prudential considerations and historically situated preconditions.

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[15] As Sarah Hoagland (2007) puts it, "There is a practice among many who are marginalized by dominant logic of promoting ignorance among competent practitioners of dominant culture and in the process, destabilizing oppressive relationality. For example, at times women keep men ignorant about certain things, and at times blacks keep whites ignorant about certain things" (p. 97).

[16] Following Lugones (2003), Bailey argues for "a curdled reading of ignorance," which can "offer us a more relational understanding of ignorance by revealing the ways in which people of color have strategically engaged with white folks' ignorance in ways that are advantageous" (Bailey: 2007, p. 84). Bailey's relational view of ignorance and its strategic uses will be discussed more fully in section 6.4.

The pluralistic and relational twists I have given to Fricker's contextualist account of hermeneutical justice are more an extension than a repudiation of her approach. My friendly amendments and warnings have tried to underscore that social silences and hermeneutical gaps are ill-understood if they are uniformly predicated on an entire social context, instead of being predicated on particular ways of inhabiting that context by particular people in relation to particular others. I have simply tried to establish that a more relational and pluralistic—*polyphonic*—contextualism offers a more adequate picture of what it means to break social silences and to repair the hermeneutical injustices associated with them.

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Epistemic Responsibility and Culpable Ignorance

In situations of radical oppression and systematic epistemic injustice, it is very hard for everybody to live up to their epistemic responsibilities. Some would argue that it becomes virtually impossible and, therefore, "responsibility" in its standard sense disappears and assignments of blame should be suspended. We should not be deemed obligated to do that which we cannot do; and we should not be blamed for failures that, given the circumstances, are not *our* failures—"Things were simply set up that way," one can say. We can appeal to what Fricker calls, following Thomas Nagel,[1] "'circumstantial' epistemic bad luck" (2007, p. 33), relieving individuals and communities of responsibility: in those circumstances people could not know any better; they did not have the resources to correct epistemic injustices. In this chapter I want to offer a more robust and more nuanced view of epistemic responsibility, one that does not simply exculpate agents and reifies injustices into the inescapable normative structure of social life; but also one that does not simply inculpate all agents equally independently of their circumstances. My view of epistemic responsibility is one that is extremely sensitive to context and to social positionality, one that rejects any one-size-fits-all approach, and one that argues that assignments and assessments of responsibilities have to be done piecemeal, case by case, and not by applying the same analysis to all agents equally, not even to all agents who share the same social environment. My view relies on a radically pluralistic conception of context,[2] according to which social contexts are always heterogeneous and polyphonic, involving a multiplicity of irreducibly diverse perspectives. Therefore, when a particular insight or view (such as gender or racial equality) is said to be unavailable and extremely hard (or virtually impossible) to attain in a particular context, we need to ask for whom and in what way, for which standpoints or perspectives as embodied by which subjects and under what circumstances. We should not presume that all subjects will find it equally hard to reach the liberatory insight in question and to overcome the systematic injustice: different subjects will face

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[1] Fricker articulates an epistemic version of Nagel's concept of "circumstantial moral bad luck." See Nagel (1979). For an earlier treatment of the analogy between moral and epistemic luck, see Statman (1991).

[2] I have defended this view of communicative and agential contexts in my *Speaking from Elsewhere* (2006a).

different challenges as they try to remove roadblocks in their attempt to learn and overcome epistemic injustices; even the very act of initiating such an attempt, of setting the process in motion and embarking on a transformative epistemic journey, will involve quite different difficulties for differently situated subjects and their perspectives.

It is indeed very hard to live up to one's epistemic responsibilities under conditions of oppression and systematic injustice, but not for everybody equally and to the same degree. Given the contexts and social positions subjects occupy, we need to determine case by case and group by group what these subjects may be (or become) in a position to know and which blind spots and bodies of ignorance they may be (or become) able to shake off in their life trajectories. And given the heterogeneity and diverse plurality of any social context, we can always find pervasive injustices differentially spread across the social body, affecting subjects quite differently depending on who they are, what positions they occupy, which activities they are engaged in, and other particularities of the context. Even the same subject may have an easier or harder time being unaffected by epistemic distortions and escaping different forms of social insensitivity as she moves across activities and contexts. And of course differently constituted and situated subjects will have different resources to fight epistemic injustices: for example, the racist and sexist stereotypes about racial minorities and women having inferior cognitive capacities (or being less rational, more intuitive, more emotional, etc.) will be internalized differently by differently genderized and racialized subjects, and these stereotypes will affect them differently in their daily activities; and, although it is of course possible to find blind adherence to these distortions everywhere (even among those most disadvantaged by them), the subject positions, standpoints, and experiences of racial minorities and women may offer special opportunities and resources to take critical distance, raise challenges, and resist the stereotypes—or quite simply to call attention to them and the effects they have on people's lives, unmasking them as stereotypes instead of silently and complicitly allowing their insidious operation behind the scenes, thus developing a form of *critical lucidity* with respect to epistemic injustices, which can be the beginning of a critical process of transformation that can start to undo the injustices. (The critical and subversive forms of lucidity—in particular, *meta-lucidity*—that can be achieved in situations of oppression will be the topic of the next chapter.) We have to adjust the epistemic responsibilities we assign to subjects and groups so that we can establish reasonable normative expectations, without demanding heroic behavior but without giving up the obligation to resist epistemic exclusions and injustices. The epistemic responsibilities we can assume have to be grounded in the circumstances of our actual lives; but epistemic responsibility also has a *counterfactual* dimension: it concerns not only what we should know given how things are, but also what we should aspire to learn given how things can become. I will start with very

general aspects of our epistemic responsibility and with common epistemic obligations that we all seem to have qua knowers, independently of our social positionality and other particularities of our epistemic lives. I will then show how, as soon as we contextualize our epistemic responsibilities (even the most general ones), their contents (i.e., what it means to live up to them) become quite different for different subjects under different conditions. Let's start by exploring the complex relations between ethical and political responsibility, on the one hand, and knowledge and ignorance, on the other.

4.1. Responsible Agency, Knowledge/Ignorance, and Social Injustice

Although not only the pragmatist tradition but even Kant himself have warned us against separating the theoretical and the practical, let's start by distinguishing between epistemic responsibility and ethical and political responsibility: the former concerns our responsibility qua knowers and learners, while the latter concerns our responsibility qua agents. In order to interrogate the relations between these different forms of responsibility and to explore the intricacies of the normative aspects of our lives, we need to ask the following questions. Are there particular epistemic obligations that can be derived from (or can be attached to) our status as responsible agents? Does acting responsibly require that we know certain things? Can our ignorance be, in some respects, not only an epistemic failure, but also an ethical and a political one? Can our ignorance stand in the way of our being (or becoming) good people and good citizens? And what about normative relations going in the other direction, from the epistemic to the ethical and political? Can our responsibility as subjects of knowledge have implications for our responsibility as ethical and political agents? Does being a responsible learner and knower require that we do certain things, that we develop certain ethical and political habits? And can our failures to act well and fairly undermine our epistemic successes? To get into this complex host of questions, I will start by rehearsing some of the relevant arguments in the philosophical literature of the last thirty years, namely, arguments addressing the issue of what our status as responsible agents can tell us about ourselves as subjects of knowledge.

Following Donald Davidson's work on self-knowledge,[3] Akeel Bilgrami (1992, 1998, and 2012) has argued that there is a special relation between responsibility and self-knowledge: in order to act responsibly and to be held accountable for one's actions, one needs to know who one is, one has to be a reliable reporter of one's inner world and know, for the most part, one's beliefs, desires, intentions, and so on. This is, according to Bilgrami, what makes self-knowledge special. It is not a special kind of certainty, transparency, or incorrigibility; it is a special relation to responsibility: self-knowledge is

[3] See Davidson (1984) and (1986).

required by responsible agency.[4] If we are to treat someone as a responsible agent, we have no option but to ascribe to her sufficient degrees of knowledge about herself so that we can say that she is doing things knowingly. Bilgrami (1998) argues that the special significance of self-knowledge is practical and ethical, rather than epistemic; and that it can only be justified on normative grounds. He summarizes his position as follows: "Self-knowledge is necessary for responsibility *for no other reason* . . . than that our *evaluative* justifications of the practices of assigning punishment and blame seem to be apt only when self-knowledge is present" (p. 215). According to Bilgrami, lack of knowledge of the world or of one's peers does not cast doubt on one's status as a responsible agent, whereas lack of self-knowledge does. I have argued[5] that there is something profoundly correct and revealing in Bilgrami's view, and yet also something profoundly incorrect and obscuring in his argument. On the one hand, Bilgrami's view brings to the fore the normativity of self-knowledge and offers a thoroughly social and practical explanation of it, without relying on problematic psychological or metaphysical theses. Bilgrami explains the special normative status of self-knowledge in terms of the special role it plays in the social discursive practices in which we talk about ourselves and our actions. Davidson (1984) had already offered a social and pragmatic explanation along these lines by arguing that self-knowledge is a necessary presupposition of our interpretative practices.[6] The core of the Davidsonian approach to self-knowledge on which Bilgrami builds is a *constitutive thesis*, namely, that having self-knowledge, or a presumptive authority on matters that concern oneself, is *constitutive* of being a rational agent and communicator.[7] All of this is extremely illuminating (although, in my opinion, the pragmatic and social account of the normativity of self-knowledge does not need a transcendental twist). But, on the other hand, in his development of the constitutive view of self-knowledge, Bilgrami makes two important mistakes: first, he overinflates self-knowledge and misconstrues its relation to accountability; and secondly, he improperly sets self-knowledge apart from other kinds of knowledge, obscuring their crucial interrelations and denying the relation between responsible agency and other types of knowledge. Let's examine these mistakes to

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[4] There are other contemporary accounts of the connection between responsible agency and self-knowledge. See especially Anscombe (1963), Moran (2001), Velleman (1989), and Wilson (2000). These authors have different views as to the type of self-knowledge required for responsible agency—observational or non-observational, inferential or non-inferential, and so on.

[5] See Medina 2006b.

[6] As Davidson puts it, self-knowledge is "an unavoidable presumption built into the *nature* of interpretation" (1984, p. 111). Departing from the Cartesian introspective paradigm, Davidson offers an account of first-person epistemic authority as exclusively "dependent on, and explained by, *social and public factors*" (1986, p. 435).

[7] Like Davidson, Bilgrami also uses the language of constitution: "it is constitutive of the very notion of intentionality that we by and large have self-knowledge" (1992, p. 248).

further clarify the relationship between responsibility/irresponsibility and knowledge/ignorance.

Bilgrami assumes an overly narrow view of self-knowledge, which focuses exclusively on its causal aspects. For Bilgrami, having self-knowledge is tantamount to having the ability to give correct causal explanations of one's action by appealing to one's mental states as their causes. As Bilgrami puts it, in order to be responsible, "we must, in general, know our beliefs and desires and our intentions because it is these states which bring about and explain our doing" (1992, p. 250). On the one hand, this is too demanding; and, on the other hand, it is too limited and impoverished. On the one hand, one can be good at identifying one's propositional attitudes without necessarily being good at using them in causal explanations for one's own behavior. In other words, I can know most of my beliefs, desires, and intentions, and nonetheless be frequently at a loss as to how exactly they cause my actions. Unless properly qualified, the claim that self-knowledge is a necessary condition for responsibility seems too strong. Doesn't it suffice to have *some* self-knowledge *some* of the time? Or do we *always* have to be *fully* knowledgeable about our beliefs, desires, intentions, and so on, in order to be responsible? According to Bilgrami, in order to be responsible *at all*, one must be able to account for one's actions in terms of one's beliefs, desires, and intentions. He is certainly right that in order to be responsible, one must *in some sense* know what one is doing. But knowing what one is doing in the *minimal* sense required for being responsible for one's actions should not be equated (and usually isn't) with knowing one's beliefs, desires and intentions and being able to explain one's actions through them. We do not exempt agents from responsibility just because they do not have the proper knowledge about the mental causation of their actions. Being accountable for one's actions is not the same as being able to give a *correct account* of one's actions, as Bilgrami claims (see especially 1992, p. 250). It is not clear that one ceases to be a responsible agent when one lacks self-knowledge *in this sense*. Cases of insanity aside, we still hold someone responsible for her actions even if she has mistaken beliefs about why she did what she did, and even if she simply did it blindly and has no clue as to how her mental states led her to do what she did. As George Sher (2009) has argued, the epistemic condition of responsible agency is misunderstood if we think that an agent's responsibility extends only as far as "the searchlight" of his or her consciousness.[8]

[8] This is the centerpiece of Sher's critique of what he calls the "searchlight view" of the epistemic condition of responsibility in *Who Knew? Responsibility without Awareness* (2009). Sher argues persuasively that our attributions of responsibility are not consistent with the narrow view of the epistemic condition that reduces it to conscious reasons for action, for there is a broad range of cases in which agents are still held responsible for what they do even though they do not realize (but should) that they are acting wrongly or foolishly.

On the other hand, Bilgrami's view is too limiting and impoverished, because the kind of self-knowledge that we can reasonably expect of responsible agents goes beyond what his causal account suggests: it involves having a sense of who one is and having for the most part justified true beliefs about central aspects of one's life and one's personality. There is more to self-knowledge than knowing one's mental states and using them in causal explanations of behavior. When I find myself reflecting on what kind of person I am, or when I am conversing with friends about my personality traits, I rarely reduce what I know about myself to discrete propositional attitudes and their causal roles. I know that I am a forty-three year-old man, that I am gay, that I am Spanish and a permanent resident of the United States, that I am a philosopher, and so on. And note that not knowing these things about myself, especially not knowing *any of them*, would be reasonable grounds for calling into question my status as a responsible agent. And note also that all those things about myself involve empirical and social facts about my life, which indicates that there are many aspects of self-knowledge that involve the external and social world and cannot be reduced to the exclusively psychological, as if this were an autonomous domain. There are indeed crucial relations between self-knowledge and other kinds of knowledge, such as knowledge of the empirical world and knowledge of the social world. And this brings us to the following questions: Is there really a special and unique normative relation between self-knowledge and responsibility? Or do the epistemic demands of responsible agency stretch beyond the scope of knowing oneself? We can answer these questions by examining the second mistake that Bilgrami's constitutive view makes.

The second mistake in Bilgrami's view involves, first, the claim that there is a special relation between self-knowledge and responsibility, and second, the corollary that there is a presumption of epistemic authority with respect to self-knowledge but not in any other epistemic domain. I agree with Bilgrami that responsible agents are obligated to maintain (sufficient degrees of) self-knowledge and those who treat us as responsible agents are entitled to expect it from us. What I do not accept is that this applies only to self-knowledge and that we cannot derive other epistemic obligations and expectations from the normative demands of responsible agency. Bilgrami (1998) emphasizes that we blame agents for failing to live up to their commitment to self-knowledge, but we do not blame agents for their lack of knowledge of the environment or from their lack of knowledge of other people's intentional states. According to Bilgrami (1998), there is a "philosophical ground" (i.e., the "constitutive" relation between self-knowledge and responsibility) upon which we can always demand self-knowledge from a responsible agent, and this is what makes self-knowledge special. He contends that there is no corresponding "philosophical ground" that supports a similar demand for other types of knowledge. In other words, according to Bilgrami, there are a priori reasons to demand that a responsible agent have knowledge of her intentional states; but we

can only demand that she have knowledge of the environment or knowledge of the intentional states of others under special circumstances. Thus, Bilgrami (1998) argues that while a lack of knowledge about, for example, Indian history in no way undermines one's status as a responsible agent, a lack of self-knowledge does disqualify the subject as a responsible agent. But it may be a mistake to separate radically one's status as a responsible agent in discursive practices from the specific responsibilities one has with respect to specific commitments. A lack of knowledge about Indian history does disqualify the subject as a responsible agent in many practices, especially in India or about India: it does curtail her responsible participation in a whole array of practices that require being minimally informed about the past of this country (e.g., political deliberations about ongoing problems of Indian democracy). On the other hand, a lack of self-knowledge does not (or at least not always) disqualify the subject as a responsible agent in all respects. As we just saw, lack of self-knowledge of the explanatory kind shows nothing more than that the agent is just not good at explaining her own mind, but not that she is not good as a responsible agent tout court. It is true, however, that a *total* lack of self-knowledge is sufficient to disqualify someone as a responsible participant in discursive practices. But so is a *total* lack of knowledge of the environment or a *total* lack of knowledge of the intentional states of others. When an agent is systematically deceived about her own intentional states, we do not consider her as a responsible agent. But, similarly, when an agent is systematically wrong about the environment or about other people's beliefs, desires, and intentions, we do not consider her as a responsible agent either. So the crucial normative relation with responsible agency can be seen in all these different types of knowledge—and, as I have argued elsewhere,[9] we can conclude that there is nothing special about self-knowledge in this respect. I will use Wittgenstein's holistic view of knowledge in *On Certainty* (1969) to elaborate on this point.

In *On Certainty* Wittgenstein emphasizes that, under normal circumstances, there are certain things I cannot doubt about myself for as long as I remain a responsible participant in discursive practices (or language-games): I cannot doubt when I have certain feelings or sensations (for example, being in pain), or when I have certain beliefs, desires, and intentions. But there are other things about myself that also seem to have the presumption of indubitability, and they are factual matters: what my name is (§328), or that I have two hands (§250), or that I have never been in the stratosphere (§222), or in China (§339) or Bulgaria (§269) for that matter. Doubting these things would result in "madness" (§281). But the same is true if I doubt certain basic facts about the world and about the people around me. There are certain doubts and certain

[9] I am referring here to Medina 2006b, from which a good part of the next three pages are drawn.

beliefs that seem irreconcilable with rationality—for example, the belief that cars grow out of the earth (§279) or that people have sawdust in their heads (§281). As Wittgenstein puts it, "In certain circumstances a man cannot make a *mistake*. . . . If Moore were to pronounce the opposite of those propositions which he declares certain, we should not just not share his opinion: we should regard him as demented" (§155).

It is indeed remarkable that our status as rational and responsible agents seems to depend on not doubting certain things, on being able to hold on to some certainties. But as Wittgenstein insistently argues, we should not conclude from this that these certainties are a special kind of infallible knowledge. In fact, they are not knowledge at all. They are, rather, the presuppositions of our knowledge; what needs to be taken for granted, to stay put or "held fast" (§144), for our epistemic practices to get off the ground. These certainties constitute the background against which our investigative practices are carried out and our knowledge claims are raised, challenged, and defended or defeated. These background certainties do not have a special epistemic status, but they do have a special relation to rationality: "The reasonable man does *not have* certain doubts" (§220). In Wittgenstein's view, reasonable thinking and reasonable acting presuppose the holistic aspect of knowledge and thought. We do not simply believe one thing at a time; our thoughts and actions require a system or framework: "a totality of judgments" (§140). This totality contains all kinds of certainties we have accumulated through our own experience and through that of others: certainties about the world, about ourselves, and about the people around us.

My beliefs about the world can be formed and made sense of only with the help of background certainties about my surroundings, for example, the certainty that "the earth has existed long before my birth" (§84). Similarly, my beliefs about my fellow humans also presuppose general certainties that go unquestioned: for example, that people have heads, or that they have parents, or that they have feelings, sensations, and emotions. But each belief in this system also presupposes many other beliefs about people's physical and mental states, their production, interaction, consequences, and so on. Subjects can be wrong about any of their individual beliefs about the world and about the people around them. Here they can make mistakes, *individual* mistakes, although they rarely do and by and large we can *trust* them on these matters and they can *trust* themselves (see §150 and §159). But for them to be wrong about *all or most* of their beliefs about the world and about their fellow human beings would be for them *not* to have a meaningful totality or belief system about these matters *at all*. This would disqualify them as rational thinkers and responsible agents, for it would leave them without a system or framework with which to think and act. Discarding *most* of our individual beliefs or rejecting the background certainties on which we rely would be paralyzing. The same can be said about the beliefs concerning our own selves and minds. They

also form a system: a system that is sustained by tacit background certainties (e.g., that I have a body; that I have a past; that I have sensations, emotions, beliefs, and desires); and a system that consists in a complex network of interrelated beliefs about oneself. By and large we are correct about ourselves and about the contents of our minds. And indeed, as Bilgrami has argued, this presumption of authority is guaranteed by our status as rational and responsible agents. *Some* self-knowledge is indeed required by rationality and responsible agency. But the same is true of other types of knowledge, such as knowledge of the world and knowledge of our fellows and their minds: they are also required by rationality and responsible agency; and no one can be considered a rational and responsible agent unless she has *minimal* knowledge about the empirical and the social world, that is, *some* correct beliefs about her surroundings. Indeed it is a trivial truth that, in the light of a massive cognitive failure (no matter in what area), people cease to be considered rational and responsible agents. So, the normative dimension and the constitutive relation with responsibility, which Bilgrami has claimed to be the special features of self-knowledge, are actually the crucial constitutive features of all knowledge, for to be a responsible agent is to be a *minimally* knowledgeable subject. Responsibility and epistemic competence are bound up with each other: there is no responsibility unless there is minimal knowledge about self, others, and the world.

So my view of the relationship between responsible agency and knowledge is both more modest and more demanding than Bilgrami's. On the one hand, responsible agency requires *only minimal self-knowledge* that need not include explanatory knowledge of how beliefs, desires, and intentions cause one's actions. But, on the other hand, responsible agency requires more than minimal self-knowledge: it requires *minimal social knowledge of others* and *minimal empirical knowledge of the world*. I subsume these epistemic implications of responsible agency under what I call the *thesis of cognitive minimums*: namely, that responsible agency requires that one be minimally knowledgeable about one's mind and one's life, about the social world and the particular others with whom one interacts, and about the empirical realities one encounters. Enjoying the status of a rational and responsible agent presupposes that we minimally know what goes on with us, with our fellows, and in the world. One cannot lose all reliability and epistemic authority in these domains and retain this status. Rational and responsible agents must have *some* correct beliefs about the subjective, intersubjective, and objective domains. In "What Is So Special About Self-Knowledge?" (2006b), I articulate and defend a different version of this thesis of cognitive minimums in terms of reasonable expectations or presumptions about epistemic authority:

> For normally functioning agents who are considered to be competent in our practices, there is the presumption of *minimal* epistemic authority in all the different areas of ordinary knowledge required for everyday

> activities . . . Rationality and responsible agency require *some* first-person authority, *some* social authority, and *some* empirical authority about the world around us. The presumption of epistemic authority in these areas reflects simply the expectation of minimal competence that derives from the presumption of rationality that applies to all those who are treated as responsible agents. (pp. 599–600)

Besides the defeasible presumption of minimal first-person authority, we find also the defeasible presumptions of minimal authority with regard to the world and our fellow human beings and their minds. These presumptions, these different forms of epistemic authority, are part and parcel of the epistemic competence required for responsible agency. But there is a crucial complication to my thesis of cognitive minimums, which appears precisely when we reintroduce the contexts of oppression and systematic injustice that we are interested in. The threefold presumption of epistemic authority can be maintained only in the *absence of systematic distortions and of cultivated forms of blindness and ignorance*, that is, under conditions of *epistemic justice*. It is only when there are no pervasive epistemic injustices, no systematic roadblocks to the development of knowledge, that responsible agents should be expected to be minimally knowledgeable about themselves, their peers, and the world. But what if there are systematic obstacles that block their access to certain bodies of knowledge and/or systematic distortions that taint their processes of knowledge acquisition in those areas? For example, in the context of racial oppression of the segregated South of the first half of the twentieth century, members of different races had very limited and constrained opportunities to know each other; and there were pervasive racial stereotypes and misconceptions that systematically distorted the testimonial exchanges across racial lines, making it virtually impossible for members of different races to learn from each other and about each other. Similarly, under conditions of sexual oppression, an oppressive and divisive gender binary can create physical and psychological contexts of gender segregation in which the masculine and the feminine cannot intermingle, and they become utterly unfamiliar (in the extreme case, unknowable) to each other.[10] I will argue that both in the case of racial ignorance and in the case of gender ignorance, the lack of knowledge about one's others (people of other races or of other genders) becomes simultaneously a lack of knowledge about

[10] By an oppressive gender binary, I mean a radical artificial separation of human features into the masculine and the feminine, which are pitted against each other, set in opposition, and treated as mutually exclusive. Many feminist and gender theorists have investigated how this oppressive binary is socially maintained, and attention has been called to processes of socialization that encourage men to ignore and/or repress their "feminine features" (to treat them as "not who they are") and women to do the same with their "masculine features." And of course these processes have direct epistemic consequences: when certain aspects of oneself are normatively deemed out of bounds, they become foreign, unfamiliar and difficult to relate to as genuine aspects of one's identity.

oneself. To put my philosophical cards on the table, my discussion of these interrelated epistemic deficits will rely on a relational view of identity and a relational view of self-knowledge—the former can be found in Latina feminists such as Alcoff, Moya, and Schutte, and the latter in critical race theorists such as Mills and Sullivan.[11] I will try to show that significant cognitive lacunas about one's peers go hand in hand with blind spots about oneself. What is important to see for now is that these epistemic deficiencies prompted and protected by situations of oppression undermine one's status as a responsible agent.

So, when we take into account contexts of oppression and systematic injustice, my thesis of cognitive minimums needs to be amended and qualified by a crucial normative condition: namely, that the epistemic expectations and presumptions of epistemic authority that derive from responsible agency should be called into question and possibly suspended (at least for some people and in some contexts) under conditions of social injustice. Cognitive minimums can be assumed to be the norm only insofar as subjects are unimpeded in their processes of knowledge acquisition. The more pervasive and deeper the epistemic obstacles are, the more exceptional it will be to meet these cognitive minimums. An unqualified thesis of presumptive epistemic authority would involve untenable idealizations, for when we talk about epistemic authority in the abstract, we tend to assume an ideal case in which there are no preexisting epistemic obstacles or disadvantages; that is, we assume that the *normal conditions* are *conditions of epistemic justice*. And why should we assume such a thing? Fricker has shown brilliantly that "various degrees of testimonial injustice happen all the time" and, echoing Judith Shklar, she denounces the pervasive misconception of thinking "falsely of justice as the norm and injustice as the aberration" (2007, p. 39). As remarked before (see section A of the introduction), the normalization of a presumed justice and the concomitant abnormalization of injustice have important ideological effects: they contribute to the invisibility of everyday injustices, to the formation of active bodies of ignorance that perpetuate the injustices and make us insensitive to the suffering they cause. Fricker's argument for the ubiquity of testimonial injustice is that, in racist and sexist societies such as ours, testimonial exchanges are more often than not indirectly affected by unjust identity prejudices, for these prejudices operate both doxastically and non-doxastically, distorting both the hearer's *beliefs* about the speaker and the hearer's *social perception* of the speaker. And, as Fricker puts it, "While it may be hard enough to police one's beliefs for prejudice, it is significantly harder reliably to filter out the prejudicial stereotypes that inform one's social perceptions directly, without doxastic mediation" (p. 36). Some instances of testimonial injustice occur because of the hearer's prejudiced beliefs, but others occur in spite of them, that is, they occur because

[11] See Alcoff (2006), Moya (2002), and Schutte (2000); and Mills (1998, 2007) and Sullivan (2006). I also formulated and defended a relational view of identity in chapter 3 of my (2006a).

of "stealthier, residual prejudices, whose content may even be flatly inconsistent with the beliefs actually held by the subject" (Ibid.). Therefore, we should conclude, with Fricker, that "the right vision of epistemic relations is such that testimonial injustice goes on much of the time" (Ibid.).

It is hopelessly naïve to think that in situations of oppression most individuals and groups will be unaffected by epistemic injustices, that they will not have internalized epistemic distortions and developed forms of insensitivity that limit their cognitive lives. Assuming that ordinary subjects in ordinary circumstances can remain unaffected by long-held and prevailing prejudices would be to assume that people can remain *epistemically innocent* even when they live their lives in contexts of oppression, that is, even when they are brought up and operate amid systematic injustices. I want to label this problematic, naïve assumption *the assumption of epistemic innocence*. This is a pervasive assumption in the idealizations of normative epistemology. It is in fact a trap that is very easy to fall into every time we lose sight of social realities and inadvertently idealize our epistemic predicament. I, for one, have fallen victim to this trap: in my earlier work on epistemic authority, I argued for the presumptive epistemic authority in everyday affairs of all subjects, without interrogating how such presumption is affected by social contexts and the subjects' positions and relations in those contexts. I contended naively, "Subjects are presumed to have *some* authority about those things that are within their power to know"; "in everyday affairs epistemic authority is the *default status* of competent subjects, a status that is not lost until there is evidence to call it into question" (2006b, p. 599). But there is evidence to question such a default status whenever we detect social disparities, relations of oppression, and structural injustices. Given the epistemic implications of a systematic social injustice, indicators of injustice are prima facie evidence for the loss of epistemic innocence and, therefore, prima facie counter-evidence against the default status of epistemic competence that could otherwise be attached to apparently responsible agents. Epistemic responsibility cannot be treated independently of ethico-political responsibility and issues of social justice. Our epistemic responsibilities are not ethically and politically neutral, but rather, deeply sensitive to social context and the levels of justice that can be enjoyed in that context. What is reasonable to expect of responsible agents to know about themselves, about their peers, and about their surroundings needs to be *socially contextualized*: the agent's epistemic obligations and our entitlement to expect and demand particular kinds of knowledge are always contextually bound.

When the thesis of cognitive minimums is detached from considerations of social justice, it is taken to apply to everybody universally and equally as if there were no significant distortions and roadblocks that could affect subjects differentially, that is, as if there were a baseline level of epistemic justice that we all enjoy equally, or as if we all retained our epistemic innocence. Minimal

knowledge about oneself, about one's peers, and about one's surroundings should not be indiscriminately expected of apparently rational and responsible people under conditions of oppression and systematic injustice. The greater the levels of social justice available in a given society, the safer it is to assume that the cognitive minimums will be respected in that society, and that the normative status of being a responsible agent will be maintained by most subjects. But, in contexts of oppression, the epistemic minimums that responsible agents must maintain are often compromised. Systematic injustices produce irresponsible agents, for they tend to lack knowledge of themselves, of others, and of the world. But are all members of an unjust society equally irresponsible epistemically, ethically, and politically? Definitely not. And is all epistemic innocence completely lost for everyone in contexts of systematic injustice? Not quite. The thesis that I will defend in the rest of this chapter is that social injustices breed both ignorance and irresponsibility simultaneously, but socially produced ignorance and irresponsibility are *context-specific and highly sensitive to social positionality*. In other words, social injustices result in a lack of knowledge and a lack of ethical and political responsibility, but these normative failures are not evenly distributed among social groups, and they do not appear uniformly across contexts of interaction and across social positions. The epistemic and ethico-political deficits created by systematic injustices typically affect all corners of the social fabric, but they are often quite polymorphous, taking very different shapes for different kinds of subjects and in different locations. The epistemic obligations that derive from our status as responsible agents get harder to carry out as contexts become more unjust, but not for everybody and in the same way. These obligations become easier to fulfill as individuals and groups make advancements toward justice; but again, this normative progress does not extend to all social groups and to all social locations simultaneously. But what we can say quite generally is that, under conditions of oppression, subjects have a harder time maintaining their status as responsible ethical and political agents (at least in part) because they have a harder time being epistemically responsible, that is, because they have a harder time being adequately knowledgeable about themselves, about their peers, and about the world.[12]

In recent decades, different approaches in social epistemology have produced rich accounts of the systematic epistemic failures that occur under conditions of oppression. In particular, I want to call attention to three bodies of literature here: the theory of ideology (from Marx to Lukacs and

[12] It is important to note that although I identify three main areas in which cognitive minimums have to be met and should be expected, the relevant epistemic areas can be grouped and carved out differently; the areas I have listed are indeed not sharply defined and autonomous, but have vague boundaries and are often interrelated in crucial ways (e.g., my emotions belong to my inner world but, typically, they involve the social world of others and are grounded in empirical realities).

beyond), race theory (from Du Bois to Mills and many others), and feminist epistemology. I will draw heavily on the last two for my analysis and discussion of epistemic failures in contexts of racial and gender oppression. Initially, in classical Marxism, theories of ideology were particularly effective in analyzing and explaining the production of social ignorance about the empirical world (the distortion of economic facts, historical facts, etc.), but much less so in providing an account of how social distortions affect more intimate domains and the personal and interpersonal knowledge we have (or lack) of ourselves. And although of course this was later addressed by many neo-Marxists (such as Althusser and Lukacs), it was race theory and feminist theory that filled in this vacuum, providing detailed accounts of how oppression produced and maintained itself through socially produced misconceptions about oneself and about one's peers. Throughout the twentieth century, race theory and feminist theory established a direct relation between social injustices and the lack of personal and interpersonal knowledge that could palpably be felt in people's lives and interactions. These theories proclaimed that racial and gender oppression had generated internalized distortions that made it very difficult for people to look at themselves and at each other truthfully. But these bodies of literature also offered accounts of how, even under conditions of systematic distortion, we could still find in certain corners of the social fabric unvarnished social perceptions and insights that could pierce the systematic ignorance rooted in oppression. Accordingly, I will draw on race theory and feminist theory in two ways: first, in this chapter, in order to elucidate epistemic failures in the areas of self-knowledge and social knowledge; but second, in the next chapter, in order to explain epistemic successes in these areas as well, that is, in order to show how people can remain epistemically responsible even under conditions of oppression. For the former, I will draw on accounts of "blindness" that have been influential in philosophical discussions of race, but also on discussions of the "invisibility" of the suffering of abused women in Third World feminism.[13] I will pay special attention to the DuBoisian notion of "double-consciousness" and its later formulations in contemporary race theory as well as in feminist epistemology, especially in standpoint theory. My argument will be that under conditions of oppression maintaining epistemic responsibility requires nothing less than developing a kind of lucidity that can only be attained thanks to kaleidoscopic perceptions through multiple angles and perspectives. But let's start with the negative, with the ways in which epistemic responsibilities are thwarted due to social injustices, so that we can then turn to the challenge of retaining the status of responsible knowers and doers and of attaining some epistemic and social justice.

[13] For a rich discussion of Third World feminist social criticism and its impact on feminist theory and democratic theory, see Ackerly (2000).

4.2. Betraying One's Responsibilities under Conditions of Oppression: Social Contextuality, Interconnectedness, and Culpable Ignorance

When is partaking in a body of social ignorance a form of irresponsibility? When and in what sense is thinking or acting on the basis of a biased social imaginary blameworthy? And is the failure in responsibility an ethical failure of the individual or a political failure of society? And can it really be properly called a failure of the individual or of the group and not a symptom of the age they happen to live in, a mere product of *bad luck*—as Thomas Nagel, Bernard Williams, or his followers could argue? We can only answer these questions through an account of the relationship between knowledge/ignorance and responsible agency. In the previous section I argued that there are cognitive commitments and expectations that are essential and unavoidable for responsible action, but that these commitments and expectations must be identified contextually in relation to the normative aspects of the relevant contexts and, in particular, to the epistemic injustices within those contexts. Now we need a contextual analysis of the violation of epistemic obligations that are necessary for responsible agency. That is, we need to ask now how we can contextually identify epistemic deficits that are bound up with people's failures as responsible subjects of knowledge and action. More specifically, to further explore the link between epistemic and ethico-political responsibility, I want to offer a contextualist analysis of our epistemic obligations to know ourselves and to know others under conditions of oppression.

My focus in the rest of this chapter will be on the first two cognitive minimums I listed above and their interrelations: the minimal knowledge about oneself and about those with whom one interacts. That is, I want to analyze contextually what I am reasonably expected to know about myself and about others by virtue of being a responsible agent, and how what I know about myself and what I know about others are intimately connected and affect each other. There are indeed blurred boundaries between self-knowledge and social knowledge, the latter including both generic knowledge about the functioning of the social world and specific knowledge about the particular others with whom we interact. Many pieces of the knowledge I have about myself are bound up with social knowledge that involves others: how old I am, which countries I have lived in and visited, whether or not I am shy, and so on. What I know about myself often involves empirical facts about social and political realities. I know myself in the social world and I know myself contextually *with* and *through* others. It is *with* them that I count my years and can tell my age (with the calendars they have supplied me, with the birthdays I have celebrated, etc.); it is *with* them that I divide the territories of the world into discrete countries and recognize policed boundaries through which I am checked when I travel; and so on. It is *through* them that I start looking at myself and at my life in a particular way; it is *through* them that I can check certain things

about myself and about my life, that I can maintain my memories and contrast my experiences, and so on. On the other hand, I also know other people contextually in ways that involve or concern *me*, however indirectly. Typically I know particular others through direct interaction in which I am not a mere spectator, but a participant, and therefore I know these others *in particular relations to me*. But even when I learn about particular subjects and social groups in apparently detached ways—for example, when I read about the president of the United States in the newspaper, when I study the history of the Hopi people, when I watch a documentary about India, and so on—even in these cases, there are always relations between these people (and their lives) and myself (and my life): for example, relations of proximity or distance, relations of similarity or difference, relations of being affected or unaffected by others in particular ways, and relations of dependence (which are not hard to imagine in the globalized world of today) or independence.

Self-knowledge and knowledge of others are interrelated in many crucial ways. I want to focus here on a particular area of intersection in which these two types of knowledge become bound up with each other in a particularly direct way. This epistemic area of intersection is what I call *knowledge of social contextuality*, that is, the knowledge of the social contexts in which our lives unfold and become entangled with the lives of others. Knowledge of social contextuality includes the knowledge of our social *positionality* and our social *relationality*: that is, it involves knowing the array of social positions/locations one comes to occupy and the network of social relations in which one's life becomes enmeshed. To know oneself contextually is to know how one occupies and lives in and through social positions and locations, and how one relates to multiple others in those positions and locations. To know others contextually is to know them in their various positions and locations and in their networks of social relations, which, however implicitly and indirectly, will typically place these others in relation to oneself by being included or excluded in—affected or unaffected by—their positionality and relationality. I will focus on an example to illustrate how deficient knowledge of social contextuality involves deficient knowledge of others and ultimately of oneself as well, thus violating two of the cognitive minimums discussed above. I will choose an example in which the failure in epistemic responsibility is not inconsequential, a case in which epistemic irresponsibility grounds ethical and political irresponsibility. My example concerns a real incident that occurred in my own academic community, Vanderbilt University. I choose this example as a starting-point of my discussion precisely because it is likely to appear as involving a fairly superficial kind of insensitivity. It may even seem to some that the incident does not amount to an epistemic injustice. But I will try to show that unfair epistemic treatments become inscribed in taken-for-granted assumptions about what is expected to be familiar and knowable in a social context—which often involve the neglect of the histories of stigmatization and

the specific vulnerabilities of minority groups. The central goal of the next section will be to show how an apparently insignificant cognitive failure is in fact an integral part of a social pattern of insensitivity about differences that needs to be exposed and calls for both individual and collective responses.

4.2.1. PIG HEADS, BURNING CROSSES, AND CAR KEYS

It happened on Saturday, October 8, 2005, at the Vanderbilt University campus. After a fraternity party in which a pig had been roasted and eaten, an intoxicated frat boy walked across the street with the pig's head and left it at the doorsteps of the Ben Schulman Center for Jewish Life. The following morning the Jewish community on campus was outraged and disgusted, and so were the visitors of the Center and the patrons of the vegetarian cafeteria in it (Jewish or not). The incident happened during the Jewish High Holy Days that begin with Rosh Hashanah and end with Yom Kippur, and many thought that "someone was sending Vanderbilt's Jewish community a chilling message during the holiest days of the year." (*The Nashville Scene*, October 20, 2005, p. 1) Both the University and the fraternity that had hosted the party launched an investigation and the student who had dropped the pig's head at the doorsteps of the Schulman Center came forward and apologized. What is most interesting about this case for our purposes is the appeal to ignorance of the pig-head dropper to relieve himself of responsibility for what had been taken to be a hateful act against Jewish people, and also the appeal to ignorance in the remarks of the university administrators on his behalf to minimize the significance of what had happened. *The Nashville Scene* reported:

> "It was a bad decision, a very bad decision," says Kristin Torrey, the school's director of Greek Life, who believes the student genuinely didn't understand the religious overtones of his action. . . . The University has taken the position that its student may be dumb, but he's no bigot. "This incident happened out of stupidity and shockingly bad taste," says Michael Schoenfeld, Vice Chancellor for Public Affairs. "But coming out of it is an opportunity to advance understanding about how the university is diversifying and about other traditions and cultures and religions and beliefs that may not necessarily be part of the traditional mainstream at the university." (*The Nashville Scene*, October 20, 2005, pp. 2–3)

The perpetrator claimed that he did not know that the building in question was a Jewish cultural center, or that pigs had any particular significance for Jewish people and pig's parts had been used to stigmatize them and attack them, mocking their prohibition to eat pork and pig's products. He claimed that he only knew that that building hosted a vegetarian cafeteria, and that he thought at the time that dropping a pig's head there would be a funny joke about vegetarians. Leaving aside how problematic it is for the pig-head dropper

and the university administrators to depict the incident as a "simple" anti-vegetarian joke (as if this involved no ethical harm), let's focus on the exculpatory aspect of their appeal to ignorance. I will also leave aside that the alleged ignorance (or parts of it) may very well be a mere excuse or cover story to disavow any possible trace of anti-Semitism in the student's conduct, for the interesting thing for my purposes here is that *even* if we believe the perpetrator's own account of his epistemic situation, there is still a failure in epistemic responsibility with ethical and political consequences. In the remarks of the perpetrator of the incident as well as in the remarks of the university administrators, ignorance was used—as it often is—as an exculpating mechanism: the subject alleges that he did not have the requisite knowledge to understand the symbolic significance that his action could have for some, for he did not know the Jewish affiliation of the location and he did not know the connection between pig's parts and the history of oppression of the Jewish people. But can one simply plead ignorance and thus shake off responsibility for one's action? Does this ignorance (assuming we believe it to be genuine) show that people were simply wrong and oversensitive in reading cultural intolerance and an ethnic attack into this case? Can we charge with oversensitivity those who thought that the Jewish community had been wronged without inspecting the intention behind the act and the state of mind of the perpetrator? We need to address sequentially two sets of questions: first, whether it does matter what the perpetrator of the action in question knew or did not know; and second, which are the inculpatory and exculpatory effects that a particular lack of knowledge may bring, and who among the concerned agents and communities can be said to be responsible for the epistemic failure and its effects.

Let's start with the normative significance of the epistemic factors for the evaluation of the action in question. One could argue that we can identify the action of dropping a pig's head anywhere other than in a garbage bin as irresponsible behavior without knowing the epistemic details of the case. But this assignment of irresponsibility would be tremendously superficial and vague: it would not identify what kind of ethical and political wrong we are dealing with and how to address it; it would not identify in what sense the agent fell short of his responsibilities and it would leave us in the dark as to the appropriate community reactions to respond to the incident and to prevent such incidents from happening again. Indeed, one should not leave the leftovers of one's meal (especially big chunks of roasted animals) at *anybody*'s doorstep, littering and causing bad odors. But what is in question is precisely what harms, if any, have been committed *in addition to* dirtying and stinking people's spaces. Of course everybody can see that the uncivil behavior of dirtying and stinking has been perpetrated—this was never in question. What was in question—and raises interesting philosophical questions about the relationship between knowledge/ignorance and responsibility/irresponsibility—is whether a stigmatizing and insensitive act has also been committed *in some*

sense, even if unknowingly, even if in spite of the perpetrator's ignorance, or perhaps *precisely because of his ignorance*: for, according to the perpetrator's own account, he would *not* have done what he did (littering and stinking with that particular object in that particular place), *had he known* the specifics of the social context of his action.

However, some would argue that the epistemic details of the case are irrelevant in a different sense: if the vulnerabilities of a group have been violated and an injury has been inflicted, a social wound has been opened whatever the executing hand happens to know or ignore. There is an important truth here: in the incident we are examining, the phenomenon of social harm did occur and was experienced as such; and, therefore, there was the unquestionable duty to acknowledge and respond to the harm and to try to prevent future incidents of this kind. A lack of response to this incident could have been construed to express a lack of concern for the vulnerabilities of the group that felt insulted, as well as an inadmissible tolerance and complicity with acts of that kind—signaling to the community that such acts can happen with impunity. But the proper community response does depend on the epistemic details of the case. What the subject knew or did not know is not only relevant, but of the utmost importance for adjudicating responsibilities not only to him but also to the relevant communities of which he is (or has been) a member. By calling attention to the normative significance of the alleged ignorance and the responsibilities that may be involved in having such ignorance, I am interested not only in the epistemic failures and the corresponding ethico-political failures of the individual student, but also in those of the communities that have produced him and his alleged ignorance, and the communities that continued to contribute to his development, including (and especially) the Vanderbilt community in which the incident took place (and of which I am also a member).

What other deficiencies can we find in the action of the pig-head dropper besides an obvious lack of civility? Did it involve a specific form of ethical and political harm? And does the presence of this harm depend on the intentions and knowledge of the agent? Typically, individualistic and agent-centered analyses of insensitive speech and action put the normative weight on the intentional states and knowledge/ignorance of actors, whereas collectivist analyses put it on the reception and the consequences of the acts in question. Analyses of stigmatizing or derogatory speech typically focus either on production or on reception, either on the illocutionary or on the perlocutionary, either on individualistic elements (such as intentions) or on collectivist elements (such as impact on a community).[14] My interactive and relational view defies these dichotomies in bringing all those elements together, for my analysis focuses on intentional states and epistemic predicaments of individuals, but as they emerge from processes of socialization in particular communities and as they operate

[14] See especially Butler (1997).

in patterns of interaction. In my view, although external (non-intentional) social criteria can be given for ethico-political harms, the intentional and epistemic aspects do nonetheless matter deeply because they can clue us in to the most appropriate understanding of and response to what happened.

The action of dropping a pig's head in the building across the street from the fraternity house, we are told, was meant as a joke among friends or peers. As such, the action can indeed be deemed ethically irresponsible, as involving not entering one's ethical relations properly (not being a good friend, a good neighbor, a good playmate). But whether it was meant that way or not, the action can also be seen as a *political* action, for it takes place in social spaces traveled by many and can affect entire groups, as in fact it did. Whether meant that way or not, the action was in fact political, for it disturbed the polis: it was taken as an offense against a cultural group, against a whole community, and in fact, ultimately against an entire series of embedded communities (as Russian dolls)—the larger Jewish community, the Nashville community (the incident appeared in the local papers and TV channels), the multicultural and interfaith communities of the South, of the nation, and so on. On the one hand, it may seem exaggerated to treat this incident as a microcosm of religious and ethnic relations in the contemporary South. But, on the other hand, the case is certainly symptomatic, and it does reveal bodies of ignorance and attitudes of disinterest and neglect that are still alive. It reveals that we are dealing with a social context in which until recently people could live with the luxury of being familiar with Christian symbols and utterly unfamiliar with all other religious and ethnic symbols. It also reveals that this is a luxury that can no longer be maintained without consequences, without getting into trouble of some sort. Of course ethnic ignorance was never inconsequential, but the context did not allow for the consequences of that body of ignorance to surface easily for white Christian subjects who had internalized the mainstream perspective blind to differences. When things of this sort happened before, harm was likely to be experienced by the disrespected minority subjects, but the harm went largely unnoticed (or at least unnoticed as "harm") by the rest. There was a time when there was no Jewish cultural center. There was a time when Jewish students were few and unnoticed. Worse yet, there was even a time in which there were no racial or ethnic others on campus, or at least the campus lived *as if they were not there*, as if the entire community was composed of white Anglo-American Christians. The social space and its inhabitants have changed dramatically, and yet there are traces of these times and their legacy, which can explain why certain things can happen to some groups and not others, and why what is commonly known or not known by members of the university community about the different groups that compose it changes dramatically depending on where each group is situated in society and within the institution and its history.

He did not know, the pig-head dropper claimed. But *should he have known*? Is this natural and innocent ignorance, or should he be blamed for it? Does the ignorance so clearly discharge or minimize his responsibility, as he and the Vanderbilt administrators assumed? Or could this ignorance in fact be *culpable*, indicating where the failure of responsibility lies? And was the student solely responsible for it, or should we blame the communities that instilled this ignorance in him or at least let it be (his family, his friends and peers, his educators, etc.)? In order to show more vividly the limited exculpating power of appeals to ignorance and at the same time their culpable aspects, let's imagine an equivalent act of vandalism taking place at the black cultural center and its perpetrator pleading ignorance in a similar way. It is hard to imagine but sadly still plausible that a white Vanderbilt student might not know that the Bishop Joseph Johnson Center is the black cultural center. However, it would be only theoretically imaginable but highly unrealistic (one would hope) that a student might not know that putting two sticks together in the form of a cross and setting them on fire has a hateful and stigmatizing significance for black people in the United States, especially in the South. It is reasonable to expect that *any* responsible member of the community in a Southern American university would have minimal familiarity with the history of oppression of black people in the South and with some hateful signs and elements in that history (such as the burning cross). In fact, that history is part of the social space we are talking about—Vanderbilt University—and has contributed to shape it in particular ways. The history of black people's struggle for gaining equal rights (including access to higher education) is clearly intertwined with the history of the university, a traditionally white Southern university that contributed to the exclusion of black people from higher learning and where blacks had to fight very hard to enter and become part of the university community.[15] How much detailed knowledge of this history is required for being a responsible member of the Vanderbilt community is a very tricky question. But it is clear that not knowing *anything at all* about this history of exclusion and the symbolic traces it has left behind is unacceptable, and it constitutes a blameworthy lack of epistemic responsibility that undermines one's status as a responsible agent in this social context.

The cognitive minimum violated here is the second one listed in the previous section: there is a lack of the minimal social knowledge of others required for responsible agency. In the hypothetical case of burning a cross without knowing its symbolic significance, we have a blameworthy lack of knowledge about black people, about their history and their perspectives. Moreover, the epistemic deficit is not just about black people but also about how they were

[15] Although today the Reverend James Lawson is a Distinguished Professor at Vanderbilt University, he was expelled from Vanderbilt in the 1960s for his civil rights activities—for leading the sit-ins that took place in restaurants in downtown Nashville in defying protests against Jim Crow segregation laws.

treated by some (now radical, though once mainstream) faction of Christian white Southerners. Of course we would take into account attenuating factors if we encountered blameworthy forms of ignorance of this sort bound up with special circumstances behind it: for example, if an international student *just arrived* from a remote part of the world and claimed to be unfamiliar with the relevant history and with the significance of the burning cross as a threatening symbol. But even for such a hypothetical international student there would be some degree of culpability: he has the epistemic obligation to find out who he is sharing his daily life with (especially if he is going to engage in risky activities such as burning sticks), and to develop minimal familiarity with the different groups that compose his community. Of course one must take into account the cultural context the subject comes from and the bodies of knowledge and ignorance that circulate in it: just like our pig-head dropper may have come from a family and a town with no access to Jewish history and culture, our hypothetical international student may have come from a country with no easy access to American history and culture (American film, literature, etc.). But the exculpating effect of the collective ignorance one has inherited gets dissipated quickly, and the longer one is exposed to communities in which there are opportunities to learn and repair that ignorance, the weaker one's exculpatory appeal to a collective body of ignorance is. If our hypothetical international student had already been in the United States for years, his allegation that in his country people do not know such things would become suspicious and eventually irrelevant. In the same way, if our pig-head dropper had been a senior at Vanderbilt,[16] his exculpatory appeal to ignorance would have been all the more problematic. One cannot take refuge in the *cultural distance* that exists between one's group and the community that one remains ignorant about *forever*. That the distance exists, or that it remains in place despite opportunities to shorten it, is precisely the root of the problem for which we have to take individual and collective responsibility. One cannot hide oneself completely in the collective ignorance in which one partakes, at least not for long. The collective ignorance may not be of one's choosing, but one cannot inhabit it comfortably and without making any effort to combat it (even when opportunities to do so present themselves), and legitimately use this inherited ignorance to excuse one's actions. Even if indirectly, by omission and inaction, one becomes an active participant in one's own ignorance if one lets it sit and grow, paying no attention to its roots and its ramifications. One's *inattention* to the ignorance one partakes in becomes *complicity and active participation*. Even if the body of ignorance remains largely unconscious and is not an explicit motivating factor with regard to one's actions, one cannot help but to have one's life affected by it. One's participation in the collective

[16] Citing federal student privacy laws, Vanderbilt University declined to release the identity of the student who confessed to be the perpetrator of the pig-head incident.

bodies of ignorance one has inherited becomes *active*, because one acts on it and fails to act against it, whether one knows it or not, and whether one wills it or not. As Shannon Sullivan (2006) has shown so convincingly in her transactional account of whiteness, racial ignorance recruits agents to act on it habitually in their daily lives, and it gets transmitted across generations through a complex array of (largely unconscious) habits and bodily dispositions that perpetuate themselves through an interesting combination of inattention and careful orchestration.

Using Elizabeth Anderson's (2011) distinction between *racism* and *racial stigmatization*, we can say that most contemporary cases of racial insensitivity are cases of racial stigmatization, even if they do not amount to conscious and self-avowed forms of racism. Both the real incident of the pig head and the fictional incident of cross-burning without racist intentions seem to fall into that category. As Anderson explains the distinction, both racism and racial stigmatization involve "the imputation of dishonorable *meanings* to stereotypes of group difference—public narratives or interpretative frames for explaining perceived group differences in terms that demean the members of the stigmatized group" (p. 45). But racial stigmatization is a broader category than racism because the latter, but not the former, requires the awareness and endorsement of stigmatizing representations. The presence of racial stigmatization only requires *practical engagement* with racial stigmas,[17] that is, acting in a way that expresses, evokes, or enacts demeaning stereotypes and scripts, even if such stereotypes and scripts remain unconscious and even if they are explicitly (and often sincerely) rejected by the agent. As Anderson as well as many other race theorists have pointed out, mainstream forms of racial stigmatization in the contemporary United States—the so-called "new racisms"[18]—have taken this implicit and unconscious form, and they coexist with vocal rejections of racist attitudes: "Racial attitudes have moved from the explicitly racist to the racially stigmatizing" (p. 52).

The defining element of the phenomenon of racial stigmatization is what Anderson refers to as an *expressive harm* or *injury*: that is, the damage of the reputation or social standing of a group, which takes place through the recirculation of stigmatizing representations. And it is important to note that the expressive harm of racial stigmatization takes place independently of the agent's intentions, conscious attitudes, and epistemic background. As Anderson puts it, racial stigmatization "does not require that the actor be conscious

[17] As Anderson explains it, "The condition of racial stigmatization consists of public, dishonorable, practically engaged representations of a racial group with the following contents: (1) racial stereotypes, (2) racial attributions, or explanations of why members of the racial group tend to fit their stereotypes, that rationalize and motivate (3) derogatory evaluations of and (4) demeaning or antipathetic attitudes. . . . toward the target group and its members. Processes of racial stigmatization consist of conduct (including habits, norms, and policies) that tends to produce, reinforce, or express that condition" (2011, p. 48).

[18] See especially Patricia Hill Collins (2005).

of or endorse the stigmatic representations"; and in the extreme case "the actor may be wholly ignorant of them" (p. 49). To illustrate, Anderson offers the example of a hotel guest who unwittingly hands his car keys to a black businessman in the lobby, on the assumption that he is on the hotel staff. This act would be racist in a full sense if it was guided by the stigmatizing idea that blacks belong to subordinate roles and lower-paid jobs. But the action in question would still be racially stigmatizing even if it wasn't motivated by demeaning representations at all: "The guest may be a foreigner, unaware of the stigmatization of blacks, and simply mistook the businessman's suit for the uniform of hotel staff" (Ibid.). Even if no racially stigmatizing stereotype or script could be ascribed to Anderson's hypothetical foreigner, his "conduct *still expresses racial stigma* by reenacting the stigmatic consignment of blacks to servile positions" (Ibid.; my emphasis). I could not agree more: stigmatization occurs because the act is expressive of racial stigma, even if the actor is wholly unaware of the stigma and does not intend his action to be an expression of it. And no matter how unintentionally and serendipitously, when an expressive injury and the recirculation of a racial stigma occur, a response is required to neutralize the expression or evocation of the stigma, so that it is not reinscribed in the interaction and its recirculation does not affect the relation among agents who find themselves in those positions. And this is still the case even if we exculpate completely the agent whose actions have given expression to the racial stigma and have caused the expressive harm. As Anderson puts it, "racial stigmatization has a public character that constitutes an expressive harm . . . even when all parties to a social interaction reject the stigma" (pp. 52–3). All I want to add to this analysis is that the lack of awareness of a racial stigma that circulates in a particular context can very easily and very rapidly lose its exculpating force. The subject's inattention to a possible reading of his action as expressive of racial stigma loses exculpatory force and in fact becomes itself a failure—a failure in epistemic responsibility—instead of an excuse, if and when agents in that position can be expected to have the requisite knowledge of social contextuality and, therefore, to be aware of and sensitive to such stigmatizing expressive possibilities.[19] This is important because it enables us to address the kind of irresponsibility involved in the cultivated inattention and insensitivity to racially stigmatizing representations that we can find in

[19] Stigmatizing expressive possibilities have to be recognized and neutralized if and when they function as "default images" that influence the interaction. Anderson argues persuasively that when this is the case, we perform "little rituals" in our daily interactions to acknowledge "the *public* standing of racial stereotypes" and to make explicit our rejection of those stigmatic representations: "A little ritual must be performed to confirm that both parties *do* disavow the stigma, so that cooperative interactions may proceed" (2011, p. 53). As an example of such a ritual, Anderson recounts an incident in which her car broke down and the black man who came to assist her began the interaction by saying "Don't worry, I'm not here to rob you," thus making explicit a stigmatizing stereotype that could operate in the situation as a "default image" in order to reject it.

particular subjects and social groups, which is constitutive of the cultivated active ignorance denounced by recent epistemologies of ignorance.

As I announced earlier, in the cases we are examining there is a lack of minimal social knowledge required for responsible agency. But at least in some of these cases, the epistemic failures extend deeper, and they include also a lack of minimal self-knowledge required for responsible agency, although this *self-ignorance* remains in the background. It is very important to appreciate the connection that often exists between our ignorance about others and our (typically more implicit and harder to see) ignorance about ourselves. To appreciate this point about the interrelation of cognitive deficits, we need to add a *reflexive* layer to our account of epistemic irresponsibility by linking irresponsible other-regarding epistemic attitudes to irresponsible self-regarding epistemic attitudes. My contention is that when an individual is epistemically irresponsible with respect to others, it is very often the case that he is also epistemically irresponsible with respect to himself, because his social ignorance also involves *self-ignorance*: ignorance about his own positionality and relationality with respect to those ignored others, and quite possibly also ignorance about certain aspects of himself that he is unable to recognize—for example, he may be unable to see how the particular configuration of his religious identity is built around the intolerance and exclusion of other religious identities.

In our hypothetical example of the cross burner we said that the alleged ignorance of the perpetrator was not only ignorance about black people in the United States and their history, but also about whites in the United States and their history, but this could not be said to constitute self-ignorance for our hypothetical foreign student, for the United States was not his cultural context. But, in a similar vein, we should say that the ignorance of our pig-head dropper is not just ignorance about Jewish people and their history, but also about Christian people and their history, for, in the Western world, it was mainly Christians who persecuted Jews and stigmatized them using pig symbols. And since the incident took place against a Christian background, the epistemic deficit of our pig-head dropper includes ignorance of an aspect of his own cultural history (which has been carefully covered over) and therefore *(socially produced) self-ignorance*. And it is crucial to note that the self-ignorance involved here concerns aspects of the agent's cultural background and history which do not simply escape his attention, but which have been carefully neglected and hidden from view in the culture's self-image and representations of itself, thus producing self-ignorant subjects, that is, subjects who ignore important aspects of their own cultural identity and cultural history.

The strategy of covering-over that produces self-ignorant subjects and communities has been defended explicitly as a deliberate educational strategy by some of the defenders of the banning of ethnic studies from high school

curricula in Arizona.[20] The defenders of the legislation proposed in the spring of 2010 to ban ethnic studies in Arizona have used mainly two arguments (which, interestingly, are in obvious tension): first, that ethnic studies (which include African American studies, *raza* studies, etc.) are intrinsically biased and instead of teaching facts teach a political ideology of subversion that makes students unpatriotic and encourages them to rebel against the American government, thus making them uncivil citizens and a threat to the social order; and second, that the history of oppression of African Americans, Native Americans, Hispanics, and other minorities "is a downer" and should not be the focus of any curricular subject. Note that this second argument, unlike the first, does not dispute the factuality of what is taught, but takes issue with the attention given to those facts, as if the selective ignoring of historical facts that are viewed as uncomfortable for some did not have the danger of resulting in a slanted education more interested in instilling an ideology than in teaching facts. The defenders of this second argument claim that the teaching of past injustices constitutes an unnecessary source of depression and pessimism about one's nation and can breed resentment, and that students should be taught to praise their nation as "the land of opportunity," without this critical baggage. It follows from the social contextualist view of epistemic responsibility that I have articulated in this chapter that this argument is advocating a dangerous form of collective ignorance, one that makes people epistemically irresponsible and ill-equipped to be ethically and politically responsible agents, for they will be in violation of the cognitive minimum of the social knowledge required for responsible agency. And this social ignorance that can result from wrong-headed educational policies (as well as from more informal cultural attitudes and everyday practices) will not exculpate subjects when they inflict unintended harms to others because of it. On the contrary, this is *culpable ignorance*, ignorance for whose maintenance individuals and communities should feel responsible and held accountable.

Bodies of irresponsible ignorance can sometimes be protected precisely by the educational institutions that could be used to fight against them. Curricula can even be designed to produce such ignorance. On January 1, 2012, it became illegal in Arizona to teach ethnic studies courses such as Mexican American studies, despite the educational benefits of such courses highlighted by an independent audit.[21] As reported by the *New York Times*, "Seven texts were ordered removed from all classrooms including *Chicano! The History*

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[20] See Santa Cruz (2010).

[21] The audit found that the Mexican-American studies program in Arizona "was doing a good job. It noted that students who took Mexican-American studies were more likely to attend college, and that the program helped close the achievement gap. The state ignored the audit, calling it flawed" (*New York Times*, March 19th, 2012, p. A12). Interestingly, the state itself had commissioned the audit and had designated an independent agency to conduct it, but nonetheless refused to accept its recommendations, alleging bias.

of the Mexican-American Civil Rights Movement by F. Arturo Rosales and *Pedagogy of the Oppressed* by Paulo Freire" (March 19, 2012, pp. A8, A12). Novels, such as *Mexican White Boy* by Matt de la Peña, were also banned—state officials explained—for "containing 'critical race theory,' a violation under a provision that prohibits lessons 'promoting racial resentment'" (p. A8). The rationale given for these prohibitions is that these texts "foster social activism" and "advocate ethnic solidarity instead of treating pupils as individuals" (Ibid.). This exemplifies well the blind spot of an educational perspective that sees the values inscribed in other perspectives as ideological biases, but it is unable to recognize its own values (for example, individualism) as ideology. Here the principles of epistemic friction formulated in chapter 1 are clearly violated: the new curricular constraints make it impossible to *acknowledge and engage* alternative perspectives, which are erased from the curriculum; and therefore, no *epistemic equilibrium* among alternative viewpoints can be attained. The new curricular censorship sanctioned by state law in Arizona provides a perfect illustration of what I will call "the social division of cognitive laziness."

4.2.2. THE SOCIAL DIVISION OF COGNITIVE LAZINESS

How do individuals develop and maintain forms of irresponsible ignorance? Not alone, but with a lot of social support and collective effort. We become active participants in collective bodies of ignorance typically without knowing it and apparently without much conscious effort on our part, but this is because there is a complex set of social structures, procedures, and practices that encourage us to go on with our daily business without taking an interest in certain things, without challenging certain presuppositions and stereotypes, and without even learning to ask questions about distortions that are simply taken for granted automatically and habitually in the way we think and act. Just as a society's available knowledge typically involves a complicated network of social mechanisms and relations, including subcommunities with expert knowledge, I want to suggest that the bodies of ignorance socially available typically involve a similar network of social mechanisms and relations, sometimes even including subcommunities with *expert ignorance*. I want to formulate the mirror image of Putnam's (1975) celebrated thesis of *the social division of cognitive labor*, namely, the thesis of *the social division of cognitive laziness*. It is not always easy to be lazy, especially when strong waves of cognitive stimulation do not cease to come our way. Sometimes it can take a lot of cognitive energy and collective preparation and effort to remain at rest epistemically speaking, that is, to keep one's cognitive powers unmoved by any stimulation, to fail to respond epistemically to any form of friction, to any exposure that can result in cognitive changes or can trigger a learning process. This addresses what has been called the *paradox of ignorance* in the recent literature, and in

fact my thesis of the social division of cognitive laziness purports to be the beginning of an answer to this problem.

As Harvey Cormier (2007) has pointed out, while traditional epistemology has focused on the so-called paradox of learning or paradox of knowledge—how we can learn so much on the basis of such meager evidence, of such poverty of stimulation—contemporary critical epistemology coming from feminist and race theory focuses on the *paradox of ignorance*: how can we fail to learn even when impacted by abundant stimulations that should trigger the formation of the relevant beliefs? How do we remain ignorant even when we have a wealth of evidence available? How does this kind of *epistemic insensitivity or numbness* come about? How are the different cognitive inabilities, atrophies, and deficiencies that support it socially engineered? My suggestion is that this is an acquired epistemic insensitivity or numbness, and its process of acquisition and maintenance involves a *social division of cognitive laziness*, a social orchestration of epistemic attitudes that gives some subjects or subcommunities a special role and responsibility in engineering and instilling the epistemic deficiencies and atrophies that support active ignorance, such as the inability to challenge certain things or to ask certain questions.

Just as there are socially designated authorities for expert knowledge in particular epistemic domains, there are also socially designated authorities for expert ignorance in particular epistemic domains: these are *expert ignoramuses* or *laziness masters* who, in a given epistemic hierarchy,[22] are the last authority in blocking paths of interrogation, in deciding what we do not know or cannot know, the questions we cannot ask meaningfully, what we simply must rely on and leave unquestioned (no matter how arbitrary it happens to be), and so on. In the case of racial ignorance, for example, such experts can be found in intellectuals and scientists who have been in charge of producing and promulgating a complex system of distorted beliefs about human races and of creating roadblocks for the critical questioning of those beliefs and the development of alternative lines of inquiry into processes of racial differentiation. A good example of the development of historically situated and concrete forms

[22] Socially established and institutionally maintained hierarchies of epistemic authority are typically used both (and simultaneously) for the production and transmission of knowledge and for the production and transmission of ignorance. Accordingly, the very same epistemic authority that some subjects and subcommunities enjoy can be used to facilitate the circulation of both knowledge and ignorance. How can we tell whether epistemic authority is properly or improperly used, whether its outputs are epistemic successes or failures, contributions to knowledge or ignorance? This question exceeds the scope of this book, but I would suggest that procedural criteria can be given to answer this question. The principles of openness and friction discussed above can be included among such criteria; and, in general, the presence of procedures that guarantee the kind of openness and contestability that is intrinsic to knowledge-production processes can be taken as a good indication that we are dealing with collective efforts to advance knowledge and to mitigate ignorance. Helen Longino's (1990) social and procedural account of objectivity is perhaps the most developed treatment of this question and one that is very congenial with the views espoused here.

of expertise in racial ignorance can be found in McWhorter's (2009) account of the development of "scientific racism" and the eugenicist movement in the United States. A more global (but equally concrete and historically situated) example can be found in Edward Said's *Orientalism*, which unmasked oriental studies as an exercise in a specialized form of racial ignorance developed by colonial powers (becoming in fact the intellectual side of colonial domination). But besides experts in this traditional and academic sense, there are also more ordinary subjects who bear special responsibilities in the production of ignorance through a social division of cognitive laziness, namely, those who are in a position to educate and are charged with the task of being vigilant about epistemic lacunas, distortions, and cognitive deficiencies. In this respect, given their participation in formative processes, parents and teachers carry particularly demanding epistemic burdens in the social division of both cognitive labor and cognitive laziness. Parents and teachers can be both inducers and inhibitors of intellectual curiosity, facilitators and blockers of critical skills and transformative processes of learning. Given their roles and positions in the community and the special epistemic obligations they have undertaken or have been assigned, they deserve special credit for the epistemic successes and failures in the cognitive development of individuals under their care. They bear *heightened epistemic responsibility* in the social production of knowledge and ignorance. But the developing individuals as well as others more indirectly related to them—including the entire social body—should also be credited and held responsible for the epistemic successes and failures in the social production of knowledge and ignorance. Note that my thesis of the heightened responsibility of some, which derives from the theses of social division of cognitive labor and laziness, does not exculpate other individuals and groups, or the community as a whole.

Returning to our example of the pig-head dropper, my view suggests that his parents and educators bear a heightened responsibility for his ignorance; and special measures have to be taken so that those who play educational roles fulfill their demanding epistemic obligations in instilling the requisite minimal knowledge of others demanded by responsible agency. But this does not exculpate the pig-head dropper, nor does it suggest that there are no concrete steps he should take to correct his epistemic failures, for he has to take responsibility for his complicity with and participation in his own ignorance, and he has to respond to it actively. Also, the diagnosis that my view suggests does not exculpate other groups or society as a whole, for they are clearly also involved and concerned even if in more indirect and implicit ways. For example, different groups should critically examine what they know and do not know about other groups, how they think and talk about them (if they do), how they relate to them (or fail to), and so on; and we should all think critically about media representations (or lack of media representations) of the different ethnic, racial, and religious groups that compose our society.

There are not only different degrees of culpable ignorance, but also different layers of it that we can identify in individuals in their different roles as knowers and actors, as well as in communities in their different roles as consenters, enablers, attitude-setters, identity-molders, and so on. In our example of the pig-head dropper, besides the epistemic failures we can identify at the individual level, we also have a number of converging epistemic failures in a whole series of overlapping communities that have contributed to maintain the epistemic lacunas in question: we have to consider the participation in the student's ignorance of the communities he comes from (his family, town, regional community, mainstream culture, etc.) and of the current communities in which he is socially embedded (his circle of friends, his extended social networks, his teachers and fellow students at Vanderbilt, etc.). In an important sense, the ignorance that facilitated epistemically the pig-head dropper's unfortunate action is an *epistemic failure of all of us* who can be related to him; and, more specifically, those of us who had educational obligations with respect to him: his parents, caretakers, elders, teachers, and so on. The intellectual communities that have participated in the subject's cognitive development as well as particular individuals who have played a special role in it, have to take responsibility for a *specific educative failure*: failing to teach him about particular others he was going to interact with (or was already interacting with without his knowing it), failing to give him minimal familiarity with the different groups of the Vanderbilt community or to make such information readily available so as to make it hard for students not to know what he alleged he did not know. Sadly, I have to report that this is an ongoing educative failure we still have not repaired, for, in discussions of this incident with my students every year since it happened, I have tested whether the ignorance in question persists and, while the overwhelming majority of them do know where the Jewish cultural center is on campus, surprisingly many have no idea about the symbolic significance of pigs in the history of the Jewish people and their stigmatization. We are dealing with a *shared* epistemic failure, a form of ignorance that takes a lot of social effort to produce and maintain. And some of us bear special epistemic burdens and responsibilities in the social division of labor and laziness that is behind the production of that ignorance.

But what kind of failure(s) exactly are we talking about when we say that someone has not fulfilled his epistemic obligations to know others? What does it mean to say that one has been epistemically irresponsible in this particular respect? Is it about the specific things we fail to know about others? Or is it about something more general, an insensitivity or blindness that goes deeper, a deficiency in our other-regarding attitudes (or social meta-attitudes), which cannot be reduced to a list of isolated mistakes or lacunas? It can be both. We can identify here *two different kinds of epistemic failure*, which are clearly interrelated and typically are different layers of the same failure, but which have their own distinctive features and require separate analyses and responses. On

the one hand, there are specific things we should know about the people we interact with: for example, that there are Jewish people on campus, that they have a cultural center, that there are certain prominent elements in their religion, culture, and history that are important to understand, and so on. One may fail to know any or all of these things; and these failures constitute (some degree of) *first-order or object-level ignorance*. But, on the other hand, my mistaken beliefs or lack of beliefs about specific others with whom I interact may also be rooted in and supported by very general attitudes about others: the inability to see others in their specificity—*blindness to differences*; or the assumption that others are utterly irrelevant to our life—*blindness to social relationality*. Here we would have a *second-order or meta-level ignorance*, which includes what I have termed *meta-blindness*—blindness to one's own blindness, insensitivity to insensitivity. Meta-level ignorance about others is produced by meta-attitudes that limit our abilities to identify and correct our ignorance about others: attitudes about who counts as a relevant other for me, in what way, for what purposes, in what set of relations, and so on. How are the object-level ignorance and the meta-ignorance about others related?

It is indeed possible to have object-level ignorance about one's peers without having meta-level ignorance about them. For example, I may be very sensitive to epistemic lacunas about Jewish people and be very vigilant about my own ignorance about them, and nonetheless I could still maintain a substantial body of ignorance at the object level (at the level of specific distorted beliefs or concrete epistemic lacunas about Jewish people). But it is not possible to have meta-level ignorance about one's peers without also having object-level ignorance about them, for the former requires and at the same time breeds the latter. Meta-ignorance cannot happen without *some* object-level ignorance: if I know all there is to know about a group at the object level, I cannot have a wholly distorted view of how they enter my world and how I can relate to them (for this systematic distortion would be accompanied by *some* object-level ignorance). Substantial portions of object-level ignorance have to be in place for social meta-ignorance to stick; but once social meta-ignorance and its supporting cognitive-affective structures are there, they will produce more first-order ignorance because they will maintain the subject's inability to learn about others and his or her predisposition to accept distortions about them. Meta-ignorance protects epistemic lacunas and distorted beliefs, that is, first-order ignorance, which in turn becomes part of the support system of meta-ignorance, that is, the fertile soil for its cultivation and its entrenchment. In other words, when it comes to the social ignorance about our peers, the object-level may or may not lead to the meta-level: it is a necessary condition but not a sufficient condition for it. But when there is meta-ignorance, we always have object-level ignorance and the imminent danger of accumulating more ignorance at that level, for meta-ignorance is a sufficient condition (although not a necessary condition) for object-level ignorance. *Meta-blindness* protects first-order forms of blindness,

which become recalcitrant and resistant to change and improvement because the recognition that there is anything that requires change or improvement is systematically blocked. Meta-blindness can, therefore, be defined as *the inability to recognize and acknowledge one's limitations and blind spots*.

But why am I interested in meta-blindness in this exploration of deficits in social knowledge and their relation to responsible agency? Because meta-blindness is the kind of active ignorance that protects itself and becomes a durable obstacle for responsibility, the kind of ignorance that has the tendency to persist in the individual's lifetime and to perpetuate itself across generations, the recalcitrant ignorance that has deep roots in cognitive and affective structures and requires a whole battery of critical interventions and structural transformations to be uprooted. What exactly do we find at the meta-level when it comes to social knowledge? What exactly does our meta-ignorance about others consist in? It can take many forms, depending on the particular meta-attitudes that make us blind to our social blindness, that is, the meta-attitudes that block our ability to identify our ignorance about others. I will provide only a sketch of two particular variants of social meta-ignorance based on two distinct sets of meta-attitudes that have been discussed in the philosophical literature on race: blindness to differences and blindness to social relationality.

4.2.3. BLINDNESS TO DIFFERENCES

Our social meta-blindness with respect to the distinctiveness of others can in turn take different forms: it can involve not seeing others *as others* (as different from oneself), or seeing only *made-up* (or exaggerated, or arbitrarily selected) *differences*, which precludes the vision of many other things that constitute the others' specific humanity. Franz Fanon in *Black Skin, White Masks* (1967), for example, offers a detailed phenomenological description of two very different kinds of blindness to differences that can be found in white ignorance. On the one hand, Fanon describes and analyzes the white person's lack of recognition of the humanity of the black person, seeing only animality or subhumanity in the black face, or seeing only exotic foreignness, a threatening primitive mask that does not let the humanity shine through.[23] But, on the other hand, Fanon also talks about another, more subtle form of blindness to human differences that can be identified even in the most benign kind of white gaze, even among the friends and supporters of black people like Jean-Paul Sartre. The Sartrean

[23] Fanon found this dehumanizing white gaze in cultural depictions of black people in films (e.g., Tarzan movies), in children's stories, in games, in novels, and so on; but he also found this blindness in the way Negroes were looked at, talked about, and treated in daily interactions, which Fanon illustrates with the famous example of a child pointing at him and yelling "Look, a Negro!" a paradigmatic example of being objectified and dehumanized by the white gaze in an ordinary context.

gaze certainly did not fail to see the humanity in the Negro; quite the contrary, Sartre spoke out for it, repeatedly acting as a public supporter of the Negritude movement and of black intellectuals such as Fanon. But Fanon's complaint is that Sartre ultimately fails to see the humanity of the Negro *in its difference*, in its specificity, quickly universalizing Negro experiences and seeing in them nothing other than universal humanity.[24] According to Fanon, Sartre's universalization of black experience is a form of racial blindness produced by *forgetting*: "Jean-Paul Sartre had forgotten that the Negro suffers in his body quite differently from the white man" (p. 138). Racial blindness of this sort forgets the specificity of black experiences of suffering.[25] This is not to say that any form of universalism necessarily involves racial blindness to differences. I do not want to take issue here with the universalistic claim that we are *all the same*—we probably can be said to be all the same in some (very general) respects. The problem I want to call attention to, echoing Fanon, starts when universalistic claims of this sort inadvertently promote other-regarding attitudes that erase differences, such as the assumption that all others are, at bottom, *just like me*. When "we are all the same" becomes "you are all just like me" is when we find a meta-problem, the source of meta-ignorance: not simply a wrong-headed attitude toward specific others, but a restrictive overarching attitude that limits how others can appear to oneself, thus affecting one's attitudes toward specific others in negative ways, restricting one's sensitivity to differences and one's capacity to learn about them. This too (and not just the blatant denials of humanity) makes one blind to human differences and becomes an obstacle to the acquisition of social knowledge.

Blindness to differences is often rooted in a blinding meta-attitude according to which others appear under one's radar as one's peers only when their differences are erased or rendered inconsequential, that is, only when they are seen as being *like oneself*. As suggested above, this blinding meta-attitude still operates in the contemporary ideology of color-blindness—for color-blindness typically sees in white and masks this presumed whiteness as absence of color. The blinding effect of this meta-attitude can be exemplified by what Elizabeth Spelman (1988) has termed the "boomerang perception" characteristic of white ways of seeing racial others. As Spelman explains, neo-racist and neo-colonialist ways of looking at racial others construe the subjects being perceived as reflections of the perceiver, hence the boomerang structure of the perception: "I look at you and come right back to myself." The logic of boomerang perception involves a

[24] In *Orphée Noir*, Sartre analyzes the Negritude movement's articulations of experiences of racial oppression as the universal symbol of the suffering of *any* human being: "one might call negritude a kind of Passion: the black who is conscious of himself sees himself as the man who has taken the whole of human suffering upon himself and suffers for all, even for the white" (2001, pp. 132–3).

[25] For an analysis and critical discussion of what Sartre failed to see—of his specific form of racial blindness, see Bernasconi (2007) and Medina (2008a).

complete lack of reciprocity and denies independence to the seen, which appears as a mere image in the universe (or imaginary) of the perceiver and thus wholly dependent on the perceiver's subjectivity. By contrast, the white perceivers do not believe themselves to be an image in other people's universe (or imaginary) and do not experience themselves as a reflection of non-white people's social gaze. As Spelman puts it, "In the United States white children like me got early training in boomerang perception when we were told by well-meaning white adults that Black people were just like us—never, however, that we were just like Blacks" (p. 12). This illustrates well how blindness to differences can be produced and maintained by deeply problematic meta-attitudes rooted in privilege, oppression, and social injustice; and once this blindness is in place, it makes people utterly insensitive to—that is, *cognitively and affectively numbed* to—the relations of privilege and oppression around them that mediate their social perceptions and their social lives. This insensitivity to racial differences constitutes a special kind of cognitive and affective numbness. The people who become so numbed or desensitized are not just blind, but *meta-blind*: they are incapable of recognizing the source and the contours of their blindness. Those who are meta-blind are *blind to their own blindness, insensitive to their own insensitivity*: they are insensitive to the cultural blind spots that they have inherited and they recirculate; they are incapable of acknowledging the presuppositions and consequences of blinding themselves to racial differences, of putting racial blinders that occlude not only the social reality of others but also of themselves and of their positionality and relationality in the social world.

Stereotypical generalizations that people take for granted and guide their actions contribute to the erasure of differences and make them blind or insensitive to marginalized subjectivities and perspectives. These generalizations are grounded in *dominant other-regarding attitudes about normalcy*, about what counts as normal or mainstream or to be expected. These attitudes about normalcy that often guide social perceptions make the normal go unmarked and unnoticed, resulting in social phenomena such as the invisibility of whiteness, of Christianity, of heterosexuality, and so on—not because these things are not perceived at all, but rather, because they are seen everywhere, because they are constitutive elements of the lens through which the world is looked at. On the other hand, these attitudes about normalcy have the opposite effect on what is deemed different: when we approach others with these attitudes, those aspects of them that deviate from what is taken to be the norm require special markers (and explanations, excuses, etc.) and acquire a *heightened visibility*, but a precarious and negative one: they become visible only *as a problem*.[26]

[26] This is of course a generalization of Du Bois's analysis of the distorted social perception, or illusionary seeing, of the Negro as a problem. In the next paragraph I offer a brief discussion of this analysis.

These other-regarding attitudes about normalcy are complicit with the status quo and contribute to the perpetuation of marginalization and stigmatization of differences. They can include, for example, the expectation that people are white until proven colored (as if white were not a color), Christian until proven of another religious affiliation (or worse yet, of no religious affiliation at all), man or woman until proven gender-ambiguous or unclassifiable, heterosexual until proven otherwise, Western until proven non-Western, and so on. Coming back to our example of the pig's head, it seems likely that some of the other-regarding attitudes that support blindness to differences operated in the student's disregard for the specificity of the cultural space he was violating and for the possible readings and consequences of his actions for particular groups that may not look at a pig's head just as an animal's part. For example, behind the social ignorance about different cultural groups on campus, we may find other-regarding attitudes about normalcy such as the following: the assumption that all unmarked Vanderbilt students are white, Christian, and Anglo-American; the assumption that all social spaces on campus are cultural spaces one is familiar with, or sufficiently similar to them, or that any dissimilarities would be inconsequential or would create special burdens only for those who are different, and so on.

A classic illustration of the blindness to differences rooted in distorting meta-attitudes toward others can be found in Du Bois's account of the so-called *Negro problem*.[27] As Du Bois seems to suggest, "the veil" that covers black people from the white gaze does not render them altogether invisible, but worse yet, it confers upon them an *illusory visibility* in the white world. This is what is most peculiar about the racial blindness in the white gaze that Du Bois describes: *the illusion of seeing*. It is not the case that black people are simply not seen at all in the white world; they are perceived deficiently, in impoverished ways. As Du Bois puts it, they are seen as a problem, as *their* (the white man's) problem, and as nothing else. The racial blindness of the white gaze that Du Bois describes consists in the projected images on black bodies of the white imaginary, which makes it impossible to see the real lives that these bodies lead, their experiences, their interests, their aspirations, and what they would call *their* problems. Following Du Bois, I will analyze in the next chapter, how "the veil" is pierced from the other side and how those who have been rendered partially invisible—deficiently seen, seen exclusively as a problem—develop both cognitive dysfunctions and a particular kind of lucidity about their own ignorance (included in what Du Bois famously termed "double consciousness"). But for now I want to call attention only to the epistemic obstacles that "the veil" creates for the white gaze. These obstacles operate at two levels, which correspond to the two layers of the racial ignorance being constructed: at the

[27] See *The Souls of Black Folk* (1903/1996).

object level, "the veil" makes it impossible for the white gaze to perceive all kinds of particular things about black people (their strivings, their suffering, their potentialities or powers, their own dreams and ideals, etc.);[28] and at the meta-level, "the veil" hides itself, it becomes as invisible to the white gaze as the real lives of black people, making white people think that their veiled world and the veiled Negro constitute all there is to see. In other words, at the meta-level, the object of racial ignorance is "the veil" itself; and because of this meta-ignorance, because one does not see "the veil" that constrains one's vision, one is victim of an illusory seeing: one is under the illusion that one sees without distortions, that one's perceptions are unencumbered by obstacles, and therefore one is ill-equipped to recognize and repair one's own ignorance. Hence the particularly challenging problem that meta-ignorance presents. The white gaze that Du Bois describes does not see the limited nature of its own perspective; it is blind to its own blindness, insensitive to its own insensitivity. It is in this respect that I think Du Bois clearly identified what I have called *racial meta-blindness*—a particular instance of the kind of meta-ignorance that can severely handicap our capacity for knowledge at the social level. This is a crucial epistemic failure that compromises one's responsibility not only epistemically, but also ethically and politically. And note that the epistemic failure here does not involve at all the failure to see the other as relevant for one's life. Quite the contrary, as Du Bois and other intellectuals have reported, in the post-emancipation United States, white folks were quite concerned (almost obsessed) with the so-called Negro problem. But acute sensitivity to the relevance of others does not preclude the blindness to (or distorted perception of) their differences. Conversely, one may not suffer from blindness to human differences and nonetheless remain socially meta-blind in another respect: namely, one may suffer from a *blindness to social relationality*.

4.2.4. Blindness to Social Relationality and the Relevance Dilemma

I want to distinguish between these two kinds of social meta-blindness because each of them can occur in the absence of the other, even when there is at least an apparent lucidity in the other respect: even when there is an acute sense of the social relevance of particular others, we may still fail to see them in their differences and remain not just blind, but meta-blind about them; and on the other hand, even when there is an acute sensitivity to differences and even rich knowledge about these differences, one may nonetheless fail to see, or have a distorted view about, the relevance of particular differences and the social relationality that binds one to those who are different from oneself in particular

[28] See chapter 1 of Du Bois (1903/1996): "Of Our Spiritual Strivings."

respects. In other words, there may be meta-attitudes that block one's sensitivity either to differences or to the relevance of these differences. I may not have any cognitive-affective in-principle obstacles to identify my ignorance about other groups that I regard as very foreign to me: for example, Hopi people, Zulus, and so on. But I may lack the interest and motivation to repair this ignorance, and I may not consider that it is my epistemic obligation to fight against it—I may regard it as desirable without considering it required or even as having much epistemic priority at all. If I fail to see how these groups are relevant to my life, I will then fail to see why minimal familiarity with their culture, history, and way of life should be required for my responsible agency and, therefore, I will also fail to see why acquiring such minimal knowledge should be counted as an epistemic obligation of mine. But I could be wrong about these things. For all I know, there could be a Zulu community in my town and I may walk by their doors every day without knowing it. For all I know, the wealth and form of life of my community may depend on the (past and/or current) exploitation of the Hopi people, and my life may be bound up with theirs in crucial ways that remain inscrutable to me. This kind of problem introduces a crucial complication about what I called the cognitive minimum concerning our social knowledge about others: who are these *relevant others* about whom we must have minimal knowledge? I will call this problem *the Relevance Dilemma*.

On the one hand, if we consider that our epistemic obligations to know others extend only to those we have direct contact with, this will be *too restrictive* because it will excuse our ignorance of members of many groups with whom we are only indirectly related: we would not be expected to know anything about those we do not see or talk to, even if our actions affect their life and theirs ours. Lack of direct interaction should not be sufficient to excuse one from epistemic responsibility toward others because social relations should not be restricted to direct contact and because the lack of contact can itself be a form of social relationality. In some cases, such as racial segregation, lack of contact can hide a social injustice with epistemic ramifications: perhaps the social settings that surround my daily life make it very difficult (perhaps almost impossible, in situations of social invisibilization) to have direct contact with members of particular groups. But in such cases my isolation does not excuse my epistemic obligations toward other members of society; it could even heighten such obligations: for example, the isolation may protect the privilege of some and the domination of others, being itself an instrument of oppression, which calls for the lack of relationality (or the invisibilization of relationality) to be repaired.[29] In short, restricting our epistemic obligations to

[29] This connects with what I have called the *Imperative of Epistemic Interaction*, which is an epistemic version—with minor modifications—of Anderson's (2011) *imperative of integration* and is inspired by her arguments concerning the problems and dangers of de facto racial segregation and of ideologies of color-blindness that obscure racial inequalities.

those with whom we have direct contact makes the requirement overly relaxed and ineffective. This cognitive requirement would lose all its normative force, for all we would need to do to escape epistemic obligations that can derive from it is to stop talking to those we do not want to know anything about, to get them out of our sight so that we do not feel obligated to learn about them. But this avoidance strategy cannot get one off the hook; this kind of isolationism (whether deliberately chosen or not) is itself a failure to meet one's ethico-political and epistemic responsibilities, not a successful way of escaping them.

On the other hand, if we leave the epistemic obligation to know others unrestricted, it will be *overly demanding*: how can I be reasonably expected to know indefinitely many other groups with which I could be related in some sense (through my history, my culture, the history of my culture, the economy I participate in, the international relations of my country, etc.)? Will I ever be able to reach minimum familiarity with all these groups so as to fulfill my epistemic obligations and to acquire the status of a responsible agent? Will I even be able to determine what these epistemic obligations are, which groups I must familiarize myself with, and in what ways? Here we encounter the second horn of the Relevance Dilemma: if *any form of relation* or set of connections, no matter how indirect, can turn others into *relevant others* whom I am obligated to know, my epistemic obligations will extend to any possible group that has ever inhabited the planet and, therefore, these obligations will become *impossible to fulfill*. And indeed an unfulfillable requirement is not a very useful one (even as a regulative ideal, if we do not know how to connect this ideal with our ordinary cognitive lives). Thus the Relevance Dilemma stands: if we construe the relation of social relevance too rigidly (restricting it to direct interactions, for example), the cognitive minimum of the required social knowledge of relevant others becomes too relaxed and deflated; but if we construe the relation of social relevance too loosely, the cognitive minimum in question becomes too demanding and inflated. My response to the Relevance Dilemma consists in three maxims, which can be construed as important qualifications on the cognitive minimum of the requisite knowledge of others for responsible agency.

In the first place, even before we are able to identify *all* our epistemic obligations, it may be tremendously useful to know how to *prioritize* the ones we know we have, so that we can start with those that have top priority. Here we can retain an insight from the interactional approach to social relevance that places a heavy emphasis on direct interactions: it would be too limiting to restrict our attempts to gain social knowledge to those interactions and to consider those with whom we interact directly as our *only* relevant others; but clearly, they are *eminently relevant* and gaining knowledge about them should be a priority. I would say, however, that (for the reasons mentioned above about problematic forms of isolationism) the emphasis should be not so much on being in direct contact, but rather, on being *connected* within a social network and on *sharing resources and/or social spaces*. Being co-participants in

social domains (e.g., in an institution such as a university, or in a social space or a social entity such as a city, a province, or a state) binds people together in an eminent way. Sharing spaces and resources makes others our *eminently relevant significant others*. I will call this guiding consideration or rule of thumb for approaching the cognitive minimum of social knowledge the *Maxim of Eminent Relevance*. This maxim does not conclusively tell us all the relevant social knowledge we are obligated to acquire, but it does tell us where we can begin. It does not give us a complete list of all our relevant others, but it does indicate who we can consider our eminently relevant significant others.[30]

A second maxim that can help us avoid construing our epistemic obligations to know others too narrowly or too broadly is the *Maxim of Openness and Vigilance*. This maxim says that we should remain forever open to find out more about other "others" and forever vigilant about possible oversights in our social perceptions. It emphasizes that we should never be content with the familiarity we have achieved about those whom we take to be our significant or relevant others, that we should always cultivate an active openness to other "others" and an active vigilance with respect to possible limitations, distortions, lapses, and omissions of our social gaze. This maxim calls for an individual and collective exercise in self-criticism about social perceptions, and a critical self-examination that is never completed, but needs to be revisited periodically. It is crucial to pay constant critical attention to the possible limitations of our social gaze. No matter how rich and diverse our knowledge of social groups may be, it is always possible that there could be some groups or subcommunities we ignore or pay insufficient attention to because we lack awareness of the social relationality that binds us to them. My argument in the last chapter about the need to pluralize the social imagination and to develop practices of *imaginative resistance* will give more content to this maxim.

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[30] A danger here is to assume that we do not have any epistemic responsibilities with respect to distant others and with respect to injustices that are not eminently relevant in our life. The maxim of eminent relevance needs supplementation to address those cases. But although this maxim does not provide a rationale for our being responsible for becoming familiar with and developing an interest in distant atrocities in which we do not have a (yet known) involvement, it is at least compatible with such responsibility. In "On the Obligation to Keep Informed about Distant Atrocities" (2006), Carlo Filice has argued persuasively for "a prima facie duty to remain informed about distant atrocities" (p. 271). I fully agree with Filice's argument and my relational view of shared responsibilities with respect to justice can accommodate a rationale for the inexcusability of remaining ignorant about major moral atrocities: *everyone* should feel concerned and implicated in a major moral atrocity such as genocide, and *no one* can legitimately decide not to take an interest in it, as if it were something of no concern for him or her, for the extermination of (or systematic harm against) a group of people from the human community should be of concern to all humans, who are not entitled to remain passive bystanders or, even worse, to look the other way in the face of radical exclusions and degradations of fellow members of the human community. No matter how tenuous our ties or relations may be, we are all members of a global human community and, as such, we have a general obligation to become informed about distant atrocities. For issues of shared responsibilities with respect to genocide, see Larry May's book *Genocide* (2010). We will come back to this topic in chapter 5.

Finally, a third maxim that can help us get out of the Relevance Dilemma is the *Maxim of Shared Responsibility to Interrogate Relevance*: individuals and communities share responsibility to determine relevance, and they have the obligation to correct each other's perceptions of social relevance. Individuals cannot be expected to grasp all their socially relevant relations with others by themselves; but this cannot be left exclusively in the hands of the community either, because social conceptions of relevance can also have blind spots and stand in need of corrections or supplementations. Social relevance is not something that we can properly identify alone, all by ourselves; making such complex determination is a shared responsibility: both individuals and communities have the obligation to find out the networks of social relations through which groups of people become relevant to each other and their lives become entangled. Individuals are not alone in the cognitive task of getting to know their relevant others; this task requires the social support of embedded communities, such as the family; the neighborhood; different associations, cultures, and subcultures; the regions and countries implicated in one's life, and so on. But at the same time, collectivities—no matter how powerful (e.g., nations)—should not be expected to function as the last and only authority on social knowledge, for they too are bound to develop limited perspectives and to have blind spots in the knowledge of social groups that they accumulate and make available. For this reason, communities have to check on each other and cooperatively function as correctives for each other; for they need collaborative processes of mutual correction to succeed in developing adequate social knowledge. Communities need to correct each other to improve the collective bodies of social knowledge they circulate, but they also have to be open to corrections and additions by their individual members. In other words, what this third maxim tells us is that we need to bring *epistemic friction* into the perceptions of social relevance of individuals and communities, so that they can challenge each other and can help each other in identifying and correcting the limitations of those perceptions. No isolated individuals or isolated communities can successfully check the appropriateness of their own perceptions of what is socially relevant or irrelevant in their life. Such perceptions need to be normatively assessed in epistemic cooperation with others: they have to be checked against the experiences and judgments of others. Social actors and social groups benefit from encountering the resistance of others against the inertia of their cognitive and affective habits of feeling concerned or indifferent.

With the three maxims I have laid out, the problem of social relevance that we need to address in order to identify our epistemic obligations to know others becomes manageable, bypassing the Relevance Dilemma and the polarizations on which it rests. My maxims serve to mitigate our blindness to social relevance, but they do not guarantee our lucidity in this respect completely, for the problem of relevance is not a problem that can be solved once and for all, but rather, one that needs to be constantly addressed if for no other reason

than the fact that social relevance is always in the making and always changing, being affected by all our practices and changing ways of life. Recent waves of globalization, for example, have transformed deeply what becomes relevant in our daily life and the various—and often distant—groups that become intimately related without direct contact. Determining social relevance is a continuous task that requires the cooperation of individuals and communities. And this task has become especially difficult in a globalized world where individuals and communities become interconnected in unexpected ways. As we shall see in the next section through the work of Third World feminists, it is not always appropriate to restrict our epistemic and political obligations toward others to those who belong to our own local, regional, or national community, or to our own cultural group. These obligations should be understood according to a *social connection model of responsibility*, such as the one articulated and defended by Iris Marion Young (2006, 2011).

Against traditional views that assume that obligations of justice only hold between those living within a single political community, Young argues that "obligations of justice arise between persons by virtue of the social processes that connect them," and "some structural social processes connect people across the world without regard to political boundaries" (2006, p. 102). The social connection model of responsibility that Young develops contends that "all agents who contribute by their actions to the structural processes that produce injustice have responsibilities to work to remedy these injustices" (pp. 102–3). This expanded notion of responsibility contrasts with the narrower conception of responsibility as blame or liability. Young's model does not replace but supplements blame and liability models which, although indispensable in some areas such as the law, do not capture everything there is in ordinary concepts of responsibility. By "being responsible" we often mean being guilty or at fault for having caused certain harms without a legitimate excuse; but in other cases we mean having "certain responsibilities by virtue of [one's] social roles or positions, as when we say that a teacher has specific responsibilities, or when we appeal to our responsibilities as citizens" (p. 119). By contrast with blame and liability models, Young's social connection model of responsibility contains five key features that will also be crucial in the account of epistemic responsibility I will develop in the remaining of the book in relation to issues of complicity. The crucial features of the social connection view of responsibility are (1) that it does not isolate perpetrators but treats them as *embedded in networks* of social relations and positions; (2) that it takes into account *background conditions* of action, especially the social structures that mediate people's actions "by presenting actors with choices" and providing "'channels' that both enable action and constrain it" (p. 112); (3) that it is more *forward-looking* than backward-looking, examining possible causes of injustice with an eye to correct them and to create new conditions of social life; (4) that it conceives of responsibility as *essentially shared*, not as individualistic or

as simply "collective" (see May: 1993);[31] and (5) that "it can be discharged only through collective action" (Young: 2006, p. 103), or, as I will put it with a friendly amendment, through the *chained actions* of interconnected individuals and overlapping communities in which they are embedded.[32] The social connection view of responsibility, as developed by Young and as modified by my resistance model of epistemic interaction, will provide the beginning of an answer to the problem of social relevance. Young's social connectionism goes hand in hand with my interactive contextualism in promoting the expansion of our sensitivities, so that we become capable of feeling concerned and compelled to respond to epistemic and political injustices in which we are implicated, very often without our knowing it. Given the five features highlighted, it should be clear already that "responsibility derived from social connection is ultimately *political* responsibility" (p. 123). And "political" here should be understood precisely in the communicative and interactive terms that Young uses to define it: "what I mean by 'politics' here is public communicative engagement with others for the sake of organizing our relationships and coordinating our actions most justly" (Ibid.).

As Young emphasizes, structural injustices are often so pervasive and extended across networks of social relations that we can legitimately say that *we are all responsible* for them. We should even consider the possibility that those who suffer the most the consequences of a structural injustice may also be complicit with it: "many of those who are properly thought to be victims of harm or injustice may nevertheless share political responsibility in relation to it" (p. 123). But it is crucial to note that the fact that we can conclude that we all share *some* responsibility in a structural injustice given our complicity with it does not mean that we are all *equally* responsible. As Young goes on to argue, different agents have different *kinds* and *degrees* of responsibility with respect to particular injustices depending on their "*position* within the structural processes" that produce those injustices (p. 126). In order to provide useful guidance for assessing responsibility, the social connection model needs to provide two sets of parameters: (1) parameters to distribute shared responsibility among individuals, groups, and institutions; and (2) parameters according to

[31] In chapter 2 of *Sharing Responsibility* (1993), May distinguishes between shared responsibility and collective responsibility in that the former is *distributed* among the individual members of a collective whereas the latter is not. When a collection of individuals, such as a corporation, bears collective responsibility for an outcome, it is the collective entity as a whole that can be held accountable and liable without this responsibility being distributed among its individual members. By contrast, in shared responsibility, each member of the group or collective is individually responsible. As Young puts it, "Each individual is personally responsible for outcomes in a partial way, since he or she alone does not produce the outcomes; the specific part that each person plays in producing the outcome cannot be isolated and identified, however, and thus the responsibility is essentially shared" (2006, p. 122). We will come back to this issue in the next chapter.

[32] For Young's account of these five features, see section V of her 2006, pp. 119–25.

which individuals can prioritize their responsibilities in the different structural injustices with which they are each complicit. The first set of parameters would be those needed for a metric that can identify the social positionality of individuals, groups, and institutions within structural processes. The second set of parameters would identify the factors that are relevant for a subject's involvement in and capacity to respond to an injustice—and here Young proposes four factors to take into account: power, privilege, interest, and collective ability. These parameters enable us to "reason about the best way to use our limited time, resources, and creative energy to respond to structural injustice," for indeed it would be "asking too much to expect most of us to work actively to restructure each and every one of the structural injustices for which we arguably share responsibility" (p. 125). But even highly qualified and contextualized claims about shared responsibility are likely to encounter opposition from individuals, groups, and institutions that—perhaps by inertia—will react defensively to protect their position and to preserve their privileges. We will come back to this issue later on. I only want to point out for now that the social connection model offers a way of deflecting the common defensive reactions that claims about shared responsibility tend to encounter in Western countries such as the United States. As Young argues, claims that many of us participate in producing injustices and we ought to stop (or try to change our ways) are often misheard because they are understood under the conception of responsibility as blame or liability; and, thus, instead of producing any fruitful dialogue, such claims typically provoke blame-shifting and excusing responses. As Young puts it, when claims about shared responsibility are construed as mere finger-pointing, they "lead more to resentment and refusal to take responsibility than to a useful basis of action" (p. 124), for

> agents who believe themselves to be targets of blame react defensively: they look for other agents to blame instead of themselves, or find excuses that mitigate their liability in cases where they admit that their actions do causally contribute to the harm [in question]. (Ibid.)

4.3. Overlapping Insensitivities, Culture-Blaming, and Gender Violence against Third World Women

Meta-insensitivity consists of indifference or lack of concern for our neglect and ignorance of the experiences, problems, and struggles of others. This insensitivity to insensitivity is multidirectional: it moves both outward and inward. Outwardly, this meta-insensitivity or meta-blindness is a disregard for our insensitivity towards others grounded in particular other-regarding meta-attitudes. But inwardly, this meta-insensitivity or meta-blindness is a disregard for our insensitivity toward ourselves—toward certain aspects of ourselves

that we disregard or even deny—which is grounded in particular self-regarding meta-attitudes. The latter blind spot can also be described as not seeing one's specificity and particularity, as not seeing one's differences with others. This is the crucial interrelation between self-regarding attitudes and other-regarding attitudes, or between ignorance of others and self-ignorance. In this section I will examine more specifically the kind of *shared self-ignorance* that can be associated with the blindness we can find in the ignorance of others. As we saw before, when an individual is epistemically irresponsible with respect to others, she is often also epistemically irresponsible with respect to herself, because her social ignorance typically involves *self-ignorance*: ignorance about her own positionality and relationality with respect to those ignored others, and quite possibly also ignorance about certain aspects of herself that she is unable to recognize. Similarly, I also want to make the same point about communities and cultures and talk about *shared self-ignorance*: when members of a community are epistemically irresponsible with respect to other groups, they are often also epistemically irresponsible with respect to themselves, because their ignorance about those considered "others" typically involves ignorance about themselves, that is, ignorance about their positionality and relationality with respect to those ignored groups. For example, although now there is a heightened—and very problematic—sensitivity with respect to Arab cultures and Arab Americans, mainstream US culture has had a long-held ignorance about the Arab world and this lack of knowledge and plethora of distortions blinded many Americans about their position and relation with respect to the Arab world as well as about the Arab members of American society and their contributions to American culture. In this way, I will try to elucidate in this section the interrelations between self-regarding and other-regarding attitudes at the collective level. Put negatively, I will offer an elucidation of overlapping and interconnected forms of social insensitivity: insensitivity with respect to other communities and cultures, and insensitivity with respect to (certain aspects and constituents of) one's own community and culture.

While the previous section focused on racial blindness, the focus of this one will be gender blindness. But rather than shifting from one to the other, I want to add the latter to the former, that is, I want to look at the intersection of racism and sexism, focusing on the phenomenon of sexual violence against women of color and non-Western women. The predicament of non-Western women and Western women of color is particularly difficult because they are the object of multiple, intersecting, and reinforcing forms of oppression; they are the Other's Other, the abject within the abject. Since at least Sojourner Truth's rhetorical cry "And ain't I a woman?" women activists of color have been criticizing the exclusion of racial and ethnic issues within the women's movement; and at least since the publication of Moraga and Anzaldúa's *This Bridge Called My Back* (1981), feminists of color have been criticizing this

exclusion in feminist theorizing. Feminist and queer activists and intellectuals have also criticized the traditional lack of concern for gender and sexual issues in race theory and in the civil rights movement. In recent years, especially in so-called *intersectional* approaches, there have been substantial efforts to forge coalitions against multiple forms of oppression and to repair the traditional lack of knowledge and concern that each liberatory movement had exhibited about other forms of oppression that were not the focus of their battles.[33] In this respect, Third World feminism has become a prominent intellectual and activist movement that addresses the interrelations between sexual oppression and racial oppression across cultures.[34] I will draw especially on the work of Uma Narayan and her analysis (1997) of domestic violence against women in different cultural contexts, highlighting the collective forms of self-ignorance that affect the social perceptions of this phenomenon.

In this section I will explore the link between collective culpable ignorance and domestic violence. What are the forms of epistemic irresponsibility that communities may exhibit in relation to the phenomenon of domestic abuse? What are the forms of ignorance that can preclude an adequate social understanding of this problem? And are these social epistemic failures *culpable ignorance*, that is, infringements of collective responsibilities? With regard to societies that become complicit with domestic gender violence by inaction, lack of concern, or active support, what is it exactly that they do not know and should have known? It is worth mentioning from the start that *domestic abuse* is a highly culturally specific concept; it is culturally specific at least insofar as domesticity and gender relations are defined culturally. This immediately raises the possibility of a particular kind of blind spot that individuals and communities may have with respect to this phenomenon, namely, a *cultural blindness* or insensitivity with respect to the cultural context in which we can make sense of what happens: people may fail to know the cultural parameters that are relevant to understand the phenomenon in question—even if the phenomenon in question is happening to them or around them, that is, even if the relevant cultural factors belong to their own culture.

Let's start with a very specific and extreme form of abuse of women by their male partners which has been the focus of attention of many colonial and postcolonial discussions of women's issues: the so-called *dowry murders* in India. As Narayan (1997) observes, it is interesting and symptomatic that dowry murders have been typically treated by Western feminists as a separate

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[33] See, for example, Lugones (2003). But, of course, the link between racism and sexism had been established much earlier by scholars such as Angela Davis (1983), who had argued that racism and sexism have to be analyzed and addressed together and through each other, and cannot be properly understood independently of each other.

[34] See especially Ackerly (2000) for a rich discussion of how Third World feminism has transformed social criticism and the women's movement.

category (and a very exotic one at that), instead of being conceptualized as regular instances of domestic abuse with their own cultural peculiarities. Why? Why the differential treatment of the same actions when they happen in different cultural contexts? Whether motivated by disputes over dowry or by something else, shouldn't the murder of a woman by her partner in the household be considered domestic gender violence? Are the Western feminists who refrain from applying the label "domestic abuse" to Third World contexts simply trying to avoid the imposition of Western categories? Or are they inadvertently building an artificial cultural distance that will hinder people from seeing connections across contexts?

Narayan warns us about the difficulties we face in learning about women's problems in other cultures. Narayan argues that women's issues have to be understood in their specificity, without applying universal criteria that erase differences but without affirming these differences in such a way that women's lives, interests, and concerns become sealed off from each other and it becomes impossible to draw connections among their problems. Narayan proposes a *politics of specificity* to get us out of the false dilemma and the impasse that has been created between the politics of identity and the politics of difference. Narayan's politics of specificity promotes an intercultural understanding of feminist issues that enables us to see both similarities and differences among women's problems as they appear in their specificity, and to draw connections among them which can be the springboard for learning processes and global political struggles. But Narayan's argument about intercultural understanding comes with a warning:

> I wish to argue that the ways in which 'issues' emerge in various national contexts, and the contextual factors that shape the specific issues that are named and addressed, affect the information that is readily available for such connection-making and hence our abilities to make connections across these contexts. (p. 86)

A first difficulty in the task of looking at women's problems in their specificity and of drawing connections among different cultural contexts is posed by what Narayan terms *border-crossing*: women's problems do not remain the same when they travel across cultural and national boundaries, but rather, they are reconceptualized and redescribed, with certain things being edited out and others edited in, certain factors being erased and others added or highlighted. Narayan argues that the border-crossing of Indian women's issues into the US mainstream culture results in an impoverished understanding of those issues by the general public, and therefore in an inability to detect possible connections between those issues and problems that US subjects may be familiar with in their everyday cultural contexts. This is in part because important contextual information is left behind; but it is also due to *stigmatizing cultural stereotypes* that lead people to look at the originating cultural

context with suspicion. To this second difficulty for cross-cultural understanding I now turn.

Stigmatizing cultural stereotyping instills a suspicious attitude toward cultural differences that encourage people to blame cultural factors for anything negative that happens in those cultural contexts that are perceived as different (the extreme case of this being the demonization of a different or foreign culture in racist and xenophobic ideologies). The literature in social psychology suggests that cultural stereotyping is a very extended (perhaps universal) phenomenon and not inherently derogatory. But when such stereotyping is grounded in preexisting prejudices against out-groups, it is stigmatizing and it distorts our perception of those out-groups and their behavior through particular biases. In a superb systematization of the empirical evidence from social psychology, Elizabeth Anderson (2011) calls attention to some of these stigmatic biases. As Anderson puts it, cultural stereotyping involves *attention biases*: "they make people more receptive to and better able to recall stereotype-confirming than disconfirming evidence" for out-groups and not for the in-group (p. 45). And they also involve *attribution biases*, which leads people "to attribute stereotype-confirming behavior to people's internal dispositions, such as their genes, culture, or voluntary choices, and stereotype-disconfirming behavior to their external circumstances, such as luck or the action of others" (Ibid.). Anderson illustrates the functioning of attribution biases in stigmatizing cultural stereotyping through an analysis of the media reactions to stranded people's behavior in the aftermath of Hurricane Katrina:

> News media described stranded blacks as "looting" grocery stores for necessities such as milk and bread, abstracting from the desperate circumstances brought on by the storm, and the fact that the flood would have otherwise destroyed these groceries. The "looting" frame fit their actions into the narratives of inner-city riots, invoking the stigma of inherent black criminality. By contrast, stranded whites hauling groceries from stores were generously inferred to have merely "found" them by innocent luck. (p. 46)

In a similar vein, Narayan calls attention to the "ways in which 'culture' is invoked in explanations of violence against Third-World women, while it is not similarly invoked in explanations of violence that affects mainstream Western women" (1997, p. 86). I will refer to this phenomenon of selectively making certain cultures and ways of life responsible for social problems as *culture-blaming*. The attention and attribution biases characteristic of stigmatizing cultural stereotyping supports this selective blaming of cultural factors for social problems when they appear in out-groups, but not when they appear in the in-group. As Narayan remarks, this selective culture-blaming is applied not only to non-Western cultures, but also to communities of color within

Western contexts. There is a marked tendency in American media and mainstream public discourses to prefer cultural explanations to address the problems of minoritized communities, whereas no cultural explanations are offered when the same problems occur among white Americans: "For instance, female-headed households, teenage motherhood, and welfare dependency have been attributed to 'cultural pathologies' within the African-American community, while 'white culture' is seldom indicted for these same problems when they occur in white communities" (pp. 87–8).

When the mechanism of culture-blaming is applied to domestic-violence murders in India, the result is that the Indian culture itself is blamed for these crimes: it is not just the particular individuals who commit them who are blamed, but also the cultural context is simultaneously indicted as an accomplice and instigator. By contrast, when mainstream US women are killed by their partners, the perpetrators are considered aberrant or perverse subjects in no way representative of their culture, and their actions are not depicted as resulting from cultural or systemic factors. What is this blindness that prevents mainstream public perceptions from identifying and discussing the cultural factors that may be at play when domestic gender violence occurs over here, whereas when it occurs over there, it is seen as a bizarre cultural phenomenon? Whence the spectacularization of *dowry murders* that so often prevents Western analysts and the general public from seeing them as instances of domestic gender violence? There are both historically specific factors as well as more general cultural attitudes that play a role here. Let me first suggest some general aspects of this cultural blindness to then turn, with Narayan, to the specific.

There is a distorting cultural stereotype operating in the background of the Western lens through which dowry murders in India are observed and reported. There is a distorting implicit assumption about Indian culture and an unwarranted implicit comparison with Western culture. The implicit assumption is that Indian culture has not produced a safe space of domesticity with boundaries that guarantee the autonomy, safety, dignity, and respect for all the members of the household; and the implicit comparison is that, by contrast, Western homes are more culturally advanced in that respect, that they are freer, more autonomous, safer, and more respectful spaces for women. These distorting assumptions and comparisons give plausibility to the following conclusions, which become hard to resist: "in their case, culture is to blame for the violence against women, which is endemic to their way of life"; "in our case, gender violence is not at all rooted in the culture, but quite the opposite: it is a radical departure from cultural expectations and normal ways of living and behaving in Western contexts."

Now let's get specific and, following Narayan, let's take a look at the particular history behind Western perceptions of dowry murders in India. As Narayan

explains, just as the self-immolation of widows or sati[35] were singled out by the British since the nineteenth century, dowry murders were singled out by the British in the twentieth century as an Indian social problem; and they were similarly used by colonial political discourses (including those of Western feminists) as a justification for the European tutelage that this backward people needed. Dowry murder (like sati) is, in this respect, a good example of the *instrumentalization of women's issues* of which not only (male-dominated) colonial politics but also (male-dominated) nationalist politics in the Third World have been guilty.[36] Dowry murder as well as sati were construed by British intellectuals as venerable Hindu traditions that were deeply entrenched in the social fabric of the Indian culture and symbolized how this culture treated women. In fact, as Narayan explains, while sati has a very problematic status as a Hindu tradition, dowry-murder is neither Hindu nor a tradition, and it did not appear as a widespread social phenomenon before the late 1970s. The Western selective attention to gender violence in India focused exclusively on (what appeared to a Western mind as) the most spectacular and bizarre cases. There has been in the West a distorting perception that these spectacular and exotic cases of violence against women are so deeply rooted in Indian culture that they constitute a cultural phenomenon—"death by culture." This social perception has been slowly and laboriously fabricated through many converging distorted views about the cultural place of dowry in India and about Indian culture more generally. As Narayan emphasizes, this cultural distortion is aided by a series of reductive assimilations: Indian culture is reduced to Hindu culture, which in turn is reduced to Hindu religion, which in turn is reduced to Hindu scriptures. We can see here some of the cultural processes that Edward Said recognized as part of the *orientalization* of cultures.[37]

I want to highlight three particular mechanisms and attitudes toward other cultures that were integral parts of the process of orientalization described by

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[35] *Sati* is the name given to the ritual in which the (apparently voluntary) immolation of a widow after the death of her husband takes place. Narayan discusses sati in detail in chapter 2 of *Dislocating Cultures* (1997).

[36] Narayan explains in detail how both colonial discourses and nationalist discourses about India have used women for political purposes, paying attention to their problems and interests only when they could be subordinated to the goals of their political agendas. In this sense, Narayan talks for example about the "cultural burden of preserving tradition" that is imposed on women by nationalists and cultural preservationists: Indian women, and not men, carry the burden of preserving the traditional way of dressing and are criticized when they wear skirts and trousers instead of saris, whereas no one puts any critical light on Indian men wearing pants and jackets.

[37] In *Orientalism* (1979/1994), Said explains with great historical detail the invention of the Orient as a crucial part of the making of the West (or the Occident). *Orientalizing* a culture, in this sense, means turning it into the Other of the West and depicting its members and their practices as deeply foreign and exotic, as that which *we* (Westerners) are not. Focusing especially on the development of so-called Oriental studies and its descendants in the Western academy, but also covering literary and media representations of the Middle and Far East, Said analyzes the different cultural distortions that went into the making of the divide East-West, Orient-Occident.

Said, and which, more generally, greatly contribute to the production of stigmatizing cultural stereotypes. The first such mechanism and cultural attitude is the *totalization* of a culture, that is, its presentation as a monolithic, homogeneous whole with little or no internal diversity. This totalizing attitude can be seen in any presentation or invocation of a total picture of a culture that paints it in a few bold strokes as having features and norms that are uncontested and have universal validity within the culture. Totalizations are fabricated through overgeneralizations and oversimplifications that completely disregard and hide the situated specificity and inner diversity of cultural identities, spaces, and practices. The "they-are-all-the-same" attitude produces simplistic totalized views of other cultures; and these totalized accounts, in turn, once they are in circulation and have social currency, help to instill and reinforce a totalizing attitude that is blind to specificity and inner differences. It is quite astonishing that this totalizing attitude could be so easily applied to a vast and heterogeneous country such as India, with so many religions, languages, ethnicities, and regional diversity. (But then again, as a multitude of race theorists from Fanon on have denounced, a similar totalizing attitude was also applied to the whole of Africa.) It is because of this totalizing attitude that India could so easily appear in the Western imaginary as a single thing with clear, distinctive features, and Western intellectuals could offer unified accounts of Indian femininity that summarily described what it is like to be an Indian woman. Narayan complains that while no Third World critic would dare to advance totalizing generalizations about *the* American woman or *the* European woman, disregarding crucial differences of nationality, language, ethnicity, religion, class, and so on, Western critics (including Western feminists) have often done so with respect to the Indian woman, the African woman, the Chinese woman, or worse yet, the Oriental woman or—in more contemporary terms—the Third World woman. While such overgeneralizations and oversimplifications would not be taken seriously about Western women, they are often accepted, or at least regarded as having some plausibility and not scrutinized with a comparable degree of suspicion, when they are offered about non-Western or Third World women.

In the second place, another important source of cultural distortions that contribute to the orientalizing of foreign cultures is the *erasing of history*. Traditionally, non-Western cultures have been presented in the West as essentially unchanging cultures, as societies that live outside history and lack the capacity to transform themselves and make progress. The colonial mindset contained a crucial ahistorical attitude through which other cultures were observed and (mis)understood, which contrasted with the historical vision that modern Westerners typically had of themselves. According to this ahistorical attitude, anything that currently is or has ever been an ingredient of a non-Western culture was considered as a constitutive part of its *traditions*. These venerable, immutable *traditions* (which sometimes included recent practices that originated

as a result of interactions with the West) were thought of as trapping the non-Western mind and as warranting Western interventions when they needed to be changed or eliminated. Although of course contemporary multicultural discourses are more nuanced and sophisticated, there is nonetheless a clear colonial legacy in Western attitudes toward Third World cultures, in academia as well as in the media and in the perceptions of the general public. For example, in contemporary feminist discussions about Third World women's issues there are still many misconceptions about ablation and female genital mutilation that reproduce this schema.

Finally, in the third place, the last distorting attitude I want to mention is perhaps the main source of cultural misrepresentations in the process of orientalization: we can call it the *exoticizing* of cultural traits and practices. This involves the obsessive focus on the most unfamiliar and strange aspects of a culture, which creates and constantly underscores the gap between us and them. This involves also the *inability to relate* to members of other cultures through the invisibilization of commonalities or connections with ways of life that are familiar to us. These commonalities and connections become hardly noticed or disregarded as unimportant or uninteresting. This exclusive focus on differences (as marked and exotic as possible) renders non-Westerners deeply foreign and other. By capitalizing on differences and hiding similarities and connections with the West, it becomes difficult for Westerners to recognize themselves in these exoticized others, to see their humanity, and to sympathize with their suffering. As Said puts it, what is lost or at least obscured through processes of orientalization is "a sense of the density and interdependence of human life" (1979/1994, p. xvii). This is indeed a principal obstacle to becoming sensitive to cultural specificity: we become blind to the specificity of human life when we totalize cultures, erase their histories, and exoticize their ways of life. In order to repair this cultural stereotyping we are confronted with the critical task of sensitizing ourselves and the general public to the "density and interdependence of human life." And this is not only a task for intellectuals and artists who contribute directly to create representations of other cultures that acquire social currency, but it is also a task for all of us, in the ways we approach other cultures (as well as our own) and talk about them. Following Said, we can say that the fight against biased cultural stereotyping involves a double task: the negative task of *resisting* totalized, ahistorical, and exoticized pictures of other cultures; and the positive task of developing "a sense of the density and interdependence of human life" across cultural contexts. Precisely because we lack this sense, and our perception of another human culture suffers from a significant insensitivity to its diversity, its history, and its everyday life, we can readily accept superficial and one-dimensional accounts of that culture as containing the truth of the culture. As an example, Narayan mentions Elizabeth Bumiller's (1991) *May You Be the Mother of a Hundred Sons: A Journey Among the Women of India*. Indulging in a glaring confusion of sati

and dowry murder, Bumiller's book presents any instance of violence against Indian women involving fire as an example of backward Third World traditions hostile to women; and thus, as Narayan puts it, Third World women appear as "suffering 'death by culture' or 'victimization by culture'" (1997, p. 112). And yet, despite these oversimplifications and blatant cultural distortions, Bumiller's book was received with praise in Western circles and reviewers went as far as to say that there finally was a "Western writer who had discovered India" in the 1990s!

Narayan emphasizes the sharp differences in the cultural attitudes of US critics when they write about gender violence in the US versus gender violence in the Third World: in the latter case, gender violence is often blamed on Third World cultures; but when it comes to home-grown gender violence, it is typically described, analyzed, and explained "in terms of non-nation specific, secularized, general patriarchy" (p. 115). What would happen if domestic abuse in the United States were presented by non-Western analysts as a distinctively American phenomenon, deeply rooted and practically inescapable in American culture and American Christianity, and possibly sanctioned by Christian scriptures? It would, of course, be *intellectually irresponsible* to promote this indictment of an entire culture, reductively identifying it with a particular religion and a particular way of interpreting religious texts (without recognizing crucial denominational differences and internal diversity within denominations). And yet doing something analogous with Third World cultures does not appear as equally implausible and irresponsible in the US literature on gender violence. As Narayan suggests, why not "explain American domestic violence in terms of Christian views about women's sinful nature, Eve's role in the Fall, the sanctity of marriage or the family, or the like" (p. 116)? And why not say that for American men beating up their wives or partners and, if necessary, killing them with the cultural weapon of choice—the all-American shooting gun[38]—is a good old-fashioned American tradition? While this suggestion is likely to be found culturally offensive, and its cultural distortions, simplifications, and overgeneralizations are easily detected, it is not so easy to find an equally heightened cultural sensitivity when it comes to other cultures. To highlight this discrepancy in cultural attitudes toward women's problems abroad and at home, Narayan proposes a thought experiment: she asks us to imagine an Indian journalist writing a book about the United States that could be considered somewhat analogous to Bumiller's book about India, for example, a book entitled *May You Be the Loser of a Hundred Pounds: A Journey Among the Women of the US*. As Narayan explains it, this book could contain

[38] As Narayan points out, it could be argued that, just as in India fire is claimed to be a culturally iconic weapon, so are guns in the United States. And indeed the American obsession with guns seems to surpass the omnipresence of fire and the cultural significance attached to it in India (which can also be explained in terms of easy availability and practical advantages which do not apply to guns).

"a discussion of the victimization of women by American culture through eating disorders, weight-loss programs, liposuctions, breast implants and other types of cosmetic surgery" (p. 114). Narayan underscores how unlikely it is that this book would be taken seriously, and how unlikely that a reviewer could possibly say that there was at last "an Eastern writer who had actually discovered the US." She encourages us to ask ourselves, "What are the structures of knowledge-production and information-circulation that make this book as difficult to imagine as it is impossible to find?" (Ibid.).

When I teach Narayan's thought-experiment and discuss it with my undergraduate students, a good number of them invariably get offended by the suggestion that the American obsession with the shape and size of women's bodies can be construed as a cultural way of objectifying and even torturing women. I think this illustrates precisely what Narayan's provocation tries to bring to the fore: how dangerous overgeneralizations based on partial and distorted information can be, how insensitive to the problems in question, how blind or short-sighted about the complexity of the phenomena and the multiplicity of relevant factors. Among the students who feel that Narayan's thought-experiment is an attack on American culture and is not analogous to Western analyses of sati or dowry, a common response is to object that whereas US women *choose* to enter weight-loss programs, to undergo cosmetic surgery, and so on, Indian women do not choose to be burned. The relation between choice and cultural pressure is of course not as clear as my students suppose. And this too is precisely what Narayan is trying to interrogate. She is encouraging us to think critically about the selective appeal to choice and autonomy in discussions of women's issues and about the differential assumptions often made about women's agency and the systematic constraints on their agency in different cultural contexts. If, as the evidence suggests, in some regions of India and among some segments of the population, there is a general cultural pressure as well as more direct and specific peer pressure for widows to take their own lives after the death of their husbands, it is indeed legitimate to question their claim that it is their choice to immolate themselves; and clearly at least among *some* US women of a certain class, ethnicity, and age-range, there is also a marked cultural pressure as well as a direct peer pressure to lose weight and shape their bodies to fit cultural expectations by whatever means, and we should similarly call into question their claim that they do so by choice, because taking this appeal to their autonomous choice at face value and not seeing here a social problem of any kind may be the result of *our blindness to social and cultural factors* that are too close to our own eyes to be seen properly.

Narayan's contrast between Western attitudes toward gender violence in the United States and in India illustrates the collective blindness with respect to different aspects of domestic gender violence *both abroad and at home*. The inability to draw connections between social problems abroad and at home is typically grounded in a *double blindness*: the inability to see others and their

problems in their own specificity, and the inability to see ourselves and our problems in their own historical, cultural, and situated specificity. And it is crucial to recognize that our shared ignorance about others goes hand in hand with our *shared ignorance about ourselves*. The crucial interrelation between collective ignorance of others and collective self-ignorance can be seen in the distorting cultural attitudes that produce the cultural blindness we just discussed. For, indeed, the orientalization and exoticization of others—whether they are foreign others or minoritized others within society—is part and parcel of the process of *normalization* of ourselves. Cultural processes of normalization manufacture the *mainstream normal subject*, just like orientalizing and exoticizing processes produce the abnormal foreign subject. And these cultural processes of normalization and abnormalization jointly blind us to things both in ourselves and in others simultaneously. Therefore, it is not surprising that what stands in the way of our ability to connect social problems in different cultural contexts and to achieve cross-cultural understanding is not only the lack of knowledge of other cultures, but also, and simultaneously, our ignorance about our own culture. As Narayan suggests, in the lack of intercultural understanding what we have is also the problem of not seeing "features of one's own context that might make a difference to the sense of 'similarities and differences' one develops" (p. 96).

Besides being vigilant about our epistemic responsibility in knowing others, we also have to bring under critical scrutiny the forms of collective self-ignorance that our culture may have about itself and in which we may partake, for this too may be behind our inability to relate to social problems properly. We have to interrogate the social imaginary in which we represent ourselves and we represent others, and which shapes cultural expectations about the normal and the exceptional among different groups and in different contexts. Why do Westerners expect Indian women to face the danger of being burned while they do not expect US women to suffer similar forms of violence? As Narayan emphasizes with her review of statistical and journalistic evidence, the American women murdered as a result of domestic violence are hardly visible in American culture; and when there are isolated cases that acquire prominence in American media, they are typically cases of violence that occurs in marginal spaces or cases of violence perpetrated by out-of-the-mainstream subjects (i.e., subjects who belong to the lower classes or to ethnic or racial minorities). For example, Narayan observes, "Publicized cases such as O. J. Simpson's trial for his wife's murder are not presented as 'typical' or 'paradigmatic' outcomes of domestic-violence situations" (p. 89). To highlight the disparity in cultural expectations and how they narrow our gaze and blind us to certain things, Narayan contrasts the "Disappearing Dead Women" in US accounts of domestic violence with the "spectacular visibility" of Indian women murdered over dowry.

What is the American public systematically exposed to (and thus trained to pay attention to) when cases of domestic violence against US women are

discussed? Besides depictions or descriptions of the bodily injuries suffered, the media and the analysts often discuss the verbal and emotional abuse that typically precede the physical abuse and the psychological sequels that the survivors exhibit. But little is said about those who do not survive; in fact, they are not even counted by government agencies! Narayan reports that official figures about US women annually killed by their partners are not readily available.[39] Looking at the FBI's Crime Index for 1994, Narayan deduced that 28 percent of female murder victims were "slain by husbands or boyfriends" and that, therefore, roughly 1,400 US women were victims of domestic-violence murder that year. Approximately 5,000 Indian women were counted as victims of dowry murder that year and, since India's population is about four times that of the US, Narayan concludes that "the proportion of the women in the US population who are victims of 'domestic-violence murder' seems *roughly similar* to the proportion of women in the Indian population murdered over dowry" (p. 99). So domestic-violence murder in the US seems to be numerically as significant as dowry murder in India; and yet, as Narayan emphasizes, the latter "is named, noted, and made into a 'specific social issue' while the [former] is not" (Ibid.). Narayan acknowledges that one could legitimately object that comparing domestic-violence murders in the US and dowry murders in India is *comparing apples and oranges*; but she replies that "there may be a point to comparing apples and oranges if one is interested in understanding some aspects of fruit" (Ibid.) and she presses on with the comparison. The comparison (with all its obvious limitations) is indeed instructive: it contributes to our understanding of how social phenomena get defined and looked at in different cultural contexts; and it helps us to think critically about which aspects of the phenomenon of gender violence different societies pay attention to and which aspects fly below the radar of social sensitivity, and about which data are systematically collected and how and which aspects of the evidence are overlooked and do not become part of the readily available social knowledge of the phenomenon. We can learn about the shape that a phenomenon has taken in the social imaginary of a culture by elucidating how the phenomenon is represented and discussed, analyzed and explained, in that society.

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[39] This contrasts sharply with the situation in European countries such as Spain, where domestic-violence murder victims are counted by institutional organizations designed by federal and local governments to monitor gender violence, and the figures produced are vociferously publicized by the media. In fact, in Spain, besides publicizing periodically the figures available, every time there is a new case of a woman killed by her partner the media takes stock of the number of cases so far that year and compares it with previous years, calling for a constant examination of the trajectory of the problem. In the Spanish context some have argued that this heightened visibility of victims of domestic abuse in the media—some even call it *a media obsession*—contributes to the spectacularization of gender violence and can have a negative impact on the general public by recirculating a pathological social script (one that can instigate potential aggressors and intimidate potential victims).

What are the statistics available and unavailable about gender violence in India and in the US? What are the questions asked and pursued about this phenomenon in each context? How does the process of data collection take place? And what are the criteria and the lenses through which the available data are processed both by experts and by the general public? Pursuing the critical interrogation prompted by these questions can help us improve our sense of similarities and differences in cross-cultural comparisons and our ability to identify blind spots and distortions that limit the available social knowledge of other cultures and of our own. It is in this respect that Narayan's comparison of social perceptions of gender violence in India and in the US is illuminating. It is informative to note that whereas gender violence in India is looked at through a comparatively narrower category—"dowry murder"—which contains culturally specific elements (i.e., a social script that is claimed to be part of the culture), in the United States it is looked at through the more inclusive and allegedly culturally neutral category of "domestic violence." It is also informative to note that, despite its apparently narrower scope, the category of "dowry murder" is used in such a relaxed and broad way in accounts of gender violence in India that it is often stretched to cover most instances of domestic violence that results in (attempted or accomplished) murder. And, as Narayan points out, this stretching of the concept is not only produced by Western analysts but also by Indian official agencies. Narayan calls attention to the generality and interpretative openness of the official definition of a "dowry murder" used by the government of India for data collection:

> any instance where the death of a woman is caused by any burns or bodily injury or occurs otherwise than under normal circumstances within 7 years of her marriage, and it is shown that soon before her death she was subjected to cruelty or harassment by her husband or any relative of her husband for, or in connection with, any demand for dowry. (p. 98)

Narayan argues that the instances of women's deaths that get counted as dowry murders in India are bound to include some accidents, suicides, and even deaths by illness, but there is no way of telling how many. By contrast, as Narayan emphasizes, American statistics are based on legal convictions rather than suspicions, and only when the victim's partner is legally convicted of the crime is the case counted as a "domestic-violence murder." The relaxed or strict nature of the criteria used is symptomatic of the cultural attitudes toward the phenomenon and the social perceptions and cultural expectations that are produced. Additionally, although Narayan does not comment on this aspect, it should also be noted that, in those cases in which Indian women were in fact killed by their husbands, the mere presence of evidence of disputes over dowry does not guarantee at all that that was in fact the motive of the crime; there may very well have been other motivations, or the case can be so complex that a myriad of interconnected factors may have played a role, or it can be so random

or unspecific that it may lack any particular identifiable motivation. However, *dowry* offers a powerful social script that narrows our gaze and brings a cultural element into prominence, offering an easy way of making sense of what happened, pointing to a ready-made social explanation and *blaming culture*. By contrast, domestic-violence murders in the US are not automatically accompanied by a single social script; and when social scripts are invoked in the American context to explain these cases, they are typically not culture-specific (i.e., not related to distinctive elements in American culture), and not even gender-specific: they include scripts built around social pathologies (such as drug abuse), or around mental illness (such as paranoia, schizophrenia, temporary insanity, or behavioral dysfunctions produced by developmental deficiencies or exposure to pathological environments).

Whether the pathology appealed to is social or psychological in nature, the pathologization of domestic violence takes the phenomenon out of the mainstream and makes it difficult to see its systemic aspects, that is, how it may be grounded in gender structures and disparities that are produced and sustained in the culture. For a subset of domestic-violence murders, there is also an economic script that turns the problem into an economic pathology and explains it in terms of economic and poverty-related factors (such as the aggressor's underprivileged background and lack of education, the crisis provoked by desperate economic conditions, etc.). This economic script typically involves an implicit or explicit indictment of a subgroup or a subculture within the United States, but it does not encourage a critical interrogation of how American society and culture may have contributed to create and maintain the conditions under which the phenomenon takes place. In the United States there is a marked reluctance to see women's vulnerability to domestic violence as something that American culture has contributed to, that is, as related to the distinctive history of the oppression and objectification of women in the United States, which has included fewer privileges and protections for women in public and private life, and has resulted in lesser degrees of economic, political, and social power for women as well as in lesser status and degrees of agency within the household.

If a whole array of mild and everyday forms of violence against women in India gets eclipsed by the spectacular visibility of dowry murders, the most violent and extreme forms of domestic abuse (especially domestic-violence murders) in the United States are rendered pathological and given only a peripheral visibility by vanishing them from what is taken to be *cultural normalcy*. Finding Indian women killed by their husbands to be expected and finding mainstream US women killed by their partners unexpected (and even shocking) reflect distorting cultural attitudes and expectations. The all-too-ready availability of a cultural script in one case and the lack of a script in the other case shape the social perceptions of the phenomena in a limiting way, closing people's eyes to certain things (even if they are there) and insistently

opening people's eyes to other things (even if they are not there). Cultural distortions produce active ignorance and blind spots not only about others but also about ourselves. The cultural blindness we have examined in this section includes ignorance about Indian women and their situations, but also ignorance about American women and their situations, for this blindness results from cultural prejudices that distort the social perception of women's problems domestically and abroad. And given that the things that we see and don't see in us (or people like us) are intimately related to the things that we see and don't see in others (in people deemed different from us), it is imperative that we compare and contrast our concerns and problems with those of people who appear to be significantly different from us, that is, that we draw connections across different social and cultural contexts, without homogenizing or compartmentalizing these contexts and the phenomena they contain, and developing an appreciation for specificity and a nuanced sensitivity to similarities and differences.

The identification of collective self-ignorance and the fight against it can benefit tremendously from cross-cultural comparisons (even if in some cases we are comparing apples and oranges). The crucial importance—indeed the need—of *epistemic counterpoints* for this purpose cannot be overemphasized, for epistemic counterpoints can lead us to identify which questions are not being asked, which data are rendered unavailable, which voices are not heard, and which aspects of the problem remain unseen. Epistemic counterpoints can offer what I have called *beneficial epistemic friction*, that is, a friction that enables us to acknowledge and engage alternative viewpoints and to reach epistemic equilibrium among alternative perspectives on a problem or phenomenon. Through this friction, epistemic counterpoints can also enable subjects and communities to detect and sensitize themselves to their blind spots and shared self-ignorance. And it should be noted that the critical vigilance about the shared self-ignorance of a society constitutes both a collective and an individual responsibility. We cannot overburden the individual with the responsibility of identifying and undoing every blind spot and every form of insensitivity that circulates in society, but this responsibility cannot be so diffused in the collective social body that particular individuals, organizations, groups, and institutions do not feel compelled or under any particular obligation to repair the forms of blindness and insensitivity involved in collective self-ignorance. A middle level of action and responsibility that is both individual and collective (without being entirely personal or entirely anonymous) can be seen, for example, in the media coverage of violence. Here we have to bring under critical scrutiny the actions of interrelated individuals, groups, and agencies, and we have to interrogate the responsibilities of journalists, editors, news agencies, authorities and institutions, the general public and differently situated specific publics that may have special responsibilities in consuming media representations critically, responding to them, and holding those who produce them accountable.

Following a well-established trend in postcolonial studies since Said, Peter Dahlgren and Sumitra Chakrapani (1982) have argued that the Western media have a marked tendency to focus obsessively on images of violence and disorder in their coverage of Third World countries. As Dahlgren and Chakrapani suggest, this reinforces certain cultural expectations among Western publics: that violence and disorder are an essential part of the cultural normalcy of the Third World, whereas peace and order are constitutive of the cultural normalcy of the West. But, as Dahlgren and Chakrapani emphasize, the problem is not only that violence in the Third World is the obsessive focus of attention in the Western media, but also the way in which the media typically depicts violence in the Third World as "devoid of social, political, or historical causation," so that "the manifestations of disorder and violence take on the quality of eternal essences which define the nature of these countries. 'That is just the way they are'" (p. 53). And thus Western publics become so used to violence in the Third World that it is received as a natural occurrence, whereas any particular occurrence of violence in the West calls for an explanation, for a special etiology. And if it is ignorance about other cultures to see their mainstream daily life as containing nothing but violence and disorder, it is also collective self-ignorance to maintain the public perception that our own culture only contains peace and order and everything else that happens must be an extraneous and foreign element. Collective self-ignorance often takes the form of being blinded by what takes center-stage in the culture, that is, by what passes for *cultural normalcy*, by what becomes so culturally prominent that it defines the culture in question and renders everything else deviant, peripheral, and marginal, and in some cases even invisible or inaudible. Through an example analyzed by Radhika Parameswaran (1996a), I will illustrate how this cultural blindness operates.

The Third World feminist and cultural studies analyst Radhika Parameswaran has developed studies of the Western media coverage of violence against Third World women (1996a, 1996b, 2001). In these studies Parameswaran shows how the Western media contributes to the victimization and "othering" of Third World women. Following Chandra Mohanty's critique of Western feminist discourse,[40] Parameswaran argues that the prevailing image of Third World women as victims of "oppressive traditional structures" marginalizes non-Western women and creates a dangerous division within the global feminist movement. In the first place, the "framework of 'traditional oppression'"—as Parameswaran calls the Western lens through which Third World women are looked at—fails to acknowledge and to properly represent the agency that Third World women have in their own cultural contexts, creating a false contrast with the agency of Western feminists, who are depicted as the only ones

[40] See especially Mohanty (2003). See also Mohanty, Russo, and Torres (1991).

enjoying a liberated subjectivity and who thereby become the rightful protagonists of global feminist struggles. In the second place, the "framework of 'traditional oppression'" renders the experiences of Third World women as "exotic" and "different," creating a cultural distance between Third World women and Western women, and turning violence into a cultural characteristic of "them" (Third World societies) and not of "us" (Western societies). Parameswaran illustrates this cultural distancing, this "exoticization and 'othering'" (as she puts it), by analyzing the media coverage of particular cases of violence against Third World women.

In "Coverage of 'Bride Burning' in the *Dallas Observer*: A Cultural Analysis of the 'Other'" (1996a), Parameswaran analyzes the reporting of the death of Aleyamma Mathew, a member of the Indian diasporic community living in the United States. Aleyamma was a registered nurse at Parkland Hospital in Carrolton, Texas, who died of burn wounds at her home. Her husband, Mathew Varughese, a machinist at the Texas Instruments Plant in Carrolton, was charged with the murder. The couple had immigrated to the US from India two decades prior to the fatal incident, in the early 1970s. The article at the *Dallas Observer* reporting on the case did not say whether Aleyamma and Mathew were permanent residents or citizens, but by 1992 they had had three American-born daughters. Aleyamma and Mathew were both Christians from Kerala, a state in the southernmost part of India. According to the *Dallas Observer*, the couple started having marital problems when Mathew began consuming alcohol in large quantities and abusing Aleyamma verbally and physically. The night of the incident, April 5, 1992, the couple was heard to have a bitter argument and minutes later Aleyamma was found by her children agonizing in pain from the flames that engulfed her and she soon died from the severe burn wounds. Parameswaran describes the *Dallas Observer* article as being framed by references to sati and dowry murder and as giving center-stage to fire as a significant cultural element in the causal process of incitement to violence by oppressive cultural traditions. The irony of the case, though, is that Aleyamma was a Christian woman and belonged to a community where marriages did not involve dowry and sati had never been a known custom. As Parameswaran puts it, "The *Dallas Observer* constructs Aleyamma as the 'other' by framing her death as the natural and inevitable consequence of oppression stemming from Indian culture and tradition" (p. 70). And this cultural distortion, this "othering," blinds us to the specifics of the case and handicaps our ability to draw connections between this case and other cases of domestic violence, both domestic and foreign.

It is highly significant for our purposes that although this case happened on domestic ground, among American residents and American citizens, and surrounded by local elements that supported the vulnerability and lack of protection of Aleyamma (poverty, social isolation, encouragement to accept male authority, etc.), the reporters nonetheless depicted it as an exotic incident

brought to us from a distant culture and they interjected themselves in the story as liberators who were "breaking a silence" about a social problem endemic in a foreign community that offers no resistance to it. Parameswaran emphasizes that she is all for breaking silences and for speaking out about culturally specific forms of gender violence, such as sati or dowry murder as well as others, but she warns us that we must be vigilant about cultural distortions and what they do to women and their problems. To begin with, we must not assume that all cases of gender violence that occur within an ethnic community will fit the pre-established cultural molds that mainstream culture has fixed for that community. This critical vigilance is required for proper reporting as well as for the critical reception of reports. In this respect, it is remarkable that the *Dallas Observer* reporters managed to maintain the uncritical cultural expectation that all cases of gender violence among Indians are cases of women being victims of oppressive cultural traditions such as sati and dowry murder, even though this expectation was not supported by *any* of the specifics of the case reported within the same story. This case illustrates very well what both Narayan and Parameswaran describe as the ubiquitous cultural construction of the burnt Indian woman, which is paradigmatic of their victimization, of making them appear to Western eyes as nothing but victims, without sufficient degrees of agency and with little potential for liberating themselves.

The stigmatization and culture-blaming performed by the reporters of the *Dallas Observer* has two potential consequences: limiting the vision of the American public with respect to Indian women and their problems, and limiting the vision of the American public with respect to itself and what is taken to be *genuinely American* and properly belonging to American culture. This brings to the fore a general feature of cultural stigmatization, namely, that it affects both our gaze toward what is considered culturally alien and our gaze toward ourselves and what we take to be part of our own culture. On the one hand, the article in the *Dallas Observer* failed to acknowledge the diversity of the Indian diasporic community, presenting a seamless, homogeneous image of a highly heterogeneous community, an impoverished skeletal picture, a cultural caricature that not only does not constitute knowledge about that culture, but actually functions as an important obstacle to learning more about it. On the other hand, the article also failed to acknowledge that the incident being reported and the subjects involved in it belonged to the American context and were deeply grounded in American culture, even if simultaneously grounded in different cultures and overlapping communities. The article implicitly appealed to sharp and fixed national and cultural boundaries through which the readers of the story and its protagonists were positioned, creating an artificial cultural distance that belies the porosity and dynamic nature of those boundaries and without sufficiently acknowledging that a multicultural society such as the United States is composed of intersecting and overlapping

communities, which have acquired an increasing complexity in the globalized world of today. This blindness to intersections, connections, and heterogeneous identifications makes it impossible for people to think of women like Aleyamma and their problems *as American*, properly and strictly speaking, while clearly they are and they should be reclaimed as such. There is an unexamined picture of the genuinely American that operates in the background and is the other side of the cultural blindness under examination.

The blindness to internal cultural differences sustains narrow definitions of and limiting cultural attitudes toward what is considered *genuinely American*, which often becomes a moving target in order to preserve cultural exclusions.[41] The blindness to social relevance that can be part of the cultural self-ignorance of a group is well illustrated by the reporting of Aleyamma's death in the *Dallas Observer*. Here we can see violations of the three Maxims of Relevance laid out in the previous section. In the first place, the Maxim of Eminent Relevance was not observed: the way the article presented the story to its readers involved a failure to recognize others as *our* significant others—as full members of our society—and their problems as eminently relevant *for us*. In the reporting there was a failure to recognize that domestic violence in Indian communities within the United States is an eminently relevant social problem and not simply some foreign and exotic phenomenon brought from faraway places that we can have the luxury of knowing nothing or little about. The incident was not presented as something that rightfully belonged to the Texan community that the readership was assumed to identify with, because the writers failed to depict the Indian immigrants who were the protagonists of the incident as full members of this community due to a lingering assumption of foreignness that affects racialized and ethnicized American communities even after they have become part of American society (suspicion of foreignness that sometimes is applied to immigrant communities of color even after many generations).[42] And this points to a second failure: the violation of the Maxim of Openness and Vigilance, for the way the incident is addressed clearly shows a failure to

[41] For example, the genuinely American often gets defined as the American born and/or the American grown. But the Americanness of those born here and their problems often gets questioned because of the presence of racial, ethnic, or cultural differences. And it is not unusual to hear about first- or second-generation immigrants who have not yet shaken off the "foreignness" of their parents—this is particularly frequent for Hispanics, for whom the suspicion of foreignness never disappears (see Gracia (2008) on this point). It is also not entirely unusual to hear a similar suspicion about any other ethnic or racial group that has preserved cultural ties with another country or region of origin no matter how loosely. Think, for example, of the Africanness of African Americans and the Asianness of Asian Americans, which are often assumed to involve a tension with American identity, whereas no such tension is suggested for the Europeanness of European Americans.

[42] For a lucid discussion of the stigma of being a *perpetual foreigner*, see Barvosa (2008), pp. 22ff. For reflections on how Hispanics in the United States are under the systematic suspicion of foreignness, see also Gracia (2008).

be vigilant about possible oversights in our social perceptions, a failure to remain open to find out more about our significant "others," about subcommunities we ignore or pay insufficient attention to, because we lack awareness of the social relationality that binds us to them. There was here a missed opportunity to expand our social gaze and overcome some of its limitations. And finally, in the third place, the Maxim of Shared Responsibility to Interrogate Relevance was also violated because there was a failure of individuals (the reporters and editors) and communities (the different publics) to work together in identifying social distortions and blind spots and in motivating social concerns more responsibly. We are all jointly responsible for reconstructing the networks of social relations that bind us together and form the fabric of social life in which many of our practices become interrelated. It is through the collective reconstructive efforts and ongoing self-interrogation that the collective self-ignorance of a society can be repaired and the social concerns of that society can be expanded and more accurately presented, for, through that reconstruction and interrogation of the social fabric and the interconnectedness of its heterogeneous elements, we become aware of how issues and problems that we previously thought did not concern us actually become part of the social spaces we occupy and of the communities we are part of or have become related to.

The cultural blindness I have discussed in this section can prevent us from seeing problems and concerns not only in other cultures but also in our own culture, very often because we fail to appreciate the social relevance that these problems and concerns have for us and/or our fellow citizens. In order to repair this blindness and the blind spots that go with it, we should exploit the diversity and heterogeneity of the social fabric and try to learn collectively and from each other, following the principles of epistemic friction that I have defended in this book. As argued above in connection with the Imperative of Epistemic Interaction, communities and subcommunities have to check on each other and cooperatively function as epistemic correctives for each other; for they need help in the complex cognitive task of developing adequate social knowledge and they have to keep their stock of social knowledge open to possible corrections and additions from different groups and their individual members. The active pursuit of *epistemic counterpoints* is one way of opening oneself to epistemic friction. These counterpoints can be issued and entertained in different ways: by comparing and contrasting how related phenomena are treated when they appear in different cultural contexts; by comparing and contrasting how social problems appear to differently situated groups of subjects within the same culture; or by critically examining how our approach to an issue changes when we approach related issues elsewhere, thus trying to identify the blind spots of our social gaze in different contexts, including our own contexts. Sometimes those social contexts that we thought were most familiar to us and closest to home may turn out to contain also elements or

aspects we were utterly unfamiliar with and ill-equipped to understand properly. In this section I have tried to illustrate how cultural blind spots operate with respect to the complex phenomenon of gender violence, suggesting also how epistemic counterpoints can help us to start exercising some beneficial epistemic friction there. But of course much more need to be said in order to begin to understand how bodies of social ignorance contribute to produce and maintain socially inadequate responses to gender violence. I want to conclude this section with some tentative reflections on paths for research in this area.

In order to learn about the forms of social insensitivity that we may encounter in the area of gender violence in specific cultural contexts, we need to ask: What are the cases of gender violence that are noticed by society? Who is considered a victim of abuse and under what circumstances? Which aspects of the phenomenon of gender violence are different institutions and groups paying attention to? What are they looking at and looking into, and how? Who are they listening to, and how? What may they not be seeing and hearing? We can start by identifying powerful cultural representations of gender violence that open people's eyes and ears to certain things but not others, illuminating and obscuring at the same time, promulgating heightened sensitivities and insensitivities simultaneously. In this sense, it is clear that in the Western world the social imaginary entered the twentieth century with a colonial legacy that depicted gender violence as something being committed principally against white women (the ones who are pure, vulnerable, and in need of protection) and mainly by savages—cultural, ethnic, and racial others—who are threats by virtue of their very identity. Sexual aggressions were depicted as resulting, first and foremost, from threats outside the household, outside one's social class and cultural group, and if possible, outside one's nation (as something that happens abroad, when we abandon the comfortable boundaries of our homeland or when foreign elements penetrate it). More generally, the stereotypical violence against women was represented as happening outside the bounds of normalcy, as being committed by *deviant subjects*.[43] This heightened sensitivity to the sexual threats and possible aggressions of women by those outside their household, class, cultural group, and nation was bound up with a significant insensitivity to the sexual violence within, that is, the insidious gender violence perpetrated by those within one's nation, one's culture, one's class, one's sexual orientation, and even one's household. The zenith of this insensitivity has been gender violence against women committed by their partners. This blind spot was directly tied to the hypervisibility that other forms of gender violence had in the social imaginary.

[43] As I go on to note below, the most elaborated and influential theoretical framework in which this argument has been made is the genealogical framework of Michel Foucault. Foucault's genealogical account of sexuality (and the normalizing discourses and disciplinary practices that shape it) has been expanded to cover race and ethnicity by postcolonial theorists (see especially Stoler, 1995 and 2010) and by queer and race theorists (see especially McWhorter, 2009).

The social imaginary of American culture has inscribed sexist and racist stereotypes that interact in shaping prejudicial social expectations and in the formation of stigmatic social scripts. Feminists of color (such as Angela Davis and bell hooks) have discussed for decades the key interrelations between sexism and racism, and the differential attention that black men and white men received as perpetrators of violence against women in the United States. And indeed the relative invisibility that the gender violence committed by white men traditionally had (and perhaps still does) was not (is not) unrelated to the hypervisibility enjoyed by gender violence committed by non-white men. What has not been as widely discussed until recently is the connection between the sexual pathologization of racial minorities and the pathologization of alternative sexualities depicted as perversions. It has only been recently that scholars in race theory and queer theory have studied the relation between the cultural construction of the non-white heterosexual aggressor (e.g., the so-called myth of the black rapist) and the cultural construction of the homosexual pervert subject (e.g. the cultural cliché of the homosexual as a potential child molester). Racial and sexual others were simultaneously conceptualized in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries as threats to *cultural normalcy* in the West. The cultural imaginary of Western societies in late modernity brought together two processes of stigmatization and social marginalization: the stigmatization of non-white and non-heterosexual subjects, who were conceived as sexual threats that could alter the social order and pollute the white race. Foucault provides a detailed genealogy of these cultural processes of stigmatization in his account of the emergence of scientific racism and of a very general form of racism supported by it: "racism against the abnormal,"[44] which was first and foremost about the primacy and privilege of the normal white subject and created a whole battery of disciplinary mechanisms for the oppression of non-white and non-heterosexual subjects who were rendered socially dangerous and deviant in the cultural imaginary thus produced.

Using the Foucaultian framework, Ladelle McWhorter (2009) has provided a persuasive genealogy of racial and sexual oppression in the United States, paying attention both to the common threads and the distinctive features of these forms of oppression. McWhorter shows how in the United States scientific racism against the abnormal, and accompanying movements such as eugenics,[45] were crucial not only for the oppression of black people, but also for the marginalization and stigmatization of everybody who was considered deviant. According to the social imaginary promoted by the American racism

[44] See especially the discussions of race in *Society Must Be Defended* (2003), which contains Foucault's lectures at the Collège de France in 1975–76.

[45] This includes a set of invasive and violent practices, such as the sterilization of entire populations. McWhorter (2009) discusses specific historical applications of eugenicist policies in the United States and how they have been covered over and the experiences and losses of entire populations forgotten.

against the abnormal, interracial sexual relations as well as homosexual relations posed an imminent social threat: the threat to compromise the purity of the white race by intermingling with those stuck in an arrested state of human development who could spread their retardation to the rest of society. In this view, both racism and heterosexism are first and foremost about *whiteness*, about the cultural construction and hegemonic affirmation of the normal white subject (the racially pure, heterosexual, bourgeois Anglo-American subject). Scientific racism was one of the central discursive mechanisms for the advancement of "the white race" and for the marginalization, oppression, and even (in some cases) extermination of any group of individuals who did not fit the mold of "the normal white subject" and were considered deviant. As McWhorter (2009) shows in historical detail, scientific racism provided a cultural frame that could be used to stigmatize different kinds of deviant subjects on the model of racial others. Thus, like blacks, homosexuals too were considered promiscuous sexual deviants who could not control themselves and did not have the kind of mature agency that white Anglo-American heterosexuals were capable of.

Some recent work in American studies and queer theory also gives support to the connection between racism and heterosexism in the United States, linking the cultural distortions and bodies of ignorance about racial and sexual minorities that plagued the American imaginary since (at least) the nineteenth century. In *Sapphic Slashers: Sex, Violence, and American Modernity* (2001), for example, Lisa Duggan examines how cultural representations of lesbian scandals were framed and discussed through the rhetorical lenses of a racist ideology that established the cultural parameters of how to talk about deviant subjects who posed a social threat. Duggan offers a detailed study of the notorious 1892 murder in Memphis, Tennessee, of Freda Ward by her former lover Alice Mitchell. Following closely the newspaper accounts of the crime and the trial, Duggan argues that the cultural tale of lesbian love murder has to be read against the backdrop of the pathologization of homosexuality and the turn-of-the-century debates over racial violence. Duggan's study shows how cultural stereotypes about lesbian sexual violence were produced by reformulating the available cultural stereotypes about racial violence, showing the connections between the multiple narratives of lesbian love, sex, and madness that her case study occasioned, and the narratives of lynching that were produced and widely circulated at the time. Duggan's study also shows that the growing field of sexology was producing a cultural narrative that marginalized women who challenged the dominant heteronormative white ideology, presenting them as unbalanced subjects who needed to be isolated from society and declared incompetent and dangerous. This illustrates the crucial connections between the oppression of women and the oppression of racial and sexual minorities in the US context. I want to suggest that the recently developed epistemology of ignorance can make important contributions here, for, as McWhorter (2009)

and others have shown, racial and sexual oppression are supported by shared distortions and overlapping bodies of active ignorance. Sexual and racial domination have produced intersecting bodies of ignorance, which were explicitly formulated in some academic discourses and disciplines, such as sexology and the sciences of race: expert bodies of ignorance that were part of a network of practices and institutions that contribute to the pathologization and dehumanization or sub-humanization (often taking the form of animalization) of sexual and racial minorities as well as of women. Indirectly, by perpetuating the oppression of these different groups these expert bodies of active ignorance were maintaining privilege, that is, protecting the privileged status of the heterosexual white man as the standard of normality and the paragon of humanity.

Given the crucial cultural connections among racism, sexism, and heterosexism, it is not surprising to find a dominant social imaginary that functions as the source of active ignorance about women and racial and sexual minorities. The hypothesis I have advanced and will continue to explore is that these distortions and bodies of ignorance that support multiple forms of oppression are maintained thanks to a lack of epistemic friction and the sustained failures of differently situated subjects to carry out their epistemic responsibilities, and that exercising epistemic resistance can produce beneficial friction that can make us more responsible and socially lucid, or at least less insensitive. This is what the Foucaultian notion of *counter-history* used by McWhorter does, namely, to bring to the fore silenced or forgotten memories, narratives, and perspectives, thus producing "an insurrection of subjugated knowledges," letting a plurality of epistemic perspectives be heard and remembered, functioning as epistemic counterpoints and correctives of each other. In the remaining chapters I will explore how the social imagination as a source of epistemic oppression can be countered and resisted and how individual and collective forms of lucidity can be attained.

{ 5 }

Meta-Lucidity, "Epistemic Heroes," and the Everyday Struggle Toward Epistemic Justice

Just as at the center of my account of vitiated epistemic subjectivities appeared a particular kind of insensitivity, a *meta-blindness* produced by lack of epistemic friction, in this chapter at the center of my account of virtuous epistemic subjectivities will appear a particular kind of lucidity, a *meta-lucidity* produced by epistemic friction. For this elucidation I will draw on feminist standpoint theory and on critical race theory, the two main bodies of literature that have examined how the epistemic disadvantages of the oppressed can at the same time involve significant epistemic advantages. I will argue that among these advantages we can find a special kind of lucidity that functions as a corrective of the meta-blindness underlying oppression that I have discussed in the previous chapters. But I will also address the issue of how to achieve (at least some degrees of) meta-lucidity for differently situated subjects, including those in a position of privilege whose life experiences may not have put them in the best position to become lucid about insensitivity. Although in the next section I will start with the special kind of lucidity that can be found among oppressed subjects by virtue of their experiences of oppression and the kinds of epistemic friction they have endured, I will go on to discuss, in section 5.2, how the social blindness of privileged subjects can be repaired so that they too can achieve some degrees of lucidity. For example, in the case of racial oppression and racial ignorance, I discuss how "white ignorance" can be corrected so that racially privileged subjects can also become lucid with respect to race and improve both their self-knowledge and their knowledge of racial others. In section 5.3 I connect these issues with the larger and more challenging issue of how to remove epistemic obstacles and achieve cognitive melioration not only for particular individuals and groups, but for the entire social fabric and in a durable way that will affect future generations. I discuss the phenomenon of what I call *epistemic heroes*, that is, extraordinary subjects who under conditions of epistemic oppression are able to develop epistemic virtues with a tremendous transformative potential. Although *epistemic heroes* (like *epistemic villains*) may exist in *some* sense (if only as dramatic exaggerations of exceptional individuals), I will argue that they should be understood as *emblems*,

that is, as figures that become emblematic because—given certain social processes and communicative dynamics—they come to epitomize the daily struggles of resistance of ordinary people within a social movement or network. But, according to my interactive social contextualism, the transformative impact of performance that we consider *heroic* is crucially dependent on social networks and daily practices that *echo* that performance. Detaching the contributions that epistemic heroes make toward justice from the social support that precedes and follows their action, I will suggest, is a dangerous trap that the dominant individualism in Western cultures sets up for social movements of resistance. I offer two examples of cultural icons of resistance who appear to be "epistemic heroines," one from the history of Latina feminism (Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz) and the other from the history of the civil rights movement (Rosa Parks), emphasizing in both cases how the removal of epistemic obstacles and planting the seed of social change are part of ongoing daily practices of resistance. I connect this everyday struggle of epistemic resistance and epistemic melioration with the transformation of the social imaginary, which will be the central theme of the final chapter.

5.1. Living Up to One's Epistemic Responsibilities under Conditions of Oppression: "Meta-Lucidity"

My contextualist argument in this chapter will try to show that, despite their being mistreated and disadvantaged epistemically, oppressed subjects tend to develop particular epistemic virtues and particular forms of lucidity, which enable them to be more properly responsive to epistemic injustices. I will contend that, under conditions of oppression, the most responsible epistemic subjects tend to be precisely those who are most disadvantaged by the oppression in question. Drawing on the contextualist view of epistemic responsibility articulated in the previous chapter, my argument goes as follows. On the one hand, while oppressed subjects have fewer or more mitigated epistemic obligations given their lack of epistemic opportunities and resources and the negative impact of epistemic injustices on them qua knowers, nonetheless they (collectively, if not as individuals) tend to exceed their epistemic duties and make epistemic contributions that (can) transform deeply the social knowledge available, providing new conduits through which knowledge can travel and blocking or destabilizing the circuits and pathways of bodies of ignorance. On the other hand, while privileged subjects have more or stronger epistemic obligations given the epistemic advantages they enjoy, nonetheless they (as a group, if not as individuals) tend to fail their epistemic responsibilities in particular respects and precisely as they pertain to the systematic injustices that they do not suffer and contribute little to overcome. In the case of racial oppression and racial ignorance we can begin to explain the paradigmatic epistemic irresponsibility

of privileged subjects and, by contrast, the epistemic virtues that oppressed subjects can develop through an application of Elizabeth Spelman's celebrated notion of *boomerang perception*, briefly discussed in the previous chapter. The racist/colonialist gaze toward racial/ethnic others has been internalized by most white subjects in the West. The narcissistic perception of the white gaze, as we saw, has a boomerang structure because it projects itself and comes back to itself, producing only the perception of its own images. Let's briefly examine the epistemic consequences of boomerang perception both on the perceiver and on the (mis)perceived (or only half-seen).

As argued in the previous chapter, the subjects who look at racialized others through the white gaze and see only the reflections of the white imaginary cannot embark on the journey of getting to know these racialized others responsibly, for ultimately, they look only at themselves and the images that their own imaginary has produced without realizing that they are doing so. Their epistemic irresponsibility with respect to others is grounded in a meta-blindness (an insensitivity to insensitivity) which, as argued above, does not see the obstacles that stand in the way of getting to know others in their differences (*blindness to differences*) and in the way of appreciating the social relevance of the real lives of others—their experiences, problems, interests, aspirations, and so on (*blindness to social relationality*). Combining Spelman's analysis and Said's account of orientalism, Maria Lugones (2003) argues that the Western/white gaze only allows the perceiver to see a racialized other as a mere *image*: "image both in the sense of imagined and in the sense of a reflection, an imitation" (p. 158). And, as Lugones goes on to explain, the mere images to which racialized others are reduced in the white gaze are *distorted self-images*: how the white perceiver imagines non-whites to be by comparison with white subjectivity. Racial others are perceived as "lacking independent history because lacking an independent subjectivity," as "the 'same' and monstrously different" (Ibid.). Following Said, Lugones argues that the West's creation of the Orient and the development of the "imaginative geography" of the West are exercises in boomerang perception: "The West acquires a sense of itself negatively through the setting of the 'us'/'them' dichotomy [and] it acquires a sense of its own value by constituting itself as the original which the Orient repeats, mimics monstrously, grotesquely" (p. 157). Thus Oriental cultures are conceived as deformed repetitions or monstrous reflections of the Western culture. Following Lugones' suggestion, I want to add that this interracial and cross-cultural blindness involves also a lot of *self-ignorance*, for the blind spot of the Western/white gaze is not only the racialized others, but also itself: the Western white subject. The social blindness in question affects not only one's perception of racialized others, but also one's perception of oneself and of one's racial group. Ultimately, as I suggested in the previous chapter, the subjects of this arrogant and narcissistic boomerang perception lack knowledge not only about others, but also about themselves: being *blind to differences*, they cannot know themselves fully

because they are unequipped to distinguish themselves from others properly; and being *blind to social relationality*, they ignore how their own life, culture, and history are bound up with that of others. Their epistemic irresponsibility consists in the simultaneous violation of the interrelated cognitive minimums of social knowledge of others and self-knowledge. Seeing *in white*, in this sense, involves a lot of blindness. It is seeing in the dark. It is being cognitively and affectively numbed. But what about those who are the objects of boomerang perception?

The racialized subjects who are looked at through boomerang perception are not seen other than as a screen on which the distorted images of the white gaze and the white imaginary are projected. For the subjects who endure it, what epistemic consequences may result from not being seen, being only half-seen, or being distortedly seen? The effects can, of course, be widely diverse, multifaceted and heterogeneous. But, following a long tradition in race theory dating back to Du Bois, I want to focus on the positive epistemic consequences that can follow from the experience of internalizing a social gaze that does not see you or sees you only distortedly. The experience of social invisibility or distorted social visibility is an experience shared by different oppressed groups: for example, traditionally, women have been rendered invisible in many social spaces, and distorted images of femininity have also circulated widely in other spaces; traditionally, the very existence of queer people has been denied or relegated to the margins, and very often their existence has been acknowledged only as a problem (a religious problem, a medical problem, a psychiatric problem, an educational problem, etc.). But it is the social invisibility or distorted social visibility of racialized others—and in particular, African Americans—that has received special attention in the philosophical literature on oppression; and the epistemic consequences of these problematic forms of visibility have been more fully explored in the philosophical literature on race. In this literature, social invisibility and distorted social visibility are typically not distinguished, being often addressed simultaneously and even treated as synonymous. And indeed not being seen and being distortedly seen typically go together, both in the case of racial seeing and in other areas of social perception: very frequently one is not seen as a homosexual person, for example, because one is improperly seen as a heterosexual person. But no matter how close and intimately connected social invisibility and distorted social visibility may be, they are conceptually distinct and can happen separately. I will start by discussing certain features and implications of social invisibility to then move to the analysis of distorted seeing and its epistemic consequences for oppressed subjectivities.

Charles Mills is one of the contemporary philosophers of race who has developed the most elaborate analyses of the social invisibility of racial minorities in the white gaze. In *Blackness Visible* (1998) Mills sketches a very suggestive epistemic analysis of Ralph Ellison's *Invisible Man* (1952). Mills emphasizes that the central epistemic problem of Ellison's black narrator is

> his "invisibility," the fact that whites do not see him, take no notice of him, not because of physiological deficiency but because of the psychological "construction of their inner eyes," which conceptually erase his existence. He is not a full person in their eyes, and so he either is not taken into account in all their moral calculations or is accorded only diminished standing. (pp. 8–9).

This is how the narrator of the novel summarizes his predicament toward the end: "Well, I *was* and yet I was invisible, that was the fundamental contradiction. I was and yet I was unseen" (p. 383). But at this point the narrator is in a position to exploit this contradiction, to use his invisibility for his own benefit and as a weapon of resistance, as a weapon of attack against blind white men: "They were blind, bat blind, moving only by the echoed sounds of their own voices. And because they were blind they would destroy themselves and I'd help them" (pp. 383–4). The self-conscious lucidity is achieved precisely by coming to terms with his complete lack of visibility as a man in the white world: "I now recognize my invisibility" (p. 384). He recognizes that all of those who looked at him through the white gaze "were very much the same, each attempting to force his picture of reality upon me and neither giving a hoot in hell for how things looked to me. I was simply a material, a natural resource to be used" (Ibid.). The narrator comes to the conclusion that whites are utterly blind to "the reality of our lives" and incapable of seeing blacks "as more than convenient tools for shaping their own desires" (p. 386).

In "White Ignorance" (2007) Mills generalizes some of the remarks of Ellison's narrator and talks about the centrality of the experience of invisibility for people of color in a white world. He writes, "What people of color quickly come to see—in a sense, the primary epistemic principle of the racialized social epistemology of which they are the object—is that *they are not seen at all*" (Mills: 2007, p. 18; my emphasis). This experience of not being seen can have far-reaching consequences in one's epistemic life. On the one hand, it may handicap one's cognitive abilities: it may inhibit one's voice and capacity to actively participate in epistemic interactions. But, at the same time, it can also have positive consequences and afford epistemic advantages: one can also comfortably and strategically occupy one's invisibility, exploiting the benefits of being unperceived while having access to bodies of evidence one is not assumed to know, of being able to use channels of communication that go undetected, of being able to exercise forms of reasoning that are not recognized, and so on. These advantages of the cognitive standpoint of marginalized subjects who have been rendered invisible have been analyzed in detail by feminist standpoint theorists such as Patricia Hill Collins (1990/2000) and Alison Wylie (2003). Collins (1990/2000) has examined the cognitive perspectives of black women as "outsiders within," that is, as subjects who are fully cognizant of the social order in which they live but nonetheless are perceived and treated

as strangers to that order. Combining the insights of race theory on invisibility with feminist standpoint theory, Alison Wylie (2003) has also examined the cognitive advantages of "insider outsiders," that is, of those who are inside of a practice but nonetheless are not considered to be part of it—or even present in it. As Wylie explains, this peculiar situation of being inside and outside a social context can give invisibilized subjects both individual and collective advantages: for example, the opportunity to collect information while unperceived, to look and hear as if one were not there; the opportunity to create a network for sharing information among those subjects whose dealings with the world and with each other go unnoticed; and the possibility of developing ways of communicating that go undetected. But as Wylie emphatically warns us, assessing the current state of standpoint theory, we cannot assume that all those who occupy marginalized locations that render them invisible automatically enjoy these epistemic advantages.[1] In chapter 1 I too, following Wylie, rejected the so-called *thesis of automatic epistemic privilege* while preserving the insights of standpoint theory.

But besides the strategic advantages that not being seen can afford, we also have to look at the structural benefits that social invisibility can bring to those who suffer it, that is, at the epistemic ramifications of this invisibility for those subjects qua epistemic agents. What is it in the cognitive structures of these subjects that can be different as a result of experiencing not being seen? Living one's life as if one did not exist, having one's presence and agency unrecognized, immediately affects one's personal and interpersonal dispositions. On the one hand, one must develop *self-regarding attitudes* that accommodate this invisibility: one must look at oneself as someone who is not seen by others in certain respects and in certain contexts. And, on the other hand, one must also develop *other-regarding attitudes* that accommodate this invisibility: one must look at others as being selectively blind to one's presence, as acting and talking as if one did not exist under certain conditions. I want to call attention to one particular aspect of this lived invisibility: the acute (and typically painful) awareness that there is an epistemic lacuna permeating the social context, a lacuna that the subject (and others like her or him) experiences but that others do not. This painful experience of cognitive failure and dissonance—of a fractured map of social perceptions with gaps that only those who fall into them are aware of—can have positive epistemic consequences; it can be a learning opportunity, one could say. Being an imperceptible object—that is, the object that occupies the blind spot of the visual field of other people's perceptions—can be characterized as an experience of cognitive excess, in this case, of perceptual excess: the realization of one's invisibility entails

[1] Also, we cannot assume that all those invisibilized subjects who belong to a marginalized group share the same standpoint. This is the other warning that Wylie (2003) issues against essentializing epistemic standpoints by relying on one-sided definitions of social groups and social locations and thus homogenizing the diverse and heterogeneous experiences that people can have within them.

that one becomes to oneself—painfully, sometimes even traumatically—the living proof that there is more to be seen than what others (some others) see. And this insight can have beneficial epistemic consequences when it is consolidated into a particular cognitive *meta-attitude* (that is, an attitude about one's cognitive attitudes): this is the meta-attitude of being always *on the lookout for more, forever more*, which is based on the *experience that there can be more than what is seen*. This is the meta-attitude that grounds the epistemic virtue of *open-mindedness* that we discussed in chapter 2, and it is a crucial aspect of what I call *meta-lucidity*. Meta-lucidity constitutes a crucial cognitive achievement that can become indispensable for retaining the status of a responsible epistemic agent living under conditions of oppression. Meta-lucid subjects are those who are aware of the effects of oppression in our cognitive structures and of the limitations in the epistemic practices (of seeing, talking, hearing, reasoning, etc.) grounded in relations of oppression: for example, the invisibilization of certain phenomena, experiences, problems, and even entire subjectivities. Oppressed subjects are in a better position to achieve these insights because they are the very embodiment of those cognitive limitations and suffer directly the cognitive biases and vitiated cognitive structures that support the relations of oppression.

Meta-lucidity can be achieved through the epistemic friction of two conflicting perspectives: the experience of not being seen can produce the painful experience of cognitive conflict between two ways of seeing—the subject's own gaze and the social gaze that does not see him. When it has this particular sociogenesis, meta-lucidity is triggered by what has been called *double consciousness* in the philosophical literature on race. Double consciousness involves the capacity to entertain two perspectives, two ways of thinking, and two ways of looking at the world. Indeed, the experience of being *invisible* typically involves the experience of conflict between two ways of seeing. Typically, not being seen is part of being hidden under distorted images that the perceiver projects; that is, it is not a matter of not being seen at all, but rather, of not being properly perceived in crucial respects because an illusory perception is blocking the view. What the subject who is not properly seen, or not seen in certain respects (qua X or Y), encounters is typically not simply the mere absence of sight, but rather a distorted way of seeing that has made itself blind to certain things. And since being unseen is thus typically accompanied by distorted perceptions, we have to shift the focus of our analysis from mere invisibility to distorted social visibility: a complex way of seeing with lots of visual contents that hide certain aspects or elements in the visual field, hiding or erasing even entire objects of perception. This fits with the way in which the white gaze has been defined in the literature on race: as the projector of images under which oppressed subjectivities and uncomfortable realities are hidden. It is this thick notion of distorted seeing that is involved in the powerful phenomenon of double consciousness, which is produced through the internalization of an authoritative way of seeing in which one

does not recognize oneself. This is indeed true of W. E. B. Du Bois, the African American philosopher who created the concept of "double consciousness." I will briefly discuss how meta-lucidity appears in double consciousness, as explained by Du Bois and the subsequent literature on oppressed subjectivities.

The expression "double consciousness" first appeared in an article that Du Bois published in 1897 in *Atlantic Monthly* under the title "Of Our Spiritual Strivings." This paper was edited and republished as the opening chapter of Du Bois's celebrated collection of essays *The Souls of Black Folk* (1903/1996). There Du Bois defines "double consciousness" as "this sense of always looking at one's self through the eyes of others, of measuring one's soul by the tape of a world that looks on in amused contempt and pity" (p. 5). As a result, Du Bois ex plains, the consciousness of the American Negro has been split: he "feels his two-ness—an American, a Negro; two souls, two thoughts, two unreconciled strivings; two warring ideals in one dark body, whose dogged strength alone keeps it from being torn asunder" (Ibid.). Du Bois remarks that the history of the American Negro is the history of the internal struggle of this two-ness. The goal of this struggle, according to Du Bois, should not be to eliminate the two-ness—the multi-dimensionality of the Negro consciousness—but rather, to learn to live with it and to learn from each of the component parts in tension. Du Bois talks about "merging" ("to merge his double self into a better and truer self"[Ibid.]), but he quickly points out that this is not a unification that betrays the differences and distinctiveness of each component part. He insists that American Negroes should not allow any of the component parts of their two-ness to win the struggle and to become dominant: the path to the resolution of the internal struggle of the American Negro will not be to "bleach his Negro blood in a flood of white Americanism" or to "Africanize America" (Ibid.). The challenge is *balance*: to achieve the harmonious mutual coexistence of two perspectives, to maintain a healthy bifurcated consciousness in which the two component parts are in communication and they enrich each other.

In his discussion of double consciousness Du Bois also uses a visual metaphor and talks about the cognitive and perceptual capacities that go along with double consciousness. He claims that the American Negro is "born with a veil and gifted with second sight in this American world" (p. 5). The Negro is painfully aware of his veiled existence and he looks at himself as veiled, as white Americans do. But he can also pierce the veil of ignorance of the white world and develop an alternative way of seeing, a *resistant perception* alongside the dominant perception he has internalized. As Lugones (2003) explains it, double vision involves "seeing oneself and one's company at once in the racist and the resistant construction," being "able to hold two incompatible and parallel perceptions at once" (p. 156). Patricia Hill Collins (1990/2000) has drawn precisely on this aspect of the Du Boisian concept of double consciousness to develop an epistemology of resistance for black women. Thanks to a bifurcated consciousness, she argues, black women can generate self-representations that

enable them to resist the demeaning racist and sexist images of black femininity in the white world. Collins finds the critical payoff and subversive potential of double consciousness in allowing the subject to take critical distance from the dominant perspective, for once you have two cognitive perspectives available to you—that of mainstream culture and that of the oppressed—you can comparatively evaluate them and look at one from the perspective of the other.[2] Indeed, double consciousness brings with it the *opportunity* to develop the ability to shift back and forth between two ways of seeing and, hence, the ability to make comparisons and contrasts between visual perspectives. But notice that this is only a *possibility*; there is no guarantee that every double consciousness will have this flexibility and dynamic inner structure. For those with double consciousness there is also the possibility of a systematic cognitive dissonance in which each of the cognitive perspectives are systematically isolated from the other. But even with the most radical form of mental isolationism, a bifurcated consciousness retains the *potential* of cognitive benefits, for even while living in cognitive dissonance a double consciousness gives the subject an incipient kind of lucidity—even if shallow—that others do not have: namely, the awareness that there are two alternative ways of seeing. But here we have only the potential of cognitive benefits, for it is often the case that "seeing in black and white" does not supply much better social perceptions than seeing "only in white" or "only in black."[3]

Indeed, the double consciousness that embodies epistemic virtues and can afford the most cognitive advantages is the one that has its internal component parts in good communication. The mere coexistence of epistemic perspectives is not sufficient for the lucidity and epistemic virtues of which oppressed subjectivities are capable; there must be *epistemic friction* between the alternative standpoints available. Concurring with Collins and other race theorists, the epistemology of resistance I have articulated also identifies the ability to shift back and forth between epistemic perspectives and to establish instructive comparisons and contrasts between them as the special source of critical power and lucidity available to oppressed subjects.

In my view, epistemically virtuous double consciousness is the consciousness that has *epistemic counterpoints inside it* and, therefore, *internal epistemic friction*. If a double consciousness brings with it not only the awareness of two

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[2] This sort of epistemic advantage can also be found in the context of scientific inquiry where women researchers by virtue of having multiple perspectives are more likely to detect sexist biases than men, as it has been discussed by another influential standpoint theorist, Sandra Harding (1991). See also the different essays in the collected volume on the philosophy of science and technology edited by Harding and Figueroa (2003).

[3] As it will be discussed later, the black and white binary that has dominated the American racial imaginary has polarized social perceptions into rigid and distorting categories and has functioned as a central source of racial blindness. Rather than a mere bifurcation of our social gaze and racial consciousness, I will argue that what is needed for genuine racial lucidity is a polyphonic and kaleidoscopic consciousness.

ways of seeing, but also the ability to connect these perceptual perspectives, the first principle of epistemic friction—the *principle of acknowledgment and engagement*—is automatically satisfied: different cognitive perspectives are being acknowledged and critically engaged. But note that satisfying the second principle, the *principle of epistemic equilibrium*, takes more work, for indeed the danger of one perspective overpowering the other—or of there being some imbalance between them—is always there. As mentioned above, Du Bois himself saw that striving toward balance should guide the journey of the Negro's double consciousness. But he was fully aware of how difficult harmonizing the images of a privileged and a subordinate perspective could be for a marginalized subjectivity, given the tremendous denigrating power that the dejected images internalized from the dominant white gaze could have on the Negro: "the facing of so vast a prejudice could not but bring the inevitable self-questioning, self-disparagement, and lowering of ideals which ever accompany repression and breed in an atmosphere of contempt and hate" (1903/1996, p. 10). In her discussion of double consciousness, Lugones (2003) also talks about this difficulty when she emphasizes that it is "unhealthy for oppressed peoples to obsess over the oppressor's perception of their subjectivity" and yet "one becomes both fascinated by it and overwhelmed by its power" (p. 156). Lugones warns us that unraveling the logic of the oppressor's gaze does not guarantee liberation; we cannot confidently think that we are on our way to a resistant subjectivity just because we understand the ideology that oppresses us and the extent to which we have internalized it, for this understanding typically has a paralyzing effect on us. How can we escape the radical imbalance of a dominant ideology (or way of seeing) overpowering any other perspective and paralyzing the subjects who hold them?

Let's remind ourselves that the principle of epistemic equilibrium was not a relativistic principle that demanded giving equal weight to all perspectives. Rather, it was the desideratum of searching for equilibrium in the interplay of cognitive forces, without some forces overpowering others, without some cognitive influences becoming unchecked and unbalanced. So the question becomes, how can we guarantee that the different epistemic perspectives available can properly check each other, serve as epistemic counterpoints to each other, so that there is beneficial epistemic friction among them? Keeping a perspective in a subordinate position with respect to a dominant perspective makes this impossible, for the values and ideals of the dominant perspective will remain unchecked and exempted from resistance. The power of white stereotypes on black life and thought can remind us all of how hard it is to resist conformity to the dominant ideology we have been born into and we have breathed as defining the air of normalcy.

How is psychic liberation from a dominant ideology possible? How is racial liberation for a double consciousness possible? We are better off not aspiring to a fully liberated subjectivity, but thinking about liberation as a constant

struggle, an ongoing task which, though always unfinished, can nonetheless meliorate our lives. Du Bois' account of the struggles of the American Negro in *The Souls of Black Folk* can be read as an account of episodes in the progressive and unfinished psychic liberation of black people in the United States. Du Bois offers a brief sketch of the history of the American Negro as the struggle to achieve this hard-to-obtain balanced subjectivity that is not simply overpowered by the dejected images offered by the white gaze. Du Bois describes this history as a hard journey full of suffering, but

> the journey at least gave leisure for reflection and self-examination; it changed the child of emancipation to the youth with dawning self-consciousness, self-realization, self-respect. In those somber forests of his striving his own soul rose before him, and he saw himself—darkly as through a veil; and yet he saw in himself some faint revelation of his power. (1903/1996, p. 9)

And these cognitive achievements became possible, Du Bois tells us, because the Negro "sought to analyze the burden he bore upon his back, the dead-weight of social degradation partially masked behind a half-named Negro problem" (Ibid.). And thus he felt something that the white man was incapable of feeling: "He felt *the weight of his ignorance*" (Ibid.; my emphasis). This is a crucial meta-insight that is both cognitive and affective: the Negro *feels* the white man's ignorance that he himself has internalized.

According to Du Bois, people of color, the target of racist oppression, are capable of seeing what the others do not see: their own degradation and the mechanisms of oppression and social distortions that produce them; they *feel* "the dead-weight of social degradation" masked as "the Negro problem," they *feel* the weight of the ignorance of the white world. And this is what crucially distinguishes them at the meta-level from racially privileged subjects: they are aware of a social illusion and what this social illusion hides; they are aware of a whole body of ignorance, a set of blind spots, to which others remain insensitive. This is *meta-lucidity*: not just lucidity about the social world, but about the cognitive attitudes, cognitive structures, and cognitive repertoires of those who navigate that social world.

The meta-insights that constitute this peculiar kind of lucidity are mainly negative: racially oppressed subjects know what they do not know, while those who are not oppressed are blind to their own ignorance, *insensitive* to it, that is, cognitively and affectively ill-equipped to confront, or even to detect, their ignorance. And note that this meta-lucidity looks both inward (into the inner self) and outward (onto others) simultaneously, piercing and bringing down illusory dichotomies between the inner and the outer, between self and others. It looks *inward* insofar as it recognizes, through the internal friction of the perspectives available to itself, the limitations and obstacles of its cognitive structure and of its different component elements. Oppressed subjects have

the cognitive advantage of being able to compare and contrast their marginalized perspective with the dominant perspective that they have internalized as standard or normal; and this epistemic friction has the potential of yielding meta-insights that can instruct subjects about the distinctiveness of each perspective as well as about their biases, distortions, and limitations. In particular, oppressed subjects, through this meta-lucidity, can become critically aware of the body of ignorance supporting relations of oppression that goes along with the dominant perspective they have internalized. But the meta-lucidity of oppressed subjects simultaneously looks *outward* insofar as the standard, normalizing perspective of mainstream culture that becomes the object of their critical scrutiny through the counterpoint of their resistant perspective is the dominant perspective that defines normality in their social environment, not just for them or their group, but for all members of society. Therefore, they can be said to hold meta-insights about the cognitive structures and epistemic habits of others in their social context. The epistemic obstacles and limitations that meta-lucid subjects recognize affect all members of the culture in question and most especially the privileged subjects, who are at the same time the most protected from these meta-insights and the most blind. In this sense, when it comes to the meta-knowledge of their own internal cognitive structures and their limitations (biases, prejudicial stereotypes, ingrained bodies of ignorance, etc.), privileged subjects tend to be ignorant about themselves, whereas oppressed subjects tend to become comparatively more knowledgeable and meta-lucid not only about themselves but also about their peers, including their oppressors. It is in this way that we can understand James Weldon Johnson's famous contention in his novel *The Autobiography of an Ex-Colored Man* (1912/1995): "I believe it to be a fact that the colored people of this country know and understand the white people better than the white people know and understand them" (p. 10).

The meta-lucidity of oppressed subjects enables them to satisfy the first two cognitive minimums previously discussed—that is, it enables them to attain sufficient degrees of self-knowledge and knowledge of their (significant) social others—and thus to become *responsible epistemic agents*, precisely when epistemic responsibility becomes rare in a context of systemic epistemic injustice. This idea fits in well with the most celebrated thesis of standpoint theory, namely, that there is a cognitive asymmetry between the standpoint of the oppressed and the standpoint of the privileged that gives an advantage to the former over the latter. As Harding (1983, 1991), among others, has argued, the perspectives from the lives of the less powerful can offer a more objective view of the social world, a view based on their experiences of being underprivileged that captures real disparities, instead of a view that ignores (or even erases) experiences of oppression and is more likely to be oblivious or blind to disparities and insensitive to injustice. In a similar vein—and with respect to very specific areas of knowledge—I have argued that the meta-lucid oppressed subjects with multiple

cognitive perspectives are the ones who, in contexts of oppression, can live up to the epistemic obligations required for responsible agency: to a sufficient degree, they know themselves and they know their (significant) others better than they know themselves—at least if their bifurcated consciousness achieves a minimal balance between perspectives, so that there can be mutual resistance and beneficial friction and not a mere overpowering of one perspective by the other (which would simply reproduce internally the relation of subordination and cognitive domination that characterizes oppression).

But how does a double consciousness with a balanced internal epistemic friction produce meta-lucidity? Seeing through the veil of ignorance can mean not only looking at the world in a different way, with fresh eyes; it can also mean *seeing the veil itself*, that is, becoming aware of epistemic limitations and obstacles, gaining insights about constraints on one's cognitive powers. Being meta-lucid about the limitations of our epistemic lives can be decisive in contexts of oppression. It can be the key to epistemic responsibility, to complying with the cognitive minimums of self-knowledge and social knowledge of others that we discussed in the previous chapter. But how can this meta-lucidity about ignorance be used subversively to resist oppression? Ellison's *Invisible Man* offers the description of one subversive possibility for this meta-lucidity: namely, trying not to undo white ignorance, but rather, to exploit it in the fight against racial oppression, that is, to maintain and even to exacerbate the blindness of racist ideologies so as to weaken white privilege, making it more restricted and easier to navigate, perhaps even making it self-undermining. This is what the narrator of *Invisible Man* suggests when he becomes aware—painfully aware—not only of his invisibility, but also of his distorted visibility, that is, of the pile of distorted images that have come to define him in the white world. He rejoices in the fact that he can also see himself as others see him, and he can use this distorted image of himself to his own advantage and against them:

> Very well, I'd become a supersensitive confirmer of their misconceptions . . . I'd serve them well and I'd make invisibility felt if not seen, and they'd learn that it could be as polluting as a decaying body, or a piece of bad meat in a stew. (p. 384)

The narrator's epistemic pessimism leads him to conclude that the only solution to the oppressive weight exerted by the blindness of white ignorance is not cognitive melioration, but to push white ignorance to its limits as a path to self-destruction for the white world and its racial oppression: "If I couldn't help them to see the reality of our lives I would help them to ignore it until it exploded in their faces" (p. 386). Thus Ellison's narrator decides to contribute to maintain white ignorance and the one-dimensionality of the white gaze until the white world implodes and self-destroys.

But is facilitating its self-destruction the only form of resistance we can offer to the white gaze, the only path for racial liberation? Du Bois and other race

theorists have sketched another possibility, which includes denouncing white ignorance and trying to change it. This is a solution to the epistemic oppression inherent in racism, which requires complex and interrelated processes of learning for differently situated groups: each group will have its own learning process to go through in order to come to terms with the epistemic injustices they suffer or help to inflict; each group will have distinctive contributions to make to repair the shared ignorance; and, given the right channels and dynamics of intergroup communication, the differently situated groups can (and should) learn from each other's learning process, thus taking advantage of every bit of cognitive and affective melioration that can be gathered from every corner of the social world. I will explore this alternative way of addressing white ignorance in the next section. But it is important to note that the different ways of fighting ignorance and epistemic oppression mentioned can be characterized as ways of *exerting epistemic friction* for the sake of progressive psychic liberation, that is, of cognitive and affective melioration. Even what Ellison as well as contemporary race theorists[4] have proposed, the self-destructive exploitation of white ignorance, turning it against itself, could be understood as exerting epistemic friction from the inside, that is, making a particular gaze or mindset *feel* its own limitations, bumping up against the world again and again until it feels *the weight of its ignorance* as a burden that makes it dysfunctional or nonfunctional. This radical form of internal friction is important, and it may be the best—even the only—way of offering resistance in certain contexts of oppression. But we have to put it in the context of a wide range of forms of resistance, some of which may lead to more durable changes, offering not only destructive but also constructive solutions through critical and subversive interventions that not only make the oppressive structures collapse but also put something (or contribute to the building of something) in their place. In this respect, I will argue, following Linda Alcoff, for the possibility of creating a *white double consciousness* so that privileged white subjects also bifurcate their cognitive and perceptual habits, attitudes, and structures by internalizing underprivileged perspectives that can exert epistemic friction and offer epistemic resistance from the inside. Similarly, from racial oppression to other forms of oppression, we can also contemplate and explore the possibility of creating—even if by a sort of social engineering that involves exerting great amounts of epistemic friction—a male, a heterosexual, a Western (or First World), a class-privileged double consciousness, as well as other possible ones.

The concept of double consciousness I have elucidated in this section is crucial to understanding the particular lucidity that oppressed subjects can achieve. But this concept needs to be *expanded* to live up to the demands that have arisen from my discussions of epistemic resistance. Although I said above

[4] See Lugones (2003) and also the discussions about strategies of subversion that exploit ignorance in Sullivan and Tuana (2007).

that a double consciousness with a balanced epistemic friction inside it constituted a virtuous subjectivity because it complied with the principles of epistemic friction, this is only true as long as there are only two epistemic perspectives available; but of course, there can always be more. What is needed is a *kaleidoscopic consciousness* that remains forever open to being expanded, that is, a subjectivity that is always open to acknowledge and engage new perspectives, and always open to strive toward a better balance among possible perspectives. The *counterfactual dimension* of this kaleidoscopic consciousness is crucial, for what is required for its production is to become capable of appreciating not only how things look from the multiple social locations available, but also, how things *might* look if we were to entertain newly created locations (or alter significantly the existing ones) and situate ourselves differently, in other words, if we were to keep considering how things might look from elsewhere. In *Speaking from Elsewhere* (2006a) I considered the critical power of eccentric forms of intelligibility ("an intelligibility from elsewhere"), which could shed light on our meanings and help us appreciate the limitations and blind spots of our semantic structures and communicative capacities (which I would now call *semantic blindness or insensitivity*). The same could be said about *a consciousness from elsewhere*, which is what we need to cultivate in order to achieve as much meta-lucidity as possible, as much insight into the cognitive limitations and obstacles of our perspectives as possible—knowing of course that *complete meta-lucidity is unreachable*, for the process of cognitive and affective melioration does not have an end and there are always blind spots that remain unnoticed.

What is needed is the cultivation of the ability to keep searching for new perspectives and actively trying to expand our perceptions and thoughts by contemplating things from elsewhere. This is the key to a kaleidoscopic consciousness. And nothing short of this complex cognitive and affective achievement will be adequate to the meta-blindness problem I have raised—that is, the problem of blind spots and insensitivities that remain hidden to the subject, who therefore becomes incapable of cognitive and affective melioration because of his insensitivity to insensitivity. For, indeed, if a double consciousness is not enough because the plural and heterogeneous nature of the social fabric can generate more than two perspectives, this problem is not solved by going to a triple or quadruple consciousness, for indeed, a fifth perspective may have been marginalized and rendered invisible and inaudible. Indeed, the social fabric can generate forever more standpoints: in fact, the perspectives of each group and even of each individual can always—at least in principle—be (further) pluralized. Instead of an infinitely pluralized consciousness, what is needed is a kaleidoscopic consciousness that has built into it a flexible and dynamic structure so that it can always adapt to the possibility of excess, that is, of there being more ways of experiencing the world than those considered. A kaleidoscopic consciousness is what is needed to confront the problem of

pluralism. And note that for a kaleidoscopic consciousness to have some degree of lucidity at the meta-level, it does not need to have full mastery of the different perceptual perspectives and standpoints (which is often impossible without having lived one's life in a certain way). Rather, it is sufficient to know that these different standpoints are there with their cognitive-affective powers and their cognitive-affective limitations—that is, that they have certain ways of framing that open our eyes, ears, and hearts to some things but not to others—and that there may be other standpoints that remain opaque or even invisible to us.

The meta-lucidity of a kaleidoscopic consciousness is first and foremost lucidity about the multiplicity of perspectives and of the limitations of one's own standpoint, and only secondarily lucidity about the specific features of those perspectives with which one's own is entangled. The metaphor of the kaleidoscope captures well some aspects of the multiplicitous consciousness that can hold and maintain active multiple perspectives simultaneously. The metaphor of the kaleidoscope underscores a fluid way of imagining ourselves and others in which patterns of relations are in flux, changing seamlessly and ceaselessly, with some relational possibilities giving way to others. This brings to the fore the *fluidity, dynamicity, and interconnectivity* that our racial consciousness should aspire to. However, the metaphor of the kaleidoscope, like any metaphor, also has its limitations, for it forces us to construe patterns of color and their interrelations as symmetric and orderly; and, of course, as we all know, the complex interrelations among racial identities are often not symmetric and orderly, but quite asymmetric and chaotic. Although the metaphor of the kaleidoscope is indeed not perfect, we can compensate for the premium it places on order and symmetry by calling attention to the fuzziness present in the transition from one pattern to another and in the relation between what is in the foreground and in the background of the kaleidoscopic image. But, at any rate, the metaphor is an improvement over the metaphor of *double* consciousness.

How does one cultivate a kaleidoscopic social consciousness that remains sensitive to differences in multiple areas of social life, producing lucidity with respect to multiple forms of oppression? And does becoming meta-lucid with respect to some blind spots and bodies of ignorance always help to become sensitive to other social blind spots and bodies of ignorance? Different kinds of epistemic injustice, though typically interconnected and exhibiting deep resemblances in their logic and dynamics, are often quite distinct and develop their own defense mechanisms, so that *a heightened sensitivity with respect to one kind of insensitivity does not at all guarantee any special sensitivity with respect to other forms of insensitivity*. In other words, what is learned in one context of injustice or as a result of certain experiences of oppression should not be assumed to be immediately transferable to other contexts or experiences of oppression. Different experiences of oppression (can) produce different kinds of double—or, better yet, *multiplicitous*—consciousness. We can talk about multiplicitous consciousness with respect to class, gender, nationality,

race, sexuality, and so on. And having one kind of multiplicitous or kaleidoscopic consciousness does not guarantee lucidity with respect to other forms of oppression: as discussed above, racially oppressed subjects can be blind with respect to gender and sexual oppression, women can have heterosexist and racist boomerang perceptions, and queers may be blind with respect to racial others or class others. Even if one is multiply oppressed (e.g., as a Hispanic, as a working-class subject, and as a gay person), it is always possible to remain in denial with respect to one's own oppression *in toto* or in some particular respects: subjects who suffer multiple forms of oppression may not even develop a kaleidoscopic vision of any kind, but remain cognitively and affectively numbed with a one-dimensional social sensitivity and a well-entrenched body of complicit ignorance; on the other hand, they may acquire some degrees of lucidity with respect to some aspects of their own oppression and not with respect to others. And, of course, subjects who are oppressed in only one respect but remain privileged in others (e.g., wealthy Anglo-American gay men) are more likely to have a limited lucidity with respect to multiple oppressions and with respect to the heterogeneous forms of social insensitivity and diverse blind spots created by social injustices. This phenomenon of the *compartmentalization of one's lucidity or sensitivity* with respect to insensitivity and blindness constitutes an important obstacle in the personal and collective learning processes concerning multiple experiences of oppression and, therefore, a crucial obstacle for the melioration of social and epistemic injustices. The *domain-specificity* of lucidity with respect to oppression can partially explain how difficult it has been for social movements of resistance to form coalitions and to fight against oppression on multiple fronts simultaneously without falling into the traps of in-fighting and divisive politics (with which we are all familiar, given the turbulent relations among the different movements within so-called identity politics).

We should be suspicious of any claim of complete lucidity or absolute sensitivity: "I feel your pain," "I feel everybody's pain"; "I see how your reality has been distorted," "I see all distortions." Just like our perceptions and cognitions, *our meta-cognitions are also always limited and must be constantly checked and expanded*.[5] The illusion of seeing or feeling everything can be another form of blindness or numbness, of not seeing anything in particular or of seeing things out of focus, of making oneself inattentive or insensitive to possible blind spots or insensitivities that may have gone so far undetected. However, this does not mean that we can only become lucid with respect to

[5] And this critical learning process of checking and expanding our perspectives requires the *interaction* of multiple, heterogeneous perspectives that resist one another and create epistemic friction. This is the rationale for the Imperative of Epistemic Interaction I have proposed. It follows from my polyphonic contextualism that the learning processes required for the melioration of epistemic injustices through resistance and friction are multiple, heterogeneous, and never-ending, for these processes are tied to indefinitely many possible perspectives that a community can contain or bring to life.

those forms of epistemic injustices we ourselves have experienced and have become reflective about in our own life. After all, the domain-specificity of lucidity is a contingent and contextual phenomenon; and, even if there is no generic (domain- and context-independent) lucidity to be attained, there are nonetheless ways of expanding our sensitivity to insensitivities and of becoming progressively more lucid about the different forms of blindness and numbness that support epistemic injustices. *The expansion of one's social sensibilities*—and with it also the pluralization of one's racial consciousness—*is an ongoing task that does not have an end*. And it is a task that individuals cannot fully carry out all by themselves. Such a task requires sustained *interactions* with significantly different individuals and groups (interactions that provide disruptions and diverse forms of epistemic friction)—hence the Imperative of Epistemic Interaction I have argued for. And, as we shall see, the task of expanding our social sensibilities also requires the cultivation of intra- and inter-group solidarities through the *chained actions* of individuals in social networks and movements (see section 5.3); and it requires not only action, but also imagination, *resistant imagination*, or the continued critical interrogation of shared forms of imagining from multiple perspectives (see chapter 6).

Some of the social and historical contingent obstacles that have been erected against this kind of expansion of one's social gaze and sensibility emerge from the creation of utterly separate vocabularies and practices to address different forms of oppression, and from the sociocultural habits of paying insufficient attention to the interconnections among oppressions and of privileging one over the others (making class or race or gender oppression the fundamental one, to which all others have to be reduced). Both the ideologies of privilege and the ideologies of resistance developed in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries have rendered us ill-equipped to develop social contexts and practices in which the complex process of *expanding one's sensitivity to insensitivity* can take place. But acknowledging all of this, I nonetheless want to suggest that particular experiences of epistemic injustice offer the learning *opportunity* to become progressively more lucid about the heterogeneous and multifaceted limitations and blind spots of cognitive-affective structures. To put it in the standard terms of double consciousness, the fracture or bifurcation of one's perceptions and thoughts has the potential not only to make oneself lucid in the particular respect of the fracture or bifurcation (for example, with respect to the racialized ways of perceiving and thinking to which one has been subjected), but also to initiate a wider process of becoming meta-lucid that may eventually reach other forms of oppression and epistemic injustice. What can be initiated, along with the heavily specific and situated meta-lucidity initially attained, is the process of expanding one's sensitivity to insensitivity: a cognitive-affective process of moral and political learning, that is, a process of sensitizing oneself to other silences, invisibilities, and distortions. But for

this expansion of one's social sensibilities to happen, the learning process has to reach a meta-level where greater degrees of lucidity about one's cognitive and affective meta-attitudes are reached.

As I argued in chapter 3, experiencing the inability to speak on certain issues, such as one's sexuality, as well as the inability of one's interlocutors to listen to these issues, *can* make one better attuned to hermeneutical gaps, that is, more sensitive to epistemic exclusions, on the lookout for what is left out. But there is *no guarantee* that this sensitivity will always flourish or that it will go far when carried over to the experiences of others in other domains. The experience of being excluded and silenced is the fertile soil for the development of a special *sensitivity to insensitivity*. But this sensitivity to insensitivity is not automatically transferred and carried over from issue to issue, from area of life to area of life, from context of oppression to context of oppression. It is always limited and contextually constrained, and it always needs more epistemic friction to continue its expansion. There are always undetected internal resistances and cognitive-affective limitations that are not experienced as such until one acknowledges and genuinely engages with other ways of perceiving, feeling, and thinking. In these encounters and engagements with differences, we experience epistemic frictions that can lead us to feel the contours of our social gaze and the blind spots of our cognitive-affective sensibilities. We can thus achieve some meta-lucidity that can facilitate other processes of cognitive and affective melioration of our social sensibilities. For example, as suggested above (in section 2.2), the experience of sexual stigmatization of a gay man *may not* necessarily make him more sensitive to the ways in which female sexuality has been pathologized and rendered opaque by the *same* (hetero)sexist culture; but he can draw on that experience, and his special sensitivity and critical openness with respect to *some* sexual matters can be used as the starting-point of a cognitive-affective learning process that will require the interaction with relevant others who have been sexually stigmatized in other respects. That is, what is required in order to be exposed to the appropriate epistemic friction that can expand one's sensitivity is an interactive process in which the subject can learn to empathize with others and to become sensitive to those aspects of their experience that have been marginalized, suppressed, or rendered unintelligible. The process of expanding one's sensitivity to insensitivity—of overcoming one's cognitive-affective numbness, of attaining greater degrees of lucidity with respect to injustices—is always an interactive social process. Although one should always tap into one's own experiences of difference, these are always limited. For that reason, the process of expanding our sensitivity requires that we connect the differences and excesses that we feel in ourselves with those felt by others that we may be ill-equipped to understand and to which we may remain insufficiently or improperly sensitive. This requires seeking others with significantly different experiences and engaging with their heterogeneous perspectives. Openness to differences—both to one's

own internal differences as well as to those of others—is the key to sufficient degrees of lucidity, sensitivity, and epistemic responsibility. (Different aspects of this openness to differences will be discussed in the next section and in the next chapter.)

My treatment of the domain-specificity of meta-lucidity as constraining but not rendering impossible the process of expanding one's sensitivity to insensitivity can be put in the context of recent developments in standpoint theory. Recently, standpoint feminists have problematized the absolute distinction between privileged and oppressed individuals by considering multiple, intersecting, and overlapping forms of oppression. Drawing on discussions of intersectionality, standpoint theorists[6] have argued that most individuals are oppressed in some respects and privileged in other respects, that is, oppressed in some contexts and practices, and with respect to some groups, but at the same time privileged in other contexts and practices, and with respect to other groups. An upper-class, heterosexual black woman, for example, may be the subject of racist and sexist oppression, but may not experience any homophobic or classist oppression. We may encounter a subject who appears to be oppressed in every respect, that is, in every context and practice, and with respect to every group we can think of—for example, the famous working-class black lesbian often discussed in the literature on oppression, to whom we would have to add many other features such as being disabled, a citizen of a Third World country, and so on. We may also encounter a subject who appears to be privileged in every respect, that is, in every context and practice, and with respect to every group we can think of—for example, the infamous upper-class white heterosexual male who is also often discussed in the literature on oppression, and to whom we would also have to add many other features such as being able-bodied, a citizen of the First World, and so on. But even the most extreme forms of privilege or oppression are not homogeneous and one-dimensional. My contextualist approach to domain-specificity calls attention to the complex interaction of privilege and oppression, and it asks us to acknowledge that experiences of privilege and oppression can be multifaceted and contain tensions. My polyphonic contextualism tries to meet the challenge raised by contemporary standpoint feminists to go beyond one-dimensional group experiences of oppression, to situate women and men within multiple systems of domination, and to explore the interrelations of their different social locations and standpoints, thus examining the complex relations among systems of oppression. Offering resistance productively and successfully to the different, but interrelated epistemic injustices produced by these systems of oppression requires that we consider a wide range of social locations and standpoints in their specificity.

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[6] See especially Bordo and Jaggar (1989), Narayan (1989), and Zinn and Dill (1996). See also Lugones (2003).

That is precisely what my polyphonic contextualism on epistemic agency attempts to do.

The scope of the lucidity that subjects achieve with respect to their cognitive-affective structures is crucially dependent on the particular genesis of that lucidity, on how it was attained and, in particular, on whether its genesis revolved around experiences of privilege or experiences of oppression. As suggested above, those subjects who develop a double or multiplicitous consciousness from experiences of oppression have an important advantage: they live and develop in such a way that their experiences become lucid without ever having been completely blind, since they have been blinded only in one dimension of their multiplicitous or kaleidoscopic vision, always compensating for the blinded perceptions with their alternative vision and thus always maintaining some degree of lucidity. But what about those who have lost sensitivity and have become blind, and not just simply blind but *actively blind*, *meta-blind*? How can *they* recover from this predicament? How can *they* fight their blindness and develop forms of lucidity? How does one get rid of internalized ignorance that one may not even be able to recognize? In the next section I will draw on the recent work of two feminists and race theorists, Linda Alcoff and Shannon Sullivan, to address these issues.

5.2. Promoting Lucidity and Social Change

How is it that in social environments in which racial or gender differences figure prominently only some subjects develop a racial or gender multiplicitous consciousness? And how is it that privileged subjects are less likely to do so? Double or multiplicitous consciousness appears to be a cognitive (and affective) accomplishment of oppressed subjects but not—at least not typically—of privileged subjects because it is occasioned by experiences of oppression. But why exactly, we may ask, shouldn't there be a fracture or a pluralization of perspectives within a privileged subjectivity? Why, for example, not a *double white consciousness*? Let's remind ourselves of the mundane ways in which double consciousness is generated, according to the classic accounts in race theory. Let's take Fanon's account, which has the virtue of offering detailed phenomenological descriptions that emphasize double consciousness not only as a mental phenomenon but also as a material one, emerging from everyday social experiences of one's embodiment. For example, Fanon describes how uncomfortably—almost painfully—he became aware of his body simultaneously in the first and in the second person under the gaze of white people on a train. He also gives an account of how his bodily schema started to feel differently, to become bifurcated, when he experienced the shock of being perceived as a rarity—perhaps even a monstrosity—by the seemingly innocent—but already arrogant—white gaze of a child who yelled "Look a Negro!" Now, why

should we assume that white people do not have a similar—or at least analogous, even if very different—experience of their racial embodiment as perceived in the second person by those who are racially different? And even if this does not happen spontaneously, couldn't an analogous experience be created, even if it has to be artificially manufactured, so that racialization is no longer a blind spot for white subjectivities? My discussion in this section tries to address these questions.

In *Mind, Self, and Society*, G. H. Mead (1934) offers an account of the development of self-consciousness in which we all go through the experience of seeing oneself in the first and second person simultaneously, that is, through our own eyes and through the eyes of others who look at us. The second person, the Thou, has a special formative force on us: it is the interlocutor facing us, addressing and positioning us in a particular way, making us feel the social gaze directed at us quite directly. According to Mead's and other sociogenetic accounts of the self, the internalization of the social gaze and the social address of others is not optional but a required formative element in identity formation: adopting the perspective of the other toward yourself, putting yourself in the shoes of the person looking at you, is a necessary step in the development of self-awareness. When it comes to racialized perception and consciousness, the problem is not that some white people have not internalized the perspective of others toward themselves—everybody who has become self-aware has done this. White arrogant perception—"boomerang perception"—arises because only one kind of subjectivity and its gaze, the white gaze, are fully acknowledged and felt. White consciousness becomes one-dimensional and arrogant because of the insensitivity to the non-white gaze and address. We all develop a sense of self by seeing ourselves through the eyes of others, but not always through the eyes of *different* others. Our responsivity to others is selective. We do not become sensitized to every gaze and every address, but only to the gaze and address of particular others. For white people, this would mean experiencing the perception of themselves as "white people" through the eyes of non-white people, and to register and internalize that gaze. Now, shouldn't this have been a common phenomenon even during segregation, even during slavery? How can an arrogant white subject fail to construe himself as an object of perception for the black gaze? How do people become impervious to the gaze and address of some particular others? How do these particular others become invisible and inaudible to them? There are basically two options here, two main ways in which this can happen. On the one hand, the most direct and basic way of desensitizing oneself to the gaze and address of particular others is by suppressing the occasions in which one can be addressed or even gazed at by them—or at least minimizing the impact of their gaze and address. And indeed during slavery and segregation there were severe constraints on black people's capacity to address and even look at white people. Even when there were no

legal prohibitions, there were informal practices and cultural expectations that heavily constrained people's agency in this respect:[7] black people were trained from an early age not to look at whites directly; and indeed staring with impunity, without even a feeling of vulnerability, has always been a clear sign of privilege. And the gaze of particular others loses its force when you do not experience them looking directly at you. But, on the other hand, there is a more subtle way of desensitizing oneself to the gaze and address of particular others, namely, by not recognizing them in their distinctiveness, as genuinely different from oneself, as true others. Even if one is gazed at and addressed by those particular others, one may not register their distinctive gaze and address, that is, their distinctive standpoint, their distinctive way of perceiving, feeling, and thinking. One may not see these others as different from the dominant forms of subjectivity one has internalized and, therefore, one may fail to adopt their distinctive perspectives toward oneself. For example, if the dominant subjectivity that has become hegemonic is that of the heterosexual white male, one may tend to construe every "other" one encounters as approximating that paradigm of subjectivity, failing to see them *qua* queers, *qua* women, or *qua* people of color and, therefore, failing to internalize their distinctive gazes, addresses, and perspectives.

The failure to adopt the perspectives of particular others toward oneself involves missing the opportunity to bifurcate or pluralize our consciousness and to move toward a kaleidoscopic perspective. This failure can be grounded in the other-regarding attitudes that we identified in the previous chapter as the source of interpersonal distortions and social blindness: the tendency to assume that all others are like oneself—*blindness to differences*; and the assumption that others are utterly irrelevant to our life, that our life and theirs are sealed off from each other—*blindness to social relationality*. Changing these very general other-regarding attitudes is prerequisite for the development of duplicitous or multiplicitous consciousness; it is what is needed in order to learn to adopt the perspectives of others toward ourselves and to get a glimpse at how things might feel when we look at the world through their eyes. How do these general other-regarding attitudes that produce insensitivity and meta-blindness function? And how can they be removed so that subjects who are initially blind to differences and to social relationality can eventually achieve some degree of lucidity? As an illustration of blindness to differences and to

[7] Black people were expected to be deferential and "to know their place" with respect to white power and status. A horrifying illustration of the very constrained and heavily policed acceptable agency of black people's gaze and forms of address can be found in the brutal murder of Emmett Till in 1955 (a black teenager who was killed and dismembered for looking and approaching—whistling at, according to some accounts—a young white woman). In general, those who violated white expectations of black deference were traditionally deemed "uppity" or "insolent." Black people's constrained agency to address whites can be exemplified in the legal context by their limited ability to give testimony—for example, blacks were often barred from testifying against a white person.

social relationality, I will use the phenomenon of *color-blindness*, whose discussion was initiated in chapter 1 (in connection with gender-blindness).

I will focus on color-blindness only as a form of *white* ignorance in the contemporary United States. Insofar as processes of racialization in the United States have been and still are structured around the black and white binary, the color blindness of white subjects can be considered a double blindness: *white-blindness*,[8] that is, blindness with respect to their own racial identity; and *color-blindness proper*, that is, blindness with respect to those who have been colored or racialized as non-whites. Notably it is only the latter kind of blindness that is explicitly professed in the ideology of color-blindness, because whiteness itself is not even registered, whereas racialized colors are in fact registered but disavowed and brushed aside. White-blindness runs much deeper than color-blindness because, for the white subject, whiteness is typically not even conceptualized as a color, but rather, as the absence of color, signifying the absence of race, rather than a way of color-coding one more racialized identity. White-blindness and color-blindness are intimately connected, and they are both crucial components of white ignorance. I will here analyze the distorting attitudes toward racialized others inscribed in color-blindness, linking the interpersonal aspects of white ignorance to the kind of self-ignorance involved in white-blindness. In particular, I am interested in elucidating the meta-attitudes in which color-blindness is grounded: meta-attitudes that channel and guide social perceptions, but also meta-attitudes that channel and guide one's self-perceptions. According to my analysis, the meta-ignorance involved in color-blindness operates through distorting second-order attitudes about one's cognitive and affective attitudes, resulting in *cognitive and affective meta-numbness* with respect to racial matters: ignorance of one's own racial ignorance and insensitivity to one's own racial insensitivity.

Two important clarifications are in order so as to understand properly this meta-blindness or meta-insensitivity. In the first place, although I have been focusing on *blindness* because the central target of my analysis is the ideology of color-blindness, it is important to note that the meta-insensitivity or numbness in which racial meta-ignorance consists goes well *beyond sight* and it affects also *other modalities* of social perception. This is to be expected, since processes of racialization operate not only through sight, but also through

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[8] In *Blindness* (1999), José Saramago describes a city ravaged by an instant epidemic of *white blindness*. Saramago's novel can be read as a parable about social insensitivity and even more specifically racial insensitivity, where those who see everything in white are unable to see anything at all. Interestingly, as those suffering from white blindness become more numerous and control spaces of interaction, the sighted become vulnerable and forced to pretend they do not see. This thought-provoking parable highlights not only the problems concerning *blindness*, but also the dangers and vulnerabilities that sight (e.g., racial lucidity) can carry in a world of blind people. Saramago offers a masterful commentary on the anxieties, aggressive reactions, and defense mechanisms that are activated when the blind realize that there is more than what they can perceive, that there is an entire realm or dimension of the world they cannot control while others have knowledge about it.

other senses, such as audition (accents, dictions, rhythms, characteristic sounds, etc.), or smell (characteristic cooking odors, body scents, etc.). The perception of racialized identities is multidimensional and highly contextual. We do not simply perceive whiteness as such, but rather, socially and historically situated configurations of white subjectivities, such as the Southern white upper-middle-class gentleman or lady, with their distinctive bodily comportments, clothing styles, accents, and so on. In the contextualized practices of racialized social perception, sight (and within it, the perception of skin color) has been given special cultural prominence, but it remains nonetheless only one perceptual modality among many for racial identification. What would happen when, for example, the color-blind subject registers the distinctively racialized accent of an African-American or Hispanic subject? In order to avoid contradictory social perceptions in which the encountered subject appears as not racialized in one sense but as racialized in another sense, the color-blind subject would have to become also accent-deaf—and in other contexts, insensitive to odor, taste, touch, and so on. In order to filter out racial elements from social perception, a cultivated kind of insensitivity or numbness has to be brought to all perceptual modalities. When taken to its ultimate consequences, the ideology of color-blindness requires the impoverishment of every perceptual modality that can carry racial markers. Although this is obscured by the obsessive focus on sight and color, the disregard of race—its erasure from social perception—requires not only blindness but the deprivation of every sense used in social perception.

In the second place, although I have explained the racialized ignorance involved in color-blindness mainly in cognitive terms, this ignorance also contains crucial *affective* elements. Racial ignorance involves both cognitive and affective attitudes and meta-attitudes with respect to racial others. This is why I think it is important to think of this peculiar kind of *blindness* as a form of *insensitivity* or *numbness*, for being insensitive or numbed conveys a lack of receptivity that is simultaneously both cognitive and affective. For example, as pointed out above, racial insensitivity may involve the failure to see the social *relevance* of race in one's interactions, and this failure is not simply a cognitive deficit, but an affective failure: it involves the inability to *feel* concerned and to have an entire array of *emotions* such as empathy, sympathy, compassion, and so on. This is why those who do not see the social relevance of the racial aspects of social experience often charge those who do as being *oversensitive*, as having a thin skin or feeling too much when racial elements are present in social interactions. And note that the disagreement is often not just about what is there to see, but rather, about what the appropriate way to feel about what one sees is; that is, it is not just a disagreement about beliefs, but a disagreement about feelings and emotions. Color-blindness involves being *affectively numbed* to the racial aspects of social experience. There are of course very different kinds of affective numbness that may be involved in racial insensitivity. For example, a

distinctive kind of affective numbness underlying racial insensitivity may consist in feeling *indifference and apathy* as a result of a cultivated lack of interest in the members of a social group and their predicament. A very different kind of affective numbness, however, would be to feel concerned by the situation of a group and by the racial injustices endured by their members, and yet not know how to talk about it and how to react to it. The latter I would call being *affectively blocked*, that is, unable to integrate in one's life what one starts to see and feel as relevant (which is characteristic of subjects who begin to become sensitive to a social injustice without at the same time having resources to come to terms with it and to make their relation to it intelligible and manageable).

How does the cognitive and affective meta-numbness involved in color-blindness relate to issues of agency and responsibility concerning racial oppression? We can understand the contemporary ideology of color-blindness as a social orchestration that enables and encourages subjects to be in denial about racial differences as significant human differences and about their own positionality and relationality in a social network permeated by relations of racial oppression. Rendering these relations invisible makes it impossible for color-blind subjects to take responsibility for them. In her classic paper on feminism and racism, Adrienne Rich (1979) already pointed out that color-blindness is an ideology that protects racial privilege because it works to conceal the partiality of the white world and how the world is perceived from the privileged standpoint of white subjects. Rich uses the concept of "white solipsism"[9] to describe the perceptual standpoint that assumes a white perspective as universal; and she refers to the ideology of color-blindness as the protective mechanism that makes that privileging of perspective go unnoticed. In their analyses of color-blindness, Benita Berry (1995) and Patricia Williams (1997) have also emphasized that color-blindness often functions as an ideological cover-up strategy that deflects issues of responsibility: color-blindness "reduces socially significant human differences to invisibleness and meaningless hype whereby one does not have to acknowledge what one does not see" (Berry: 1995, p. 46); "the very notion of blindness about color constitutes an ideological confusion at best, and denial at its very worst." (Williams: 1997, p. 4) More recently, Linda Alcoff (2006) and Shannon Sullivan (2006) have also analyzed color-blindness in a similar way. Sullivan describes the contemporary ideology of color-blindness as "one of the hiding places of the terror of whiteness" (p. 127). "White people often are strongly invested in not knowing much about whiteness" (p. 128). And although the habit of ignoring race is typically presented as "a graceful, even generous, liberal gesture," this form of socially orchestrated ignorance, far from being innocent, actually operates "as

[9] In a similar vein but with respect to sexual blindness, Rae Langton (2009) has coined the expression "sexual solipsism," linking the objectification of women to a heterosexist gaze that is incapable of fully acknowledging another subjectivity with its own desires, feeling, emotions, and interests.

a shield that protects a person from realizing her complicity in an oppressive situation" (Ibid.).

Following Berry and Williams, Alcoff (2006) has explained the phenomenon of color-blindness as motivated by "a (white) anxiety about seeing race" (p. 200). She tells us that in her experience, growing up in the post–civil rights South, "color blindness was regularly claimed by white folks and regularly repudiated by folks of color": "There seemed to be an anxiety about the perception of race on the part of some whites, a fear of acknowledging that one sees it" (p. 199). These observations about color-blindness fit in well with my analysis of other-regarding attitudes and meta-attitudes that produce blindness, for color-blindness can be understood as a socially cultivated meta-attitude through which a particular group tries to monitor and control what they see and are willing to acknowledge as relevant and significant. The meta-attitude of color-blindness identifies the perceptual judgments that have to be disavowed, and the interpretations and valuations that have to be blocked and jettisoned, because we cannot find a place for them in the life we want to picture for ourselves—a life without race. One may think that this chosen and self-induced blindness cannot possibly involve meta-blindness, but rather, meta-lucidity, for one must recognize the chosen limitations of one's social gaze in order to cultivate it and to train one's eyes to the imposed blinders. However, although there is an important amount of self-awareness about racial seeing in color-blind ideologies, these ideologies remain blind about the relevance and significance of racial differences, and they rest on a meta-ignorance about the presuppositions and implications of one's cognitive and affective attitudes with respect to color differences and racial differences. General distorting attitudes that remain blind spots in these ideologies are (1) the reduction of race to color (and racial differences to color differences); and (2) the delusions about people's abilities to abstract from color differences and to achieve social perceptions "without color." Color-blindness, even when self-consciously cultivated, can qualify as *meta-ignorance* or *meta-blindness* when and because color-blind subjects do not fully know what they don't know, that is, the implications of their racial ignorance, the presuppositions and consequences of ignoring the social realities of race. This meta-blindness makes the color-blind subject cognitively and affectively ill-equipped to confront the contours of their ignorance at the object level, that is, unable to interrogate what is involved in ignoring race. In other words, the meta-attitudes that often accompany the ideology of color-blindness often instill in people a *meta-numbness* or *meta-insensitivity*: under the influence of this ideology, people run the risk of becoming numbed or insensitive to their racial insensitivity—to what this insensitivity means for the social locations they occupy and the social lives they lead.

Applying the analysis of the other-regarding meta-attitudes that produce blindness developed in the previous chapter, the self-induced blindness of the

color-blind subject can be understood as a *double blindness*: blindness to differences and to social relationality. Repairing the damage that the internalization of the color-blindness ideology produces in people's cognitive-affective structures would require, therefore, repairing their meta-blindness with respect to the visibility and significance of racial features and racial relations; or, to put it in the positive, it would require achieving meta-lucidity with respect to the forms of human diversity and human relationality that race has produced. In other words, the key is to figure out how to open people's eyes to racial differences as significant human differences, and how to make racial features and relations relevant to their life. In my view, this task can be segmented into two phases or subtasks: a *diagnostic phase*, in which we gain positive and negative insights about our cognitive-affective functioning when it comes to the judgments of racial perceptions and the judgments of the significance and relevance of race; and a *reconstructive phase*, in which we pursue interventions and transformations aimed at instilling new attitudes and habits that can meliorate our cognitive-affective functioning in these matters. The diagnostic phase has as its primary goal a kind of self-mastery or getting to know ourselves better: becoming aware of the habits and practices that inform and sustain our perceptions, judgments, and cognitive-affective attitudes; whereas the reconstructive phase has as its primary goal the reconstitution of personal and social structures: the rearrangement of interpersonal relations, social conditions, and social contexts in and through which new habits and practices can develop so that our perceptions, judgments, and cognitive-affective attitudes can eventually acquire a different shape—that is, through the engineering of deep personal and social transformations that can lead to cognitive-affective melioration.

In *Visible Identities*, Alcoff offers a phenomenological account of the perceptual practices that make race (or processes of racialization) visible or invisible, which can go a long way in the diagnostic phase of repairing racial blindness. Alcoff argues that the reduction of racism and the melioration of racial relations require becoming reflectively and critically aware of our perceptual habits and practices concerning race. As she puts it, in our fight against racism, "our first task . . . is *to make visible the practices of visibility itself*" (2006, p. 194). To put it in the terms of my analysis here, the fight for racial justice requires a kind of meta-lucidity, that is, lucidity with respect to racial seeing. It is in this sense that Alcoff undertakes the task of making practices and habits of racial seeing visible. In order to "unlearn racial seeing," racial seeing must first be acknowledged and carefully investigated. The first task is, therefore, to unmask the invisibility of racial constructions and of whiteness in particular. Alcoff argues that visibility is the primary field of operation of racial constructions: "Because race works through the domain of the visible, the experience of race is predicated first and foremost on the perception of race" (p. 187). But, at the same time, racial constructions—and especially privileged ones—while

inscribed in the very structure of perception, typically escape conscious perception and remain imperceptible. Alcoff describes this phenomenon in Foucaultian terms: "Visibility is a trap" (p. 191); what is rendered permanently visible—that which is inscribed on the body itself, "the flesh of the visible" (Ibid.)—is in an important sense rendered invisible: it is constantly being seen and not seen at the same time. What is hidden from view, precisely through perceptual practices, is the process of racialization as such, because "visible difference naturalizes racial meanings" (p. 191). Racial seeing as such is not open to view; the processes of racialization that come to structure our social perceptions are not seen, and yet our perceptual habits and our field of vision cannot escape them. The racial meanings inscribed in the body become part of the underlying structure of our perceptual habits, that is, part of the taken-for-granted background against which our social perceptions take place. As Alcoff puts it, racial seeing

> makes up a part of what appears to me as the natural setting of all my thoughts. It is the field, rather than that which stands out. The perceptual practices involved in racializations are then tacit, almost hidden from view, and thus almost immune from critical reflection. (p. 188)

And this immunity that perceptual processes of racialization acquire through their invisibility and inaccessibility to conscious reflection is a phenomenological feature common to all habitual perceptions: "Our experience of habitual perceptions is so attenuated as to skip the stage of conscious interpretation and intent. Indeed, interpretation is the wrong word here: we are simply perceiving" (p. 188). And what is simply perceived adopts an air of necessity. As Alcoff explains, locating race in the domain of the visible has the phenomenological result of experiencing racial differences as natural and immutable (see especially p. 192).

Alcoff's phenomenological account can explain two things simultaneously: why perceptual processes of racialization "are nearly impossible to discern and why they are resistant to alteration or erasure" (p. 188). At this point, however, this account can make it difficult to see how personal and social change can be possible for those who have been exposed to racialized perceptual practices: "are we not led to pessimism about the possibility of altering the perceptual habits of racialization?" (p. 189). Alcoff finds a source of optimism in the heterogeneity and pluralism of human experiences. She claims that there are "multiple schemas operating in many if not most social spaces," and that this multiplicity can serve to "mitigate against an absolute determinism and thus pessimism" about racial seeing (Ibid.). The plurality of alternative ways of perceiving that can be found even within the most strictly disciplined and constrained field of social perceptions can be exploited to produce changes and effect meliorations that improve social relations. This fits in well with the pluralism and polyphonic contextualism I have defended and with my emphasis on epistemic friction and resistance. As Alcoff puts it,

> Perceptual practices are dynamic even when congealed into habit, and that dynamism can be activated by the existence of multiple forms of the gaze in various cultural productions and by the challenge of contradictory perceptions. To put it simply, people are capable of change. (Ibid.)

Note that Alcoff points to tensions and contradictions in perceptual practices that can be exploited for change; and this is part of what I have described as standpoints exerting *resistance* against each other, thus making themselves noticed, felt, through a kind of *epistemic friction* that is both cognitive and affective. In this case, the epistemic friction to be sought is a perceptual friction that can produce critical awareness of *multiple* ways of seeing and can point in the direction of change. And it is important to note here that the key is to acknowledge the potential multiplicity of perceptual perspectives and not just two possible ones. For, although acknowledging that there is *more than one* perspective is a great step forward in breaking racial solipsism (and the cultural monopoly and hegemony associated with it), the reduction of potentially heterogeneous and multiple perspectives to two opposed and clearly differentiated kinds leads to a dangerous polarization that obscures differences and creates artificial social divisions.

In the contemporary United States, the goal of overcoming the social divisions created by racial oppression calls upon us to resist the black and white binary, which in the American imaginary has reduced multiple and heterogeneous racial perspectives to two polarized and artificially separated racial consciousnesses, conveniently color-coded in two clearly distinct and opposed colors in order to enforce a stark contrast and an aversion to mixing. The black and white binary rests on two crucial interwoven and simultaneous mistakes: the reductive identification of racial consciousness with color consciousness[10]; and the artificial polarization and dichotomization of perspectives. The black and white binary creates a false dichotomy with respect to racial differences: either they are blackened and acquire a negative heightened visibility, or they are whitened and acquire a neutralized invisibility through assimilation or normalization. The cognitive and affective meta-attitudes that operate in these processes of blackening and whitening have to be rejected and replaced with a very different kind of sensibility with respect to racial differences if we want to transcend the false dichotomy between color obsession and color-blindness, and move toward a richer kind of racial consciousness that overcomes the problems of color coding in black and white.

How does the black and white binary contribute to racial insensitivity and meta-blindness? As Franz Fanon (1967) suggested, in the racial imagination of Western cultures, white is the color of the unmarked mainstream subject. In the social perceptions controlled by this racial imagination, people will see in

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[10] For the distinction between "race consciousness" and "color consciousness," see Gutmann (1996).

white and they will imagine themselves and their fellows as white subjects. According to this racial imagination, people are *white by default*, that is, *white until proven colored*, until something calls into question their status as normal subjects within the culture. In this racial imaginary, differences are blackened and can only be perceived negatively, as departures from normalcy. Blackened differences acquire a heightened negative visibility, whereas whiteness goes unnoticed and becomes a blind spot. The presumed whiteness of normal subjects is masked as absence of color. Within this racial imaginary, the attempt to overcome stigmatizing differences becomes the attempt to whiten these differences, that is, to assimilate them to the white mainstream until they are no longer perceived as differences. But notice that this kind of color-blind perception smuggles in whiteness (or *whitening processes*) into the social world under the appearance of the absence of color. Whiteness is thus masked as discoloration or color-neutrality. This kind of color-blindness is part of a racial ideology that privileges the white mainstream and tries to assimilate all other possible embodiments and perspectives (no matter how different) to the mainstream white culture. Within this racial imagination, *a color-blind universe is a white world*.

In order to find alternative ways of racial seeing that can create beneficial epistemic friction, we do not even have to abandon the dominant white world and resort to differently racialized ways of seeing. Epistemic friction can be found even within white perception. Subjects who have internalized white perception can be more or less lucid about their racial structures of social perception; and we can find particularly lucid subjects who have become critics of their racialized standpoint. We can see this in what Alcoff calls the phenomenon of "white anti-whiteness." Alcoff uses Jack Kerouac as an example of someone who was able to develop some degrees of meta-lucidity about white perception, felt a deep discomfort with the white standpoint that he recognized as his own, and became critical with the white world from within. Kerouac wrote, "I wished I was a Negro, a Denver Mexican, or even a Jap, anything but a white man disillusioned by the best in his own 'white' world. (And all my life I had white ambitions!)" (1998, p. 56). Kerouac feels disillusioned with the values and aspirations of his own white culture and, as Alcoff explains, "out of this disillusionment he senses the arbitrariness of his dominant status, which makes it impossible for him to rest easy with it or relax in it. And thus he longs to escape it" (p. 186). But, as Alcoff points out, even in his non-white sensibility, Kerouac "operates from within a white schema of signification (a paradox that can also beset nonwhite bodies)" (Ibid.). In Kerouac's experiential accounts of racialized spaces and of lived racial meanings and identities, Alcoff sees the testimony of a discrepancy or disequilibrium between first-person experiences and an internalized historico-racial schema (which produces what Fanon called "a corporeal malediction"). Alcoff claims that this disequilibrium is becoming more common and typical of white subjects who feel trapped and dissatisfied with the standpoint of a hitherto uncontested racial seeing:

> I would suggest that today, more and more whites are experiencing a similar disequilibrium, as they come to perceive the racial parameters that structure whiteness differently in different communities—white and nonwhite—and may find that none of these can be made coherent with their own preferred body or postural image. (Alcoff: 2006, p. 187)

Given the new social and cultural conditions of today, it is increasingly hard for whiteness to remain invisible. Whiteness has been revealed, unmasked. And this revelation or unmasking is painful; it produces discomfort for privileged racial identities, which were previously unnoticed and typically felt unproblematic. Critical white voices now come to join the critical voices of racially oppressed subjects. The dominant white gaze has come under attack by anti-white whiteness. Many subjects who were recruited to arrogant white perception in subtle ways during their upbringing and early socialization find many opportunities throughout their lives to grow uncomfortable with this racial way of seeing and to develop a critical distance with it. More and more subjects find it difficult to occupy and live privileged positions within a racialized world without hesitation and lack of comfort. More and more subjects find it difficult to inhabit the white gaze as a matter of course—no questions asked, no worry felt. Farewell to an invisible and uninterrogated white common sense. The white gaze—the dominant way of racial seeing in mainstream culture—has been rendered visible and has been challenged from all angles, including by whites themselves. Yet, as Alcoff goes on to argue, we have to keep in mind that the very interesting and productive phenomenon of white anti-whiteness is full of dangers and mystifications, with the possibility of self-delusion and overestimating one's powers to overcome racial perceptual practices and to become disloyal to one's race. Alcoff analyzes two versions of white anti-whiteness, which—although they are commendable, because they contain insights that many white subjects remain blind to—nonetheless fail to produce a sufficiently critical awareness of white identity that can take responsibility for racial oppression in a productive way. I would say that what we have in these instances is *white consciousness without racial lucidity*, that is, we have ways in which white people become self-conscious about their racial identity but insufficiently lucid about how deep this identity goes and about its multifaceted complicity with relations of oppression. In these instances of white anti-whiteness, the *reconstructive* phase cannot even begin because the *diagnostic* phase has not been completed: in other words, the reconstitution of one's racial identity (one's racial attitudes, cognitive-affective structures, habits, etc.) becomes practically impossible when one does not yet have an adequate understanding of one's racial identity and the network of relations in which this identity is inscribed.

One such form of white awareness without sufficient racial lucidity that Alcoff analyzes is the one developed by Judith Katz in the 1978 book *White*

Awareness: Handbook for Anti-Racist Training. According to Alcoff, Katz offers a psychologistic account of racism devoid of social or historical content and without much attention to its structural underpinnings: "Katz makes no reference to exploitation or the need for a redistribution of resources, and instead treats racism as a psychological pathology that can be solved through behavior modification" (pp. 211–12). Carefully avoiding self-indulgent white guilt fixations, the focus of Katz's approach is the psychological destructiveness of racism for white identity: "She holds that racism causes whites to suffer; it cripples their intellectual and psychological development and locks them 'in a psychological prison that victimizes and oppresses them every day of their lives'" (p. 211). For Katz, the only hope for a healthy white subjectivity that can retain "self-trust" and "self-love" is the repudiation of racism, the cultivation of a robust antiracist attitude that denounces the unfair privileges and supremacist ambitions on which whiteness has been constructed. As Alcoff notes, in Katz's account whiteness acquires a purely negative meaning and, "unlike ethnic identities, it has no other substantive cultural content" (p. 212). And although Katz recognizes that it is important for white people to "develop a sense of positive identification with their whiteness," as Alcoff argues, Katz's "book provides no help in determining what the positive aspects [of whiteness] might be" (Ibid.). Although this form of white awareness can certainly open people's eyes to the significance of racial differences, this significance becomes purely psychological and mainly negative, and this is shortsighted. Those who successfully complete the behavioral therapy recommended by Katz may become psychologically lucid about race while at the same time remaining quite blind about the social, historical, and structural significance and relevance of racial differences in their life. They may acquire important degrees of psychological lucidity because the self-centered therapy may enable them to understand aspects of their psyche that they did not understand before—in particular, they may learn how racism and unfair racial relations have contributed to impoverish their affective lives, even if they do not learn how they can become enriched. But these subjects remain ill-equipped after the therapy to understand the social, historical, and structural aspects of their positionality and relationality in a racialized world.

The second form of white anti-whiteness that Alcoff analyzes and finds wanting is that of the web journal *Race Traitor: A Journal of the New Abolitionism*. As Alcoff describes it, the *Race Traitor* web forum was

> a space where radical whites [could] share and spread ideas, get feedback and criticism from people of color, and help to educate themselves and their readers on the "true" history of the Civil War and the neglected legacy of white resistance to racism. (p. 213)

Unlike Katz's white anti-whiteness, these traitors to whiteness have an explicitly sociohistorical and structural approach to racial identities and racial

relations. The contributions to the journal tended to be critical analyses of current social phenomena with a special emphasis on class issues. As Alcoff puts it, the central target of critique of this movement is white supremacy, as "an ideology used by the wealthy and powerful to fool the white poor into being more race-loyal than class-loyal, blinding them to their own interests" (Ibid.); but, with its working-class political perspective on whiteness, "the journal tends toward class reductionism that sidelines other kinds of struggles and homogenizes class interests" (Ibid.). As Alcoff points out, intersectionality is an important blind spot of *Race Traitor*, which pays insufficient attention to the multifaceted aspects of oppression, how race intersects with gender and sexuality, and how feminists and queer activists can be important allies in the fight against racism. Another important limitation that springs from the class reductionism of *Race Traitor* and curtails the lucidity that its racial education can provide, is that racial identities and relations have only a sociohistorical and structural significance and lack psychological depth. *Race Traitor* bloggers can certainly not be accused of being blind to the significance and relevance of race, and yet they can be quite myopic about the psychological impact that racial relations and practices have in their lives.

It is far from clear that *Race Traitor* bloggers developed any appreciation for the immediate psychological relevance of their racialized social environment for their deep cognitive-affective structures and habits. As Alcoff puts it, the journal has "the tendency to emphasize that most whites have not committed racist violence" and "to promote a disassociation or disidentification between whites (especially the working class) and racist institutions" (pp. 215–6). This obscures how internalized racist attitudes can haunt us despite our best intentions, and it plays in the hands of the insidiousness of our complicity with racist practices and institutions, which can take many forms.

Symptomatic of the psychological and cultural naïveté of *Race Traitor* was its calls for the abolition of the white race. Alcoff does not doubt the significance (even expediency) that betraying the social and cultural expectations of whiteness can have. Indeed, "in the civil rights movement, white individuals refused white solidarity over Jim Crow and sat in at lunch counters with African Americans, rode in the back of buses, and marched in open opposition to their communities" (p. 215). But she argues that, outside the context of particular social and political movements (which tend to be well-scripted), acts of white treason are less predictable and can have harmful unintended effects. For Alcoff, the most obvious problem with the proposed abolition of the white race is "that whites cannot completely disavow whiteness or distance themselves from their white identity." (Ibid.) Alcoff considers the act of white treason discussed by one of the contributors to *Race Traitor*, Edward H. Peeples: at a Richmond newsstand in 1976 he was told by the white cashier "You don't want this newspaper; it's the colored newspaper," to which he replied "You

must think I'm white," leaving the cashier furious and at a loss about what to do with this "white Judas" (Ibid.). Alcoff does not doubt that acts of "white treason" such as this one can have critical significance, but she warns us that we should not overinflate what they achieve and that we should keep in mind that "such acts cannot completely eliminate the operation of white privilege, and the subsequent treatment of the 'white Judas' will be affected by both his whiteness and his treason" (Ibid.). Since any single action undertaken by a white person with the goal of undermining white privilege leaves such privilege largely in place, it would be naïve for the white subject to feel, on the basis of such action alone, "entitled to disengage with whiteness without feeling any kind of responsibility for white racist atrocities of the past" (Ibid.). So *Race Traitor* was ultimately inadequate for the task of producing the kind of racial lucidity for white subjectivities that would allow them to take responsibility for racial injustices and to contribute to the melioration of racial relations.

What is needed is a way of bringing together the psychological and the sociohistorical and structural, offering subjects the kind of lucidity that can help them to understand the racialized standpoints they have inherited and at the same time can guide them in their attempts at reconstituting their racial identities. So here we need to turn to *the reconstructive phase* of repairing racial blindness: we need to explore ways in which subjects can reconstruct their perspectives and learn to inhabit them in new ways, so that they can reconstitute their positionality and relationality in a racialized social environment. As Alcoff suggests, "only the creation of new structures of identity formation" (p. 216) can meet the challenge of offering genuine racial liberation for white subjects, so that they can take responsibility for the structural racism that has informed their privileged standpoint and at the same time overcome complicity with ongoing racist practices. But developing a positive sense of identity while taking responsibility for racial oppression is not easy for white subjects, for the recognition of responsibility can be shattering. As Alcoff puts it, "whites' moral culpability . . . threatens their ability to imagine themselves as having a socially coherent relation to a past toward which anyone could feel a positive attachment" (p. 217). What is needed is a *transformative but not shattering lucidity* that enables subjects to see how their whiteness has been constructed socially and historically vis-à-vis other identities, and at the same time a lucidity that points in the direction of *new ways of inhabiting that identity*. This requires a *context-sensitive approach* that examines racial attitudes and habits as they operate in the particular context in question, and an approach that is both sociohistorically and psychologically sensitive, carefully tracing the genesis of racial standpoints and offering an array of possibilities for how they can be phenomenologically experienced by different individuals. Alcoff finds an example of a fairly successful localized attempt at coming to terms with a racist past and offering paths for the rearticulation of racialized (and, in particular, white) subjectivities in Michael L. Harrington's *Traditions and Changes: The*

University of Mississippi in Principle and in Practice. This is a textbook that Harrington developed to use it in his University Studies 101 class at the University of Mississippi. Without shying away from providing a complete account of Ole Miss's racist past, Harrington offers the students a way of positioning themselves in resistance to that past and as part of a sustained effort to create an antiracist university identity and to locate racial solidarity at the center of university life. Harrington does this through a critical and revisionary approach to U.S. Southern history and American history, arguing that U.S. cultural and political traditions have a dual character, containing both ways of institutionalizing oppression and inequality and ways of appreciating freedom and equality and trying to achieve them for all.

Emphasizing and exploiting the dualities, tensions, and contradictions that can be found in one's heritage, Harrington's book gives students the sense that they can learn and draw from the unfinished projects of the past, while at the same time warning them about the negative things that have also become part of their culture, of their traditions, and even of themselves, which need correction and melioration. With respect to race, the book urges Mississippians to acknowledge racism and to work together to fight it, developing racial solidarity so that black and white Mississippians can support each other and advance common goals. Through critical, open, and democratic reflection, Harrington's book and course aim at recruiting students to the task of transforming their university, their community, and themselves. Although acknowledging its important limitation (e.g., no class analysis or discussion of reparations or redistribution of resources), Alcoff finds here a good illustration of what a local attempt to fight racial blindness and to instill a transformative lucidity with respect to racial identities and positionalities can look like. And given Ole Miss's white past and its overwhelmingly white student population, Alcoff appreciates in particular what Harrington's book and curricular efforts can do for the reconstruction of whiteness and the reconstitution of white identity:

> I found *Traditions and Changes* to provide a helpful model for acknowledging white complicity in racism and the need to repudiate key aspects of white identity within an overall project that seeks to develop a collective transformation toward a nonracist white identity. (p. 221)

Following on the steps of Harrington's emphasis on the dualities and tensions of American (and, in particular, white American) culture and history, Alcoff emphasizes the importance of developing a bifurcated white standpoint that articulates and exercises this dual approach in relation to its cultural past, present, and future. It is interesting to note that this bifurcation of white consciousness is very different from the one that generated the double consciousness of black people for Du Bois and Fanon: it is a double attitude with respect to oneself, a dual perspective on what is recognized as one's own (one's cultural past, present, and future), which need not involve the internalization of the

perspective of racial others or even be occasioned by interactions with these non-white others. Alcoff uses the expression *white double consciousness* "to name [the] two-sided sense of the past and the future" that "white identity needs to develop" (p. 222). As Alcoff herself recognizes, this notion of a white double consciousness does "not involve the move between white and black subjectivities or black and American perspectives, as Du Bois and Fanon developed the notion" (p. 223).[11] But this kind of "double consciousness" achieved without epistemic friction in actual encounters with others will not be sufficient and it will remain quite shallow: As the Imperative of Epistemic Interaction emphasizes, a rich epistemic life requires experiencing resistance from significantly different perspectives in social interaction.

I want to go beyond Alcoff's account of white double consciousness in two ways. In the first place, following my Imperative of Epistemic Interaction and drawing on Shannon Sullivan (2006), I want to argue for a notion of white double consciousness produced through epistemic friction in actual bodily encounters with differently racialized others. In the second place, I also want to argue for a multiplicitous or *kaleidoscopic* consciousness—rather than a *double* consciousness—that includes the multiplicity of perspectives required for genuine open-mindedness and for avoiding the arrogant perception that keeps excluding even when it pretends to acknowledge (a colonizing gaze that conquers the perspectives of others, rather than being transformed by them). A good starting point for these extensions of Alcoff's account is Sullivan's phenomenological and pragmatist account of the racialized habits of whiteness in *Revealing Whiteness* (2006). This account goes along well with Alcoff's anti-intellectualist, embodied, and practical approach that claims that "rational arguments against racism will not be sufficient to make a progressive move," and that we need to address the deep "psychic process of identity formation" (p. 221).

Sullivan offers a situated account of embodied racial habits that is both psychological and sociohistorical, and points in the direction of a double or multiple consciousness for white subjects in a Du Boisian and Fanonian sense. As Sullivan's account makes clear, the kind of racial self-consciousness required by white double consciousness will be different from the racial awareness of black double consciousness in crucial respects, but both forms of double consciousness must coincide in the following: they require a kind of shattering of a bodily schema produced by the internalization of the gaze of differently racialized others toward oneself, which can only happen in *actual bodily encounters with racial others* that disrupt the normal operation of one's racialized transactional habits and produces a vivid racial awareness, a new way of seeing oneself.

[11] "Instead," she goes on to argue, "for whites, double consciousness requires an ever-present acknowledgement of the historical legacy of white identity constructions in the persistent structures of inequality and exploitation, as well as a newly awakened memory of the many white traitors to white privilege who have struggled to contribute to the building of an inclusive human community." (Ibid.)

Racial awareness of this sort involves seeing yourself as others see you, as racialized in a particular way different from them, making you self-aware of that difference in your bodily transactions with them. In her elucidations of Fanon's account, Sullivan makes clear that it is not sufficient to have tensions or dualities within one's psyche in order to have double consciousness; you need specific events, *lived disruptions*, that trigger the fracturing of one's subjectivity, the "zebra-striping of the mind," as Fanon calls it (1967, p. 63).

Sullivan recounts some personal experiences in which her psychosomatic racial habits were disrupted and a new kind of racial consciousness started to emerge. Even in apparently simple experiences such as a middle-class white person's evening ride on the bus with black workers returning home, the subject can experience an uncomfortable and heightened consciousness about how she might be perceived by others as a differently racialized subject. She might internalize the gaze of these others and look at herself through their eyes, as an object in their world. As Sullivan puts it, what occurs in cases like this is "the shattering of a white person's 'normal' bodily schema into a racial epidermal schema: I became white, not neutral, and my whiteness interfered with the smooth, non-reflective living of my body" (p. 117). Sullivan emphasizes that experiences of racialization do not disrupt bodily schemas in the same way for those perceived as white and privileged and for those perceived as colored and underprivileged:

> While [the experience] transformed my body into an object to manipulate, the historico-racial valuing of whiteness as good and blackness as evil was not disturbed. . . . Even my disrupted bodily schema retained its white privilege. While unsure of how to live my body, I was never reduced to a subperson who faded into non-existence. (Ibid.)

Although there is no "zebra-striping" of the white mind strictly speaking, white consciousness can nonetheless be pluralized; that is, it can acquire inner diversity through disruptions that force it to take the perspectives of differently racialized others toward itself. And the more a white subjectivity is pluralized—that is, the more it internalizes the gazes of racial others and learns to see itself as a perceptual object for them—the more lucidity it can achieve about its positionality and relationality with respect to racial differences. There are many differently racialized others; we can be the object of perception of many different standpoints and gazes. It is highly distorting to dichotomize the social gazes available into two: the mainstream gaze, or the gaze of privilege, or the white perspective, on the one hand; and the marginalized, out of the mainstream, or colored perspective, on the other. Within each side of this polarization we find distinctive groups, experiences, and perspectives. If we take this social pluralism seriously, we need a more expansive lucidity about our positionality and relationality with respect to racial differences: we need not only a double consciousness, but a *multiplicitous* or *kaleidoscopic consciousness* that

does not reinscribe the black-and-white binary in one's racial imagination. To this aspect of racial lucidity I now turn.

We need to move toward a kaleidoscopic (rather than merely dual) perspective on racialized identities. As argued above, what is needed is a *kaleidoscopic consciousness* that remains forever open to being expanded, that is, a subjectivity that is always open to acknowledge and engage new perspectives. The expansion of one's social sensibilities—and with it also the pluralization of one's racial consciousness—is an ongoing task that does not have an end. And it is a task that individuals cannot fully carry out all by themselves. Such a task requires sustained interactions with significantly different individuals and groups (interactions that provide disruptions and diverse forms of epistemic friction). This is what the Imperative of Epistemic Interaction of my polyphonic contextualism tries to capture. In order to expand their social sensibilities and overcome their blindness and numbness, individuals need the sustained support of other particular individuals with whom they can interact, the support of networks of individuals of which they can be a part, and of social movements that can create the conditions for deep transformations and the restructuration of cognitive-affective attitudes. The epistemic friction produced by the interaction of heterogeneous standpoints can yield a critical awareness of multiple ways of perceiving and can point in the direction of change, of the melioration of our perceptual attitudes and habits. But note also that—as Alcoff emphasizes—change is not easy, and it takes more than merely becoming aware of one's blind spots by experiencing tensions and contradictions. Lucidity with respect to one's blindness or insensitivity is a *prerequisite* for genuine change and cognitive improvement, a necessary but not a sufficient condition. What else is needed for overcoming racial blindness and defective habits of arrogant seeing? Retraining one's sight and widening one's vision; that is, developing *new habits* of racial perception and gender perception. It is crucial to note that this reconstructive task of repairing blindness and expanding social sensibilities starts with *friction*, the kind of friction that can be both disruptive and reenergizing: a friction that can disrupt established habits (e.g., racist or sexist habits), but can also constitute the starting point of new chains of performance where new social habits get consolidated. In the next section I will argue that although deep transformations of social sensibilities require friction produced by acts of resistance, this kind of insurrectionary resistance is the complex and laborious work not only of individuals but also of social networks and of social movements: It is in social networks and movements that individual acts of resistance are *echoed* in performative chains of insurrection that can have far-reaching consequences. In the final chapter I will elaborate on my elucidation of the transformative task of expanding social sensibilities by focusing on resistant imaginations. As I will argue, the task of expanding our social sensibilities and attaining a kaleidoscopic social consciousness requires the continued critical interrogation of the collective imagination from multiple perspectives, from

the resistant imaginings articulated by heterogeneous social networks and movements.

5.3. Echoing: Chained Action, "Epistemic Heroes," and Social Networks

In some contexts it may appear that it takes exceptional individuals and communities with exceptional qualities to overcome the collective blindness in question and to develop a hitherto unknown kind of lucidity. I will call these exceptional individuals and groups *epistemic heroes*. I will not call into question that there are indeed individuals who display out-of-the-ordinary qualities and virtues (such as courage), and that we owe them a great deal for their work toward epistemic justice. But I will argue that these *epistemic heroes* are neither necessary nor sufficient for the social and cultural changes required for achieving greater degrees of epistemic justice. These deep changes in the dynamics of social recognition and epistemic interaction can only be produced by the *chained actions* of individuals and groups, which I understand as the interconnected and mutually influencing actions that become chained in social networks and sometimes in social movements (with different degrees of explicitness, self-awareness, and organization). When acts of resistance are not simply isolated instances without repercussions, but they become the chained actions of individuals and groups linked through social networks, these acts of resistance become *echoable*, that is, they acquire a repeatable significance and, therefore, they are memorable, imitable, and have the potential to lead to social change. In some cases, the echoing of acts of resistance can be so self-conscious and widespread that it can consist in what is typically called *collective action*, that is, the deliberate coordinated action of all (or most) members of a collective, or the action of some executive branch that acts on behalf of the collective. So, for example, the acts of mourning that took place in the United States after 9/11 can be said to constitute not only chained, but *collective* action in either of those two senses: entire collectivities acted or reacted to the event at unison in vigils and remembrance acts of various sorts; but there were also specific actions that the US government or its representatives produced on behalf of the entire nation. But, on the other hand, in other cases, chained acts of resistance can consist simply in the spontaneous actions of a small cluster of individuals which, after repetition, coalesce in such a way that they become a *traceable performative chain*, with each action in the chain having traceable effects in the subsequent actions of others.

Chained actions are actions that echo or resonate with one another, actions that overlap and share a conceptual space or a joint significance, actions that can be aligned and have a (more or less) clear trajectory. When the performative chains become big enough and their trajectories explicit enough,

chained actions lead to the formation of more or less organized groups or social movements, such as the women's movement or the civil rights movement. But I want to emphasize from the beginning that while social groups and movements require the chained actions of individuals for their existence and operation, individuals can engage in chained actions prior to and independently of the existence of an already formed social group or movement. When actions become chained, the agents who produce them automatically become members of a *social network*, even if they are unaware of that membership, that is, even if they are unaware that their action contributes to a particular performative chain through which they become linked to others. In this sense, there is an important distinction between a social network and an organized social group or movement: the former can be implicit, unconscious, spontaneous; but the latter has to be at least minimally explicit, self-conscious, and deliberate. At the level of language and communication, a social network becomes an organized social group or movement—*a public*, Dewey would say—when and because its members engage in communication with one another and make their problems, interests, and goals explicit, developing their own discursive resources and distinctive ways of talking about themselves and their experiences.

Social networks constitute a hybrid category in between that of individual actors and that of well-defined social collectivities. Similarly, I introduce the notion of chained action as a hybrid, middle ground between the notions of individual and collective action. For chained action is an action with individual elements, the significance of which can only be properly understood within a chain of actions, being thus crucially dependent on the actions of others, indefinitely many others, but always particular others and not (at least not necessarily) entire collectives or social groups. These chained actions can have narrower or wider social impact depending on the nature and scope of the perfomative chains in which they are inscribed. The measure of the efficacy of chained actions is how they reverberate in the subsequent actions of others; and these reverberations consist in performative reactions, that is, ways in which the chain of actions is taken up by the acts of others. So, when it comes to chained actions, the issue of *uptake* is key. In the assessment of a particular cluster of chained actions, we must always ask: What are the reactions that it provokes? What are the social networks in which this cluster of actions is taken up? What are the performative chains in which the cluster reverberates?

The hybrid notion of chained action can help us get out of impasses and false dichotomies produced by polarized views of agency—purely individualistic or purely collectivistic views. In particular I am concerned here with the a false dichotomy concerning *responsibility*, namely, that our responsibility can only be discharged in one of two ways: through individual action understood as the action of each isolated individual independently of what everyone else does; or through the collective action of all, understood either as the coordinated action

of all the members of a collective acting at unison or as the action of the executive branch of a group on behalf of the entire group. But of course both options are quite inadequate for addressing issues of shared responsibility such as the ones we face in widespread epistemic injustices (such as the ones relating to insensitivity, social silences, hermeneutical lacunas, or collective bodies of ignorance, discussed above). On the one hand, isolated individual actions are typically ineffective, and this level of response misses the depth of the problem. On the other hand, the collective action of the entire social body is typically not feasible or realistic, especially as a starting point when we begin to address an injustice. My notion of chained action derives from the social connection model of responsibility defended in chapter 4; and it tries to make explicit the distinctive way in which shared responsibilities are to be discharged. As Iris M. Young (2006) emphasizes, structural injustices call for collective responses and not merely individual ones; they demand that we assume shared responsibility and that we act together: this shared, "forward-looking responsibility can be discharged only by joining with others in collective action" (p. 123). But, at the same time, this collective response is also individual, for it involves the particular actions of particular individuals: "The structural processes can be altered only if many actors in diverse social positions work together to intervene in these processes to produce different outcomes" (Ibid.). In the light of this last point, I want to rephrase Young's formulation of the normative demand of shared responsibility as the demand to unite in *chained*—rather than collective—action, in order to emphasize that the actions through which shared responsibilities are discharged are always individual and collective *at the same time*. With this friendly amendment, I want to make room for individuals to start discharging their shared responsibilities and working toward justice *even when* few individuals are yet engaged in anything resembling collective action. Even in that dismal scenario—which is exactly what we find at the beginning of a new struggle toward justice—it is *possible* for individuals to start living up to their responsibilities and displaying some degree of virtue. How else could clusters of individuals pioneer new social struggles and begin resisting complicity and working toward justice? It is a mistake to think that there is nothing individuals can do to discharge their shared responsibilities *until* there is an ongoing collective action to join. Of course isolated acts of particular individuals will not repair structural injustices, but it is important to distinguish clearly between *achieving* justice and *discharging* one's responsibilities. Individuals can start discharging their responsibilities and becoming increasingly more virtuous agents even when they cannot yet change the structural conditions with their acts and, therefore, their activities (perhaps even their entire lives) will fail in achieving (or even bringing us closer to) justice. But these efforts and acts of resistance are *not in vain*, even when they do not stand a chance of bringing about justice: in the first place, resistant acts of this sort break down the complicity of the agents in question and thus result in the melioration of their moral characters; and, in the second place, the way in

which these resistant acts disrupt complicity and challenge complacent attitudes shows a performative move in a different direction, which has the potential to open up new possibilities of action. Perhaps in the long run, and after these gestures are continued in long performative chains, the resistant actions may have made a contribution toward justice after all. The account of resistance in terms of chained actions I am proposing fits in well with what is known as *connected activism* in the contemporary literature.[12] But I want to stress that resistance through social networks and the chained actions of their members has a long history and explains the resistance struggles of intellectuals, leaders, and activists of past centuries; and, therefore, connected activism should not be restricted to social networking as this is understood in the twenty-first century.

According to my particularistic social contextualism, as individuals we need to find a way to start discharging our share of responsibility in the epistemic injustices that permeate our lives (e.g., social silences, hermeneutical lacunas, bodies of ignorance, insensitivity). This discharge may involve all kinds of adjustments and interventions in our daily behavior (from reacting to silences differently, to entering communicative interactions differently, changing our listening and speaking habits, etc.). And of course what we can do has a lot to do with our positionality, our relationality, and the social contexts we inhabit: who we are, where we are, who we are interacting with, in what particular activity and dynamic, and so on. But it is important first of all to recognize that we *all* have (typically plenty of) particular things to do in the work toward justice. It is important not to expect heroes to save us and not to excuse ourselves behind the anonymity of a collectivity. It is important to appreciate the ordinary ways in which people can resist injustices in their daily activities. As discussed above, we have to adjust the epistemic responsibilities we assign to subjects and groups so that we can establish reasonable normative expectations, without demanding heroic behavior but without giving up the obligation to resist epistemic exclusions and injustices. According to my polyphonic contextualism, the strength of resistance resides not in isolated individual agency or in anonymous collective agency, but rather in the interconnected actions of particular individuals in particular contexts. Looking at the chained acts of resistance of particular individuals in social networks can preserve this specificity for us, without our losing sight of the general fights for justice of which they are part. In order to make my particularistic social contextualism perspicuous, I propose to take a critical look at what passes for heroic behavior in the fight against gender and racial oppression in specific social and historical contexts. Through my critical assessment of alleged heroines, I will examine the

[12] I am grateful to Brooke Ackerly for pointing out to me the connection between my view and contemporary forms of global activism, especially "connected activism." For discussions of "connected activism," see especially Allison Fine (2006) and (2007). For a lucid discussion of global feminism that emphasizes the crucial importance of becoming aware of "global connectedness," see Ackerly and Attanasi (2009).

role that the interconnected actions of particular individuals within a social network play in overcoming injustices.

In the next two sections I will discuss the contributions to epistemic resistance that individuals *and* social networks make, highlighting how *individual and collective lucidity* with respect to oppression and epistemic injustices are mutually dependent and mutually supportive. On the one hand, movements of resistance and shared forms of lucidity are often occasioned by—and critically dependent on—the acts of defiance of particular individuals whose epistemic agency can be described as exceptional, even *heroic*. And yet, on the other hand, no single individual (or set of isolated individuals operating autonomously) can be deemed solely responsible for undoing a systemic epistemic injustice and transforming an entire pattern of social perception, for the transformative power of their action depends on their being *echoed* by others, that is, on their being taken up by members of a social network whose collective efforts and actions form a pattern of transformation. In my discussions of insurrectionary acts and positions of resistance in these sections I will focus on the connection between lucidity and one particular epistemic virtue: courage. I will focus on epistemic agents who are courageous in pursuing participation in epistemic practices despite their exclusion, and in persevering in epistemic journeys despite all obstacles. But I will also discuss how courageous forms of political activism involve both individual and collective forms of lucidity, both as its presupposition and as its consequence. I will argue that although courage is indeed a crucial epistemic and political virtue that belongs to individuals, the transformative impact of courage depends on courageous acts being echoed by others and reverberating in a social chain until their effects become consolidated in new habits and attitudes, that is, in the normative restructuring of practices.

The two examples I will use to illustrate acts of resistance that exhibit epistemic and political courage could not be more different. The first one will be Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz: a seventeenth-century intellectual deeply involved in academic debates and exerting epistemic friction as an eccentric figure within an intellectual elite. My second example will be Rosa Parks: a mid-twentieth-century grass-roots activist whose actions became emblematic of the resistance struggles of ordinary working people of color. But, although they could not be more different, these are both iconic figures in social movements of resistance: Sor Juana is one of the earliest and most prominent figures in the history of Latina feminism, and Rosa Parks is one of the most iconic figures in the history of the civil rights movement. Both remarkable women planted the seed of social change as part of ongoing daily practices of resistance. What is common to both, in my interpretation, is that their acts of insurrection (and the lucidity involved in them) linked up with social movements in such a way that their resistance could be *echoed* and could thus reverberate through social networks and practices, even though their deeds are (mis) remembered as isolated and individualized acts of heroism.

5.3.1. Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz: Epistemic Courage, Resistant Imagination, and Epistemic Friction

Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz was the transgressive living proof of the intellectual accomplishments that women in seventeenth-century Mexico could achieve and were denied. For this reason, she became a dangerous figure for the gender norms regulating the production and dissemination of knowledge, and for the authorities that enforced those norms. Sor Juana's amazing intellectual achievements became her downfall: her passion for knowledge brought her prominence in the Hispanic world but also persecution. In response to this persecution as a woman of letters—and more specifically in response to being prohibited to read or write, Sor Juana wrote her "Response to Sor Filotea de la Cruz" defending women's access to and participation in the epistemic practices involved in the production and consumption of knowledge. In what follows I will highlight a few provocative ideas that can be found in this letter and in her epistemological poem "*Primero Sueño*" ("First I Dream"; 1994) where she reflects on the limits of knowledge.

It is interesting that Sor Juana's conduct was considered both intellectually transgressive and also sexually transgressive: she was accused of conducting multiple lesbian affairs with prominent women in Mexico (or New Spain, as it was called at the time). Sor Juana often reflected on the erotics of knowledge. In her writings she often brings together the sensual and the epistemic aspects of interpersonal relations. For Sor Juana, the process of learning is emotionally charged; and one of the emotions required for the acquisition of knowledge is *courage*, the willingness and audacity to test the limits of the world that is given to us, to take risks and question taken-for-granted boundaries. Sor Juana teaches us that knowledge is not an easy matter; it takes courage. Epistemic agents are courageous agents, for knowledge is elusive and we never know where our pursuit of knowledge might take us: perhaps to places we didn't want to go. Knowledge requires courage and perseverance because it is all too easy to quit our epistemic journey, to be dissuaded by the fear of not ever knowing, of trying in vain, of our views becoming more distorted as we advance, and ending up with more—rather than less—ignorance at the end of the journey. In "*Primero Sueño,*" Sor Juana describes this elusiveness of knowledge and the epistemic fears that result from it in the following way:

> Knowledge runs away
> and cowardly our discourse derails
> . . .
> understanding gives us its back,
> and astonished our discourse gets frightened
> . . .

because it fears—cowardly—
understanding badly, or never, or late.[13]

But if everyone needs epistemic courage, there is a special kind of courage that the pursuit of knowledge requires for epistemically marginalized subjects, that is, for those subjects who have been excluded from the epistemic practices involved in the production and consumption of knowledge.

Epistemically marginalized subjects are those who have been deemed not fit for the epistemic journey, just as in the Greek myth Phaëthon was depicted as ill-equipped to control the chariot of the sun and Helios had to resort to violence and kill him to prevent a disaster. Interestingly, Sor Juana alludes to this mythological narrative; and in the context of her letter to Sor Filotea—arguing against the claim that reading and writing were improper for her as a woman—the myth can be read as a fable about epistemic hubris, an allegory that is used to police the access to epistemic practices and to keep women excluded from the production of knowledge. The myth thus becomes a legitimating and threatening epistemological narrative: one that justifies epistemic prohibitions against women and also tries to scare women from any possible transgression. But Sor Juana's use of the narrative is subversive. Perhaps we should note that Phaëthon was *thought* by Helios to be unfit for controlling the forceful and yet delicate device at his disposal. Perhaps the emphasis should be on Helios' *presumption*: perhaps the precipitous character in the story, the one who rushes to judgment and action is not Phaëthon in daring to control the chariot, but rather, Helios in *thinking* that Phaëthon can't do it and in stopping him, a premature destruction (the killing of Phaëthon) dubiously justified by invoking a bigger *imaginary* destruction (the destruction of the world if Phaëthon is not stopped).

More important, as Sor Juana seems to suggest, *everyone*, and not just women (and who is to say who is a woman?),[14] can be Phaëthon. But the

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[13] This is my own English translation. Here is the original Spanish text:

Huye el conocimiento
y cobarde el discurso se desvía
. . .
da las espaldas el entendimiento,
y asombrado el discurso se espeluza
. . .
porque teme—cobarde—
comprenderlo o mal, o nunca, o tarde . . . (p. 118)

[14] As I have argued elsewhere (2008b), both with her actions and with her intellectual production Sor Juana questioned the taken-for-granted gender binary that separates men and women and subversively criticized established gender roles. In Sor Juana's writings and in her own life we find subjects who have to disguise their gender identity in order to become epistemic agents. Sor Juana herself describes how she had to become what I call an *epistemic agent in drag* and pass as a boy: "It came to my attention that in Mexico City there were schools, and a University, in which one studied the sciences. The moment I heard this, I began to plague my mother with insistent and importunate pleas: *she should dress me in a boy's clothing* and send me to Mexico City to live with relatives, to study and be tutored at the University. She would not permit it" (p. 15).

fact that any of us could lose control of the epistemic means available to us does not mean that we should refrain from using them and from trying to exercise epistemic control over them. Despite Sor Juana's constant critique of epistemic arrogance and constant (even excessive) exercises of humility, she argues that we should not get discouraged by the difficulties and dangers involved in the pursuit of knowledge. For, no matter how extreme these difficulties and dangers may be, they make the journey and its achievements all the more valuable; and it is ultimately up to the subjects themselves (regardless of their gender identity or sexuality) to decide whether they are up to the challenge and whether the epistemic risks are worth taking.

No matter how courageous we may be, it is possible that the more we strive to know, the less we understand. This skeptical concern is one of the central themes of Sor Juana's poem "First I Dream." I want to call attention to two different sets of reflections in this epistemological poem: first, reflections on the limited and precarious nature of human knowledge, where the skeptical theme appears; and second, reflections on the imagination and the poetic exploration of unrealized possibilities that go beyond the things we have experienced. It is in this second set of reflections that a renewed hope for human knowledge is articulated. Our experiential perspectives can be broadened with our capacity to imagine, to survey possible worlds in which alternative experiences can be had. This kind of imaginative knowledge has a crucial counterfactual dimension: even if the actual world does not allow certain experiences to be had, their possibility can be used as the basis of an alternative knowledge, an *epistemic counterpoint* to lived experience and knowledge, which is still grounded in real life and embodied experiences.[15] Entertaining epistemic counterpoints makes possible what I have called internal *epistemic friction*, through which the subject can interrogate her own meta-attitudes, that is, her attitudes about cognitive-affective attitudes, thus alleviating not only her ignorance but also her meta-ignorance. This is the critical epistemic role that a *resistant imagination* can play, allowing for increasing degrees of lucidity in our cognitive-affective lives.

For Sor Juana, the imagination is an important source of self-knowledge and of knowledge of possible human realities. It is (at least in part) thanks to this epistemic role of the imagination that Sor Juana can identify important limitations in our cognitive faculties (in reason and in the senses) and in our intellectual activities (in philosophy and in the sciences) without thereby falling into radical skepticism or mysticism (that is, without maintaining that knowledge is impossible or esoteric). We are not bound by the limitations of any single human capacity or of any single intellectual discipline: to confront the limitations of reason and faith, we can resort to the imagination; to the limitations of science and religion, we can offer poetry.

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[15] We can find here an analogue to Maria Lugones's (2003) concept of "*world-travelling*."

Our imaginative explorations can correct and extend our knowledge of the world and our knowledge of ourselves. Sor Juana emphasizes the role of the imagination and of literature (especially poetry) in the articulation of possible experiences and embodied knowledge—gendered, sexualized, and racialized knowledge. We should pay attention to the epistemic importance of dreaming; of imagining; of conceiving of alternative futures, presents, and pasts; of thinking up alternative (counterfactual) possibilities, alternative lives. The imagination can be a valuable source of knowledge, and literature can be a precious domain for explorations in which alternative knowledges can flourish, resisting and challenging each other and making themselves richer and stronger in the process. It is in this sense that a resistant imagination that provokes epistemic friction is an invaluable tool for addressing epistemic problems concerning sexual and racial differences, for it offers possibilities for fighting sexual and racial ignorance and for developing alternative gendered, sexual, and racial epistemic perspectives. I take this suggestion to be one of the key lessons we can learn from Sor Juana's reflections. And it is important to note that the critical epistemic role that the imagination can play in our cognitive-affective lives becomes possible through the epistemic resistance not only of particular individuals, but also of social networks and movements. In other words, the critical and transformative power of a resistant imagination requires both individual and collective efforts.

Sor Juana's critical imaginings had the power they did in rethinking the role of women in the production and reception of culture, because those reimaginings were taken up and echoed by others, and they became part of new cultural narratives in which social identities and positionalities were reimagined. These new, emerging cultural narratives were in the making long before Sor Juana came onto the scene; and their slow and fragmentary construction was achieved by the contributions of many eccentric voices: other Latina women who came before Sor Juana and many others who came after her. These courageous individual voices of resistance have to be acknowledged, but the complex interconnections among them as well as the social presuppositions of their effective critical agency also need to be recognized. The courage to persevere in our epistemic journeys and to speak out for alternative standpoints is certainly a feature of virtuous epistemic agents, of individuals such as Sor Juana who initiate and facilitate epistemic transformations for all of us. But indeed, resisting and subverting cultural gender norms is not something that Sor Juana did all by herself.

On the one hand, Sor Juana developed and employed her critical voice and agency as a member of a religious order—the Carmelites—which made it possible for her to become a woman of letters and to acquire a prominent social and intellectual position. And this order in particular had an internal history of subversion and had accumulated many past acts of resistance, of female voices against the male-dominated ecclesiastical and monarchic institutions.

Besides, Sor Juana was able to cultivate strong connections with the aristocracy and with a network of intellectuals who constituted the intellectual elite of Hispanic culture at the time. Being part of this elite and being under the protection of some of its members enabled Sor Juana to do and to say things that she could have never achieved by herself. On the other hand, the resistance and friction exerted by the critical voice of Sor Juana was *echoed* by many others both during her lifetime and thereafter. To begin with, her contemporaries, both supporters and critics alike, took her seriously and engaged with her writings and positions; and this was indeed a crucial mechanism by which her voice and her writings acquired currency and became a point of reference for future acts of resistance and for other eccentric voices wanting to exert epistemic friction, which in turn slowly eroded the epistemic exclusions and moved the center of gravity of the social imaginary away from uncontested male privilege. Thus the individual words of an eccentric voice such as Sor Juana's become part of interconnected discourses that *echo* each other and become mutually supportive (even if in tension). As I have argued elsewhere (2006a), it is in this way, through this *echoing*, that eccentric voices and discourses become interwoven into emerging cultural narratives, and these narratives offer new ways of imagining that exert epistemic resistance.

But deep epistemic transformations and the correction of epistemic injustices are achieved not only with words and discourses, but with actions and practices—as my Imperative of Epistemic Interaction reminds us. Besides the epistemic friction that alternative narratives and cognitive standpoints can produce, we also need the epistemic friction of insurrectionary acts and contestatory practices (i.e., the epistemic friction of actual interactions in which there is resistance). We need forms of activism that in changing the social standing of subjects can change epistemic attitudes and habits of social perception, for indeed in addressing issues of exclusion and marginalization that distort the social perceptions of a community, we need to resist not only hegemonic ideologies, but also hegemonic sociopolitical structures and institutions that mediate social interactions and sustain the injustices in question. This requires political resistance and deeply transformative forms of activism. To this form of resistance and the epistemic virtues that sustain it, such as courage and lucidity, I now turn.

5.3.2. Rosa Parks: Counter-Performativity, Chained Agency, and Social Networks

There is probably no act of resistance more celebrated than that of Rosa Parks on her bus ride home in a cold December evening in Montgomery, Alabama, in 1955, when she refused to give up her seat so that a white passenger could enjoy the privilege of sitting by himself in a row without a Negro. And it is important to note that segregation practices were such that not only could

white passengers claim a seat taken by a black passenger, but they could also claim the privilege of sitting in a row without any black passenger, even if it was in the black section of the bus. Parks was sitting in the black section toward the rear of the bus when she was asked to move by a white man after the white section had filled up. She famously refused: she was arrested, taken to court and fined, and the rest is history. But what passes as the official history, the commonly heard history, is a suspiciously schematic and naïve picture of social transformation propitiated by the courageous act of an ordinary individual who—we are often encouraged to assume—could have been anyone. Rosa Parks is typically portrayed as an isolated individual actor, and her act of resistance as a spontaneous reaction, the spontaneous reaction of a tired working woman returning home who could simply not take it any more. However, Parks had attempted similar acts of resistance against bus segregation laws and practices before; and she had been trained to do so, coached to act in particular ways to the request of white passengers, bus drivers, and police officers in these attempts at insurrection. She herself (1994) traces the roots of her acts of resistance back to the Underground Railroad. And she was not the only one. She was actually not the first, but the third black woman arrested that year for refusing to uphold bus segregation practices. And yet—not only in pop-culture depictions, but even in textbooks and academic discourses—Parks's actions are described as the random and lucky performance of an isolated subject. This misdescription and the companion misremembering of this iconic act of resistance are philosophically and politically revealing: they reveal individualistic biases of our mainstream culture and our dominant political philosophies, as well as misconceptions about the cognitive-affective conditions and structures required for insurrectionary acts and contestatory practices. These biases and misconceptions make it very hard to see what is required for effective resistance, that is, for producing critically lucid agents capable of actions with genuine transformative potential.

Was Rosa Parks's act of resistance a lucid act? Was it grounded in and motivated by a special kind of lucidity about the racial oppression it was trying to subvert? I will argue that this legendary act of insurrection was informed by lucid social perception; and—I will argue—what infuses this act of resistance with critical force and transformative potential was not only the lucidity of the agent who executed it, but also (and more important) the *lucidity of a social movement*. Rosa Parks's performance was the result of the carefully calculated activities of an insurrectionary consciousness that she shared with other local activists and members of an emerging social movement of resistance. And yet even well-informed feminists on the left without a conservative agenda, such as Judith Butler, have described Parks's performance as the act of defiance of an individual agent. In *Excitable Speech* (1997) Butler uses Parks's infamous act of resistance to criticize the limitations of a purely social account of performativity such as Pierre Bourdieu's, and to develop her own account of *counter-performativity* centered around individual agency.

According to Butler, Bourdieuian subjects are completely engineered by the social systems in which they emerge and operate, and their *habitus*—the set of receptive and productive dispositions that govern their performance—is thoroughly determined by dominant social forces. In this Bourdieuian social framework, according to Butler, there is no space for resistance: it is not possible for agents to act contrary to social expectations and to deviate from the established dominant habitus. For Butler, the problem with the Bourdieuian view of performativity is that it allows for no performance that has not been previously authorized by the dominant social forces. By contrast, Butler wants to make room for a different kind of performativity, *counter-performativity*, which consists of acts that go beyond what subjects have been authorized to do so far. Butler argues that the normativity that governs social performance is never fully determined and established, and it is always open to contestation. She emphasizes that subjects can always deviate from established normative expectations and even act in complete violation of prior authorizations in the attempt to establish new forms of authorization. Emerging alternative forms of social authority can spring from the insurrectionary acts themselves without those acts having yet being independently backed up by any authority or established power, that is, without having yet being authorized by anything other than the agent herself who authors the act.

In her discussion of agency in *Excitable Speech*, Butler sets up Bourdieu as her antagonist in the following way: whereas the Bourdieuian account of the habitus suggests that the performativity of social agents is fully controlled by the social systems that authorize their acts, Butler insists that discursive agency is always *excessive*, for it always exceeds what speaking subjects have been authorized to say and do. As she puts it, "This *excess* is what Bourdieu's account appears to miss, or suppress: the abiding incongruity of the speaking body, the way in which . . . it remains uncontained by any of its acts of speech" (1997, p. 155; my emphasis). For Butler, the Bourdieuian habitus cannot accommodate this excess because it is always retrospective and backward-looking, without being aware of its history and its contingent determinations from the past. And indeed Bourdieu often talks about the social production of the habitus in these terms, describing our embodied habits as the storage of past behavior produced by the process of "incorporation, which exploits the body's readiness to take seriously the performative magic of the social" (1980, p. 161). Through the mechanism of incorporation, the habitus hides its own contingent genesis and forgets its social determinations,[16] projecting the performative possibilities that the social milieu has offered as the only possibilities that can exist, as the exhaustive range of possibilities established by some kind of

[16] For an account of this phenomenon, which I have termed *genesis amnesia*, see my (2003). As I argue there, Wittgenstein also talks about this phenomenon in similar terms in his discussions of learning and social normativity.

(fictional) necessity—a necessity produced by forgetting the contingency of the social order and naturalizing its effects (which is what Bourdieu calls "the performative magic of the social"). Butler, by contrast, emphasizes that there is always a performative excess that escapes this mechanical social production of behavior. And this excessive aspect of performativity is what makes counter-performativity possible: the omnipresent implicit capacity of our performance to go beyond all prior authorizations is, for Butler, what creates possibilities of resistance. Butler uses Rosa Parks's famous act of civil disobedience to illustrate that performativity against the system is always possible. When Rosa Parks refused to give up her seat,

> she had no prior right to do so guaranteed by any of the segregationist conventions of the South. And yet, in laying claim to the right for which she had no prior authorization, *she endowed a certain authority on the act, and began the insurrectionary process of overthrowing those established codes of legitimacy*. (1997, p. 147; my emphasis)

Butler portrays Rosa Parks as a single individual against the system, opting to transgress all authorized boundaries; and, more generally, she describes acts of resistance as individual acts of transgression against the system in which the individual finds herself trapped. Melissa Clarke (2000) has objected that this inadequately prioritizes individual agency over socially constructed agency (i.e., the habitus), arguing that Butler "underestimates the force of the social situation, overemphasizing the ability of subjects to opt for resistant performances" (p. 163). Terry Lovell (2003) develops an entire essay aimed at refuting Butler's claim that Rosa Parks herself "endowed a certain authority on [her] act," arguing that the isolated individual cannot be the sole source of authorization of her acts and that Rosa Parks's act of resistance came to command a very different kind of authority, one that is socially based and is socially effective. As these Bourdieuian feminists have argued, both Butler's reading of Bourdieu and her alternative proposal centered on individual agency are misguided. I will follow these Bourdieuian feminists in order to offer a different picture of counter-performativity, arguing that it is a mistake to pit individual agency against collective agency, because they are interrelated and cannot be understood independently of each other. This is why I propose to focus on the concept of chained action, which is both individual and socially extended at the same time and can help us overcome the polarization and false dichotomy between individual and collective views of agency.

We need to take a closer look at the social conditions of possibility of individual acts of resistance such as that of Rosa Parks. We need to bring to the fore the interrelations between individual insurrectionary acts and ongoing social practices that make those acts possible or at least leave room for them. Indeed Rosa Parks's act of resistance, though clearly a brave act of defiance that disrupted legally binding norms and standard practices, was not an act that

stepped outside all available social practices of the time. Quite the contrary, it was clearly an act that took place at the crossroads of conflicting practices: *practices of oppression*, such as Alabama bus segregation practices, and *practices of resistance*, that is, those emerging patterned activities developed by groups of local activists such as the sit-ins at whites-only lunch counters and the sit-ins at whites-only sections of buses—the latter being one of the practices Rosa Parks contributed to shape, without her act being the first one or even fitting the description of what became the stereotypical act of civil disobedience in segregated public transportation. Both Clarke (2000) and Lovell (2003) reconstruct the social support that Rosa Parks's act received and the socially constructed habitus that went into her courageous performance. Clarke urges us to identify the "points where counter-performativity is possible, or even predictable" (p. 165). How did Parks's resistance become socially feasible and socially efficacious? What social conditions and social processes went into her ability to act so courageously, and into her act's having the social repercussions and transformative effect that it did? As Clarke asks, "How did Parks acquire the habitus that enabled her not to move and give her seat to a white man?" (Ibid.). Clarke gives two very different characterizations of Parks's habitus to feel entitled to her seat and to remain seated, wrongly assuming that both characterizations converge and are fully compatible. Clarke's Bourdieuan account of Rosa Parks's counter-performativity operates at two levels: relating Parks's performance to *habits of privilege*, and relating it to *habits of resistance*. I find the first level of analysis unpersuasive and unnecessary, whereas the second level of analysis is crucial and right on target.

On the one hand, Clarke (2000) argues that Parks's performance could be the expression of a habitus of privilege that moves the agent to feel entitled to what she has and ill-disposed to give it up. However, Parks was a working-class black woman who was not at all likely to have a privileged habitus in which entitlement figured prominently. Although Clarke is certainly right that working-class blacks and upper-class blacks in 1950s Alabama had very different kinds of habitus, her hypothesis that Parks may have developed some sort of hybrid habitus with features characteristic of both social classes is quite artificial. Clarke speculates that, because Parks attended a teacher's college, she may have picked up some of the habits of privilege that upper-class blacks started to exhibit around that time. But this part of her account is highly ad hoc and—worse yet—it rests on a conceptually confused description of Parks's performance. Motivating this part of Clarke's account is the following thought: "Parks would have had to somehow be produced with a habitus that allowed her to be *able to play the game of the privileged*" (p. 166). However, in refusing to give up her seat, Parks was not at all playing "the game of the privileged"; she was playing a very different game, *the game of resistance*: she was not comfortably assuming privilege, she was *resisting* it! And the game of resistance is not at all about holding on to entitlements. It is, rather, about refusing to be subjugated

and about undermining unfairly allocated entitlements or privileges. Very different kinds of dispositions—not simply those of the privileged—are required to pull that off: one's habitus needs to admit the ability to refuse to occupy a position of subordination, which is very different from—almost antithetical to—the predisposition to occupy a position of privilege. The kind of *courage* that resistance requires is not at all the same as the kind of "courage" (if it can receive that name) involved in holding on to privilege when this privilege is in jeopardy: the agent's position in the social field and in the distribution of power across it could not be more different; and the risks and vulnerabilities involved are worlds apart. And also the kind of *social lucidity* involved in resistance is quite different from the one typically involved in privileged social agency: it is not merely a lucidity about one's own entitlements; it is a lucidity about one's social location vis-à-vis that of others, that is, a lucidity about the normative interrelations among differently situated subjects and about the gap between what these subjects are given and what they are owed—in short, a lucidity about social injustice.

The courage that Rosa Parks exhibited in her performance can only be explained in Bourdieuian terms by attributing to her *a habitus of resistance*, and not a habitus of privilege. Fortunately, the latter is also part of Clarke's Bourdieuian account of Parks's counter-performativity. Although she mistakenly attributes to Parks "a habitus of someone accustomed to having privileges" (p. 167), she also correctly attributes to Parks the cultivation of habits of resistance and develops an account of how these habits prefigured Parks's celebrated act of civil disobedience. And there is indeed ample evidence that throughout her life Parks cultivated habits of resistance. Through her personal experiences and her training in activism, Parks became disposed not to conform to established normative expectations in the hope of producing a more just social field, so that what happened that famous December evening of 1955 was not at all a lucky accident or a random, spontaneous act of an isolated individual actor. Clarke summarizes well Parks's history of cultivating habits of resistance in the following passage:

> [Parks's] life showed evidence that she indeed had the habit of acting against the explicit restrictions of the culture. She was 42 when the bus incident occurred, and had spent her lifetime in the resistance movement. She had been escorted off a bus 13 years earlier for entering at the front ("whites only") door. Parks was more than just a member of the NAACP, she was its secretary. She was also the leader of a youth group that was scheduled to attend a major conference just days after her 1955 arrest. . . . The affiliation with the NAACP, and the occurrences of other acts of transgression then can be seen as precisely evidence of Parks's having the set of dispositions that enabled her to transgress the explicit boundaries of the social structure. (p. 167)

So Parks's act of resistance was in fact socially sanctioned and "authorized," "albeit by the growing authority of the insurrectionary groups like the NAACP" (Ibid.) and not yet by mainstream culture. In the light of Clarke's Bourdieuian account, we can see that the sharp dichotomy that Butler sets up between individual and collective agency—between the liberating agency of the resisting individual and the oppressive agency of the social system—does not work. We cannot fully and properly understand the individual acts of Rosa Parks independently of the collective agency of an emerging social movement of resistance. Those acts originated in a socially developed habitus, that is, in the practical dispositions to counter-perform that Parks developed as a member of a social movement of resistance. As Clarke argues, Bourdieu has more theoretical resources to offer to a philosophical account of resistance than Butler gives him credit for: "Bourdieu's notion of habitus provides the conceptual means for understanding the situation of resistance within its social conditions. His work reminds us of the social conditions of the very possibility of resistance" (p. 167).

But what are the central theoretical tools that the Bourdieuian framework has to offer to a social account of resistance and counter-performativity? Two ideas are crucial for such an account. One is Bourdieu's emphasis on the heterogeneity of the social field as always including different social classes, which are themselves, in turn, internally differentiated. The very mechanism of *distinction* that he is famous for is a mechanism for the differentiation of the social field: social classes are formed by distinguishing themselves from each other, and new classes emerge from old ones through distinction. Bourdieu's account of generational conflicts in terms of a social struggle for distinction, for example, shows how the new habitus of a younger generation gets formed through acts of resistance and insurrection directed against the normative expectations of the established habitus of the older generation. Because a social field is always fractured and composed of many groups and subgroups (which are dynamic constructions that keep changing), there are always multiple and diverse social perspectives available, and social actors always have a wide and heterogeneous range of options available to them. As Clarke puts it, "The range of options is much wider than those explicitly sanctioned by the dominant class" (p. 167). Possibilities of resistance arise because of the heterogeneity of the social field and its processes of internal differentiation that keep producing (and encouraging) differences. The heterogeneous and conflictual nature of the social field that Bourdieu emphasizes can also be understood in terms of *social friction*: the friction of social classes and social worlds that challenge each other in the social contexts in which they coexist. The complexity and heterogeneity of social fields always allows for the possibility of finding or producing sites and opportunities of resistance. And this shows that resistance is a social and systemic phenomenon. Therefore, agents do not have to be all alone in their acts of rebellion; they do not have to resist dominant powers all by themselves.

Their attempts at insurrection can be coordinated and orchestrated, that is, woven into performative chains of resistance, so that the insurrection takes place through social networks and social movements and becomes politically effective, altering institutional arrangements and social structures. And if insurrectionary acts are not to remain isolated, disconnected, and politically inefficacious, resistance has to become part of the habitus of social agents.

This brings us to the second crucial idea that we find in Bourdieu for a social theory of resistance, namely, that "there exist dispositions to resist" (Bourdieu and Wacquant 1992, p. 81). Bourdieu points out that there can be social classes—and oppressed groups are indeed excellent candidates—that can develop their habitus around dispositions to violate the normative expectations that dominate the social field, that is, around what we have called, in Butlerian language, dispositions to counter-perform. Besides his references to these dispositions (and to the cognitive-affective structures that support them) in his discussions of generational conflicts and class struggles, Bourdieu also talks about them in his analysis of the cultivation of transgressive attitudes in artistic production (e.g., pp. 105ff). As Bourdieu puts it, the task of a social approach to resistance is "to examine under what conditions these dispositions [to resist] are socially constituted, effectively triggered, and rendered politically efficient" (p. 81). The key challenge that the Bourdieuian framework raises for any account of resistance is the need to identify the social conditions of counter-performativity. This challenge can only be met by carefully contextualizing insurrectionary acts of resistance. This is what the social contextualism I have been defending in this book also recommends.

My contextualist approach suggests that we should start by asking what the enabling and constraining effects are of the social contexts in which acts of resistance take place. So far we have focused on the enabling conditions that we find in the available social practices and in Rosa Parks's own social history. But there are also constraining or limiting factors that we find in the social context. Why were Parks's previous attempts at resistance as well as those of other black activists unsuccessful, or at least unable to have a noticeable impact and to initiate an effective chain of political transformations? Why was this particular instance of resistance so successful? Why did it become so iconic? Why this one and not the other ones? Terry Lovell (2003) offers a comparative analysis of the different insurrectionary acts that challenged bus segregation practices—those of Parks prior to 1955 as well as those of other black activists—without achieving the prominence and the performative legacy of the legendary one. Lovell asks, "What was the difference between these acts that 'endowed' one but not the others with authority, to mark it as the beginning of an insurrectionary process?" (p. 8). Lovell's analysis does precisely what my social contextualism suggests, namely, to look at what came before and what came after these acts so that we can assess their specific effectiveness—or lack thereof—in their particular social contexts. This is what it means to socially

contextualize acts of resistance, and this is what Lovell's Bourdieuian account offers.

On the one hand, Lovell's analysis of the antecedent conditions that made possible the success of Rosa Parks's resistance underscores issues of *social recognizability*. As Lovell emphasizes, it is important that "at the level of everyday practice, actions like that of Rosa Parks in December of 1955 were familiar to drivers and passengers alike" (p. 8). Claudette Colvin, another black activist who counter-performed to challenge bus segregation practices and was also arrested earlier that year (in March of 1955), is reported as saying, "I thought [the driver] would stop and shout and then drive on. That is what they usually do" (Ibid.).[17] A social movement of resistance against segregationist practices was reaching momentum and acquiring social visibility. Insurrectionary acts such as those of Colvin and Parks were being repeated often enough that they became a visible social phenomenon, and the reaction to them by the authorities and the courts had been escalating. As Lovell puts it,

> The difference between the 1955 cases and the earlier ones surely lies in part in the enhanced mobilization of coercion and the law in response: the arrests, detentions, charges and convictions, and most analysts attribute this escalation to the mounting resistance in the South, including Alabama, to a number of Supreme Court decisions, including most importantly the landmark Brown case of 1954 relating to segregation in schools, which had ruled against the segregationist practices of the South. (p. 8)

With their repetition and their orchestration by emerging activist organizations, acts of resistance against bus segregation practices became standardized. There was even a standard protocol, a regular and expected way of proceeding in these contexts of resistance both for activists and for the various social agents who could act to protect the observance of segregationist practices (the bus drivers, other passengers, police officers, etc). As Lovell puts it, "A *reiterable practice* was in formation" (p. 8; my emphasis). Any of the individual insurrectionary acts have to be understood as contributing to that reiterable practice in the making; and, therefore "it would be a mistake to look for an original act of transgression" within that practice, which was progressively being shaped, for the designation of any particular act as the absolute origin of the insurrectionary performative chain would be arbitrary. And since the effectiveness of Parks's act only became possible in the context of that reiterable practice, Lovell argues, *pace* Butler, that "we need to look beyond Parks's 'performance' on that day in 1955 to understand the authority of her act of resistance" (p. 9). We need to look at what happened before that day; but, even

[17] For this quotation, Lovell cites page 11 of the article "She Would Not Be Moved" by G. Younge in *The Guardian Weekend* (December 16, 2000).

more important, we need to look at what happened in the aftermath of that particular bus incident: "we should recognize that the originality of Parks's action lay in the response it produced" (p. 8). And we need to distinguish here between two different and equally important levels of responses: the legal responses and the sociopolitical responses. At the level of legal repercussions, Parks's act of civil disobedience was indeed special: Parks's conviction for violating the Alabama bus segregation ordinances was challenged and a long legal battle ensued, with an appeal to the federal justice system and eventually to the Supreme Court. This case challenged the constitutionality of segregation in public transportation and, finally, in December of 1956, the Supreme Court ruled that Alabama's bus segregation ordinances were unconstitutional. As this legal battle was taking place, Parks's act of civil disobedience also provoked strong political responses at the local, regional, and national level. As Lovell puts it, it was

> the response of the Montgomery black community organizers, and ultimately, the actions of thousands of black people in supporting the boycott . . . which "endowed" Parks's act with a *retrospective authority* that the earlier incidents, including those that involved Parks herself, lacked. (p. 9; my emphasis)

The critical and transformative force of Parks's resistance, far from being immanent and locatable within the act itself, as Butler suggests, is crucially dependent on antecedent and subsequent conditions. This is what Lovell's conclusion underscores: that "the authority of Rosa Parks was retrospective, the outcome of a process of group formation that was social and collective" (p. 10).

Parks initiated a pattern of insurrection because her act was so widely repeated by activists that it progressively expanded from a local to a regional and eventually a national boycott of segregationist practices. And it is important that Parks's act of resistance produced not only repetition, but *echoing*. It was indeed crucial that it was imitated and that it became a model to follow in a growing movement of resistance. But it was also crucial that the act resonated in many different ways and in many different corners of the social fabric beyond activist practices. Parks's resistance was echoed by the discourses of black leaders coming into national prominence such as Martin Luther King (who spoke of the case in Montgomery shortly after Parks's arrest). But it was also echoed by white voices and the mainstream discourses of white culture: it was widely discussed in the mainstream media, depicted in powerful representations of popular culture, mentioned in a wide variety of debates about race and class from the streets to academia. Clearly many people, practices, and institutions contributed to the echoing of Parks's resistance. The social conditions were slowly and gradually produced for this echoing of a particular act of resistance to become possible. In a social climate in which public opinion was growing increasingly uneasy with segregationist arrangements, especially

when enforced with violence and producing social unrest, the time was right for a sympathetic character and her suffering to provoke a response in the general public. The time was right for (a sector of) public opinion to be moved by an anti-segregationist act of resistance that was answered with a forcible removal, an arrest, and legal sanctions. And thus this particular incident became an effective tool for making people rethink carefully who in this political battle was on the side of social justice: the local authorities and local courts, or poor old (and tired) Rosa?

It was the echoing of a complex and heterogeneous social network—rather than the intentional agency of any particular set of individuals or single group—that explains the critical and transformative force that Parks's resistance acquired. This complexity is obscured by Lovell's insistence that Parks was *chosen* by local black activists as the most *suitable* candidate to initiate an effective chain of counter-performance. As Lovell puts it, "The choice of Parks as 'suitable' was initially the result of the judgment of local black activists, and their choice was confirmed by the subsequent success in mobilizing the black community to participate in the bus boycott" (p. 10). But was Rosa Parks *chosen*? And was she chosen by *the black community alone*? It is clear that there were social processes at play that selected her and her performance, but these processes are mis-described if they are depicted as reducible to intentional processes, to a choice. For in these processes we find much more than intentional agency; what we find when we examine the social forces and chains of events that played a role is a mixed and hybrid kind of agency in which intentional and non-intentional acts of individuals and groups become interwoven, enabling and constraining each other in complex ways. This is what I have called *chained action*.

In chained action there is a confluence of heterogeneous elements shaping a particular pattern of action that becomes repeatable, *echoable*, and is both individual and collective at the same time. In chained action there is a mixture of lucid and blind agency—with different kinds of lucidity and blindness in the different individuals and collectivities involved. Reducing this complexity to a choice is misleading. On the other hand, Lovell is right in calling attention to the crucial role played by black activists and the black community in this complex process, but it was not completely up to them to decide who could mobilize a widespread boycott and become an iconic figure of resistance. I agree with Lovell's Bourdieuian point that dominant culture and the dominant classes are not the only source of authority and the only ones with "the power to confer 'symbolic capital'" (Ibid.). And Lovell is certainly right in emphasizing that "the willingness of the black community in Montgomery to accept Parks as 'a suitable standard-bearer' for their cause" (Ibid.) was of the utmost importance. Indeed black activist groups and organizations played a crucial role in giving center stage to Parks and her act of civil disobedience. She was not produced by white culture, and her act of resistance was not turned into

what it became by white power. But neither were Parks's notoriety and the iconic status of her counter-performance manufactured by the black community *alone*. Other segments of the population and other organized groups also helped. Some white and mixed organizations and institutions, and eventually even the mainstream media and the general public, also played an important role (even if they joined the efforts of resistance at a later point). It is this complex and heterogeneous range of uptakes and responses that we need to take into account to paint the complete picture of the subversive and transformative force that Parks's counter-performance acquired within a social pattern of resistance.

An opportunity of resistance was seized, not chosen. But why was this particular opportunity so successful? And why Parks? Why couldn't one of the other local activists have become the protagonist of this cultural script of resistance in the making? It is clear that her act of resistance and not that of other activists who were counter-performing in similar ways around that time was exploited by local activists, black leaders, and a growing movement of resistance. Lovell gives an account of the special "suitability" that black activist groups found in Parks. I want to reformulate the issue slightly so that the question becomes not what made Parks and her act especially *suitable*, but rather, especially *echoable*. *Echoability* provides a much more specific and fine-grained notion than mere suitability to assess the likelihood of an insurrectionary act to become part of a performative chain of resistance with transformative potential. Echoability is a more clearly relational concept than suitability: to ask about the echoability of Parks and her actions is to ask about the social relationality that binds together Parks with other actors, as well as her actions with those of others. My reformulation of the issue of "suitability" into an issue of "echoability" is an attempt to shift the focus from the actor's conformity with certain standards to the interrelations of performative chains enmeshed in social networks. Lovell summarizes well some of the features that made Parks a sympathetic character and her action potentially echoable across a wide spectrum of social locations: Parks's background and profile exhibited the markers of working-class status, which made her a likely regular bus commuter; she spoke quietly and displayed a peaceful and apparently docile demeanor, lacking any sign of aggressiveness or irrationality; and, most important of all, Parks's appearance provided a compelling image of middle-age respectability with her rimless spectacles, her neatly kept graying hair, her clean and tidy clothes, and so on. Other activists lacked some (or even all) of these features. There is a particularly sharp contrast between Parks and Claudette Colvin, who is described in the following way:

> A feisty high school student . . . who defended her right to the seat in language that brought words of disapproval from passengers of both races . . ., Colvin was crying and madder than ever by the time

> the policeman told her she was under arrest. She struggled when they dragged her off the bus and screamed when they put on the handcuffs. . . . immature, prone to breakdowns and outbursts of profanity . . . pregnant . . . Colvin would not do. (Branch: quoted in Lovell: 2003, pp. 11–12)

As Lovell emphasizes, "Colvin lacked the insignia of respectability that Parks embodied" (p. 12). Everything about her played into the hands of stigmatizing stereotypes about black rebellious characters as being unreasonable, out of control and needing tutelage: "Too dark-skinned, too 'rough' in class terms, too young, too loud, and pregnant and unmarried" (Ibid.). Parks's figure and her action were *sympathetic* in ways in which those of other activists were not; and this sympathy is crucial for her performance to become reiterable and echoable. But this sympathy, which was exploited by local activists and emerging groups of resistance, clearly shows that Parks's act of insurrection contained a lot of concessions to the normalizing expectations and racist stereotypes of the white mainstream culture of the time. As Lovell argues, this brings to the fore that we can "find elements of submission/consent to norms within the most courageous acts of resistance, and vice versa, elements of resistance in the *habitus* of submission" (Ibid.). Pure and uncontaminated acts of resistance are not to be expected, but neither are pure and uncontaminated acts of submission without the slightest hint of possible discomfort and without the seed of a possible resistance. This ambivalence between resistance and submission that, following Bourdieu, Lovell emphasizes in our social agency is a double-edged sword: it underscores that even in the most constrained and heavily disciplined social practices we can find possible sites of resistance; but it also brings into light that any act of resistance—even the most radical—can be normatively constrained and may contain concessions to established powers. Social constraints on acts of resistance can be identified by investigating their echoability. This is what my discussion of how Parks's counter-performance was rendered echoable has tried to show.

Many interrelated social processes had to converge to make Parks's act of insurrection into what it became: *an emblem* of the social struggle that was taking place. And it is crucial to note that Parks's figure and action became echoable as *an emblem*, but not as a subversive force with a voice and a criterion of her own. As Lovell's analysis shows, with the notoriety that her act of resistance achieved, Parks did not become "a leader but *an emblem* of the mundane harassment that black people routinely suffered: an 'innocent' victim of impeccable credentials who had suffered abuse on the buses" (p. 11; my emphasis). Parks was given *a place, but not a voice*, in the activist groups and the emerging movement of resistance in the battle against segregation. What the social movement of resistance needed was *an emblem, not a voice*: an image of respectability that resonated with a general public and could be echoed by a

wide range of differently positioned agents, including mainstream subjects. As Lovell aptly puts it, Parks was used as an emblem by the social movement, but she was not allowed to occupy a leadership position. She was repeatedly "shunted aside" at rallies, and when Nelson Mandela visited Detroit in 1990, "Parks was left off the VIP list, and was made an uneasy party to the reception group as an afterthought. . . . There was no real leadership role for her in the SCLC, the organization she helped to create" (p. 15). Lovell correctly suggests that, among other factors, the dominant (white) norms of gender relationships are to blame for the marginalization of Parks within the civil rights movement. I would add that both being a soft-spoken woman and being a working-class subject with little cultural capital are features for which she was selected as a sympathetic figure and, at the same time, features that contributed to her marginalization within the movement of resistance. As I have been arguing, we should not be surprised to find concessions to heterosexist and classist norms in the social struggles against racism. Movements of resistance should not be expected to be devoid of submission and domination, which is all the more reason why we must cultivate multiplicitous movements of resistance that exert friction on each other, and can thus correct each other and compensate for each other, without ever expecting a movement of complete liberation in which pure resistance opposes pure submission.

Bringing together some of the key Bourdieuian themes of this section, we can sum up its central point as follows: possibilities of resistance are produced by the social friction of heterogeneous social fields, and they are performatively exploited—both individually and collectively—by agents with a habitus of resistance, with dispositions to counter-perform. Sometimes these possibilities are perceived and seized by particularly lucid and courageous individuals, but it takes an entire network of interconnected individuals and/or a social movement to exploit effectively these possibilities of resistance in chained actions. Even when resistance starts with courageous individual acts, it does not become politically effective and transformative for as long as these acts remain isolated and disconnected. Hence the importance of *echoing*: acts of resistance need to be *echoed* through the social fabric—that is, reacted to, engaged with, remembered, mimicked, and resonated in subsequent words and actions in multiple ways—in order to acquire prominence and become part of a performative chain or social pattern. It is when acts of resistance are echoed that they can become repeatable, readily intelligible, and woven into patterns of insurrection that can lead to social change. Although there is no invisible hand directing this process and there is indeed plenty of contingency and sheer luck in it, the emerging shared (or sharable) lucidity of social networks and social movements is crucial for the identification of sites of resistance and for the echoing of insurrectionary acts.

There is only so much that isolated individuals can achieve by themselves. Hence the importance of *interactive processes of communication* being available

to social agents, so that they can relate to each other, pool their resources, compensate for each other's blindness, share their (always limited) lucidity, and collectively exploit possibilities of resistance. Attempts at insurrection need to become not only repeatable, but also widely echoable if they are to leave a noticeable cultural mark (i.e., a transformation in the culture that affects all groups and not only the ones who engage in the insurrectionary acts). And echoability often requires that we repair the insensitivity that blocks fluid social relations and processes of communication among members of society. The melioration of cognitive and affective structures that I have focused on in this book is aimed at the improvement of social relationality and of the communication among social agents and social groups, so that relations of solidarity become possible and increasing degrees of lucidity can be achieved by individuals and groups. Iris M. Young (1990a, 1990b) has been one of the leading political theorists who have drawn attention to the importance of improving and expanding the processes of communication available in our public life, so that we can achieve a vibrant pluralistic democratic culture in which differences are not only tolerated but appreciated and integrated in our life in common. The importance of forging relations of solidarity that can bring together individuals into well-communicated social networks and social movements cannot be overemphasized: this will be further discussed in the next chapter through Carol Gould's (2007) concept of "network solidarity." We should not wait for epistemic and political *heroes* to save us; we all have the shared responsibility of improving our social perceptions and the social processes of communication available to us. Following Bourdieu, I have also suggested that we also share the collective responsibility for producing social locations, social relations, and social subjectivities that are congenial with the cultivation of habits of resistance, so that differently situated subjects and groups can exert friction, interrogate the social order, and expand the available range of options for the epistemic and sociopolitical life of a culture.

As we have seen in our discussions of Sor Juana's and Rosa Parks's acts of resistance, the fight against epistemic marginalization (such as that of women) as well as the fight against social injustices that are not distinctively epistemic (such as racial segregation in public transportation) require the mobilization of shareable acts and of shareable imaginings. This shareability typically involves disrupting or interrupting well-entrenched forms of social ignorance and meta-ignorance. There are indeed particular individuals who play a key role in the fight against epistemic injustice and in facilitating social lucidity. We have called them *epistemic heroes*, but we have seen that their *heroism* is a complex cultural artifact in which a multiplicity of individuals, groups, and publics are implicated. Their so-called *heroism* becomes possible and effective only within specific social contexts and thanks to the support of social networks and social movements. *Heroic* acts become such only because of the

place they have been given within social movements of resistance. Sor Juana and Rosa Parks are indeed icons of social contestation and insurrection. If anybody can qualify as *heroes* of epistemic and sociopolitical resistance, they certainly should. But they could not have accomplished what they did by themselves, or solely by virtue of their courage or other epistemic and political virtues (which themselves were socially produced). Their actions and their characters were rendered possible by the social support they received. It is thanks to the fertile soil of a particular social field that they could develop the attitudes and habits of resistance that they developed; and it is thanks to the subsequent social support of networks and movements that their insurrectionary acts could be echoed and woven into collective practices of resistance. We should not minimize the key contributions that particular individuals make to the fight against social and epistemic injustices. But it is important to emphasize that individual contributions have to be interwoven into a network of collective efforts, and that the ultimate protagonist of the fight across contexts and across generations is a *social network of resistance*—a network that in some cases becomes an organized group or movement. We need to interrogate critically the special place that particular individuals come to occupy within social networks, bringing to the fore the social conditions under which their critical interventions become possible, and highlighting the social consequences of their actions that lead to new forms of identifications and new forms of social relationality and group dynamics. This points in the direction of a contextualized notion of solidarity that supports individual acts of resistance and sustains their echoing, thus facilitating their effective and mutually reinforcing interconnections and making chained actions possible. But for this form of solidarity and chained action to become possible, the social imaginaries available have to be transformed. In the next chapter I will elucidate what is involved in transforming a social imaginary so that the social fields in which we act can provide sites of resistance.

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Resistant Imaginations and Radical Solidarity

Just as gender violence and domestic abuse are typically preceded by verbal violence and stigmatizing expressive treatments that weaken subjects and make them vulnerable to harm, collective harms and atrocities (such as genocide) are typically preceded by symbolic stigmatizations of the targeted population and by particular expressive harms that become socially accepted and even habitual (the use of slurs and denigrating language against that group; attitudes and discourses that make them suspect and cast doubt on their acceptability; the demonization of their behavior, culture, and customs; etc.). The preventive work required to minimize the possibility of groups being mistreated requires that we direct our critical gaze not only toward actions and practices, but also toward *language and the imagination*: we need to examine critically the patterns of communicative interaction and the discursive and imaginative resources through which different groups and their standing in society are conceptualized and talked about. Just as in order to prevent gender violence it is imperative to be as vigilant as possible about abusive language and abusive patterns of interaction that can inflict verbal and psychological damages that create vulnerability to physical violence, in order to prevent collective harms we also need to watch out for abusive verbal treatments and for the circulation of ways of imagining collective subjectivities (e.g., racial or sexual identities) that demean them and prevent their inclusion in the community or their equal standing within it. For this epistemic preventive work of justice, I want to bring together Iris Young's and Larry May's views on shared responsibility, introduced in chapter 4.

Young acknowledges May's influence on her social connection model of responsibility but with some reservations, the main ones being (1) that while her model is mainly forward-looking and oriented toward addressing ongoing injustices, she claims that "May's theory of shared responsibility remains backward looking: he is concerned to assign responsibility for harms that have occurred and reached a terminus"; and (2) "May also focuses more on subjective states (such as attitudes) as factors that link persons to responsibility for a wrong, and says little about more objective social structures that connect persons to moral wrongs or injustices" (2006, p. 122). Both of these complaints

reflect false dichotomies that are important to undo in order to understand properly the work of shared responsibility (especially in its epistemic dimension), for shared responsibility for justice is both forward-looking and backward-looking, and it has both structural and subjective aspects. These double aspects are accommodated in May's work on collective harms such as crimes against humanity (2005) and genocide (2010). Assuming responsibility for social harms is eo ipso undertaking commitments to prevent them in the future. As May emphasizes, this is the main point of acknowledging *bystander responsibility*:[1] "the recognition of the fact of widespread complicity, and of one's role in it, is crucial for self-understanding and then also for providing an impetus for change in those societies" (2010, p. 263). On the other hand, identifying complicities and shared responsibilities requires looking into the structural processes that make the harms possible, but also into the subjective states of those who did nothing to stop them, as reflected in the relevant interactions. Since May is interested in legal responsibility and legal justice, he often focuses on the subjective states of those involved in harms against groups. But he also considers structural processes and has developed detailed analyses of the responsibility of institutions (especially those institutions that have permitted or promoted widespread violence; see his 2005 and 2010). And May has also been concerned with linking legal responsibility to more expansive notions of responsibility, which include the shared responsibility for changing one's community (1993) and the moral responsibility of bystanders (2010).[2]

The task of shared responsibility has multiple and heterogeneous dimensions: it is backward- and forward-looking, structural and subjective. And in fact, we cannot properly attend one aspect of this task without attending the other. The forward-looking and backward-looking aspects are crucially interrelated, for we need to understand properly how actual injustices have been produced in order to address those that are still ongoing or may affect us in the future. On the other hand, the structural and the subjective also go hand in hand: structural processes that cause or facilitate harms work through patterns of interaction and people's entrenched habits and attitudes, which in turn are mediated by social structures. Assuming shared responsibility for *epistemic*

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[1] See especially May's discussion of the different kinds of bystanders and their responsibilities in the section "Bystanders and Shared Responsibility" (2010, pp. 258–63).

[2] As May points out, "The idea of bystander complicity certainly blurs the line between moral and legal responsibility" (2010, p. 260). Cases of omission and indirect involvement can present hybrid cases of moral and legal responsibilities, for even those who have played a minor role in the harm in question could be held legally responsible in "lesser localized trials that focus on the small fish," as May puts it (p. 259). But even those bystanders who have played no role at all in the harm can be held morally responsible and they can feel "stained with taint" for what has occurred and for their not having done anything to prevent it: "Bystanders do not necessarily have dirty hands, but they are nonetheless often tainted by association with the harms and wrongs that they could have prevented or mitigated on their own, or where such things could have been accomplished if only these bystanders had organized" (p. 260).

harms brings together the subjective and the structural in a particularly perspicuous way. On the one hand, when it comes to injustices that concern issues of knowledge, ignorance, and interpretation, we cannot avoid taking into account the agent's subjectivity; and, on the other hand, as I have argued throughout this book, epistemic responsibility cannot be properly identified and addressed independently of the agent's social position within structural processes and networks of social relations. Our critical gaze must be both retrospective and prospective in tracing trajectories of epistemic harm and preparing to intervene in them; and our interventions must critically engage with structural processes and their subjective accompaniments simultaneously (with structural racism and racist attitudes, with structural sexism and sexist attitudes, etc.). The convergence of these heterogeneous elements can be appreciated in the role played by *the imagination* both in the production and in the prevention of social harms. We need to address how the social imagination can become exclusionary and stigmatizing, making certain groups vulnerable to expressive and epistemic harms, and promoting the social tolerance of their suffering. In order to prevent or minimize possible occurrences of harm, we need to be vigilant about the exclusionary and stigmatizing aspects of the social imaginings that circulate in a community and are shared by (many of) its members.

The imagination can be both empowering and disempowering. It can create and deepen vulnerabilities, but it can also make people stronger and able to resist. Different ways of imagining can sensitize or desensitize people to human experiences—not only those of others, but even one's own; they can make people feel close or distant to others—and even to aspects of themselves; and they can create or sever social bonds, affective ties, and relations of empathy or antipathy, solidarity or lack of solidarity. Stigmatizing ways of imagining play a crucial role in causing expressive and epistemic harms—and more indirectly other kinds of harm as well—by distorting and excusing the suffering of some, making it appear as if it were tolerable or even necessary. But *resistant* ways of imagining can contest exclusions and stigmatizations, and they can help us become sensitive to the suffering of excluded and stigmatized subjects. In this chapter I will discuss the battle of imaginations that is characteristic of social conflicts and situations of oppression. Using the pluralistic and relational view developed in this book, I will argue that in order to develop a *resistant imagination*, our imagination has to become pluralized, polyphonic, and experimentalist.

Following Wittgenstein, Linda Zerilli (1998 and 2005) has argued for the central role of the imagination in the struggle against sexual oppression. She has criticized the feminism of recent decades for becoming too abstract and theoretical, detached from the ordinary practices that need to be relived and reimagined in new ways so that we can start inhabiting them differently. As she puts it, women's liberation requires "change at the level not of theory and

knowledge, but of imagination and action" (1998, p. 443). Zerilli argues that in the struggles for sexual liberation epistemology always arrives too late: "the powerful hold that 'the straight mind' . . . has on our subjectivity and our practices—our thinking, acting, and desiring—is not dependent, finally, on a network of knowledge claims" (p. 436). And she goes on to suggest that the games we (feminist and queer intellectuals) play with knowledge claims and counterclaims amount to "little more than window dressing over prior agreements in judgment about what counts as a woman and what counts as a man" (Ibid.). But in this critique Zerilli assumes a narrow conception of epistemology restricted to issues of justification of knowledge claims. I agree with Zerilli (and Wittgenstein) that epistemology thus conceived is impotent, ineffectual, and always arrives too late. But, as the arguments in this book have tried to show, this is not at all true when we expand our conception of epistemology to include not only (or primarily) the justification of knowledge claims, but also and more fundamentally the very production of knowledge and ignorance and the formation of cognitive and affective capacities that make knowledge possible. This expanded conception of epistemology encourages us to consider problems of knowledge and ignorance as they appear in our actual epistemic lives and in our daily interactions; and it presents us with the critical task of assuming shared responsibility for epistemic injustices and of interrogating the appropriateness of our cognitive-affective structures. As suggested by Zerilli, to address issues of exclusion and stigmatization we need a change in imagination and action because we need to reimagine our categories not in a theoretical way, but in our daily interactions, as they function in our actual practices, so that our reconceptualizations redirect our ordinary practices and our ways of relating to each other. It is important to appreciate that, as suggested by Zerilli and other Wittgensteinians, imagination and action must go together, and that a critical reimagining is not a purely intellectual exercise, but rather, a complex rearticulation that engages our emotions and our will and ultimately affects our capacity for action. In order to underscore the affective dimension of the imagination, it is important to talk about imaginative sensibilities; and in order to emphasize its practical and action-oriented aspects, it is important to talk about imaginative practices.

As Zerilli has argued, the problems of exclusion and stigmatization of women and sexual minorities do not pose a purely theoretical difficulty. I would not go as far as to say, with Zerilli, that "the difficulty here is not intellectual" (p. 449). But I would say that the problems we face in the struggles for inclusion are not *merely* intellectual, but also affective and practical, for they are problems that concern first and foremost our sensibilities and our action. Therefore, I would agree with Zerilli that "the difficulty is a problem of the will" (Ibid.). But our epistemic agency typically engages the will and the intellect simultaneously. In our epistemic life, our volitional and cognitive(-affective) structures work in tandem (even when there are tensions, dissonances, and

dysfunctions between them). This is especially clear in the case of the imagination. Let me begin my discussion of the role that the imagination plays in our epistemic life by calling attention to what has been called in the recent literature the phenomenon of *imaginative resistance*.[3] Why do we encounter resistance to imagine certain things and not others? And, in particular, why do we experience such resistance when invited to entertain fictional scenarios that violate our moral intuitions and values, and not when asked to imagine fictional worlds that violate our factual sense or the laws of physics? "I have a much easier time following an author's invitation to imagine that the earth is flat than I do following her invitation to imagine that murder is right," that genocide is legitimate, or that racial oppression is justified (Gendler: 2000, p. 58). This presents a puzzle, the so-called "puzzle of imaginative resistance," which, as formulated by Gendler, is "the puzzle of explaining our comparative difficulty in imagining fictional worlds that we take to be morally deviant" (p. 56). The solutions offered to this puzzle have provided useful insights into the functioning of the imagination. I want to call attention to two such insights.

In the first place, the phenomenon of imaginative resistance underscores that the exercise of the imagination engages the will and not only our intellectual capacities. As Gendler argues, "The primary source of imaginative resistance is not our *inability* to imagine morally deviant situations, but our *unwillingness* to do so" (p. 56). And this source of resistance, this unwillingness, shows that "the imagination requires a sort of participation that mere hypothetical reasoning does not" (p. 80). In this sense, Moran (1994) has distinguished between hypothetical reasoning and the "dramatic imagination." In our dramatic imaginings—where there is a narrative with subject positions with which we can identify, disidentify, or counter-identify[4]—there is a kind of active participation and involvement that is not required in mere counterfactual reasoning. Not only our cognitive structures, but also the moral sentiments and general affective structures underlying our agency are involved in the workings of the imagination. In other words, the imagination engages our moral sensibilities.

In the second place, the kind of active participation and involvement that we find in the imagination has to do with how an imaginative perspective *positions* us in the world, opening up and closing off ways of *relating* to others. The exercise of the imagination concerns our positionality and relationality in the actual world and how this world can be expanded into other possible worlds, imaginatively inhabiting possible relations and communities that could be formed and sustained, given certain conditions. The phenomenon of imaginative resistance shows that in our dramatic imaginings we cannot entirely

[3] See especially Richard Moran (1994) and Tamar Szabo Gendler (2000).

[4] See my "Identity Trouble" (2004a) for a discussion of the concepts of identification, disidentification, and counter-identification.

suspend our relation to the actual world. No matter how far they travel, our imaginings remain anchored in—or at least *relatable* to—the actual world. As Gendler (2000) puts it, the unwillingness that is at work in imaginative resistance is "a function of my not wanting to take a particular perspective on the world—this world—which I do not endorse" (p. 74). In Gendler's view, the source of imaginative resistance is to be found in our positionality, relationality, and moral attachments within the actual world. When we are inclined to reject a story in its own terms and resist that way of imagining, what we have encountered is "a problem with our relations to the *actual* world": "we are unwilling to follow the author's lead because in trying to make that world fictional, she is providing us with a way of looking at *this* world which we prefer not to embrace" (p. 79). According to Gendler, independently of how realistic or unrealistic fiction may be, there are always *some* relations between the fictional worlds that we imagine and our actual world. She characterizes these relations as relations of exportability and importability: there are at least *some* things that we export from our actual world to the fictional scenario, and at least *some* things that we import from the fictional scenario into our world. In this sense, the exercise of the imagination always concerns (however indirectly) our world; and, therefore, the imaginative perspective we adopt toward the fictional world will have *some* bearing on our perspective on the actual world. In Gendler's words, "Cases that evoke genuine imaginative resistance will be cases where the reader feels that she is being asked to export a way of looking at the actual world which she does not wish to add to her conceptual repertoire" (p. 77)—for example, a white supremacist perspective, or a Nazi or genocidal outlook.

The imagination is an exercise in perspective-taking, a way of inhabiting spaces and relating to others that connects up with our actual world, establishing a bridge between our world and other possible ones that we may not want to build, for the traffic of this bridge can be problematic in both directions: we may not want to import things from the fictional scenario into our world, thus accepting that the fictional world can become our world; and, on the other hand, we may also not want to establish an imaginary world by exporting alleged phenomena and relations that we do not accept as existing in our world (e.g., deserved extermination, racial or sexual superiority or inferiority) into the fictional scenario. In our imaginings we relate to possible worlds as worlds that could have been or could become ours given certain conditions (no matter how far-fetched). Unlike the deliberations of cold hypothetical reasoning where we remain mere spectators and contemplate situations that are simply given to us, the dramatic imagination presents us with counterfactual scenarios in which we are affectively and morally implicated and, as a result, we may be willing or unwilling to entertain such scenarios in the terms given to us. We can refer to the former as *cold* counterfactuals and to the latter as *hot* counterfactuals. Hot counterfactuals are those imaginings in which our affective attachments and

moral and political commitments are at play; and, therefore, our imaginary inhabitation (rather than mere contemplation) of fictional realities can compromise our positionality and relationality as moral and political agents. When it comes to value-laden phenomena and relations in our dramatic imaginings (or hot counterfactuals), our own values, moral, and political intuitions are in play. It is for this reason that the imagination can play a key role in processes of moral and political learning. In the dramatic imagination we explore our inhabitation of possible scenarios that, insofar as they concern forms of social positionality and relationality, call for moral and political reactions; and bringing these reactions into the open is a great opportunity for moral and political learning. Dramatic imaginings concern our agency and how far we are willing to extend this agency in possible situations, for these imaginings present us with would-be realities that our agency can contribute to sustain or undermine, depending on our willing acceptance or our resistant rejection of these realities in their terms.

Our capacity to imagine and its limitations go to the very core of our moral sense and political agency, delineating the contours of our moral and political sensibilities. We should interrogate the limits of our imagination and identify where imaginative resistance lies so as to become able to control it, instead of being controlled by it. This critical interrogation requires that we examine the easiness with which we imagine certain things and the difficulties we face in imagining others. Sometimes our habitual and automatic ways of imagining need to be disrupted or transformed in order to repair or prevent unfair treatments—for example, if it has become habitual in a culture to represent women as weaker than men. The point here is to exert imaginative resistance where there is none. But in other cases what presents an obstacle for justice is not the facility with which we have grown accustomed to imagine certain things, but rather the difficulties that new ways of imagining encounter. That is, sometimes the problem is not the lack of imaginative resistance but its presence. This is what happens when there is resistance to insurrectionary imaginations that envision new social realities and a world in which long-standing patterns of injustice cease to exist. The critical task is not to eradicate or cultivate resistance for resistance's sake. What I am interested in is the *interaction of resistant imaginations*. Following the Imperative of Epistemic Interaction I have been arguing for, my suggestion is that mutual melioration can be achieved through the interaction of the imaginations of people of different sensibilities. Imaginations with different moral and political sensibilities can function as *epistemic counterpoints* to each other. This interaction of imaginations can provide a venue for moral and political learning. By comparing and contrasting their imaginative resistances, people can become sensitive to other ways of imagining and inhabiting worlds of possible experiences.

I want to distinguish two senses of epistemic resistance at the level of the imagination. At the object level, we can exercise resistance against imagining

certain things, that is, resistance with respect to the content of particular hot counterfactuals—for example, that a black woman would behave in a particular way, that a white straight man doing so-and-so would constitute a particular kind of act, and so on. At the meta-level, we can exercise resistance against a particular way of imagining; this is a resistance that targets a whole perspective or frame—for example, looking at the world through the lenses of white supremacy ideology. For example, in pre-Nazi Germany the preventive work of justice would have required to exercise imaginative resistance at both levels: at the object level by resisting particular ways of stigmatizing Jews and other groups (countering the lies that were spread, the stigmatizing stereotypes in circulation about Jewish people, gypsies, homosexuals, etc.); and at the meta-level by resisting an imagination that divides humanity into superior and inferior classes and what Foucault has called the "racism against the abnormal."[5] Working at these two levels, the imagination offers a way of resisting the formation of social insensitivities, blocking the formation of the kinds of blindness and meta-blindness that are behind patterns of injustice, as discussed above. But for the resistance of the imagination to do this work of justice, it is important to go beyond imaginative resistance as a mere occasional and visceral reaction, and to work toward imaginative resistance as a self-conscious exercise in which we engage with others so as to compare and contrast our resistances and deliberate about them. I want to move from imaginative resistance—as an isolated phenomenon—to *resistant imaginations* as a structural phenomenon that requires social support and practices of interaction. The point is to maintain live and fluid the interplay of resistances and the epistemic friction of heterogeneous imaginations. In my pluralistic and relational view, what is to be avoided is letting one particular imaginative horizon or frame rule the day and become hegemonic, without any other way of imagining offering resistance, and making the subjects who grow under their influence become insensitive to the blind spots of the frame. What is to be avoided is the complete lack of imaginative resistance, but also the rigidification of one particular form of imaginative resistance. We need to become attentive to the plurality and dynamic nature of imaginative resistances, cultivating interactive resistant imaginations. The intuition behind my polyphonic contextualism is that the interaction of resistant imaginations can be the right antidote against social insensitivity—against blindness and meta-blindness—and, therefore, a centerpiece in the struggles against epistemic injustices. But for interactive resistant imaginations to produce beneficial epistemic friction and work toward justice, there must be an interplay of resistances from *plural* perspectives, for no matter how much similarly structured imaginations interact and deliberate about their reactions, they may remain unable to detect and repair

[5] See *Society Must Be Defended* (2003), briefly discussed above in section 4.3 and more fully below in sections 6.3 and 6.4.

their insensitivities and blind spots. So my argument about the imagination will turn on the cultivation of pluralistic communities of resistance. Only with the pluralization of social imaginations can the interaction of resistant imaginations help produce adequate democratic sensibilities. In order to establish that premise, I will begin with a discussion of pluralism.

6.1. Pluralistic Communities of Resistance

Pluralism can be used descriptively and normatively. In a descriptive sense, pluralism captures the *fact* of diversity and heterogeneity in the social field. As discussed in the previous chapter following Bourdieuian insights (see especially section 5.3.2), social fields are produced through social differentiation, and even the most monolithic and homogeneous of social fields will contain a variety of social locations, group differentiations, and agential possibilities. But alongside processes of social differentiation there are indeed also social processes that hide, constrain, and even erase differences. These are processes of social unification and homogenization as well as processes that silence, marginalize, or invisibilize differences without destroying them. Uniformity and homogeneity can be social realities as powerful as diversity and heterogeneity, and most (if not all) social fields contain elements of both poles. How should we handle this tension between diversifying and homogenizing tendencies? What should we do with social differences? To address these questions, pluralism can be used not only descriptively, but also normatively.

In a normative sense pluralism refers to our obligations with respect to social differences: What attitudes should we cultivate? How should we arrange our practices so that differences are respected and promoted? More specifically, what are our distinctively epistemic obligations in this respect? What should we do individually and collectively so as to guarantee (as much as possible) that differences are recognized, properly understood, and taken into account in people's social experiences and social imaginings? In the normative sense of pluralism, I am interested in elucidating the constitution of pluralistic publics and the role that the social imagination plays in that constitution. We can find a rich tradition of social and political pluralism in American philosophy, especially in John Dewey and William James. Following Dewey, pragmatists have argued for the need to promote pluralistic publics and open communities of difference required for vibrant democratic cultures. But it is also worth noting that pragmatist feminists have argued that Dewey's notion of a public is not pluralistic enough.[6] And although I draw political inspiration for my conception of heterogeneous publics and pluralistic communities of

[6] See Erin Tarver (2010). Dewey has been criticized for speaking of *the* public in the singular, as if society as a whole was committed to the attainment of a single voice or perspective. See also Colapietro (2004).

resistance from John Dewey, William James's relationalism and thoroughgoing pluralism will take center stage. By bringing together bedfellows as unlikely as James and Foucault, I hope to show in this chapter that pluralistic publics can flourish only if we cultivate epistemic practices of resistance and insurrection that constantly interrogate the operations of the social imagination and the repository of images and social scripts that it produces—the so-called *social imaginary*. I will start by laying out my normative conception of pluralism through the discussions of heterogeneous publics that we can find in the writings of two contemporary feminist theorists, Iris Marion Young and María Lugones. Then, in the next three sections, through a discussion of the retrospective and projective work of the social imagination, I will develop an argument for a radically pluralistic epistemology of diversity and politics of specificity. My aim is to explore the role of the *social imagination* in aiding or obstructing the formation of pluralistic communities and open publics, in facilitating or precluding beneficial epistemic friction through critique, resistance, and the cultivation of open-mindedness.

In *Justice and the Politics of Difference* (1990a) and in *Throwing Like a Girl* (1990b), Iris Young criticizes social processes of unification and homogenization and argues for the need of pluralistic publics for contemporary democracies. Instead of a unified and homogeneous public sphere, what democratic life needs is "a group differentiated citizenship and a heterogeneous public" (1990b, p. 121). Young identifies two democratic dangers that lead to impoverished views of democratic life: on the one hand, "the pressures for a homogeneous citizenry" and "the ideal of the public realm of citizenship as expressing a general will" (1990a, pp. 116–7); and, on the other hand, the egoistic and self-centered view of the political process as the arena where individuals and groups fight for their own interests. Understanding group affiliations as part of the very core of people's identity and social agency,[7] Young argues that "it is possible for persons to maintain their group identity and to be influenced by their perception of social events derived from their group specific experiences and at the same time to be *public spirited*, in the sense of being *open to listening to the claims of others and not being concerned for their own gain alone*" (1990a, p. 120; my emphasis). This Youngian notion of being *public spirited* is crucial to understanding the cognitive-affective attitude of being open-minded and capable of developing social sensitivities that can lead to pluralistic forms of solidarity—the social bonds required for heterogeneous democratic communities. This notion goes well with the kaleidoscopic perspective that I have argued for in the previous chapter and with the radically pluralistic collective sensibilities that I will argue for in this chapter.

[7] Rejecting the liberal contractual conception of a social group as something one simply decides to join, Young argues that group membership runs deeper and is prior to one's capacity to choose how to develop one's social identity and agency: "one finds oneself as a member of a social group whose existence and relations one experiences as always already having been" (1990b, p. 122).

In Young's view of a heterogeneous public, differences are irreducible and the core of democratic life is communication across those differences, which should be fostered by a shared "commitment to the need and desire to decide together society's policies" (1990a, p. 121). According to Young's communicative model of the heterogeneous public that constitutes a democratic citizenship, "each of the constituent groups affirms the presence of the others and affirms the specificity of its experience and perspective on social issues"; and they can jointly arrive at "a political program not by voicing some 'principles of unity' that hide differences but rather by allowing each constituency to analyze economic and social issues from the perspective of its experience" (1990a, p. 123). Young's pluralistic model of communicative democracy stresses the importance of acknowledging our limitations in the communicative activities that make up democratic life (especially but not exclusively those related to political representation), and of cultivating a careful attentiveness to the danger of misrepresenting perspectives: "People from one perspective can never completely understand and adopt the point of view of those with other group-based perspectives and histories" (1990a, p. 121). A group's perspectives cannot be fully understood and properly represented by those who remain outside it; non-members cannot speak for the group. But, on the other hand, the members of a group cannot claim to be its single voice, for they need to be attentive to the heterogeneity and inner diversity that any complex social group can have or develop.

Young finds in the women's movement a good example of the progressive pluralization and diversification of a group, which led to a recognition and appreciation of its heterogeneous voices and a new respect for those who, within the group, speak in multiple voices: those who speak as women of color; as lesbian, bisexual, or transgender women; as Third World women, and so on.[8] As Young puts it, within feminism and the women's movement, there was a progressive group differentiation through "structured discussion among differently identifying groups of women" (p. 162); and through the internal fight against different forms of insensitivity or "blindness" (especially racial and ethnic blindness, but also blindness with respect to class, sexual orientation, and nationality), there "emerged principled efforts to provide autonomously organized forums to those who see reason for claiming that they have as a group a distinctive voice that might be silenced in a general feminist discourse" (Ibid.). Through the unmasking of and fighting against multiple exclusions that sustained the shallow appearance of monolithic unity and homogeneity (the voice of the middle-class, straight white women speaking on behalf of all women), women of color, working-class women, LBT women, Third World women, and

[8] For a classic sampler of early systematic efforts for making these differences heard within feminism and the women's movement, see Moraga and Anzaldúa's *This Bridge Called My Back: Writings by Radical Women of Color* (1981). See also the early work of Angela Davis (1983).

others eventually acquired a voice within the movement. The development of the feminist movement has brought to the fore the inner diversity and irreducible heterogeneity of feminist perspectives, which, far from destabilizing or endangering the vibrancy of the group (except for occasional divisive conflicts), actually reenergized the social movement and gave it new strength through the plurality of its voices. This evolution has produced the articulation of feminist subjectivities that celebrate not their homogeneous unity but their inner differences, making it possible not only for the group as a whole but also for its individual members to value *the otherness within themselves*: not only social groups but also their individual members contain inner multiplicity and heterogeneity, and these internal differences within ourselves also need to be heard and valued. As Young puts it: "Rather than seeking a wholeness of the self, we who are the subjects of this plural and complex society should affirm *the otherness within ourselves*, acknowledging that as subjects we are heterogeneous and multiple in our affiliations and desires" (1990a, p. 124; my emphasis). The idea that we have *others within* has been explored in the recent literature in different ways.[9] Of special philosophical relevance is the formulation of this idea that can be found in Edwina Barvosa's *Wealth of Selves* (2008). Barvosa construes internal diversity and heterogeneity as constitutive of the self, and argues for ways in which multiple identities can be integrated so that pluralism, ambivalence, and even inconsistency can be rendered livable and productive.[10]

María Lugones (2003) praises Young's conception of a heterogeneous public and, in particular, what she sees as its call for "a revolution in subjectivity" which can lead subjects to devalue unified and homogeneous identities and to value multiplicitous and heterogeneous identities. But Lugones complains that Young "lacks a conception of a multiple subject who is not fragmented" (p. 139), and she argues that Young's problematic equation of multiplicity with fragmentation is due to her failure to thematize the interrelations among differences. According to Lugones, Young fails to address the overlapping and intersecting relations among groups and their social predicaments, in particular those of oppressed groups: "she fails to address the problem of the interlocking of oppressions. Fragmentation is conceptually at odds with seeing oppressions as interlocking" (Ibid.). According to Lugones, a discrete view of different forms of oppression—such as racism, (hetero)sexism, classism, and so on—as operating autonomously and independently of each other goes hand in hand with a discrete view of differences as self-contained and fragmented. Lugones urges us

[9] For a case study that elaborates this idea in great historical detail, see Yovel (2009).

[10] Barvosa argues that the basis of the self-integration of multiple identities should not be found in rank-ordered systems or in coherent life narratives, but rather in integrative life projects. See especially chapters 5 and 6, in which Barvosa explores the following question: "Is there a free-form mode of self-integration that can accommodate contradictory and divergent aspects of the self and allow individuals to draw moral and political direction creatively from their contradictions?" (2008, p. 140).

to tackle two interconnected tasks simultaneously: to develop an understanding of multiple oppressions as interlocked, and to develop a view of differences as interrelated, thus moving beyond what she sees as Young's conceptions of the heterogeneous public as composed of *discrete* social groups and of the multiplicitous subject as *fragmented*. Lugones's attempt to bring to the fore the interlocking of oppressions and the interconnections among differences starts with the crucial observation that the phenomenon of the isolation of each form of oppression has to be understood as itself an instrument of oppression and marginalization, as an ideological tool for dividing and separating forms of resistance, as an integral part of the politics of oppression and the politics of marginalization *within* oppressed groups (see especially p. 140). On the one hand, the separation and disconnection of oppressions reinforces domination and favors the privileged: "Avoiding recognition of the interlocking of oppressions serves many people well, but no one is served so well by it as the pure, rational, full-fledged citizen" (pp. 140–1). On the other hand, this separatism is internalized by oppressed groups themselves, and it becomes a roadblock for the creation of coalitions across oppressed groups and a mechanism of marginalization that devalues the standing within each group of those members who suffer multiple forms of oppression and have allegiances to diverse groups without fully fitting into any of them: "Liberatory work that makes vivid that oppressions must be fought as interlocked is consistently blocked in oppressed groups through the marginalization of thick members" (p. 141).

Arguing that group membership is not univocally and homogeneously bestowed upon all those who fall within a group, Lugones distinguishes between *transparent* and *thick* members of a group: members are "transparent with respect to their group if they perceive their needs, interests, and ways as those of the group and if this perception becomes dominant or hegemonical in the group"; and they are "thick if they are aware of their otherness in the group, of their needs, interests, ways, being relegated to the margins in the politics of intragroup contestation" (p. 140). Different subjects inhabit their group membership quite differently, developing different forms of blindness and lucidity as well as different forms of agency within the group: "as transparent, one becomes unaware of one's own differences from other members of the group" (Ibid.), whereas, as thick, one is acutely aware of one's differences (as deviances from standard members) and of one's marginal status within the group. In Lugones's view, it is the overall fragmentation of society into discrete groups that leads to the internal fragmentation of these groups and ultimately to the psychological fragmentation of the subjectivities within them:

> If the person is fragmented, it is because the society is itself fragmented into groups that are pure, homogeneous. Each group's structure of affiliation to and through transparent members produces a society of persons who are fragmented as they are affiliated to separate groups. (p. 141)

Lugones develops a thorough critique of the logic of purity and homogeneity that produces fragmentation and the artificial separation of groups into discrete social formations. To this homogenizing and separatist logic of fragmentation, Lugones opposes "the logic of impurity, of *mestizaje*," which "provides us with a better understanding of multiplicity, one that fits the conception of oppressions as interlocked" (Ibid.). Lugones argues that *mestizaje* (racial and cultural mixing as it has been cultivated, for example, in some Hispanic communities) offers a good model for "a complex version of identity politics and a complex conception of groups," making it possible to appreciate "the enmeshing of race, gender, culture, class and other differences that affect and constitute the identity of the group's members" (pp. 141–2).

In the face of social fragmentation and pervasive blindness to differences operating at various levels, how can we promote people's lucidity with respect to the multiplicitous heterogeneity of society as a whole, with respect to the inner diversity of their groups, and with respect to the inner complexity and heterogeneity of their own identities? To begin with, it is important to note that these various levels of heterogeneity or potential differentiation should not be conceived as simply containing *things to be observed*, but rather, as being comprised of both actualities and potentialities, of marks or aspects already developed as well as features and capacities to be created through one's actions and recreated through one's imagination. Through the dominant logic of fragmentation and what Lugones calls the mechanism of "split-separation," the social imaginary makes little room for the recognition and appreciation of multiplicity and heterogeneity. And differentiation becomes a difficult and complicated business, for one thing because social and psychological mechanisms of repression can work in such a way that differentiation becomes equivalent to deviation and bears the marks of stigmatization. Differences can be so deeply repressed that their very existence (that is, their actualization) can be *not only in question, but even out of the question*—and here we could cite many examples of individuals and communities being in denial about certain possibilities because things have been socially and psychologically arranged in such a way that certain things (e.g., being gay, lesbian, bisexual, or transgendered) cannot happen. To open ourselves and our communities to repressed differences, the kind of lucidity we need to produce must bring to the fore not only dormant potentialities, but also those that are inhibited and deeply repressed. This lucidity has to become capable not only of recognizing and appreciating stigmatized differences that are already there, but also innumerable other differences that could be energized through critical interventions in the social and psychological arrangements that have constrained processes of identity formation. In other words, this lucidity requires not only incisive perception, but also creative imagination and transformative action. In this respect, Lugones's notion of "curdle-separation" is useful.

Unlike the "split-separation" of the logic of homogeneity and fragmentation, "curdle-separation" is a critical way of dissociating oneself from stereotypical and hegemonic conceptions of identity (see especially pp. 142–3). This critical separatist positioning tries to break up oppressive homogeneities and separations and to bring to the fore the marginalized status of deviant members. It is what I have discussed elsewhere as the process of *disidentification*.[11] "Curdle-separating" involves taking critical distance from exclusionary configurations of identity in the attempt to pluralize standardized views of group identity by bringing difference into the group perspective in question: for example, dissociating oneself from the standard conception of femininity and showing that there is a different way of being a woman, another way of inhabiting that kind of identity that has been hidden or silenced, marginalized or stigmatized. Lugones's primary example of "curdle-separation" is what she calls "lesbian separation" within feminism and the women's movement (see especially pp. 142–4). She emphasizes that lesbians "curdle-separate" from dominant conceptions of femininity by rejecting heterosexist constructions of themselves and highlighting "all sorts of ambiguities and tensions that are threatening to purity" (p. 142).

I want to underscore three interesting aspects of Lugones's notion of "curdle-separation." In the first place, this critical form of "separation" (or disidentification) facilitates new forms of solidarity across multiple forms of oppression. In particular, Lugones is interested in emphasizing the fruitful connections between the "curdle-separation" of lesbians and that of Latinas within the women's movements, as closely related ways of pluralizing, critically transforming, and making more inclusive the feminist perspective: "our struggle, the struggle of lesbians, goes beyond lesbians as a group. If we understand our separation as curdle-separation, then we can rethink our relation to other curdled beings. Separation from domination is not split-separation" (p. 142). Something similar could be said about the queer movement, namely, that it has the potential of forging relations of solidarity across different forms of oppression by bringing together stigmatized subjectivities from different oppressed groups—for example, gender queers, sexual queers, racial and ethnic queers, class queers, and so on. In the second place, the notion of "curdle-separation" underscores the action-oriented dimension that the contestation of identity categories can take. Contesting and reconstituting configurations of identity take a transformative critical agency, and not only critical thought. "Curdle-separation is not something that happens to us but something we do. . . . [T]hat we curdle testifies to our being active subjects, not consumed by the logic of control. Curdling may be a haphazard technique of survival as an active subject, or it can become an art of resistance, metamorphosis, transformation" (p. 144). In the third place, and connecting directly with my arguments in previous

[11] See Medina (2004a) and chapter 2 of Medina (2006a).

chapters about meta-blindness and the meta-attitudes at play in racial and sexual ignorance, Lugones's notion of "curdle-separation" as a critical form of resistance can be conceived as a social commentary that operates at a meta-level by contesting meta-attitudes about group identity and bringing into them a radical openness to difference. In the following passage Lugones summarizes masterfully how "curdling" works as a social meta-commentary and how it encounters resistances at a meta level, where negative attitudes about differences, impurities, and mixing contribute to maintain privilege and relations of domination:

> Curdled behavior is not only creative but also constitutes itself as a social commentary. All curdled behavior, thought, and expression contain and express this second level of meaning, one of social commentary. When curdling becomes *an art of resistance*, the curdled presentation is highlighted. There is the distance of meta comment, of auto-reflection, looking at oneself in someone else's mirror and back in one's own, of self-aware experimentation. Our commentary is not straightforward: the commentary underlines the curdling and constitutes it as an act of social creative defiance. We often intend and cultivate with style this social commentary, this meta meaning of our curdling. When confronted with our curdling or curdled expression or behavior, people often withdraw. Their withdrawal reveals the devaluation of ambiguity *as threatening* and is thus also a meta comment. It announces that, though we will not be acknowledged, we have been seen as threatening the univocity of life lived in a state of purity, their management of us, their power over us. (pp. 145–6; my emphasis)

How can we collectively resist oppressive homogenizing tendencies? How can we pluralize our communities and produce genuine (and not split or fragmented) heterogeneous publics? How do we cultivate a positive appreciation for differences? By cultivating epistemic and practical virtues not only individually, but socially, and creating the cultural and structural conditions that can open up spaces for the expression and appreciation of different perspectives, of the indefinitely many ways of thinking, acting, and living that can be part of a pluralistic society. We need to create the conditions in which contestatory practices of social commentary (such as Lugones's "curdling") can flourish. In this book I have developed a polyphonic contextualism that emphasizes the practices of resistance and contestation—of epistemic friction—that need to be in place to meliorate situations of oppression and work toward social and epistemic justice. I have focused specifically on the melioration of cognitive-affective structures that guide our social perceptions (chapters 4–5) and communicative exchanges (chapter 2–3). In what follows I will explore the role of *the social imagination* in that melioration, in the fight against epistemic injustices and for achieving truly pluralistic communities

and democratic heterogeneous publics. We need to identify and resist the bodies of active ignorance and the oppressive homogenizing tendencies contained in and perpetuated by the social imaginary. The aim of an epistemology of resistance here is to elucidate the practices and attitudes that can improve the social imagination and facilitate our openness to differences. This elucidation requires an exploration of the oppressive and liberating ways in which the social imagination can work, that is, the ways in which we imagine ourselves and our communities so that we may open up possibilities for some and foreclose them for others, often contributing unknowingly to maintain forms of privilege and oppression. The task is to develop a critique of the oppressive aspects of the social imagination and to point in the direction of the liberatory role that the imagination can play. I will argue that the social imagination has to be *radically pluralized*, so that, by placing a radical openness to differences at its core, we can use the imagination critically to open up paths for liberation and to construct heterogeneous publics that function democratically. In the next section I will develop the first part of my argument about the social imagination by staging a conversation between radical democratic theory and feminist theory, more specifically, between Chantal Mouffe and Moira Gatens. My contribution to that conversation will be developed through William James's pluralistic insights into the imagination. In sections 6.3 and 6.4 I will highlight and bring together the critical contributions that Foucaultian genealogy and Jamesian pragmatism can make to pluralize the social imagination and to fight epistemic exclusions. As in my discussions of testimonial knowledge, self-knowledge, and social perception in the previous chapters, my approach to the imagination is also action-oriented and, far from falling into a spectatorial view of our social and cognitive lives, it adopts the immanent perspective of the agent within situated practices.

6.2. Normative Pluralism and Radical Solidarity

In this section I will investigate how a Jamesian pluralism, in conversation with recent philosophical analyses of the imagination, can help us appreciate the imaginative aspects of our cognitive and ethical lives. I want to explore the implications of two particular insights that we can find in James. In the first place, I will argue that from a pluralistic approach to the imagination we can derive not merely descriptive insights, but normative ones: we have an obligation to explore the limits of our imagination and to expand it; we have to take responsibility for the things that we are capable of imagining, but also for the things that we are contingently unable to envision. I will argue that achieving critical awareness of the limits of our imagination is not only an individual task, but also (and necessarily) a social enterprise that requires interactions

with indefinitely many particular and heterogeneous others. I am interested, first and foremost, in elucidating how a pluralistic approach to the social imagination can lead to improved forms of social relationality and to forms of social identifications that can meliorate democratic life. It is in this context that I will propose a notion of *radical solidarity* that departs from contemporary proposals in the literature on radical democracy, and it points in the direction of an ethics and a politics of *acknowledgement*.[12] Acknowledging other lives and other possible experiences—even unlived and unlivable ones, even those that are not only different from ours but in conflict with ours—is not an easy task. And that ethico-political task that the imagination confronts us with includes, among other things, coming to terms with what Vincent Colapietro (2010) calls "the tragedy of the unlived life" (p. 1). Failures of the individual and the collective imagination are often failures to acknowledge experiences and lives that deserve to be taken into account and to be made sense of. Expanding our imagination in pluralistic ways is, therefore, crucial for being able to acknowledge the lives and experiences of others properly, and to fulfill our ethical and political obligations properly. A pragmatist account of the imagination can help us with this difficult normative task of proper acknowledgment.

In the second place, on the basis of James's insistence on the inseparability of the cognitive and affective aspects of human experience, we should understand the achievements and failures of the imagination as *cognitive and affective* achievements and failures. When we find ourselves unable to envision certain experiences and meanings, certain pasts or futures, certain lives, our blindness and deafness to these possibilities constitute a kind of insensitivity or numbness that involves both cognitive and affective limitations: the incapacity to see or hear certain things, but also the incapacity to feel certain emotions and to relate to (or empathize with) people's experiences. The failures of our imagination contribute to this kind of insensitivity, to our becoming *cognitively and affectively numbed*. This numbness is what Megan Craig describes in her analysis of J. M. Coetzee's novel, *Disgrace*, as "a general inability to appreciate or to see as significant the lives of others," as being "blind to multiple sources of significance," as being "out of touch with life, cut off from new possibilities and visceral instances of pluralism" (2010, p. 1). Craig argues that the correction of such insensitivity and the melioration of our openness to the lives of others require the cultivation of a deep and pliable emotional core. She finds the key to this emotional melioration in James's account of *grace* as a plastic ethical responsiveness, as the "capacity for renewal and recalibration

[12] I use this Cavellian notion to convey a hybrid normative notion that goes beyond knowledge and combines cognitive and affective elements. See Cavell (1969). This Cavellian gesture brings to the fore one aspect of the convergence between my Wittgensteinian view and Colapietro's in "The Tragic Roots of Jamesian Pragmatism" (2010). It is also directly related to the notion of acknowledgment that figured in the first principle of epistemic friction I proposed in chapter 1: the principle of *acknowledgment* and engagement.

that allows one to respond with sensitivity to ever-changing demands" (Ibid.). My Jamesian approach to the imagination will try to show how pluralistic ways of exercising our individual and collective imagination can contribute to the development of that sensitivity, and to the sense of interconnectedness with other people and other forms of life required for being *gracious*.

How can a pragmatist view of the imagination help us to be gracious and to meliorate our ethical and political sensitivities? In the 2000 edited volume *The Pragmatist Imagination*, the editor Joan Ockman credits William James with the invention of the pragmatist imagination by posing the question of what it is to imagine (to think, to design, to construct) in relation not to "things made" but to "things in the making." Following the line of research opened by the contributors to that volume (but also going beyond it), I want to argue that James's pluralism offers the resources for a conception of the imagination that can be the foundation of a radically democratic conception of sociability or *radical solidarity*. But let's get there through contemporary discussions of the imagination in feminist theory.

Imagination is not a luxury or a privilege, but a necessity. Individuals as well as groups cannot have any sort of identity and agency without the capacity to imagine themselves, their worlds, and those who inhabit them. To have an identity and to be the subject of meaningful experience requires the imagination. Bringing together Spinoza and contemporary feminist theory, in *Imaginary Bodies* (1996) Moira Gatens has argued that the embodied imagination opens the normative space of our ethical and political lives. Not only our body, but also our *imagined* body or body image are crucial ingredients of our identity and agency and, therefore, of our ethical and political lives:

> One important aspect of the human body's ability to function as an apparently independent entity is *the body image*. Writers on the body image argue that such an image or gestalt is the basis of our intentional and of our social lives. (p. 35)

How does a human body become an ethical and political subject? Through the imagination, or more specifically, through an embodied and action-based imagination that mediates interpersonal activities. The embodied imagination supplies us with the required capacity to recognize our experiences and actions as our own in the present, past, and future; it is through the imagination that we project ourselves into the past and into the future so that we can trace a life trajectory through our experiences and actions. The imagination supplies us with the minimal cohesion required for identity and agency. And what goes for the individual goes also for the group: group identity and collective action also require the support of the imagination, a socially shared imagination.

As Miranda Fricker (2007) puts it, the social cohesion required for any kind of group identity is "dependent upon agents having shared conceptions of social identity—conceptions alive in the collective social imagination" (p. 14). Fricker

argues that what she terms *identity power*—a form of social power derived from belonging to a group, from partaking in a shared identity—"requires not only practical social co-ordination but also imaginative social co-ordination" (Ibid.). The social power that derives from group affiliation is typically not equally distributed in society. Our collective imaginings, Fricker argues, differentially empower the members of some groups and disempower the members of other groups. She applies this analysis to gender categories and ask us to think of "men" and "women" as collective identities animated by the social imagination. The identity power that emanates from these gender categories is distributed by relations of inclusion and exclusion in these collectives: we are empowered and disempowered in particular ways by being perceived as belonging or not belonging to one or another of these social categories; and these social perceptions to which we are all exposed are mediated by shared imaginings available in our cultural milieu—imaginings we have all internalized even if we do not endorse them and try hard to repudiate them.

As Fricker puts it, the way identity power operates in our interactions "depends very directly on imaginative social co-ordination: both parties must share in the relevant collective conceptions of what it is to be a man and what it is to be a woman" (Ibid.). And Fricker goes on to emphasize that "the operation of identity power does not require that either party consciously accept the stereotype as truthful" (p. 15):

> The conceptions of different social identities that are activated in operations of identity power need not be held at the level of belief in either subject or object, for the primary *modus operandi* of identity power is at the level of the collective social imagination. Consequently, it can control our actions even despite our beliefs. (p. 15)

The work of the social imagination here refers to *shared modes of representing and relating*, which are prior to and independent of particular beliefs and affects. The social imagination that goes into the formation of our shared identities and coordinated actions underlies our doxastic and affective life, but is not directly tied to any specific doxastic and affective commitment that we may have. Once internalized, the social imagination permeates the cognitive and affective dimensions of our experience, without being reducible to a mere list of specific cognitive commitments and affective reactions. The influence of any particular social imagination is deeper and more insidious than it appears to those who partake in it and, therefore, it is extremely hard to change: for example, we may consciously (and even, to an important degree, sincerely) disavow all our sexist beliefs and emotions, and our thought, affectivity, and action may nonetheless still remain mediated by a sexist social imagination. A social imagination is inscribed in our habitual ways of thinking, acting, and feeling. We can understand this social, embodied imagination on the model of the *habitus* that Pierre Bourdieu articulated (as the "structuring structure" that

regulates the receptivity and productivity we are capable of as thinking, sentient, and acting beings).[13] But the most elaborated discussion of the constitutive role that the imagination plays for our individual and collective experience and action can be found in another neo-Marxist thinker of contemporary French philosophy: Cornelius Castoriadis.

What Castoriadis calls the *radical imagination*[14] is to be distinguished from a merely combinatorial or associative mental capacity. He credits Aristotle with distinguishing for the first time the kind of creativity that opens our minds and bodies to a realm of intelligibility from a merely mechanistic imagination that reproduces, imitates, or combines according to rules (1997b, pp. 319–320). The radical imagination, Castoriadis tells us, involves invention or creation; it is the capacity to generate images not only in a visual sense, but "in a general sense," which includes the creation of "significations and institutions" (p. 322). This generative symbolic capacity provides a horizon of understanding and interpretation; it is "a *vis formandi*" (p. 322) that regulates our symbolic capacities. Castoriadis's radical imagination is "a sensory, and more generally bodily, imagination" (p. 331). Like Bourdieu's habitus, it is an embodied form of symbolic receptivity and productivity. Castoriadis emphasizes that this embodied generative capacity is always located within the individual, but also that it always goes beyond the individual: my imagination is mine but not only mine, just as my "'experience' is not just 'my own'" given its "biological and social genericity" which makes it sharable (p. 325). It is in fact through the radical imagination that our experiences become interconnected and sharable, for, according to Castoriadis, a meaningful experience always involves "an imaginary creation" that derives from the generative symbolic capacities that we share with others. As Castoriadis puts it,

> Our "personal" experience is our personal home—and this home would not be a home, but a solitary cave, if it was not in a village or a town. For, it is the collectivity that teaches us how to build homes and how to live in them. We cannot live without a home but neither can we remain hermetically enclosed in "our" home. (p. 325)

Castoriadis's discussions give support (and inspiration) to the crucial relation that contemporary feminists such as Gatens and Fricker have seen between the imagination and the identity and agency of individuals and groups: both individuals and groups need imagination to have a sense of

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[13] See Bourdieu (1984) and (1991).

[14] The imagination can be *radical* in at least two senses: radical insofar as it goes to the roots of our ways of thinking, feeling, and behaving; and radical in a political sense, insofar as it is critical and contains the potential for radical cultural and sociopolitical changes. How can we approach the radical imagination (the kind of imagining that underlies our thinking, feeling, and acting) so that it can be at the service of a radical politics (so that it can also be radical in a political sense)? This is the question that Castoriadis posed and we are addressing.

themselves and to have the minimal unity, coherence, and continuity required for action. As Castoriadis put it in his earlier writings on the imagination, "no social life can exist" without "social representing" (*legein*) and "social making/doing" (*teukhein*), which are the creative activities made possible by the "radical, constitutive, instituting imagination" (1997b, p. 204). Castoriadis stresses that our shared ways of representing and making/doing are not purely anonymous, but remain always dependent on the imaginings of particular (embodied and situated) subjects. For that reason, any particular social imagination, no matter how homogeneous and monolithic it may appear, always contains individual differences and idiosyncrasies. In fact, the social imagination always encounters difference and otherness both within itself and around it. In order to acknowledge this heterogeneity and to make it productive, the social imagination has to be *radically pluralized both across individuals and across groups*.[15] There are many different social groups with their distinctive imaginations and, at the same time, within any given group, although its members may share certain ways of creating and representing, their shared imaginings will nonetheless include internal differences given the distinctive positions and trajectories of the different members of the group and the idiosyncrasies of their individual imaginative capacities. And, as Castoriadis puts it, we must "recognize that there is a *multiplicity of 'first-person' collective 'experiences'* among which there is . . . no privileged one" (1997b, p. 325; my emphasis). Precisely because there is no privileged experiential perspective, he goes on to say, the most adequate perspective philosophically and politically is the one that rejects all privilege, "the one which made itself capable of *recognizing* and *accepting* this very multiplicity of human worlds, thereby breaking as far as possible the closure of its own world" (Ibid.). This is an accurate description of the pragmatist temperament held and defended by James and its radical openness to diversity and heterogeneity.

A core demand of James's radical empiricism is that we make ourselves "capable of *recognizing* and *accepting* this very multiplicity of human worlds," (Ibid.) of *acknowledging* the diversity and heterogeneity of human experiences and of the experiential worlds we create. And this demand has to be grounded in a radically pluralistic notion of the imagination, for it requires that we try to make ourselves capable of envisioning alternative experiential worlds—even if we cannot ourselves inhabit those worlds—and that we remain forever open to imaginative experimentation. According to James, in our creative transactions

[15] It is this radical pluralization that the phenomenological tradition failed to accomplish, according to Castoriadis. And this is the core of his critique of Husserl and Heidegger: "when one moves, as the last Husserl and the first Heidegger, from the egological, strictly phenomenological point of view . . . to the 'life-world,' one has just exchanged the egocentric for an ethno- or sociocentric point of view, solipsism on a larger scale" (1997b, p. 325).

with the world around us and with each other, plural and heterogeneous experiential worlds emerge.

We find in James a robust notion of the radical imagination, an individual and collective imagination that has to be radically pluralized and remains forever open to diversity, to multiple and heterogeneous ways of thinking, doing, and imagining the world. The temperament that James's pragmatism tries to instill revolves around "the habit of always seeing an alternative" (1978, p. 4). It is a pluralistic temperament that calls upon us to cultivate the capacity of always being able to imagine things differently. As James puts it,

> Philosophic study means *the habit of always seeing an alternative*, of not taking the usual for granted, of making conventionalities fluid again, of imagining foreign states of mind. In a word, it means the possession of mental perspective. (1978, p. 4; my emphasis)

We can only understand something by putting it in perspective; and we can only properly assess its value by comparing it with all possible alternatives that we can envision. Note that this comparative and contrastive exercise remains always open-ended, for it concerns not only the alternatives that have been already articulated and are readily available, but also those we can create or imagine—hence the crucial role that creativity and the imagination play in our normative assessments. But of course our creative and imaginative powers are always limited and, therefore we must always remain committed to the continuous expansion of the imagination and the active pursuit of new perspectives that can put our current appraisals in a different light. Different cultural groups, new generations, eccentric individuals, or perhaps even our future selves can come up with alternatives that had escaped us before. We must deem our valuations tentative, transitory, and always open to revision.

An important aspect of the radical openness of our normative assessments to heterogeneous perspectives relates to the fallibilistic attitude cultivated by all pragmatist thinkers. But James's empiricism combines an unflinching fallibilism with a thoroughgoing pluralism. In his view, the always tentative nature of the appraisal of our experiences must contain a multiplicity of perspectives that speak to each other and engage one another.[16] It is not sufficient to remain forever open to corrections. It is also necessary to be open to reformulations, to deep rethinking or reimagining, to shifting perspectives. According to this radical pluralism, experiential contents are not properly examined until they have been considered from different angles (as many as possible) in relation to each other, that is, as they become responsive to multiple

[16] Hence the centrality of a pluralistic imagination for our capacity to comply with the first principle of epistemic friction formulated in chapter 1: the principle of acknowledgment and *engagement* with different experiential standpoints.

perspectives. In this pluralistic view, the reconstruction of human experience must be *polyphonic* and *kaleidoscopic* without ever limiting the number or kinds of voices and perspectives to be engaged in that reconstructive process. The normative and hermeneutical task of making sense of our experiences remains always unfinished and open to contestation, that is, forever open to the challenges and calls for transformation that can emerge from indefinitely many perspectives. This openness to indefinitely many perspectives is both cognitive and affective, and it is grounded in our embodied imagination: in our cognitive-affective receptivity and sensitivity to experiential perspectives. In order to be able to assess (cognitive and affective) commitments and to determine which ones we want to live by, these commitments must be exposed to the *challenges* posed by different perspectives and confront the *resistances* that arise from different viewpoints. In this way, from James's pluralism we can derive a strong notion of *contestability*: the reconstruction and assessment of our experiences are always open to reevaluation through the critical engagement with an indefinite number of experiential standpoints. And there are no limits to this pluralistic process of contestation and reevaluation other than *the contingent limits of our imagination*. Of course no matter how hard we try to live up to this radical pluralism, our individual and collective imaginations remain always limited. But the particular limitations of our imagination at any given time are not fixed in stone; and, if we cultivate the pluralistic openness recommended by Jamesian pragmatism, it is always possible for these contingent limitations to be overcome through the critical engagement with individuals, groups, or cultures whose experiential worlds and imaginations are sufficiently different. In this sense James's radical empiricism and pluralism encourage us to actively seek encounters with significantly different ways of imagining and experiencing the world. Nothing short of this is required for sensitizing ourselves to forever more experiential perspectives, for making ourselves sensitive to new possibilities and meanings for human life.

Jamesian pluralism urges us to make our experiences and imaginings radically open to the contestations and calls for transformation that may arise in our perfectionist attempt to become sensitive to the experiential and imaginative perspectives of others, constantly fighting against becoming cognitively and affectively numbed. This notion of experiential openness and radical contestability can be seen as underlying James's call for a critical process of interrogation of our truths, a process in which the truths that we rely on are constantly being refreshed and put in sync with our experiences as well as with the experiences of the heterogeneous, multiple others we encounter. James warns us against relying uncritically on the truths of the past—the truths of others (or of our former selves)—that is, against accepting inherited truths independently of the life experiences from which they were drawn. The pragmatist approach to truth that James recommends requires a reconstruction of

experience that is both *retrospective* (unearthing the particular experiences that gave rise to particular truths) and *prospective* (exploring the potential for future experiences and future actions of the truths in question).[17] This pragmatist reconstruction of experience that is invoked in James's discussions of truth is crucially dependent on a radically pluralistic view of the critical imagination, that is, on the kind of imagination that enables us to envision *alternative ways of inhabiting experiential worlds* and to articulate the relevant *experiential counterpoints* through which things can look and feel quite different. And what is the payoff of these reconstructive and imaginative efforts? A central aim of the pragmatist reconstruction of experience is to establish a solid ground for a shared life. The imaginative reconstruction and evaluation of our experiences has the potential to create relations of *solidarity* with fellow thinkers and inquirers whose appraisals can be coordinated with ours, even if our valuations and theirs don't coincide or even converge. A community of experience is a *community of solidarity*, that is, a community of subjects who are prepared to think and believe together as they act upon their beliefs through collaborations, and who are ready to be responsive and accountable to each other as they try to share their experiential vantage points and to coordinate their actions. And note that being prepared to think and believe *together* should not be confused with thinking and believing *the same* or in the same way, just like acting together should not be reduced to doing the same thing. James's radical pragmatism demands that we cultivate openness to diversity while at the same time achieving the coordination of our thoughts and actions. As I have suggested, meeting this demand requires that our imagination be pluralistic and that we make our experiential standpoints open to the challenge and contestation of indefinitely many heterogeneous perspectives.

James's pluralism underscores the crucial significance that radical openness to diversity and contestability has for the individuals and collective lives we lead. The formation of a community of experience and solidarity that can accept and celebrate differences requires the *openness to critical engagement* with an irreducible plurality of experiential and agential perspectives. The collective imagination must be radically pluralized—without constraining the number and kind of possible perspectives and "the multiplicity of 'first-person' collective experiences"—to echo Castoriadis (1994, p. 325)—which can be included in it. It must be rendered open to contestation in this indefinite and radical way. A society's sense of itself—of its past, present, and future—must always remain radically open to contestation. And this radical contestability, far from being a threat to social cohesion, actually constitutes

[17] These two aspects of the pragmatist method that James recommends for linking truth to experience are internally related. For a discussion of these two aspects of the Jamesian view of truth, see Medina (2010), especially pp. 129–30.

the basis of a particular kind of social relationality that is precisely what pluralistic democracies require for their members to come together and to engage in civic life. In this radically pluralistic view, democratic solidarity and democratic participation revolve around diversity and critical engagement with differences; and they do not have to be grounded in or aimed at consensus—whether facilitated by common features, a common culture, or shared views emerging from processes of deliberation. In this sense the pluralistic view inspired by James that I am presenting converges with Chantal Mouffe's critique of deliberative democracy in her essay in *The Pragmatist Imagination* (2000), where she argues that a vibrant democratic life does not result from the mere resolution of conflict and the settlement of disputes through agreement; social contestation is necessary for genuine democratic participation. As she puts it,

> Too much emphasis on consensus together with an aversion toward confrontation leads to apathy and disaffection with political participation. . . . While consensus is necessary, it must be accompanied by dissent. . . . Consensus is needed on the institutions that are constitutive of democracy, but there will always be disagreement concerning the way social justice should be implemented in and through these institutions. In a pluralistic democracy such disagreements should be considered as legitimate and indeed welcome. They provide different forms of citizenship identification and are the stuff of democratic politics. (p. 72)

It is Mouffe's central claim in this paper that the decline of the political is due to the lack of democratic forms of identification offered to citizens, that is, "identifications through which passions could be mobilized toward democratic designs" (p. 68). Mouffe argues that democratic citizenship becomes a reality only when collective forms of identification become available, that is, when they are "made available by discourses that construct specific 'subject positions' that allow individuals to acquire a democratic political identity" (Ibid.). Mouffe argues that consensus models of democratic participation can only offer shallow (purely formal) and ultimately oppressive (because exclusionary) collective forms of identification that disregard or even erase differences. By contrast, she sees "politics as aiming at creating unity in a context of conflict and diversity" (Ibid.). And she sees this as being provided only by "a vibrant agonistic debate about the shape and future of the common life" (Ibid.). It is not agreement but disagreement that constitutes the core of democratic life. According to Mouffe, democratic life should be thought of and structured on the model of *agon*, of confrontational politics: "the central category in democratic politics is the category of the 'adversary,' the opponent with whom we have in common a shared allegiance to democratic principles but with whom there is disagreement about their interpretation" (Ibid.). I agree with Mouffe's critique of deliberative democracy and her diagnosis of contemporary political

apathy and impoverished forms of democratic life. I also share the challenge that her diagnosis raises for contemporary views of democratic participation. But I disagree with the agonistic model she proposes as the most adequate model of democratic participation. I think that the pragmatist tradition—and especially James—provides a far more adequate pluralistic view of democratic solidarity, one that does not replace agreement with disagreement, or unity and conformity with division and agonism. Mouffe operates with a false dichotomy between agreement and disagreement, as if we had to choose one of these poles for our model of social relationality for democratic societies. There are indeed other modes of social relationality and democratic engagement besides consensus and agonism. Agreement and disagreement are not always the only choices available when differences are encountered. When significantly different perspectives come into contact, their interaction may not necessarily aim at agreement or disagreement; their coexistence could be regulated by something different and perhaps deeper: being accountable and responsive to one another, and developing the kind of mutual understanding that makes that responsivity possible.

Radical contestability calls for radical responsivity or *radical solidarity*. The ever-present possibility of contestation demands critical engagement and a response to the normative challenges raised by differences; but it is far from clear that the responsivity in question has to take the form of agreement or disagreement, or that the form of solidarity demanded must take an agonistic form, as opposed to other forms of social coordination and relationality. Mouffe's agonistic pluralism, however, confuses the openness to differences and contestation with "the ever-present possibility of antagonism" (p. 72). On the basis of this conflation, Mouffe argues that "the aim of democratic politics . . . is to 'domesticate' hostility, to create the institutions through which this potential antagonism can be transformed into 'agonism,' in which instead of having a relation friend/enemy, we will have a confrontation between adversaries" (p. 73). But "the adversary" is only one among the many forms that our positionality and relationality in democratic engagements with difference can take. We need a much broader model that allows for a wider variety of pluralistic democratic encounters. Our radical openness to differences and contestation and the possibility of radical solidarity with an indefinite number of heterogeneous perspectives can be achieved and maintained in a plurality of ways, and not only by cultivating adversarial relations. Perhaps the broader figure that we need to conceptualize a radically pluralistic form of relationality with our fellow citizens is that of *the fellow traveler* or *the fellow experimenter*: a fellow member of a community of experience and action mediated by a shared imagination that can give citizens, not common views, but common access to plural ways of imagining their past, present, and future. A pluralistic conception of the pragmatist imagination is an important element in that radically pluralistic view of democratic solidarity

that can be an alternative to both the consensus view of democracy and the agonistic view of democratic participation. Mouffe is wrong in thinking that only by moving from consensus to agonistic confrontation can we escape apathy and disaffection, and a more vibrant political engagement with differences becomes possible. The apathy and disaffection that Mouffe talks about involve ways of being cognitively and affectively numbed to the demands of public life, which can only be repaired by a pluralistic social imagination that promotes sensitivity and openness to diversity without reducing our normative engagements with differences to agonistic confrontations. This is what *radical solidarity* involves: a self-interrogating and always open-ended capacity to acknowledge and respond to indefinitely many heterogeneous perspectives.

In *The Pragmatist Imagination* (2000) Mouffe raises the challenge of "reversing the dangerous trend of disaffection with democratic institutions which . . . constitutes a serious threat to the future of democratic institutions" (p. 73). Mouffe argues that although pragmatists like Rorty have developed a far-reaching critique of the rationalistic and universalistic views of democracy—such as deliberative democracy—which provide an impoverished and insufficient view of democratic life, pragmatism has nonetheless failed to provide an adequate alternative. I think, however, that this alternative can be found in Dewey and James, and that the pluralistic view of collective imaginings that I have sketched in bringing together Castoriadis and James can offer an account of what Mouffe claims to be needed for revitalizing democratic politics: collective forms of identification that do not erase differences and remain always open to processes of social contestation. Like Mouffe's agonism, a Jamesian radical pluralism shows us how democratic societies can achieve unity in and through—and not at the expense of—diversity. But the collective forms of identification promoted by a radically pluralistic social imagination are not necessarily agonistic. This non-agonistic model of critical engagement and social contestation can be seen in the joint work on the collective imagination of two feminist theorists: Moira Gatens and Genevieve Lloyd.

In *Collective Imaginings* (1999), Gatens and Lloyd argue that the achievement of openness to differences requires taking some critical distance with respect to one's own social imaginary, so that one becomes critically aware of the limitations of one's imagination and in a position to pluralize and expand the common horizons provided by the social imagination. To develop their view of the critical openness of the social imagination, Gatens and Lloyd draw on James Tully's notion of *critical freedom*, which involves, among other things, cultivating "the ability to see one's own ways as strange and unfamiliar, to stray from and take up a critical attitude towards them and to open cultures to question, reinterpretation, negotiation, transformation and non-identity" (Tully: 1995, p. 206).

What are the individual and collective efforts required to achieve society's radical openness to difference and what I have called *radical solidarity*? A partial answer to this question can be drawn from Gatens and Lloyd's critical interrogation of the collective identifications formed through a social imaginary conception of one's past, present, and future. Gatens and Lloyd are particularly interested in our responsibility to the past and how society develops a sense of itself and of its present and future on the basis of particular imaginary appropriations of the past:

> The various demands for the recognition of difference that mark contemporary politics invariably include the demand to acknowledge the *essential contestedness of stories and imaginings* about the past of collective bodies, along with the enduring effects of those narratives in the present. The conflicted, and often bitter disagreements that have characterized the Truth Commissions in Chile and Argentina, Bishop Tutu's Truth and Reconciliation Commissions in South Africa, and the *Historikerstreit* in Germany, attest to the *political importance, for present identities of how, and by whom, the past of a society is conceived, imagined and narrated*. Which memories and narratives are endorsed by legal recognition, historians or the general public, matters to the ability of individuals and groups to imagine themselves as possessing a past, a present and a future, that is, as possessing an identity. (pp. 137–8; my emphasis)

Gatens and Lloyd argue that the social imagination is not merely reflective of but actually constitutive of the forms of sociability that shape our lives. One of the crucial ways in which the social imagination constitutes our lives and who we become is by offering particular ways of relating to the past and of integrating the past in our present life and projecting it into the future: the social imagination makes it possible for past practices and ways of thinking to become "embedded in all our institutions, our judicial systems, our national narratives, our founding fictions, our cultural traditions" (p. 143). But this means, Gatens and Lloyd go on to argue, that taking responsibility for the social imagination is taking responsibility for a shared past and how this past affects multiple others:

> What we are responsible for is the way in which the past endures in our present—both in the form of inherited practices and as memory. How we remember, commemorate or deplore the past matters to our present relations with different others. (p. 148)

We have to take responsibility in the present for the *failures of our imagination*, that is, for the manner in which our collective imaginings contribute to prolong social harms and exclusions that were initiated in the past. In particular, Gatens and Lloyd call attention to the special problems that arise in this respect for societies with a colonial past in which native populations were displaced,

excluded, and oppressed: without a radical rethinking of the past, the institutions of contemporary democratic societies with a colonial past will continue to "oppress, marginalize or, at best, ignore those who did not figure in their design." (p. 139) Contemporary forms of marginalization of indigenous populations still bear the traces of past displacements and exclusions; and these ongoing forms of oppression cannot be fully eliminated and overcome without a radical transformation of the social imagination by opening it up to multiple forms of contestation and making it answerable to oppressed and previously excluded perspectives. To illustrate this point, Gatens and Lloyd analyze the example of the so-called Mabo judgment in which Australia's High Court overturned the legal fiction that Australia was *terra nullius* prior to British colonization. As Gatens and Lloyd explain,

> Eddie Mabo was one of five people who took a claim to the High Court of Australia for the legal recognition of their traditional ownership of land in the Torres Strait area, an area which had been annexed to the Australian state of Queensland in 1879. Mabo and others claimed that their entitlement to their land derived from their membership of an organized social group, governed by law, who had occupied and cultivated their land continuously since colonization. Their claim was a direct challenge to all the assumptions underlying the "settlement" of Australia. (p. 140)

As Australia's High Court commented in its judgment in the Mabo case, a case like this can be taken as an opportunity to critically rethink the relation of *all* Australians to their land, and also as an opportunity to critically rethink their relation to each other, and to their common past, present, and future. As Gatens and Lloyd put it, "The *Mabo* judgment disturbed not only mining, farming and other financial interests of present-day non-indigenous Australians, it also severely disturbed the social imaginary which grounds the 'we' of contemporary Australian identity" (p. 146). "The process of de-colonization cannot avoid dealing with these multiplicitous pasts in the endeavour to negotiate a just and fair present for all" (p. 148). And this brings us to a larger point about *shared responsibility* with respect to the social imagination that we have inherited and internalized and are somehow immersed in. It is only collectively that we, as members of pluralistic societies, can develop the "capacity to accept responsibility for the harmful effects on others of the social imaginaries which we inhabit and which have formed us as the types of persons we are" (Ibid.). Ongoing contestations and critical interrogations of the social imaginary—as exemplified by the Mabo case—are not just occasions either for reopening wounds and revitalizing antagonisms or for forging new agreements. The consensus-dissension false dichotomy actually obscures what is most interesting and promising about these instances of radical contestations of the social imaginary, namely, that they are occasions for the collective rethinking and reimagining that

can trigger multiple and interrelated processes of self-transformation for differently situated groups and standpoints as they assume radical responsivity and solidarity with each other and are brought together as a community of shared concerns—not a community of agreements or disagreements. And it is in fact crucial that we do not assume a priori that the collective processes of self-critique associated with radical contestability be aimed at either the merging of perspectives or at fostering antagonisms, but rather at the ongoing self-transformation of a radically pluralistic social imagination, which can have quite different effects and can be viewed quite differently from different perspectives. I do not want to deny, of course, that both agreement and disagreement can be part of these processes of self-interrogation and self-transformation that are triggered when the social imagination opens itself to radical contestation; but these transformative processes can include and yield all sorts of things: new agreements and disagreements in some cases, but also new forms of communication, new forms of respect, new shared understandings or shared concerns, new forms of coordination, new habits and attitudes, and so on. *Acknowledgment*, rather than agreement or disagreement, is the crucial normative relation that brings people together through a radically pluralistic sensibility. And acknowledgment is precisely an ethical relation that, through cognitive and affective means, we establish with others (with their experiences, problems, aspirations, values, etc.) through the imagination. A vibrant democratic community of shared concerns can only be created by the mutual acknowledgment of indefinitely many different forms of human experience and human life that a radically pluralized social imagination makes possible.

What is crucial in a society's attempts at self-critique and at assuming shared responsibility for its social imagination is well described by Gatens and Lloyd in the following thought: "Encounters with significantly different others may open one imaginary to another, offering perspectives and opportunities for the re-negotiation of identity" (p. 146). The collective transformation of the social imagination "must be thought and negotiated with actually existing different others in historical time" (p. 147)—hence the importance of the *embodied* aspects of the imagination, of an imagination grounded in actual *bodily interactions* with significantly different others in the flesh. As Gatens and Lloyd put it, "Negotiating difference necessarily involves the embodied presence of the relevant parties because negotiating difference involves negotiating (at least two) 'worlds'" (p. 148). And this critical and transformative engagement with different experiential perspectives can only happen with specific, embodied, situated others, for it requires "the exercise of the capacity to see the *specificity* of one's own world as one among others" (p. 149; my emphasis). As Carol Gould (2007) has put it, a genuinely pluralistic solidarity "requires an effort to understand the specifics of the other's concrete situation, to imaginatively construct for oneself their feelings and needs, and to listen to their own account of these, where possible" (pp. 156–57). Radical solidarity is indeed a very demanding

form of social relationality, and its demands affect both our cognitive-affective structures and our practices. Radical solidarity requires a very challenging form of social sensibility, but it also requires political work: that is, it demands that we develop cognitive and affective capacities that enable us to acknowledge indefinitely many experiential perspectives in their specificity and concreteness; but it also demands from us a political commitment to create and sustain contexts and practices that foster the flourishing of genuinely plural perspectives and voices that can critically engage each other without having to suppress their differences. The tasks of radical solidarity are indeed not easy tasks. The normative implications of a radically pluralistic approach to the social imagination do not make our life easier, but they provide guidance in the difficult struggle to meliorate our life in common while becoming forever more sensitive to our differences. In the next section I will explore how to develop radical solidarity with the past by using a properly pluralized social imagination retrospectively, or—in other words—by contesting any hegemonic monopolization of the past through exclusionary historical narratives. Drawing on Foucault, I will try to show how genealogical investigations and insurrectionary practices of counter-memory can produce epistemic friction and keep always alive the critical interrogation of the social imagination.

6.3. Epistemic Friction and Insurrectionary Genealogies

What we need in order to maintain the ongoing possibility of resistance is *epistemic friction*. Epistemic friction involves the mutual contestation of differently normatively structured knowledges; it interrogates epistemic exclusions, disqualification, and hegemonies. Epistemic friction is acknowledged and celebrated in pluralistic views of our epistemic negotiations and our cognitive lives, but not every kind of epistemic pluralism makes room for epistemic friction in the same way. In this section I want to explore the implications of a thoroughgoing epistemic pluralism for genealogical investigations. For this purpose, I will compare and contrast Foucault's pluralism with two different kinds of epistemic pluralism that can be found in American philosophy, arguing that Foucaultian pluralism offers a distinctive notion of epistemic friction that has tremendous critical force.

Different experiential and agential standpoints can make different contributions to genealogical investigations and even offer alternative genealogical histories. Given the right sociopolitical conditions, the critical reconstruction and reevaluation of our beliefs can (and should) be reopened and resumed whenever new standpoints appear on the scene, but also whenever we discover that certain voices or perspectives were never considered or were not given equal weight. Thus it is not surprising that populations feel particularly compelled to reopen the conversation about their past when the sociopolitical conditions

change in such a way that voices and perspectives that had previously been ignored or not fully taken into consideration can now participate differently in the reconstruction of their past, because they enjoy a different kind of agency. For example, this has been happening periodically in different ways and on different fronts in the public debates about past dictatorial regimes that have taken place in countries such as Argentina, Chile, or Spain.[18] In these countries, different segments of the population (as well as particular individuals) have demanded a sustained effort to critically revisit the reconstruction of a shared past in the light of evidence, testimony, and articulations or interpretations of facts that challenge established beliefs or are simply not integrated in the collective memory and "official history" in circulation. There is a plurality of lived pasts and of knowledges about the past that *resist* unification and create *friction*. But what are we to make of this *resistance and friction*? Pluralistic views of truth and knowledge make productive use of those forms of epistemic friction and resistance, whereas monistic views regard epistemic diversity always as a problem. I will restrict myself here to pluralistic views, but I want to emphasize that different kinds of epistemic pluralism involve different normative attitudes with respect to epistemic diversity and the kinds of epistemic friction and resistance that heterogeneous perspectives can exert.

I want to distinguish three very different attitudes with respect to epistemic differences and the plurality of heterogeneous perspectives that we can find in pluralistic accounts of truth and knowledge. In the first place, in classic pragmatists such as C. S. Peirce and G. H. Mead (at least under some interpretations),[19] we can find an approach to epistemic practices that places emphasis on the plurality of experiential perspectives, but nonetheless preserves a commitment to unification, so that all available standpoints must ultimately be subsumable under a *single perspective*—for example, if we were to reach a hypothetical end of inquiry, or if we were to push our communicative processes far enough until all perspectives were heard and integrated. This is what I call a *converging pluralism*. For converging pluralisms, the diversity and heterogeneity of conflicting perspectives

[18] In Spain multifaceted debates about how to remember and talk about the civil war and Franco's dictatorship have raised wide-ranging questions about objectivity and justice, covering many diverse issues from reparations and restitutions, to modifying the historical narratives available so as to include other voices and perspectives, and to changing all kinds of elements in public life that echo past events and past subjects in particular ways (sometimes celebrating or commemorating, sometimes stigmatizing), through street names, the display of symbols, public art, and so on. All of these issues are addressed by the new legislation (the so-called "Ley de Memoria Histórica") proposed by the socialist government in Spain, which passed in July 2006. This new legislation has sparked more heated debates, being criticized by some for not going far enough (e.g., for simply recommending, instead of demanding, the removal of fascist symbols) and being criticized by others for unnecessarily "reopening wounds" that should be left undisturbed because they can only heal with time (or, some have even suggested, through *forgetting*).

[19] Alternative—and more interesting—interpretations of Peirce and Mead can be found in Colapietro (1989) and Aboulafia (2006).

are merely contingent—and in principle, transitory—features of our epistemic practices that we should aspire to eliminate or at least minimize. By contrast, in more thoroughgoing pluralistic views such as that of William James, diversity and heterogeneity are unavoidable features of our epistemic lives that can be hidden or repressed only with violence and exclusions, but can never be fully erased. In Jamesian pluralism, though more radical, the possibilities for epistemic friction and resistance are qualified and constrained for the sake, not of consensus and unification, but of *coordination and cooperation*. This is what I call a *melioristic pluralism*.

As I have argued elsewhere,[20] by contrast with consensus theories of truth and knowledge, according to James's radical fallibilism and pluralism, the openness to contestations and reinterpretations of our beliefs never goes away and constitutes the very normative core of our epistemic lives: this openness calls attention to the kind of accountability and responsiveness to others required by our epistemic agency. However, although in this pluralistic view epistemic differences and conflicts are not erased, they are put at the service of mutual improvements. On this melioristic pluralism, epistemic contestations and negotiations are directed toward improving the objectivity of the different standpoints available, toward correcting their biases and mistakes, and toward maintaining their truth *alive*—that is, dynamic, adaptable, and integrated in the lives of those who hold those experiential perspectives. Although here there is no aspiration to combine and unify all perspectives into a single one, there is the normative expectation that the interactions among diverging perspectives will result in an increase of objectivity and in the improvement of the articulations and justifications of beliefs and epistemic appraisals. In this view, epistemic friction among perspectives is always an opportunity for learning from each other and correcting each other. In section 6.4 I will defend a version of this melioristic pluralism, but first I want to call attention to a different kind of pluralism that we can find in Foucault: a *guerrilla pluralism* with a particularly radical subversive force. It is my view that this more subversive pluralism is precisely what is needed to address *radical exclusions*. In other words, I will argue that *guerrilla pluralism* is what we need when equitable and fair melioration for all is not yet possible, that is, when in a fractured society the conditions are not given for beneficial epistemic friction that results in mutual corrections and a collective process of learning in which all social groups can participate.

In a Foucaultian pluralistic framework, epistemic frictions are no more tools for learning than they are tools for unlearning (for undoing power/knowledges—e.g., for undoing ways of remembering and forgetting, when it comes to knowledge of the past). In this view, epistemic frictions are not

[20] See Medina (2010) and (2011).

merely instrumental or transitional—that is, tools for, or steps toward, harmony or conflict resolution. Epistemic frictions are sought for their own sake, for the forms of *resistance* that they constitute. This is why I call this more radical epistemic pluralism that can be found in Foucault a *guerrilla pluralism*. It is not a pluralism that tries to resolve conflicts and overcome struggles, but instead tries to provoke them and to re-energize them. It is a pluralism that aims not at the melioration of the cognitive and ethical lives of all, but rather, at the (epistemic and sociopolitical) *resistance* of some against the oppression of others. This is a pluralism that focuses on the gaps, discontinuities, tensions, and clashes among perspectives and discursive practices. With respect to knowledges of the past, Foucaultian genealogical investigations do not simply revive alternative memories that can act as correctives of each other and cooperate without losing their specificity, as a Jamesian melioristic pluralism would have it. Rather, Foucaultian genealogical investigations resurrect *counter-memories*, not just for the sake of joint cooperation, but for the sake of reactivating struggles and energizing forms of resistance. In this view, alternative memories are not simply the raw materials to be coordinated in a heterogeneous (but nonetheless shared) collective memory; rather, they remain counter-memories that make available multiplicitous pasts for differently constituted and positioned subjectivities and their discursive practices.

Despite differences in depth and radicality, Foucault's and James's pluralistic approaches have overlapping commonalities and they are both part of a genealogical approach to truth, or—more accurately—to ways of establishing, articulating, and transmitting truths within the different economies[21] of discursive practices. The pluralistic and genealogical approach to truth defended by both James and Foucault offers a piecemeal approach that is not in the business of identifying what makes all our truths true.[22] Rather, the piecemeal approach of pluralistic genealogy is in the business of examining, case by case, the diverse ways in which particular truths are settled, challenged, negotiated, evaluated, and reevaluated in particular contexts. Both James and Foucault call attention to our proclivity to forget how truths have been established, to block the memories of the multiple experiences and struggles that went into the making of those inherited truths. For both James and Foucault, truths are made, not given; they are made in and through our practices, experiences, and valuations. But we are prone to forget about their genesis. This is what I have

[21] And it is worth mentioning that both Foucault and James make explicit use of economic metaphors to elucidate the normative structures and dynamics of discursive practices or "discursive regimes." In his discussions of the pragmatic value of truth as "what is expedient" in our thought and action, James talks about "the cash-value of truth" and of cashing out the value of truths by elucidating their roles in our practices and experiences. See James (1975a), page 110.

[22] Substantive theories of truth are defined by their attempt to identify such a general truth-maker. Consensus theories of truth, for example, find it in agreement (whether local or universal). See Medina and Wood (2005).

called *genesis amnesia*.[23] Insofar as they try to undo this amnesia, Jamesian and Foucaultian genealogies are as much about forgetting as they are about remembering; that is, they pointedly target oblivion from different angles and perspectives and for different purposes. However, in this *undoing of oblivion*, James tends to focus on the positive experiences that went into the making of established truths, whereas Foucaultian genealogies bring to the fore the forgotten struggles, silenced voices, and violent exclusions. I will briefly sketch how the genealogical approach appears within Jamesian pragmatism to then turn to the radicalization of the genealogical approach by Foucault, hoping to bring into a sharper focus the contrast between a melioristic and a guerrilla pluralism.

The genesis amnesia with respect to the truths circulated in our discursive practices is problematic because it forces us to accept inherited truths independently of the life experiences from which they were drawn. James warns us against the danger of relying uncritically on fixed truths, for this means relying on the experiences and valuations of others or of our past selves, which may have lost their force and appropriateness in our current experiential contexts. Fixity is a property that human truths cannot have. The fixation of truth once and for all would mean mental death; it would mean putting an end to our epistemic lives. Our body of truths always has to be critically revisited in the light of new experiences. In James's view, truths cannot simply be taken for granted, because they become *inert* or *dead* truths, truths that have been removed from the stream of life and are presented in complete independence from particular experiential contexts and particular experiential subjects.[24] Truths have to be related to the subjects in whose life they make a difference, to their experiences and valuations. According to James, when truths are detached from the life experiences that gave them birth, they lose their vital force and they become rigid, ossified, *dead*. Truths cannot be simply *found*; they have to be created or recreated to be *alive*. This live quality and potency of truth reside in what we can call the *performativity* of truth. *Living* truths are truths of our own making. Of course, the living truths we make today will be the dead truths of tomorrow. Truths cannot simply be recirculated in our epistemic practices, for they lose their action-guiding value and productivity when they are detached from concrete life experiences, becoming ossified by habitual use. But this does not mean that we cannot rely on those beliefs that have been previously accepted as true. Our epistemic activities need to rely on a stock of truths that have been previously established in our transactions with

[23] See Medina (2003).

[24] As James puts it in a brilliant passage, "Truth independent; truth that we *find* merely; truth no longer malleable to human need; truth incorrigible, in a word; such truth exists indeed superabundantly . . .; but then it means only the dead heart of the living tree, and its being there means only that truth also has its paleontology and its 'prescription,' and may grow stiff with years of veteran service and petrified in men's regard by sheer antiquity" (1975b, p. 37).

the world (our own as well as others'). But the older truths on which we rely cannot be simply taken for granted; they have to be subject to a critical epistemic examination that traces them back to their experiential sources. This is why James claims that, besides a method, pragmatism is "a *genetic* theory of what is meant by truth" (1975b, p. 37; my emphasis). We have to uncover how truths have been made. James tells us that we should keep in mind that even the most ancient truths "also once were plastic. They also were called true for human reasons. They also mediated between still earlier truths and what in those days were novel observations" (pp. 36–7). In James's view, the epistemic analysis of our beliefs requires the genealogy of those ideas and thoughts that have been *made true* in our practices. But of course genealogies are driven by present concerns and interests and, therefore, they are simultaneously backward-looking and forward-looking. Jamesian genealogies trace the vital trajectories of our truths within our practices, presenting them at the crossroads between the life experiences and actions of the past and those of the present and future. The critical task, for James, is to trace the practical trajectories along which the life of those truths have run their course, trying to determine if there is still some life left in them, and what paths their present and future life can take.

But notice that the exclusive focus of Jamesian genealogies is on continuities and convergences in alethic trajectories within our practices. A Jamesian genealogy tries to uncover what our truths have done so far and what they can still do for us. A Foucaultian genealogy goes much further and its attention to epistemic differences is more radical. A Foucaultian genealogy tries to uncover what our truths have never done for (some of) us and never will; and it tries to connect the truths generated within a given practice with the untruths that are also generated alongside them, digging up all sorts of epistemic frictions and struggles that reveal the competing and alternative truths that may lie in the interstices of a discursive practice or in counter-discourses. Thus, as argued above, in Foucault we find a more radical and uncompromising epistemic pluralism, a guerrilla pluralism. Grounded in this pluralism, Foucaultian genealogical investigations have their primary focus on discontinuities and divergences in alethic trajectories that can interrogate the continuities and convergences that we take for granted, and thus produce *an insurrection of subjugated knowledges*. Foucaultian genealogy is not only a way of refreshing or reviving our past in the light of our present; it is the more radical attempt to make our present and our past alien to us, to look at historical trajectories with fresh eyes, with different eyes, so that they appear as strange artifacts. And this process of *self-estrangement* of which Foucaultian genealogies consist involves the unearthing of the radical differences that lie within our practices and within ourselves, but which have been silenced, marginalized, stigmatized, excluded, or forgotten. A genealogy animated not simply by a melioristic pluralism, but by a guerrilla pluralism, requires more than merely revisiting the past to see

how and why things were settled in the way they were; it requires interrogating and contesting any settlement, making the past come undone at the seams, so that it loses its unity, continuity, and naturalness, so that it does not appear any more as a single past that has already been made, but rather as a heterogeneous array of converging and diverging struggles that are still ongoing and have only the appearance of having been settled. When social divisions and social struggles become the focus of attention, genealogies lead to the splintering of the present and the past into irreducibly heterogeneous presents and pasts that resist unification and contain multiple crossroads full of friction.

Insurrectionary genealogies exploit the openness of our (indefinitely multiple) pasts. As G. H. Mead suggested in the *Philosophy of the Present* (1949), the past is as open as the future,[25] and they are both equally dependent on the present. As Mead puts it, "the novelty of every future demands a novel past" (p. 33). The past is renewed in and through our interpretative practices; it is rendered present in our lives through interpretations that are always the result of re-descriptions and negotiations from the vantage point of the present informed by our current vision of the future.[26] For this reason, our past is *incessantly novel*: we make it and remake it, incessantly, in every present.[27] But here an important worry arises: *the worry of instrumentalization*. We can do harm to past subjects by instrumentalizing their struggles, by co-opting their voices and experiences and using them for our own purposes. If forgetting or ignoring past subjects and their struggles can be unjust, we also commit injustices by spoilating past lives.

We have obligations with respect to subjects of the past, who had their own interests and values. For example, those who have lived under slavery, the victims of Auschwitz, those tortured and killed by dictatorial regimes, the thousands who die every year in the United States without medical attention or basic necessities should be remembered not simply because we find it useful or in our interest, but because their lives and deaths deserve critical attention and to be put in relation to our own. Following Mead as well as critical theorists as different as Jürgen Habermas and Walter Benjamin, James Bohman (2009) and Max Pensky (2009) have argued against the instrumentalization of the past and for the need to give moral recognition to past subjects and moral weight to their experiences and perspectives. As Bohman puts it, "We do not

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[25] I have argued, however, that there are serious problems with this claim if taken literally, and that some qualifications are required. See Medina (2011).

[26] Max Pensky (2009) has argued that "the key terms" for the reconstruction of the past "are 're-description' and 'negotiation': the past is negotiated, and re-negotiated, across a spectrum of differing players, all of whom may have differing (even internally inconsistent) motives for the construction of a preferred version of a shared past" (p. 77).

[27] As Pensky (2009) remarks, "Both Mead's and Benjamin's thoughts on the nature of historical experience and the relation between present and past converge in a vision of a *shared* past that is *incessantly novel* insofar as the past is the ongoing production or performance of interpretive practices" (p. 81).

just deliberate *about* the past but rather *with* the past" (p. 123; my emphasis). From a Foucaultian perspective the instrumentalization worry is appeased not by giving moral recognition to subjects of the past as partners in deliberation, but rather by acknowledging their agency and power/knowledges, whether or not these can be recruited to our deliberation processes in the way we would like. This is what radical solidarity and the politics of acknowledgment sketched in the previous section demand of us.

In the thoroughly pluralistic view of epistemic agency that we find in the Foucaultian framework, there is an irreducible plurality of centers of experience and agency that function as centers of *resistance and contestability*. Differently situated discursive subjectivities have differential capacities to contest and resist the truths/untruths and the knowledges/ignorances that surround their discursive lives. And insofar as our predecessors are treated as discursive *subjects*—and not as mere objects to be manipulated at will—we need to take into account their perspectives. Insurrectionary genealogies must take into account the experiences and valuations of past subjects, in which we can find challenges, subversions, and resistances of all sorts. It is there where genealogical investigations draw their critical force; it is in the friction between forgotten and silenced lives and the lives of the present where the insurrections start to happen. Animated by a guerrilla pluralism, Foucaultian genealogies, far from contributing to instrumentalizations and subjugations of the past, are in fact tools for resisting them; their critical power resides precisely in resisting unifications and totalizing perspectives.

Genealogical investigations are informed by multiple processes of interpellation with traffic going in all directions. In particular, two very different forms of interpellation are in play: genealogists interpellate past subjects, but they are also interpellated by subjects of the past. And this *double interpellation* involves a mutual process of estrangement: we make past lives alien, as they also make our own lives strangely unfamiliar. So, in insurrectionary genealogies, far from making ourselves free to remember or forget in whatever way seems most convenient to us, we make ourselves vulnerable to the past by opening our memories to the challenges and contestations of various subjects—the subjects in our present and in our future as well as those in the past—with whom we compare and contrast our discursive perspectives. In genealogical investigations of this sort the engagement with past subjectivities is mutually transformative: we open ourselves up to interrogation by voices and perspectives hidden in our past, while at the same time we cast them in a new light that they did not enjoy before the genealogical encounter. Through these critical transformations, new connections are brought to light, new possibilities of resistance are activated, and new forms of solidarity become possible. Without losing sight of the specificity of local struggles, without subsuming them under grand movements of liberation, genealogical investigations help us see the interconnections among historically situated forms of subjugation. Through insurrectionary genealogies

we can become part of multiple communities of resistance—past, present, and future—which, without being unified, intersect and overlap in complex ways, creating friction of all sorts. Drawing on the epistemic friction among multiple sources of agency and multiple power/knowledges, insurrectionary genealogies activate counter-memories that make available multiplicitous pasts for differently constituted and positioned subjectivities, making it possible to form plural and heterogeneous forms of solidarity with the past, and opening up new possibilities for social contestation. We need insurrectionary genealogies and *guerrilla* pluralism to fight radical epistemic exclusions, to make hegemonic official histories that monopolize the social imagination explode. But we should not give up on the possibility of epistemic and sociopolitical melioration. It is my suggestion that the pluralization of the social imagination should combine a guerrilla pluralism and a melioristic pluralism, using the former for its deconstructive tasks and the latter for its reconstructive tasks whenever the social conditions make these tasks possible. In the next two sections I will elaborate this peculiar combination of guerrilla and melioristic pluralism.

6.4. Guerrilla Pluralism, Counter-Memories, and Epistemologies of Ignorance

The critical battle against the monopolization of knowledge-producing practices involves what Foucault called "an insurrection of subjugated knowledges." When it comes to knowledge of the past and the power associated with it, this battle involves resisting the omissions and distortions of official histories, returning to lost voices and forgotten experiences, relating to the past from the perspective of the present in an alternative (out-of-the-mainstream) way. And this is precisely what the Foucaultian notions of "counter-history" and "counter-memory" offer. Official histories are produced by monopolizing knowledge-producing practices with respect to a shared past. Official histories create and maintain the unity and continuity of a political body by imposing an interpretation on a shared past and, at the same time, by silencing alternative interpretations of historical experiences. Counter-histories try to undo these silences and to undermine the unity and continuity that official histories produce. Foucault illustrates this with what he calls "the discourse of race war" that emerged in early modernity as a discourse of resistance for the liberation of a race against the oppression of another, for example, of the Saxons under the yoke of the Normans.[28] In lecture IV of *Society Must Be Defended* (2003), Foucault sets out to analyze the

[28] Foucault argues that in Europe—and especially in England—"this discourse of race war functioned as a counter-history" (2003, p. 66) until the end of the nineteenth century, at which point it was turned into a racist discourse (aimed not at the liberation of an oppressed race, but at the supremacy of an allegedly superior race that views all others as an existential threat).

"counter-historical function" of the race-war discourse in early modernity (pp. 66ff). Part of what the race-war discourse did was to retrieve the untold history of a people, which could be used as a weapon against the official history that legitimized their oppression. This counter-history tapped into the subversive power of a silenced historical experience and reactivated the past to create distinctive knowledge/power effects: new meanings and normative attitudes were mobilized so that what was officially presented as past glorious victories that legitimized monarchs and feudal lords as the rightful owners of the land to whom taxes were owed, now appeared as unfair defeats at the hands of abusive conquerors who became oppressors and had to be overthrown.

The ability to identify omissions, to listen to silences, to play with discursive gaps and textual interstices is a crucial part of our critical agency for resisting power/knowledges. Lacking that ability is a strong indication of one's inability to resist epistemic and sociopolitical subjugation, of the limitations on one's agency and positionality within discursive practices. And the ability to inhabit discursive practices critically that we develop by becoming sensitive to exclusions—by listening to silences—enables us not to be trapped into discursive practices, that is, it gives us also the ability to develop *counter-discourses*. Indeed, being able to negotiate historical narratives and to resist imposed interpretations of one's past means being able to develop *counter-histories*. This is why *guerrilla* pluralism is necessary in the face of radical exclusions: because when available discourses leave no room for certain voices to be heard or to sound intelligible, these excluded standpoints have to develop voices and acquire agency in opposition to the available discursive practices, that is, in *counter-discourses*.

Becoming sensitive to discursive exclusions and training ourselves to listen to silences is what makes possible "the insurrection of subjugated knowledges": it enables us to tap into the critical potential of demeaned and obstructed forms of power/knowledge by paying attention to the lives, experiences and discursive practices of those peoples who have lived their life "in darkness and silence" (Foucault: 2003, p. 35). In his discussion of "the insurrection of subjugated knowledges," Foucault highlights two different aspects of subjugated knowledges that are crucial to understand their critical potential, that is, the kind of insurrection that they can be mobilized to produce. In the first place, Foucault emphasizes that subjugated knowledges are "historical contents that have been buried or masked in functional coherences or formal systematizations" and that are dug up by new forms of scholarship (p. 7). By resurrecting these buried and masked blocks of historical knowledge, the critique of institutions, discourses, and hegemonic histories becomes possible. For example, Foucault remarks that what made it possible to develop a genealogical critique of the asylum or the prison was the retrieval of blocks of historical knowledge present but masked or buried in "functional and systematic ensembles." (Ibid.) These blocks of historical knowledge make critique possible because they

"allow us to see the dividing lines in the confrontation and struggles that functional arrangements or systematic organizations are designed to mask" (Ibid.). The historical dimension of subjugated knowledges is crucial because it enables us to see, diachronically, different substrata or deposits of ongoing epistemic subjugations by calling attention to the social struggles and conflicts that have been part of the production of institutions and discourses, but have become buried in their interstices.

In the second place, Foucault also highlights another key aspect of subjugated knowledges: they are "knowledges from below," "unqualified or even disqualified knowledges."[29] (Ibid.) The lack of sanction or pedigree, their marginalization and stigmatization, is a crucial part of the epistemological subordination or exclusion that makes them subjugated knowledges. But Foucault is quick to point out that these disqualified or unqualified knowledges should not be identified with folk knowledge or common sense, which is excluded from the realm of science and erudition, but has great currency in mainstream epistemic markets. By contrast, a subjugated knowledge is the one that suffers a more pervasive social exclusion and stigmatization: "a knowledge that is local, regional, or differential, incapable of unanimity and which derives its power solely from the fact that it is different from all the knowledges that surround it" (p. 8). These are knowledges that are not articulated or voiced in the *proper* way, knowledges without accepted credentials; in short, knowledges without social currency because of the history of epistemological exclusions and marginalizations that have kept them out of official markets for epistemic transactions. This second feature of subjugated knowledges is also what makes social critique possible by calling into question official and hegemonic knowledges and interrogating the exclusions that they rest on. Thus, referring to his own genealogical critiques of institutions like the asylum or the hospital and of discourses such as psychiatry or medicine, Foucault remarks that "it is the reappearance of what people know at a local level, of these disqualified knowledges, that made the critique possible" (p. 8).

A perfect illustration of these two features of subjugated knowledges and their critical potential can be found in Ladelle McWhorter's use of the local and forgotten blocks of historical knowledge which she uncovers in her genealogy of racism in the United States. In her research of the eugenics movement, McWhorter (2009) found that between 1927 and 1972 "poor people in Virginia were rounded up by the thousands and taken to Lynchburg and Stauton to be sterilized" (p. 296). About 8,500 were forcibly sterilized, McWhorter tells us.

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[29] These are "knowledges that have been disqualified as conceptual knowledges, as insufficiently elaborated knowledges: naïve knowledges, hierarchically inferior knowledges, knowledges that are below the required level of erudition or scientificity" (p. 7).

> In Virginia, and elsewhere, the memories are still there—scattered, in pieces, dispersed into this or that individual's or family's shame and pain—but still there. The knowledge of what was done to two generations of Virginia's poor, her disabled, her nonconformists, her misfits, is a local knowledge shared by ordinary people. . . . It is knowledge that for decades was *not recognized as any kind of knowledge at all* and that barely recognizes itself as such even now. (pp. 296–7; my emphasis)

McWhorter points out that in the last twenty years "a small contingent of researchers has disinterred a lot of the buried evidence to corroborate" the ignored, but not forgotten historical knowledge of that official campaign against the disabled and the vulnerable. In this hidden but remembered historical knowledge from below we can appreciate the two aspects of subjugated knowledges that, according to Foucault, contribute to make critique possible: the buried but documentable historical information and the locally scattered memories that were never allowed to amount to more than unqualified and dismissible experiences. As McWhorter puts it,

> By foregrounding historical material that hegemonic histories and official policies have de-emphasized or dismissed, [the genealogical researchers] have created an erudite account of scientific racism and eugenics, and in so doing they have critiqued received views and called into question some aspects of the epistemologies that support them. (p. 297)

As Foucault puts it, the aim of a genealogy is to provide "a meticulous rediscovery of struggles and the raw memory of fights" (2003, p. 8). Genealogical investigations aim at unearthing multiple paths from buried or forgotten past struggles to the present. By opening up new ways to think about the past, genealogical investigations constitute critical interventions in the social imagination that can help us make our sense of a shared past more pluralistic and open to diversity. By promoting a critical awareness that things are as they are because of a history of past struggles that are hidden from view, genealogical reconstructions can have a great impact on how we confront our struggles in the present. As McWhorter argues, "One consequence of that awareness is the recognition that today's status quo was far from inevitable and need not persist into tomorrow" (2009, p. 296). Genealogies are *insurrections* against monopolizations of the social imagination; they provide new venues for imaginative appropriations of a heterogeneous past, which in turn open new paths for projections into the future. And it is important to note that the possibilities of critique that are opened up by unearthing marginalized past struggles benefit not only those whose experiences and lives have been kept in the dark, but the entire social body, which can now become critically conscious of the heterogeneity of histories and experiences that are part of the social fabric. Countermemories can produce a critical transformation of society's self-image and of

the social imagination as it is lived and exercised from different social locations. And this is why McWhorter's genealogy of racism makes racial oppression relevant in novel and unexpected ways to a wide variety of groups and publics that can now relate to old struggles in new ways.

Genealogies are insurrections of subjugated *knowledges*. And the plurals here are crucial, for the plurality of insurrections and of subjugated knowledges has to be kept always alive in order to resist new hegemonic unifications and hierarchizations of knowledge.[30] Insurrections of subjugated knowledges and their critical resistance can be co-opted for the production of new forms of subjugation and exclusion (new hegemonies) or for the reinforcement of old ones. The only way to resist this danger is by guaranteeing the constant *epistemic friction* of knowledges from below, which—as I have argued elsewhere (2006a)—means guaranteeing that eccentric voices and perspectives are heard and can interact with mainstream ones, that the experiences and concerns of those who live in darkness and silence do not remain lost and unattended, but are allowed to exert *friction*. Genealogies have to be always plural, for genealogical investigations can unearth an indefinite number of paths from forgotten past struggles to the struggles of our present; and the insurrections of subjugated knowledges they produce also need to remain plural if they are to retain their critical power, that is, the capacity to empower people to resist oppressive power/knowledge effects, the capacity to pluralize the social imagination.

To conclude this section I want to connect the critical and transformative possibilities underscored by the Foucaultian guerrilla pluralism with the ongoing discussions in epistemologies of ignorance I have drawn on in previous chapters. It is surprising that Foucault is not widely cited and discussed in the epistemologies of ignorance developed in Feminist Standpoint Theory and Critical Race Theory. Lorraine Code is one notable exception here. In "The Power of Ignorance" (2007) she acknowledges and makes explicit use of the Foucaultian approach: "I follow Michel Foucault in recognizing the impediments to knowing what is not 'within the true' . . ., thus within the knowable, within the conceptual framework held in place by an intransigent hegemonic discourse, an instituted social imaginary" (p. 226). This Foucaultian perspective that Code echoes contains two crucial insights for the epistemology of ignorance. The first crucial insight is the idea that a discursive framework

[30] The danger that the critical work of genealogies can be reabsorbed by hegemonic power/knowledges is brilliantly described by Foucault: "once we have excavated our genealogical fragments, once we begin to exploit them and to put in circulation these elements of knowledge that we have been trying to dig out of the sand, isn't there a danger that they will be recoded, recolonized by these unitary discourses which, having first disqualified them and having then ignored them when they reappeared, may now be ready to reannex them and include them in their own discourses and their own power-knowledge? *And if we try to protect the fragments we have dug up, don't we run the risk of building, with our own hands, a unitary discourse?*" (2003, p. 11; my emphasis).

produce *spaces of knowability and unknowability* simultaneously, so that there will be things that lie within the true (*"dans le vrai"*) as well as things outside it for agents who operate within that framework. In other words, the epistemic agency that subjects have within a discursive practice is such that their knowledge and ignorance are co-constituted: their epistemic lucidity and their epistemic blindness go hand in hand, mutually supporting each other. As another epistemologist of ignorance, Shannon Sullivan, puts it, "Rather than oppose knowledge, ignorance often is formed by it, and vice versa" (2007, p. 154). For this reason, Sullivan suggests that we talk about "ignorance/knowledge," instead of talking about ignorance and knowledge separately, so that we undo certain epistemic illusions: in particular, "the purported self-mastery and self-transparency of knowledge, as if nothing properly escaped its grasp" (Ibid.).

The second crucial idea that derives from the Foucaultian approach is that there is *no such thing as epistemic innocence*, for we always operate from a space of knowability and unknowability, from a knowledge/ignorance framework. And this problematizes the notion of culpable ignorance. On the one hand, as Code remarks, there is no such thing as "an innocent position from which 'we' could level charges of culpability" (2007, p. 226). Therefore, as Code insists, in dealing with the epistemic aspects of particular forms of oppression, we should be very careful not to indulge in the naïve charge of epistemic culpability—"They should have known better"—for very often subjects *could* not have known otherwise and, therefore, the charge of culpability is vacuous. On the other hand, however, interstices within discursive practices as well as alternative practices are often available; and they present opportunities for epistemic resistance, for challenging ignorance/knowledge structures, and genealogical investigations can be used to point out how these subjugated knowledges could have been used, how people could have known otherwise by drawing on them, and how they could have become able to undo epistemic exclusions and stigmatizations—hence the insurrectionary power of subjugated knowledges, which genealogical investigations try to mobilize. As Sullivan puts it, echoing Foucault,

> The creation of ignorance/knowledge through relations of force often is unbalanced and unequal, as is the case in colonized lands. But as a dynamic, relational process, it involves the active participation of all "sides" and includes the possibility of resistance to and transformation of the forms of ignorance/knowledge produced. (2007, p. 155)

A Foucaultian guerrilla pluralism enables us to see how different possibilities of resistance appear for differently constituted and situated subjects as they develop different forms of agency with respect to power/knowledge, or rather, power/ignorance-knowledge. Let me briefly sketch how this insurrectionary genealogical pluralism can be put to use against ideologies of racial oppression and the forms of *white ignorance* that they produce.

In his recent work Charles Mills has developed a critical epistemology of ignorance which—I want to suggest—overlaps with Foucaultian insurrectionary genealogies in interesting ways. In "White Ignorance" (2007) Mills emphasizes the role that official histories and hegemonic forms of collective memory play in sustaining white ignorance, and also the crucial role that counter-memory needs to play to resist and subvert the epistemic oppression that condemns the lives of marginalized people to silence or oblivion. As Mills puts it, a crucial element in white ignorance is *the management of memory*, which involves socially orchestrated, exclusionary processes of both remembering and forgetting: "if we need to understand collective memory, we also need to understand collective amnesia" (2007, pp. 28–9). (And indeed forgetting can be a source of collective identification as powerful as remembering—to the point that some would like to talk about the *United States of Amnesia*.) Mills emphasizes that there is "an intimate relationship between white identity, white memory, and white amnesia, especially about nonwhite victims" (p. 29). But fortunately we have "both official and counter-memory, with conflicting judgments about what is important in the past and what is unimportant, what happened and does matter, what happened and does not matter, and what did not happen at all" (Ibid.). Mills argues that the postbellum national white reconciliation was made possible and was subsequently maintained thanks to "the repudiation of an alternative black memory" (p. 30). There have been all kinds of mechanisms in white epistemic practices that have contributed to maintain this repudiation in place: blocking black subjectivities from giving testimony, keeping black testimony—when given—out of circulation,[31] exercising an epistemic assumption against its credibility, and so on. In multiple venues of epistemic interaction in the white world, from the streets of white suburbs to the lecture halls of the academy, black voices have been traditionally minimized and heavily constrained in their ability to speak about their own experiences,[32] when they have been allowed to speak at all (think, for example, of how witnesses of lynching were terrorized into silence until not too long ago). "Black counter-testimony against white mythology has always existed but would originally have been handicapped by the lack of material and cultural capital investment available for its production" (p. 33).

The black counter-memories that Mills describes as getting systematically disqualified and *whited out* certainly count as subjugated knowledges in a Foucaultian sense. And Foucaultian genealogical investigations that tap into

[31] As Mills puts it, "The 'testimony' of the black perspective and its distinctive conceptual and theoretical insights will tend to be *whited out*. Whites will cite other whites in a closed circuit of epistemic authority that reproduces white delusions" (2007, p. 34; my emphasis).

[32] As Mills points out, "Slave narratives often had to have white authenticators, for example, white abolitionists" (2007, p. 32).

those subjugated knowledges could produce the kind of subversion and insurrection that Mills calls for:

> White ignorance has been able to flourish all of these years because a white epistemology of ignorance has safeguarded it against the dangers of an illuminating blackness or redness, protecting those who for "racial" reasons have needed not to know. Only by starting to break these rules and meta-rules can we begin the long process that will lead to the eventual overcoming of this white darkness and the achievement of an enlightenment that is genuinely multiracial. (p. 35)

But how can "a white epistemology of ignorance" be destabilized and resisted? Insurrectionary genealogies are invaluable critical tools for denouncing the epistemic exclusions and stigmatizations that sustain white privilege and white ignorance. A critical epistemology of ignorance informed by a Foucaultian guerrilla pluralism can achieve a kind of *epistemological insurrection* that goes beyond a mere inversion of white epistemology, that is, beyond an epistemology of the victims. Mills has argued that since white ignorance has produced an inverted epistemology that protects it—white epistemology—the critical task is to reinvert the inverted epistemology of the privileged into an epistemology of the oppressed. But is this enough? Alison Bailey (2007) has argued that the reinversion strategies do not work because they reinscribe the logic of purity, failing to accept duplicities, multiplicities, and, in short, the complexities of our epistemic lives. As she puts it, "Re-inversion strategies are the only solutions purity has to offer. However, I do not think re-inverting inverted epistemologies will have radical long-standing effects. *Under purity, inverted epistemologies can only be re-inverted and not shattered*" (p. 87).

Drawing on María Lugones (2003), Bailey urges us to abandon the logic of purity and to shift to a curdled logic that can accommodate radical differences and the multiplicitious nature of our subjectivities. This curdled logic brings ignorance and epistemic oppression under a different light, and it opens up new possibilities of resistance and critique: "a curdled reading of ignorance will offer us a more relational understanding of ignorance by revealing the ways in which people of color have strategically engaged with white folks' ignorance in ways that are advantageous" (p. 84). As Bailey puts it, curdled resisting subjects are those who "take hold of the double meaning of their actions" (p. 89) and navigate "a world where both dominant and resistant logics are present" (p. 90). Curdling is a way of keeping alive the duplicities and multiplicities of our practices and of ourselves, finding opportunities for resistance within them. This curdling is very congenial with the guerrilla pluralism I have described as animating insurrectionary genealogies. The forms of epistemological resistance that insurrectionary genealogies can offer go well beyond a mere reinversion of epistemic relations. But this should be taken as an extension of—or even simply as a friendly amendment to—the

critical project confronting the epistemology of ignorance that Mills has formulated for us. Bailey herself seems to recognize this when she writes, "If we examine Mills's 'epistemology of victims' through a curdled lens we see that it also includes an *epistemology of resistance*" (p. 87; my emphasis). And, as I have argued, Foucault offers the theoretical resources for an epistemology of resistance that goes beyond a mere reinversion of relations of epistemic subordination and is capable of producing more complex epistemic subversions, perhaps even the *shattering* of epistemic economies.

6.5. Resistant Imaginations: Toward a Kaleidoscopic Social Sensibility

But after epistemic regimes are shattered, we have to undertake a process of reconstruction with the pieces we are left with, not in order to produce a new overarching regime, but in order to make our heterogeneous (and sometimes conflicting) epistemic practices livable, to make them properly communicated and, wherever possible, coordinated, so that—without the unification of a hegemonic epistemic regime—these practices don't dissolve into chaos, but remain functional and continue to exert beneficial epistemic friction in our cognitive-affective lives. *Guerrilla* pluralism has a lot to offer in terms of epistemic disruptions and processes of unlearning, but very little in terms of epistemic regrouping and resuming processes of collective learning. If we *only* had the epistemic subversions and insurrections of this *guerrilla* pluralism, we would be doomed to relativism. However, what underlies the epistemology of resistance and the polyphonic contextualism I have defended in this book is not relativism, but *relationalism*. It is social relationality that has been the focus of the critique of epistemic injustices and also the focus of the fight toward epistemic justice in my epistemology of resistance: the different forms of blindness and meta-blindness involved in epistemic injustices concern social relationality, and the different kinds of lucidity required by epistemic justice are also first and foremost lucidity about social relationality. I will argue in this section that it is William James's *relationalism* that can teach us how to move from epistemic (and sociopolitical) insurrections to epistemic (and sociopolitical) meliorations, providing robust and interconnected notions of objectivity and solidarity.[33]

James's philosophy seems oriented toward the individual and her experiences, but not so much toward interpersonal relations. However, despite his recalcitrant and unqualified individualism, there is also a strong social element in James's philosophy. This impetus toward the interpersonal and social is found in his pluralism and relationalism. James's radical pluralism is based on

[33] See my essay "James on Truth and Solidarity: The Epistemology of Diversity and the Politics of Specificity" (2010), from which the next few paragraphs are drawn.

a theory of relationality according to which nothing can be understood in and by itself, but rather in relation to other things, in a network of relations. In this relational view, the identity of things is concocted in a network of interdependences; and to have a sense of self is to have a sense of the dependences that compose one's life, for we can understand the identity of something only by grasping the fabric of relations in which that thing appears. It is essential to distinguish this relationalism from the holism that is often attributed to figures like Wilfrid Sellars, Nelson Goodman, and W. V. O. Quine. Whereas the Jamesian relationalism is based on open-ended networks of relations that are typically unfinished and indeterminate, the holism that often circulates in contemporary American philosophy requires finished and complete wholes (whether they are language-games, frameworks, or webs of beliefs). James's relationalism is beyond the usual dichotomy between atomism and holism and actually undercuts it, for, without assigning priority to the component parts or to the whole, it prioritizes relations and calls attention to their formative and transformative character in shaping the relata. From a relational perspective, to understand the identity of something is to understand how that thing is related to many other things, but also how it can become entangled in many other *potential* relations: it is not only the factual relations that are already given that matter, but also those other potential relations that can unfold or be created.

The identity of each thing is bound up with diversity, for each thing enters into constitutive relations with many other things and becomes entangled with a wild diversity of entities to which it is related in a network of interdependences. From this point of view, *issues of identity have to be understood as issues of diversity*: the others are essential to the self, for it is in networks of relations that individuals and groups are formed. Diversity is not a multicultural invention of postcolonial and globalized societies. In this view, diversity is the human condition. We are diverse and heterogeneous beings who are shaped and reshaped through diverse and heterogeneous networks of interpersonal relations. James's conception of the self underscores this deep sense of relationality and involvement with those around us.

For James, the self is a bundle of relations: the self is formed in and through the relations in which it becomes involved; we negotiate our identity in these relations. As he puts it, "Every bit of us at every moment is part and parcel of a wider self, it quivers along various radii like the wind-rose on a compass, and the actual in it is continuously one with possibles not yet in our present sight" (1977, p. 131). As John McDermott (1986) has shown, despite James's unflinching individualism and his explicit rejection of sociality as a constitutive aspect of the self, the Jamesian Promethean self is not a solitary self but a member of a community of experience and interpretation that cannot help but be enmeshed in social networks, for it is a relational unit that shrinks and

grows as it relates to others.[34] Our identity is always open and unfinished, not because of a deficit but because of an excess, always containing *a more*, an inexhaustible well of possibilities.

Life is always full of surprises, of unexplored possibilities, of what James calls "relational novelties." And each relational novelty has the potential to transform our life orientation insofar as it affects the set of relations that have become constitutive of our identity. As James suggests, in a *kaleidoscopic* fashion, each new relation not only engenders new relational possibilities but also transforms retroactively all the relations previously experienced. Relational changes do not take place simply around us as something external, but they penetrate the very fabric of our being and force us to revisit and reevaluate previously established relations around which our life revolves. Although relational novelty can be found everywhere, we are not always open to the relational changes they can bring about. In fact, the openness to relational changes seems to be the exception more than the rule. As suggested by James, we live a good part of our life as if we were *dead*: "We live our life through *the path of least resistance*," through prefabricated relations and relying on generic categories ("man," "woman," "straight," "gay," "white," "black," etc.), whose generic meanings we take for granted without exploring them or reimagining them. We have to resist this ossification. We have to offer resistance to remain truly alive and to avoid living our life "through the path of least resistance." And this requires a *resistant imagination*—an imagination that is ready to confront relational possibilities that have been lost, ignored, or that remain to be discovered or invented.

Resistant imaginations work both retrospectively and prospectively. Our imaginings can be conformist or resistant when they look back into our past, when they look forward into our future, when they look around in our present, and when they look sideways into alternative realities. Moreover, in the relational view of the imagination suggested by James, these different directions that the imagination can take are interrelated and affect each other: the ways in which we imagine pasts, presents, futures, and alternative worlds influence each other, each having the potential to open our eyes to things that we did not see before (e.g., historians opening the eyes of news reporters, or science fiction writers opening the eyes of readers of history and news reports). Let's start with the retrospective side of a resistant imagination. Indeed, a resistant imagination requires a *resistant memory*. Memory is always selective and surrounded by oblivion, just as sight is surrounded by blind spots. But there are some forms of oblivion that harm us individually and collectively. These include the forgetting of the experiences of those who have not been heard or taken into account, but also the forgetting of the lost possibilities of those who could not live their lives as they would have liked. As James's account of the

[34] See McDermott's "The Promethean Self and Community in the Philosophy of William James" (1986, pp. 44–58), especially page 52 and pages 55–56.

relational possibilities that compose our life suggests,[35] by forgetting that things could have been otherwise we become doomed to *impotence*. Reopening the conversation about experiential possibilities that have been lost, ignored, or forgotten involves pluralizing the imagination and including more perspectives in it. Recovering lost or forgotten relational possibilities requires listening to new voices, interacting with different experiential perspectives, and training our eyes and hearts to see and feel things through the perspectives of differently embodied and socially situated others—which is what my Imperative of Epistemic Interaction demands. As James's relational and experimentalist view recommends, in order to avoid an ossified life, we need to abandon the path of least resistance; that is, we have to *resist* the easy denial and the easy oblivion of unexplored possibilities that surround the lives we fall into and the identities we come to adopt. And just as a resistant memory can help us overcome the kind of oblivion that constrains our minds and numbs our sensibilities, a resistant forward-looking imagination can help us cultivate openness to possible changes of the relational networks in which our identities are enmeshed: as the snake sheds its skin to grow and keep on living, perhaps we also have the vital need to open ourselves up to relational changes.

In order to come to terms with our relational core, we need to explore how our identities have been formed by remembering certain relational possibilities and forgetting others. Hence the crucial significance of a genealogical approach for achieving lucidity about the relational structures that support our collective and individual identities. Our memory, both individual and collective, is an interactive *achievement* that requires the social support of others: it is forged and maintained through negotiating processes (often unconscious) in which different experiential standpoints intersect and different agential perspectives are coordinated. The past of individuals and peoples is not something fixed and inert; our epistemic relation with the past is always in the making through our agency and negotiations. The past is constantly being recreated in our everyday practices, reimagined through a plurality of heterogeneous interpretative activities, formal and informal, conscious and unconscious. There is always an irreducible plurality of experiential and agential perspectives involved in these practices: the agents who participate in the interpretative practices that recreate the past and reimagine it have (or at least *can* have) differently organized and differently situated selves with different temperaments, and they go about differently in the assessment of their memories and in the reconstruction of their past.

[35] As expressed by a James scholar, John McDermott, each relation that is asserted in our lives brings with it a set of relations that are denied: "The path of least resistance [is] the result of having said 'no' to countless alternatives. Saying 'yes' to a relational possibility often has the unfortunate consequence of having to deny that we have said 'no' to a series of competing relational possibilities. Having denied that we have said 'no,' it is too infrequent that we reopen the conversation, tending rather to accept our situation as inevitable and fixed" (1986, p. 55).

Our beliefs about the past maintain their vital force, if they do, thanks to day-to-day epistemic negotiations embedded in a complex network of interpretative practices that always involve a multiplicity of perspectives. It is within these plural and diverse interpretative practices that our epistemic negotiations about individual and collective memories take place.

Can plural and heterogeneous imaginations collaborate in the sharing of memories and the reappropriation of their past? Is it possible to achieve an imaginary co-inhabitation of a shared past? Not without the interaction of resistant imaginations and the pluralization of the social imaginary. A full discussion of the epistemic negotiations that take place in interpretative practices about the past is beyond the scope of this chapter. What I want to underscore is the crucial role that the interaction of heterogeneous imaginations and experiential viewpoints play in those negotiations. An important insight to draw from James's pluralism and relationalism is that the *openness to interaction and negotiation* with an irreducible plurality of experiential and agential perspectives is a precondition for the *objectivity and justice* of our epistemic practices. When we assess the objectivity of our beliefs about the past and of the interpretative practices in which they were formed, we have to consider whether there has been an unbiased process of negotiation among differing perspectives, that is, whether our beliefs and interpretations have been compared with others in a negotiating process in which each perspective has been given an equal voice and treated with equal respect. In this sense, our assessments of objectivity are at the same time assessments of the fairness of the relevant epistemic practices in which beliefs are articulated, interpreted, and justified. In these practices agents are differently situated and sometimes excluded. Therefore, in our epistemic analyses we have no option but to examine whether the social and political conditions for fair comparison and contrast among alternative interpretations are given. In this view, epistemic analysis cannot be properly conducted without a sociopolitical critique in which issues of inclusion, exclusion, marginalization, and oppression are raised and addressed. This suggests that our interpretative practices should be guided by a cluster of desiderata that contain both cognitive and political elements, such as the inclusion of alternative viewpoints, the equality of voices and opportunities to speak, and the need of genuine normative engagements with conflicting positions. The desirability of these elements in our practices derives from their epistemic and political benefits: for example, removing biases and exclusions, reducing inequalities among participants, and improving people's capacities to speak and to listen to others. In this view *epistemic and sociopolitical melioration go hand in hand*; and a lack of openness to interaction and negotiation results in a double deficit: the lack of objectivity and the lack of justice.

It is important to note that the imaginative reconstruction of one's past is a never-ending task. No matter how much critical reflection goes into the establishment and evaluation of our memories, the critical reconstruction of

our beliefs about the past cannot reach an end point and be declared final. Our epistemic negotiations and appraisals cannot have complete closure or finality because that would mean to foreclose the possibility of ever reopening our conversations about a shared past, of inviting new voices and perspectives to participate in the critical reconstruction of shared memories. Although the process of evaluation and critique will certainly come to a halt for all kinds of contingent reasons, it has to remain open and ready to be resumed because there can always be new forms of epistemic engagement and unforeseeable negotiations that can have an impact on our beliefs. James's thoroughgoing fallibilism and radical pluralism suggest that the genealogy of our beliefs can always be revisited.

The reinterpretability and renegotiability of our beliefs about the past have been viewed by many as an obstacle to historical objectivity and historical truth; they think that (at least in principle) we should be able to determine and fix the veridicality of our memories once and for all, so that we reach a point where we can no longer change our minds through reinterpretation and renegotiation. However, James's radical fallibilism and pluralism suggest that, far from being at odds with objectivity and truth, the openness to reinterpretation and renegotiation of our beliefs is in fact what makes it possible to improve their objectivity, to correct their biases and mistakes, and to maintain their truth *alive*, that is, dynamic, adaptable, and integrated in our lives. The openness to negotiation that James's pluralism recommends points in the direction of what I have called *radical solidarity*: the cultivation of an ever-expanding accountability and responsiveness to indefinitely many others, which is required by a resistant epistemic agency.

As more perspectives are taken into account in our epistemic negotiations, we can improve the articulation and justification of our beliefs, and our epistemic appraisals thus become more objective. The reinterpretation and renegotiation of our beliefs should be thought of as opportunities for learning from each other and correcting each other. But, in this view, what is considered objectively true is *not* identified with whatever is agreed upon.[36] In the Jamesian view, the open-ended epistemic negotiations through which we establish and reevaluate the truth of our beliefs are *not* driven toward *unification and consensus*; the goals that guide them are, rather, *coordination and cooperation*

[36] James's radical pluralism cannot support a *consensus theory of truth*, whether relativistic or universalistic. In the Jamesian view, truth is not identified either with the current agreement of particular communities à la Rorty, or with the ideal agreement of a universal community à la Habermas. See especially Habermas (2005) and Rorty (2000). Both Rorty and Habermas, like James, argue for a deep connection between objectivity and justice, linking the epistemic and the sociopolitical. Rorty does it by rooting this connection in the local agreement in values and ways of life that happens to rule the day in a particular community. By contrast, Habermas argues for purely formal and abstract notions of objectivity and justice that are grounded in the notion of *universalizability* (i.e., the capacity to become part of the universal consensus of all rational beings who can be communication partners). By contrast, James does not appeal to agreement—whether actual or ideal—as the foundation of all truths.

through genuine normative engagements.[37] In other words, what matters is that views are compared, contrasted, and critically evaluated vis-à-vis each other, but not that they converge and merge into a single, unified perspective. At the end of the day, our negotiations may yield a multiplicity of heterogeneous truths. In the Jamesian view, such multiplicity should be expected, since there is an irreducible plurality of different epistemic perspectives. In some cases, we may find out that the different truths in the running are different but combinable or at least capable of coexisting in coordination. In other epistemic disputes, we may find out that there is a radical clash in which different epistemic assessments remain at odds with each other.[38] The status, scope, and implications of these epistemic differences cannot be decided a priori, prior to the actual engagements among competing perspectives. James's pragmatic view of truth recommends an attitude or temperament in epistemic practices, but it does not provide a method for resolving disputes or a general account of the epistemic and sociopolitical force that our truths can have in all contexts.

James argues that we should always talk about truths in the plural. He defends the diversification of truths according to plural contexts, plural practices, and plural interests. In this view, truths are *relative* to the always changeable reality we cope with in our experiences and practices. But James's alethic pluralism should not be conflated with *radical relativism*.[39] Such *relativism* would clearly be inadequate for a contextualist epistemology of resistance that aspires to meliorate our epistemic lives and help us achieve greater degrees of objectivity and epistemic justice. Resistant imaginations cannot play any critical role and exert beneficial epistemic friction if any way of framing and interpreting is as good as any other. In the imaginative reconstruction of a shared past, for example, resistant memories are neutralized if they are thought of as operating in a leveled field in which any memory is as good as any other. A community of resistant memories cannot be formed if people simply make up

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[37] That is, through engagements in which the different parties enjoy a minimal amount of equality and respect, and they really take into account and address each other's concerns.

[38] There can be different kinds of clashes and incompatibilities. The competing truths under consideration can be uncombinable because they contradict each other or because they occupy different and nonoverlapping spaces. The former case raises issues relating to the bivalence of truth; the latter case raises issues of incommensurability.

[39] Besides what I say below, other considerations can be used to distinguish James's pluralism from radical relativism. For James, no matter how diverse and heterogeneous our epistemic practices happen to be, there is always the *possibility* of coordinating the truths that emerge from those practices. In James's view, this ever-present possibility is guaranteed by the general interests of mankind, that is, by the interests that relate to adaptation and the survival of the species. These general interests constitute the ground for what James calls our "general obligation to do what pays," which is what brings us all together as truth-seekers. In this naturalistic perspective, truth is viewed as what proves to be reliable and adaptive in the long run. Although James calls attention to the relativistic elements in our assessments of truth, his empiricist and pragmatic relativism in conjunction with his naturalism make room for a strong notion of objectivity, which goes well beyond the strictures of radical relativism.

the facts and choose whatever revisionary history is most convenient for them. It is not the case that if people continue negotiating long enough, they may be able to establish by consensus any belief they wish about past events and past subjects (e.g., that the Holocaust never happened), and that they can make this belief true. The Jamesian approach rejects this naïve constructivism and revisionism. For one thing, James's pluralism demands that we give normative weight to all subjects and their experiences; and this includes subjects of the past, whose experiences we cannot simply choose to disregard or shape at will without compromising the objectivity of our beliefs and epistemic appraisals. In this view, there is an irreducible plurality of centers of experience and agency that function as centers of *resistance and contestability* in our epistemic negotiations. All experiential subjects have the capacity to contest and resist our truth claims and epistemic assessments. And insofar as our predecessors are treated as *subjects*—and not as objects we can manipulate at will—we need to take into account their perspectives. The imaginative reconstruction of the past must include the experiences and valuations of past subjects, in which we can find questions, challenges, and resistances of all sorts.

The imaginative reconstruction of our past—both individual and collective—has to contend with a plurality of perspectives and must, in that sense, be polyphonic. The memory of an individual or of a people cannot be *monopolized*, that is, it cannot be completely unified and fully controlled by a single perspective. Hegemonic unifications of memories do exist both at the collective and at the individual level, effected and policed by oppressive regimes and oppressive personalities. But no matter how successful these hegemonic unifications happen to be in erasing tensions and repressing differences, there are always alternative interpretations and possible contestations even if they remain implicit or unconscious, that is, even if the possibility of epistemic dissent cannot yet be realized. Our genealogical exercises situate truth claims and narratives in and among different experiential and agential perspectives; and thus they open us to possible contestations and resistances, inviting us to enter into epistemic negotiations. It is in this sense that genealogy is a critical exercise of resistance, which has the potential to change not only our understanding of our past and of ourselves, but also our social and political relations to others with whom our lives are entangled, that is, those with whom we share a past, a present, or a future. Critical genealogies mobilize resistant memories and activate resistant imaginations. This exercise in retrospective critical resistance can have both epistemic and sociopolitical efficacy since it has the transformative capacity to reshape both epistemic and political communities simultaneously through critical interventions that affect both shared interpretations and shared values.

The epistemic interaction of resistant imaginations should seek the melioration of our life in common, but it does not need to aim at the configuration of a common vantage point from which we can all survey the world together.

The guerrilla pluralism discussed above reminds us that a common vantage point is not always possible or even desirable. But the interactive and connected view of epistemic agency that my epistemology of resistance has offered is fully compatible with a melioristic pluralism that aspires to the coordination of perspectives, so that standpoints become, not merged or fused together, but connected and attentive to each other, allowing the subjects who hold them to discharge their shared epistemic responsibilities with respect to justice. While being always attentive to social fractures and exclusions, and without aspiring to hegemonic unifications of perspectives, we can aim at the sharing of experiences and at the coordination of action whenever possible. We need at least to try to connect epistemic standpoints, to unearth their possible relations, and to facilitate epistemic negotiations across them. In these negotiations we have to take *responsibility* not only for our beliefs, but also for our ways of imagining and orienting ourselves in the world, with their sensitivities and insensitivities. As I have been discussing throughout the book, a key obligation in our epistemic interactions is to improve our sensibility with respect to the standpoints of indefinitely many others who can become our interlocutors. In this perfectionist challenge, the imagination can help us or handicap us in our ability to relate to others and to approach potential interlocutors as *specific* others who pose specific challenges and demands—for these others will not be properly recognized and understood as a Generalized Other à la Mead or as a formal universal community of communication à la Habermas, without acknowledging the specificity of their experiences and perspectives.

As suggested above, James's pragmatic pluralism is not radical enough because it pays insufficient attention to exclusions, silences, and discontinuities, focusing mainly on the continuities forged by the experiences that have been actually shared and not those that have been silenced, marginalized, or rendered unintelligible. But besides expanding and radicalizing the genealogical side of Jamesian pluralism, we also have to complement it with another side: its *projective* side, which involves the prospective aspect of our epistemic appraisals and the projective use of the social imagination. Our epistemic appraisals are be both *retrospective and prospective*: we assess our beliefs, epistemic habits, and attitudes at the crossroads between the life experiences and actions of the past and those of the future; that is, we evaluate how our beliefs, habits, and attitudes can guide us in mediating the interface between the actualities and the potentialities of our life. Thus understood, our epistemic appraisals require the critical examination of where our diverse and heterogeneous epistemic perspectives come from and where they can take us. How can we produce a shared social sensibility—a set of cognitive-affective relational attitudes toward one another that can guide our life in common—on the basis of epistemic differences rather than at their expense, that is, by exploiting these differences and their interactions rather than by suppressing them? This has

been the guiding question behind the different discussions of this book. These different discussions have converged on the following suggestion: we need to cultivate attitudes and practices of contestation and resistance to produce a *kaleidoscopic social sensibility*.

In this chapter I have argued that our social imaginings have to be radically pluralized and opened up to epistemic friction in order to meliorate our social sensibilities and to create or improve relations of solidarity. The social imaginary often forecloses possibilities of epistemic friction and resistance; and, as we have seen, failures of the social imagination contribute greatly to the formation and consolidation of various forms of social blindness and insensitivity that result in epistemic injustices. Because of a lack of a pluralistic social imaginary that accommodates resistant imaginations that contest and resist each other in unimpeded ways creating epistemic friction, a kaleidoscopic social sensibility is often lacking and people's epistemic lives get trapped in social blindness and meta-blindness, that is, in social insensitivity and in the insensitivity to their own insensitivity. Exclusionary social imaginaries and deficiently resistant social sensibilities result in a lack of empathy, in the accumulation of cognitive-affective obstacles that makes it difficult to see others as our peers or fellow-travelers and to see their experiences as having bearing on our life. Through the pluralization of the social imagination and the cultivation of a kaleidoscopic social sensibility, we can meliorate our social perception and learn increasingly better to see people's problems, interests, and needs in their own terms and in relation to our own, becoming interested (even invested) in them.

It has been the goal of this chapter to show that radical solidarity becomes possible when we can attain a radically pluralistic social sensibility that enables us to come together without having to sacrifice our differences. We can establish a solid epistemic ground for a shared life not through the unification but through the diversification of perspectives, if these heterogeneous standpoints learn to communicate and to engage one another. The critical examination of our epistemic life has the potential to create relations of *solidarity* with fellow thinkers and inquirers whose epistemic appraisals create friction with ours, even if our valuations and theirs don't coincide or converge. A community of thought and interpretation is a community of solidarity, that is, a community of subjects who are prepared to think and believe together as they act on their beliefs through collaborations, and who are ready to be responsive and accountable to each other as they try to share their experiential and agential perspectives. My polyphonic contextualism strongly suggests that our epistemic appraisals have a marked sociopolitical dimension and, when properly conducted, they are always an exercise in social criticism that addresses issues of inclusion and exclusion, of equal participation, and of social responsiveness. Given this convergence of the epistemic and the sociopolitical, it is not surprising that my polyphonic contextualism and relationalism can draw

simultaneously from two bodies of literature often considered disparate and unconnected: the social accounts of objectivity in feminist epistemology and the particularistic accounts of solidarity in feminist political philosophy and critical race theory.

On the one hand, a good part of contemporary feminist epistemology and feminist philosophy of science converges with the social contextualism I have defended in this book. In previous chapters I made ample use of the crucial contributions of feminist standpoint theories for an epistemology of resistance. I also want to emphasize now the similarities between the James-inspired pluralistic view of epistemic solidarity I have sketched in this chapter and the pluralistic view of objectivity that Helen Longino (1990) has developed in the philosophy of science. Although Longino does not cite James or give any indication that he may have inspired her, she emphasizes that pluralism and (a somewhat eccentric form of) empiricism are the pillars of her view of objectivity, and therefore it is not surprising that this view can be easily linked to Jamesian ideas. Although Longino doesn't use the expression "epistemic solidarity," her pluralistic negotiating model of objectivity can be understood as an account of it. In this model, objectivity is explained as the achievement of a *critical dialogue* among genuinely different perspectives, a dialogue guided by epistemic and political values that relate to diversity. Among these values that are simultaneously epistemic and sociopolitical, especial prominence is given to those that cluster around the multilayered notion of *equality* among participants and perspectives: equal access to education, cultural capital, and disciplinary power; equal authority in scientific disciplines, journals, and institutions; equal distribution of resources among groups; and so on.

On the other hand, insofar as it does not presuppose unity, identity, or the sharing of common features, my conception of radical solidarity should be understood as in line with recent pluralistic accounts of solidarity in critical race theory and feminist political philosophy, in particular, those of Tommy Shelby (2005) and Carol Gould (2007). These accounts[40] criticize the homogenizing and essentializing tendencies of traditional views of solidarity, according to which you can have solidarity with others only insofar as you are the same in some respect, that is, insofar as you enjoy similar attributes or share a standpoint. As an alternative, according to the pluralistic and particularistic accounts of Gould and Shelby, relations of solidarity are sustained by heterogeneous *social networks*. Gould, in particular, proposes a *network* conception of solidarity that goes along well with the social connection

[40] Shelby (2005) focuses on the intra-group solidarity of African Americans, whereas Gould (2007) focuses on the inter-group solidarity of trans-national movements. Despite their clear differences in focus and orientation, these accounts exhibit some interesting similar features that converge with my own view of radical solidarity.

model of responsibility and the account of activism as chained action I defend in sections 4.2 and 5.3.

6.6. Conclusion: Network Solidarity

Unlike those views that base solidarity on sharing an identity, a set of properties, or a perspective, *network solidarity* is not achieved at the expense of differences, but rather, through relations that preserve differences, that is, through the construction of networks of heterogeneous elements. Networks of solidarity are formed by weaving together problems, values, and goals that, though often irreducibly different, can overlap, converge, or simply be coordinated so that they can be addressed simultaneously and enjoy mutual support. As Gould puts it, in this view "solidarity is a disposition to act toward others who are recognized as different from oneself, in the sense of being differently situated" (2007, p. 9). Pluralistic views of this kind unmask (and show how to overcome) the misconception that solidarity requires shared identity or *assimilation*, which is central to the American multicultural model based on the image of the melting pot.[41] In recent critical race theory, there has been a movement toward pluralistic views, that is, a movement away from a conception of racial solidarity based on shared properties and toward a conception based on common problems and concerns. Criticizing racial and cultural essentialism, theorists such as Narayan (1997), Gooding-Williams (1998) and Shelby (2005) have shown how we can have solidarity without unification or homogenization.[42]

According to the pluralistic view of radical solidarity I have proposed, bonds and shared commitments are established on the basis of (rather than at the expense of) an irreducible diversity of experiential and agential perspectives, and with an eye to fostering and strengthening this diversity. This is a view of solidarity in which differences are not overcome, abstracted, unified, or subsumed under a more general viewpoint. *Pace* unitary accounts of solidarity that erode diversity and stifle dissent and epistemic contestation, my polyphonic contextualism and relationalism underscore the importance of arranging our practices so as to cultivate diversity, and encouraging us both to establish sociopolitical structures that promote diversity and to develop investigative and

[41] See Medina (2004b), where I criticize assimilationist models and non-pluralistic views of ethnic and racial solidarity.

[42] The most exhaustive and detailed exposition and defense of a pluralistic view of racial solidarity along these lines is the one articulated in Tommie Shelby's *We Who Are Black* (2005). Similar pluralistic and non-essentialist views of solidarity have also been defended by other philosophers in the recent feminist literature, especially by feminists of color. See Lugones (2003) and Moraga and Anzaldúa (1981). For an account of the convergence between race theory and feminist theory on a pluralistic conceptualization of solidarity and group identity, see Medina (2003).

justificatory practices that invite differences. Both in its epistemic and its political dimension, my polyphonic contextualism and relationalism suggest melioristic possibilities that can be achieved through resistance and friction of heterogeneous perspectives that can achieve greater degrees of lucidity and mutual respect by engaging with each other and becoming aware of their own limitations and interrelations. My epistemology of resistance offers a way of bringing together objectivity and solidarity: through the genealogical and projective exercises of an (always expanding) kaleidoscopic social imagination, we can identify and correct biases and exclusions and thus improve simultaneously the degrees of objectivity and solidarity that our practices exhibit. Epistemic and sociopolitical critiques can make important contributions to the formation of pluralistic communities in which different understandings and interpretations as well as different values and political commitments are coordinated. Epistemic and political solidarity should be promoted through a critical social imagination that uncovers the *specificity* of human experiences, the *concreteness* of human life, and the *distinctiveness* of individuals, groups, and cultures. For this to be possible we need to pluralize the social imagination that mediates our relations and sensibilities. This pluralization requires the interaction of resistant imaginations, which can produce beneficial epistemic friction and facilitate the development of expansive social sensibilities. As I have argued in this chapter, a kaleidoscopic social imagination that incorporates plural perspectives is the key for the development of expansive social sensibilities that respect differences and take an interest in the specifics of indefinitely many heterogeneous others with whom we share social spaces and can form communities.

Our inability to even register certain forms of exclusion and stigmatization and to become sensitive to them involves a failure of the imagination. As Naomi Scheman puts it with respect to the oppression of gender and sexual non-conformists: "Heteronormativity . . . functions in part through the quotidian complicity of those who cannot imagine—or desire—an alternative" (1997, p. 150). An increasing awareness and sensitivity to gender and sexual oppression and the achievement of new forms of solidarity become possible if and when gender and sexual dissidents acquire a new role and agency in the shared sexual imagination, hence the crucial importance of pluralizing our imaginative power and achieving a more kaleidoscopic social imagination. And this is an objective that we should all aspire to and that we all have *some* obligation to help achieve, depending on the specificity of our history and of the social locations we occupy. As Iris Young has suggested and as we discussed at the beginning of this chapter, we can see in the tortuous history of the women's movement a model for the increasing pluralization of a public that, through multiple and difficult battles, has learned to develop a sensibility that has demonstrated (not without difficulties and the suffering of many) a growing respect for internal differences. The women's

movement seems to have achieved an increasingly kaleidoscopic social perspective and indeed the social imagination of this community has been pluralized substantially (even if there is still more work to do in this pluralization). Women of color, non-heterosexual women, working-class women, Third World women, transgendered women, and other underprivileged and multiply oppressed women have played a special role in this process. But we should not expect the most oppressed to carry the biggest burdens. On the contrary, within social movements of resistance and liberation, we should expect more from those who are closer to the center, the more mainstream subjects, the ones who—even if oppressed—enjoy certain privileges and certain comfort, and are therefore comparatively less vulnerable.

As Sandra Harding (1991, p. 288), for one, puts it, privileged subjects should be conscientiously disloyal to their privilege and cultivate "traitorous" attitudes and orientations that disrupt unquestioned assumptions and prejudices. As Scheman puts it, there are "good reasons for encouraging creatively playful, politically serious border transgressing on the part of those who could . . . safely reside on the more privileged side" (1997, p. 150). Even if they have motivational as well as cognitive-affective obstacles to engage in the self-questioning and contestation of their own privileged perspectives, those who occupy positions of privilege in particular respects owe this labor of resistance to themselves and to the subordinated others with whom their lives and social positions are entangled. This is an important part of what Scheman has called "queering the center by centering the queer," calling attention to the resources that queer theory has to offer. "Queering the center by centering the queer" involves resisting and contesting what has been deemed normal and paradigmatic by fracturing and redirecting our social imagination and social gaze. But it is crucial to note that, as Scheman argues, this subversive practice of resisting and contesting established presumptions of normalcy is something that not only those perceived or designated as queer can and should do, but a critical task that falls on all of us, and especially on privileged subjectivities. This involves making the familiar and obvious newly strange and queer, bringing to the fore the processes of exclusion and stigmatization that go into what has been deemed normal and paradigmatic by the social imagination.

Consider the difficult relations between the transgender community and the women's movement. Clearly the demands and critical interventions of the transgender community have been crucial in problematizing gender categories and in creating specific forms of epistemic friction with established gender expectations. But, as Scheman has argued, although those subject positions that have been rendered unintelligible are particularly fruitful in the battle against heterosexism and against the oppression of a rigid gender binary, we should not expect the transgendered subjects themselves to be the ones solely responsible for resisting oppressive gender stereotypes and for bringing gender lucidity into our lives. As Scheman argues, this falls on all of

us and especially on the gender-conformists and gender-privileged, who need to start with a process of self-estrangement that calls into question their comfort and easy conformity with the gender binary.[43] The exclusionary and stigmatizing aspects of the male-female gender binary is felt more acutely by transsexual and gender-nonconformists, whose lives and experiences have been rendered unintelligible, but "it ought to fall to those of us who occupy positions of relative safety and privilege to complicate our own locations, to explore the costs of our comfort, and to help imagine a world in which it would be safe to be non-, ambiguously, or multiply gendered" (Scheman 1997, p. 133).

As Jane Addams suggested, we should all expose ourselves, make ourselves vulnerable, and let ourselves be guided by feelings of *perplexity* that can activate frictions and resistances going in many directions. Resistance can take many forms depending on where we start and how we position ourselves with respect to normalizing tendencies and expectations. But whatever shape they take, concerted efforts at resistance and the reverberation of chained acts of resistance through social networks can go a long way toward facilitating the pluralization of the social imagination and the expansion of social sensibilities. It is through resistant imaginations that we can improve our social sensibilities and make new forms of solidarity possible.

[43] Scheman makes this point using herself as an example. This is how she describes the starting point of her own gender-queering process, which did not begin with a proclivity to question gender categories and to undergo a process of self-estrangement: "My own gender identity has never been a source of confusion, nor have I puzzled over what it means to say that I am a woman, and this certainty has been untouched by my increasing inability to define gender. My certainty has its original grounding in my relative easy conformity with heteronormativity" (1997, p. 133). But the relative privilege and comfort of gender-conformist women (as compared with transgendered subjects who fall outside the gender binary) should not be taken to weaken or minimize in any way their status as oppressed subjects in relation to sexism. As Scheman puts it, "One need not downplay the oppression of women to acknowledge that a certain sort of privilege, one essential for social validation as human, attaches to being located squarely on one side or the other of the gender divide. Those of us who, as stably female-gendered feminists, would choose to see that boundary blurred to oblivion need to learn how to see and be seen as allies by those whose lives it slices through" (p. 133).

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I do not pretend to have solved all the problems concerning our shared responsibilities with respect to epistemic injustices. But I hope that my discussions contribute to promote critical awareness of (1) the crucial interrelations between epistemic injustices and sociopolitical injustices, and (2) the insufficiencies of purely individualistic and purely collectivist views of responsibility with respect to justice, making room for a hybrid view of *shared* responsibility. The first point has been addressed throughout the book: our obligation to resist and fight oppression has a crucial epistemic dimension, which demands that we critically examine and take responsibility for what we are capable and incapable of communicating, interpreting, and knowing—hence the need to address epistemic injustices concerning active ignorance, silences, expressive harms, hermeneutical lacunas, limitations in our abilities to listen, to interpret properly, to respond to each other's expressive acts, and so on. The second point concerning *shared* responsibilities for epistemic injustices has also been developed throughout the book, but especially in the last three chapters: in chapter 4 I examined the prima facie epistemic responsibilities with respect to others with whom we interact, and I endorsed Young's *social connection* model of shared responsibility as the key to addressing issues of epistemic justice; in chapter 5 I introduced the notion of *chained action* to explain how shared responsibilities can be discharged; and in chapter 6 I argued that we have the shared obligation to exercise *resistant* ways of imagining that make us sensitive to symbolic exclusions, expressive harms, and epistemic mistreatments, developing a conception of *network solidarity* grounded in a kaleidoscopic social imagination. Epistemically responsible agents and communities must interact and cooperate in order to live up to their shared responsibilities with respect to justice: they must exert resistance in their epistemic interactions in order to identify and interrogate silences, bodies of ignorance, and epistemic marginalizations of all sorts (hermeneutical and testimonial, for example); they must engage in chained actions that mitigate the epistemic injustices that support relations of oppression and subordination; and they must jointly pluralize their ways of imagining so as to resist hegemonic imaginations. Nothing short of all this will do the forward-looking and preventive work required to mitigate epistemic injustices and to avert them in the future. There remains the lingering concern that my view of epistemic responsibility may be too demanding, asking subjects to feel responsible for what they do not know and

cannot imagine. Life is demanding indeed, but I do not want to impose on our epistemic agency more obligations than those minimally required by our demanding epistemic life.

My account of epistemic responsibility is likely to appear as too demanding because, in my view, we are asked to assume responsibility for what we do not know and for what we cannot imagine. However, the normative demands of my account are not impossible to meet because they are *shared* and call for collaborative and joint efforts. Moreover, as argued in chapters 4–6, my polyphonic contextualism makes those demands manageable. In my contextualist view, assuming responsibility for our ignorance and lack of imagination does *not* involve being held responsible for *everything* we do not know and for *everything* we cannot imagine. The key here is the problem of relevance, that is, to be able to identify those failures of knowledge and imagination that make us insensitive in ways that handicap our interactions and our ability to repair injustices, protecting privileges and facilitating forms of oppression. The proper contextualization of epistemic responsibility that I propose helps us identify the forms of social insensitivity and numbness that make us complicit with forms of oppression such as homophobia, racism, and sexism in particular contexts. What are the most eminently relevant cognitive and imaginative failures that individuals and communities should feel responsible for and undertake the obligation to repair? A discussion of the relevance problem and of the proper contextualization of epistemic responsibility was developed in 4.2.4, where I proposed three maxims for making epistemic responsibilities manageable: the Maxim of Eminent Relevance, the Maxim of Openness and Vigilance, and the Maxim of Shared Responsibility to Interrogate Relevance. These maxims do not provide an algorithm for handling epistemic obligations, but at least they tell us where to begin in developing epistemically responsible agency in our interactions with others and in assuming shared responsibility for epistemic injustices.

But there is only so much that an epistemology can do. My discussions in this book offer an expanded view of epistemology as essentially normative and social, suggesting that our epistemic lives are inextricably interwoven with our ethical and sociopolitical lives. But my expanded conception of epistemology also underscores the limitations of epistemological analyses, which remain impotent unless coupled with deep personal changes (new ways of thinking and imagining) and continued with a transformative activism capable of changing social structures and relations. This required collaboration of the critical tasks of epistemology with activist undertakings follows from two central insights in feminist epistemology that have been the pillars of the epistemology of resistance I have defended in this book. On the one hand, following standpoint theorists (Code, Harding, Wylie, etc.), I have established a strong connection between the epistemic and the agential, between the cognitive makeup of agents and the social locations and the networks of social relations

they occupy—what I have called the *positionality* and *relationality* of epistemic subjectivities. Given this connection, it follows that the melioration of our epistemic life will require *action*, that is, sustained efforts to change patterns of interaction and to transform social locations and relations. On the other hand, I have also followed recent feminist epistemology that has focused on the emotions and the role they play in our epistemic life (Fricker, Jones, Sullivan, etc.), bringing together the cognitive and the affective. In order to underscore the affective dimension, whenever possible, I have tried to reformulate problems of *sight* and *blindness* in social interaction into problems concerning social *sensitivity* and *insensitivity*. This new focus on *sensitivity* and *insensitivity* is intended to bring to the fore the role of empathy and affect in the epistemology of social recognition. Indeed, when we identify deficiencies in our epistemic interactions with others and forms of complicity with epistemic injustices, these typically run deep and are rooted not only in our cognitive structures, but also in our affective structures. It follows from this that our epistemic self-improvement and the correction of epistemic vices will require deep cognitive and affective restructuring and rearranging our most intimate experiences and relations where those structures are formed. This is not easy to do, especially when we have already been *numbed* cognitively and affectively at the meta-level, in our second-order attitudes (i.e., our attitudes with respect to our ways of knowing, feeling, relating to others, and so on). We need disruptions, provocations, and, in short, resistance from others, so that our interactions with significantly different others can trigger productive self-problematizations and beneficial epistemic friction. Just as in our ethical and political life, achieving responsibility in our epistemic life is essentially a joint and interactive endeavor. We would not go very far in epistemic melioration if we are left to our own devices, or if we cultivate segregationist or isolationist habits that seal us off from those who have significantly different standpoints, for it is only by interacting with them and experiencing epistemic friction that we can begin to detect our blind spots and the limits of our epistemic sensibilities. Hence the Imperative of Epistemic Interaction I have argued for.

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